high that he used his "poitá" to fasten its tendrils, but as the plant shot up faster than he could supply thread, its charge was given to a Káyasth. Hence it is that a Bráhman cannot enter a pân-garden without defilement.

The pân-garden (Bara-Barej) is regarded as an almost sacred spot. Its greatest length is always north and south, while the entrances must be east and west. The enclosure, generally eight feet high, is supported by "Hijul"[1] trees, or betle-nut palms. The former are cut down periodically, but the palms are allowed to grow, as they cast little shade, and add materially to the profits of the garden. The sides are closely matted with reeds, jute stalks, or leaves of the date, or Palmyra palm, while "Nal" grass is often grown outside to protect the interior from wind and the sun's rays. The top is not so carefully covered in, wisps of grass being merely tied along the trellis work over the plants. A sloping footpath leads down the centre of the enclosure towards which the furrows between the plants trend, and serves to drain off rain as it falls, it being essential for the healthy growth of the plant that the ground be kept dry.

The pân plant is propagated by cuttings, and the only manures used are "Pák-matí," or decomposed vegetable mould excavated from tanks, and "Kalí," the refuse of oil mills. The plant being a fast growing one, its shoots are loosely tied with grass to upright poles, while thrice a year it is drawn down and coiled at the root. As a low temperature injures the plant by discolouring the leaves, special care must be taken during the cold season that the inclosure and its valuable contents are properly sheltered. Against vermin no trouble is required, as caterpillars and insects avoid the plant on account of its pungency. Weeds are carefully eradicated, but certain culinary vegetables such as pepper, varieties of pumpkins, and cucumbers, "palwal," and "baigan" (egg-plant), are permitted to be grown. Pân leaves are plucked throughout the year, but in July and August are most abundant, and therefore cheapest; while a garden if properly looked after continues productive from five to ten years. Four pân leaves make one Gaṇḍa, and the Bíṛa, or measure by which they are sold, nowadays equals in Eastern Bengal twenty Gaṇḍas, although formerly it equalled twenty-four.[2] Pân leaves are never vended by the Baraí himself, but are sold wholesale to agents (Paikárs), or directly to the pân sellers.

The varieties of the Piper betle are numerous, but it is probable that in different districts distinct names are given to the

[1] Sanskrit Ijjala (*Barringtonia acutangula*).

[2] In the "Bháṭí" country (Báqirganj), thirty-six Gaṇḍas equal one Bíṛa.

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same species. The "Kafúrí," or camphor-scented pân, allowed by all natives to be the most delicately flavoured, is only grown at Sunnárgaon for export to Calcutta, where it fetches a fancy price. The next best is the "Sanchí," which often sells for four anas a Bíṛa. The commoner sorts are the "Desí," "Bangala," "Bhátiál," "Dhál-dogga," and a very large leaved variety called "Bubná." The usual market price of the inferior kinds is from one to two paisa a bíṛa.

It has been mentioned that the "Bara" is regarded as almost sacred, and the superstitious practices in vogue resemble those of the silk worm breeder. The Baraí will not enter it until he has bathed and washed his clothes, while the low caste man employed in digging is required to bathe before he commences work. Animals found inside are driven out, while women ceremonially unclean dare not enter within the gate. A Bráhman never sets foot inside, and old men have the presentiment that on entering the same injury will befall them as is supposed will happen if they pass under the washerman's clothes line, or the trellis on which gourds are trained. It is frequently insinuated, however, that the village lovers often whisper beneath its shade; but, possibly this is merely idle gossip.

At the present day individuals belonging to the Dhobá, Chaṇḍál, and Sáha castes, as well as Muhammadans, manage pân-gardens, but they impiously omit the ceremonies necessary for preserving the Bara clean and unpolluted.

BATTÍ-WÁLAH.

The usual candlemakers are Ghulám Káyaths, who are also retailers of pân.

Bee's-wax is boiled and poured into cold water, then re-boiled and run into moulds. Coloured wax candles are rarely fancied by natives, but those required for the services of the Roman Catholic church are always tinged pale yellow.

BEDIYÁ.

In every province of India bands of vagrants, vaguely styled Nat, Kanjar, Brajbásí, or Banjára, are met with, who correspond to the gipsies of Europe, and bear a striking resemblance to one another. In the delta of the Ganges, boats being the only means of conveyance, the nomadic tribes move about in vessels which

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vary in build according to the particular division. In Bengal these vagrants are generically known as Bediyá, from the Sanskrit Vyádha, a hunter. Each division (bahr) has its route fixed beforehand by a Nardár, or Murabbí, who resides in a central locality within easy reach. He promotes the general interests of the tribe, selects the boats which are to form the fleet, appoints a director to each party, and punishes any disobedience, such as leaving the fleet and joining another. He settles all disputes, and if any serious difference occurs, takes evidence and delivers judgment. Fees are paid to him at marriages, and presents of clothes are given on other festive occasions.

Once every year the different tribes of Bediyás meet to consult, to celebrate marriages, and to lay in a supply of goods for retail during the ensuing year. On the full moon of Kártik (Nov.-Dec.) Hindus bathe at the old junction of the Brahmaputra and Ganges. Afterwards a fair, lasting a month, and known as the Váruni Mela, is held, to which traders from all parts of Bengal, and Upper India, resort. At it the merchants of Dacca, Silhet, Tipperah, and Mymensingh, buy their annual stock of merchandise, and hither come the Bediyás to replenish their stores. Each fleet brings its own Nardár, but when all have united one supreme head is elected, who directs the affairs of the whole tribe as long as it remains together.

The Bediyás have unfortunately given up most of their old customs, and been transformed within the last fifty years into uninteresting, and prosaic, Muhammadans. The Farazi Maulavís practising on their credulity, have made out that these wanderers are really the descendants of Núh Nabí, or Noah, who being a Bediyá, lived in a big boat with all his family!

At the annual gathering a Maulaví is always present to instruct his disciples, to teach the boys to pray, to perform marriage services, and to superintend the rite of circumcision. Although he wields much influence, the Maulaví is unable to wean the Bediyá from all his old Hindu superstitions; red lead (Sindúr) is still his symbol of marriage, and of married life, and the "Marocha," or four plantain trees, is the altar at which alone the marriage ceremony can be properly performed. Many women continue to tattoo the forehead like their Hindu sisters, and all classes invoke Manasa Devi, and engage Bráhmans to perform "púja" to a particular deity in times of sickness.

The Bediyás of the present day are as reserved as the Nat and Kanjar of Hindustan, and rarely talk freely to strangers. They still understand Hindustání, and sing Hindustání songs, but they converse in Bengali with the villagers, and in an

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Argot, or cant, language with their own people. The Bediyás and Nats mutually disclaim any relationship, but now and then the tall muscular figures, and unmistakeable features of the true Nat, or gypsy, are seen among the Bediyás, and when such persons are appealed to, they confess that either they, or their forefathers, came from Upper India. The Bediyá, however, is so cunning and so clever at giving answers to stop further enquiry, that what he says must be received with caution. Nevertheless, we know that early in this century the gypsies of Bengal followed the customs of their ancestors in the north-west, and had not in mass become converts to Islám. They regarded religion with indifference, and if a deity was worshipped in private, he was in public discarded for any idol or god adored by the villagers around.

Like the gypsies in all lands, the Bediyá carries in his features the stamp of a peculiar race, and from exposure to heat, glare, and privations, he is tanned of a darker brown than the Bengali artizan, and vies in swarthiness with the fisher Kaibartta, and rustic Chaṇḍál. It is rare to find a pretty girl or a handsome man, but the prevalent countenance is characteristic, and quite different from the usual Bengali cast of features. The profile is generally fine, the nose being straight, narrow, and often aquiline. The forehead is broad, sometimes intellectual. The figure is short, and the limbs less sinewy and graceful than among gypsies. The elders become corpulent, and rarely live to a green old age. Hard work and child-bearing soon efface the beauty of the young women, who are wrinkled hags at thirty. Men and women dress like ordinary Muhammadans, having laid aside the jackets and petticoats formerly worn. The men are remarkably lazy, and may often be seen enjoying a siesta, or a pipe, while the wife with a babe at her side is rowing, or punting the boat. The Bediyá boat never carries a sail, and as a rule there is only one rowlock, consequently only one person pulls at a time. Still this hard working, patient woman, is an affectionate wife, a sympathising and indulgent mother, who, without a thought for herself, devotes her whole time and attention to the recovery of a sick child, or fever-stricken husband. In the hospital at Dacca, the devotion of these women often excites admiration and respect, as they, with few exceptions, are the women who most frequently accompany their sick relatives, and, regardless of the depressing effects of a hospital ward, sit by their bedsides day and night, anticipating wants, and calming the restless patient.

The Bediyás, like their kinsfolk the gypsies, are often charged with being thieves, and whenever a robbery is committed near a Bediyá fleet, they are suspected. This evil reputation, however,

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is often taken advantage of by professional thieves, who trust to escape detection by casting suspicion on the Bediyá.

Various attempts have been made to wean the Bediyá from his unsettled habits, but only with partial success. Until the interior of the country is opened up by roads, the wandering trader will be welcomed, and his goods find a ready sale. At present his movements are uncertain, depending on the state of the rivers, and when the creeks get dry, the fleets disperse to suitable places, where a piece of land on the bank of a river is rented, a tent pitched, and the boats hauled on shore, and repaired. This encampment is occupied till the end of May, when the periodic rains enable them to set out on their annual circuit. Although the mass of Bediyás lead this life, a few go to other districts to collect shells, while those of settled habits return to their home, and cultivate land like the peasantry.

The boats of each Bediyá subdivision differ in some respects from all others, and by this difference can be distinguished at a distance. The boats of the Sámperia have the bow and stern raised, while those of the Shándárs are horizontal. The "Chhapar," or tilt, of boats belonging to the Mál, Sámperia, and Bázígar, is fastened outside the gunwale, while those of the Ba-bajiyá and Shándár are fastened inside, with mats hung outside to prevent water entering. The boats of the Gáyan again are merely canoes with raised wooden bulwarks, and an opening towards the stern. The roofs of all Bediyá boats are rounded, tapering towards one or both ends, and except in the case of the Gáyan, having two openings, one towards the bow, the other towards the stern.

Under the Muhammadan government, there was an officer who kept a register of all the tribes of wandering musicians and performers; according to some authorities they varied in number from eighteen to thirty-two sets. A tax, known as "Chandína Damdári," or "Bajantarí," was levied on them, being included under the head of "Sáir," or miscellaneous imposts. For the year 1777–8, the collection for the Dacca division, including Mymensingh and Silhet, amounted to rupees 2,761. 4. 0; namely, Damdárí, rupees 821. 4. 0; and Bajantarí, rupees 1,940. 1. 8. At a still earlier date the aggregate of the two taxes amounted to rupees 4,500 a-year.

The following are the seven divisions of Bediyás in Eastern Bengal:—

(*a*) Ba-bajiya,
(*b*) Bází-gar,
(*c*) Mál,
(*d*) Mír-shikár,
(*e*) Sámperia,
(*f*) Shándár,
(*g*) Rasia.

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(*a.*) Ba-bajiya.

The origin of this name is disputed, but it is probably derived from the Sanskrit Baṇijya, or Baṇij, trade. By their kinsmen they are called Lava and Paṭwa, the former in Sanskrit meaning a section, the latter a derivative of Paṭa, a screen.

The Ba-bajiya are pedlars. Their wares are very miscellaneous, consisting of gaudily painted wooden bracelets, waist-cords, tape, brass finger rings, nose rings, glass beads, wooden cups for oil, playing cards, looking glasses, sandal wood chains, and fish-hooks. They make voyages to Silhet, bringing back shells for lime, and pearls used in native medicine. Few sportsmen are bolder divers, and none excel them in spearing fish, especially mullet, with the harpoon.

The Ba-bajiya keep dancing monkeys, and, like the Bází-gars, teach their daughters acrobatic feats; while adults perform tricks of legerdemain with all the mysterious flourishes, and fluent talk, of the wizard tribe.

Though assuming to be Muhammadans, they chaunt songs in honour of Ráma and Lakshmaṇa, and exhibit painted canvas scrolls, representing the redoubtable deeds of Ráma and Rávaṇa, and the exploits of Hanuman.

The women have the reputation of being skilful in the treatment of infantile diseases, and in the removal of nervous and rheumatic pains. They occasionally tattoo, but are not so expert as the Natní.

(*b.*) Bází-gar.

The Bází-gar is generally called by Bengali villagers Kabútarí, from his tumbling like a pigeon (Kabútar), or Bhánu-matí, from the daughter of Vikramáditya of Ujjayana, the first person, according to Hindu tradition, who practised jugglery and conjuring. Another familiar name is Ḍorá-báz, or rope dancer.

The Bází-gar women and girls are the principal performers; the men play tricks with balls and knives. The girls are very supple, twisting and bending their bodies into most bewildering figures. One of the ordinary feats is fastening a buffalo's horn in front, climbing to the top of a pole on which a board is fixed, and resting on the point of the horn, spinning round at a rapid and giddy pace.

The women dabble in medicine, and prescribe for children ill with fever, or indigestion. A favourite remedy for the latter is the juice of the "Sem," or flat bean, mixed with lime made of the common shell, called Ṣambúka. They are also cunning rubbers for rheumatism, and dexterous curers of toothache.

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In Dacca the Bází-gars rarely live ashore, but in Farrídpúr they have become cultivators, and are being rapidly absorbed into the village population. These families are very thrifty, purchasing standing crops and disposing of them at a profit, or leasing a grove of date palms, and making money by the sugar extracted.

In physique the Bází-gars resemble the Nats and Kanjars of Hindustán, and they often admit that their immediate ancestors came from Gházípúr, or Upper India.

(*c.*) MÁL.

The name Mál is derived from the Sanskrit Mála, a hillman, but according to their own account they were wrestlers (Malla) at the court of the Dacca Nawábs, and gained the name from this profession. From their dexterity in extracting worms from teeth, the nickname Poṇkwah is often given.

Notwithstanding their roving habits, peculiar physiognomy, and characteristic figures, the Máls repudiate any connection with the Bediyás, but neighbours can recollect when relationship was readily admitted. At present Máls are with difficulty recognised. As a rule they are Mahájans, or bankers, never dealing in pedlar's wares, but advancing small sums on loan, rarely exceeding eight rupees, and on good security. The rate of interest charged is usually about fifty per. cent. per annum, but this exorbitant demand is less than that exacted by town bankers. The borrower has also to pay the writer of the bond a fee, called Taḥríri, calculated at the rate of two paisa for each rupee.

The Dacca Máls never keep snakes, and know nothing about the treatment of their bites. The women, however, pretend to a secret knowledge of simples, and of wild plants. They are also employed for cupping, for relieving obscure abdominal pains by friction, and for treating uterine diseases; but never for tattooing.

Mals do not intermarry with other Bediyás, or with Muhammadan villagers, and if a stranger asks in marriage a Mál maiden, he must leave his paternal home, relinquish his calling, and adopt the life and habits of a Bediyá. This custom, formerly insisted on by all Bediyás, has been gradually given up by families realizing the advantages of settled life, but its general disuse is still resented by the older members.

(*d.*) MÍR-SHIKÁR.

The Mír-Shikár, or Chiṛí-már, the smallest subdivision of

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Bediyás, only musters some hundred boats. They capture singing birds, "Bulbuls," and parrots with birdlime and the Sátnalí rod, or with nooses of horse-hair. Formerly game was killed with arrows, but these antiquated weapons have given place to the Mungír fowling piece.

The following animals captured by these hunters are sold for medicinal purposes, or for charms.

Ban-rahu, Manis, or scaly anteater. If bound on the arm its scales are reputed to cure palpitations of the heart.

Mahokha, or Pán-Korí, the common crow pheasant of India. Killed on a Tuesday or Saturday, its flesh cures enlargement of the spleen, and puerperal disorders.

Penchá, the spotted owlet of Jerdon. Its claws and droppings, pounded with betel-nut, are, according to Muhammadans, a very powerful and certain philtre.

Dáuk (*Gallinula phœnicura*). When dried its flesh is highly beneficial in rheumatism.

(*e.*) SÁMPERIA.

The Sámperia are the snake charmers of Bengal, who, like other Bediyás, huckster miscellaneous goods in the villages of the interior, and manufacture fish-hooks and such like articles.

The snakes usually exhibited are the Jáit,[1] or cobra; the light and dark varieties of the Ophiophagus Elaps, named by them Dudh-ráj and Mani-raj; the python; a beautiful whip snake, with red, black, and yellow spots, called "Udaya Sámp;" and a large brown snake with black stripes on its neck, known as "Ghár-bánká," from the singular way it bends before striking.

These snakes are caught in the forest. When one is seen the Sámperia pursues, and pins it to the ground with a forked stick. He then rapidly glides his hand along, and fixes his thumb over the first vertebra, the animal being rendered quite helpless. If the snake be a poisonous one, the fangs are barbarously torn out, but the poison "bag," the most profitable product of his dangerous trade, is carefully preserved. Snake poison is highly valued by Hindu physicians, being used in the treatment of diseases, and fetching in the market from fifteen to sixteen rupees a "bhari."[2]

Another valuable prize is the tick (Kilní), occasionally found on the hood of the black cobra, about which the most fabulous stories are told. One of these parasites fetches a large

[1] The common name for the Cobra de Capello is "Gohmaná," or "Gokhrá.' In Sanskrit it is "Krishna-Sarpa."

[2] A "bhari," or Sicca rupee, equals 179 grains.

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sum of money, as it is popularly believed to be a certain preservative against snake bites, and poisons in general.[1]

The cobra does not feed on snakes, but the Ophiophagus, as its name indicates, does. The Sámperia feeds his menagerie on fish, frogs, and mice. Domesticated snakes, with the exception of the python, rarely live more than five months in captivity, and never breed. Incredible as it may seem, snake charmers assert that all kinds cast their slough once a month. In a wild state this occurs once a year.

Sámperias have no specific for snake bite, but each man carries, as a charm, the root of the "Bhatráj," a forest creeper, but the specimen shown by one was a twig of the common wild vine (*Vitis Indica*). The popular belief is that the bud (málatí) of the "Bhatráj" is a specific, but the Sámperia deny this. When any one is bitten by a poisonous animal, the Sámperia follows a rational treatment. He ties a string round the limb, sucks the wound, bathes the extremity in hot water, and covers the bite with the leaves of the "Bhatráj." One of the company then recites Hindustání mantras, or incantations, which are usually utter gibberish.

The Sámperia are in great request for the due performance of the Manasa Devi festival, in the month of Srávan (July-Aug.), being engaged by Bráhmans to exhibit their collection, and make the snakes crawl in front of the idol. Manasa Devi still maintains her position as the patron deity of Sámperias, and no Mulla has as yet dared to cast her down from her pedestal.

When snakes are exhibited the Sámperia plays on a pipe, while his wife, or child, chaunts a monotonous Hindustání song, and irritates the reptile to strike by threats and shouts.

The Sámperia is also a sportsman. He tames jungle cocks to entrap wild ones, and the "Kora" (*Gallicrex cristatus*), a bird famous for its pugnacity. When he is in want of food he tethers it near a marsh, arranging a low screen with three movable leaves from which horse-hair nooses hang. The wild bird advancing to test the courage of his captive brother, gets entangled, and falls an easy prey to the Bediyá who is lying concealed in the brushwood.

The Sámperias, like other Bediyás, keep tame cormorants to drive fish into the net, for he is a great fisherman, although he never sells what he catches. When moored near a jungle he stalks deer, and shoots partridges, paddy-birds and egrets.

(*f.*) Shándár.

This is the most orderly and industrious of the Bediyá divi-

[1] Regarding the Sarpa-mani, Gara-mani, "snake gem," or carbuncle of romance writers, see "Asiatic Researches," xiii, 317–328.

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sions. Many have settled in Dayáganj, a suburb of Dacca, but others live in boats. Their name is derived from the Persian Shánah, a comb, corrupted into Hánah by the Bengalis. This comb, or more correctly reed, through which the warp threads pass, is in great demand by Tántís, and Juláhas, for their looms, as no other workmen can make them so cheaply and artistically. The framework of the comb (dhangi), is made of split bamboo, and the teeth (gaibi) of well seasoned wood from Kachár. The latter are fixed at equal distances apart by strong cotton thread. The sale of these combs obliges the Shándárs to visit villages where weavers reside, and Dacca where the Tántís work. This intercourse with the working classes has civilised them.

The Shándár, however, follows other trades. Like gypsies he is a "Manihár," or pedlar, buying beads and trinkets; making neck bands; purchasing waist-strings (Kardhaní) from the Paṭwá; and needles, thread, and tape, from the Mughuliyá shop; which are retailed in the villages.

The Shándárs are also expert divers, and, when anchored in suitable localities, gather the common bivalve shells (sípí), and sell them to the Chunarí, or lime burner. They also use the Sát-nali, or bamboo rod of seven joints, tipped with birdlime, catching "bulbuls," and other small birds. Like the Sámperia they keep tame "Koras," jungle cocks, and cormorants, and, if able, take out a gun license to shoot game.

Shándárs form the largest division of the Bediyás, often associating with the other septs, but never in a friendly manner. They have all become Muhammadans, wearing the skull cap and dress of the villagers, from whom they cannot be distinguished. As a rule Shándárs are short, muscular men, more communicative, and less suspicious of strangers, than the ordinary Bengali peasant. Many of the race peculiarities have been lost, but Muhammadans banish them from society, and refuse to intermarry, to eat, and to pray with them. They seldom speak, or understand, Hindustání, and Bengali is the spoken language.

A class called Gáyan, literally a singer, has separated from the Shándár, but is already disappearing in the ranks of the village Muhammadans. The Gáyan, instructed by teachers, believe they are descended from Jihád Gáyan, who accompanied Sháh Jalál in his conquest of Silhet, and state that they emigrated from that country in covered canoes, differing in build from those inhabited by other Bediyás.

The Gáyan is usually a peasant, and when absent from home the wife watches the crops and tends the cattle. Any relationship with other Bediyás is warmly repudiated, for which reason the Farazí sect sometimes concedes to them the rights and

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privileges of other Mussulmáns, and this concession has transformed these vagrants into rigid Puritans. The Gáyan women are secluded, and the other Bediyás are reproached for indelicacy in allowing the women to wander about unveiled and unprotected.

The Gáyan sing Bengali songs in public, and the musical instruments in use are the violins, called "Sárangí" and "Behlá."

(*g.*) Rasia.

A few gangs of this subdivision are now and then met with in Dacca, but they are more numerous in Pubna. Their boats are of curious construction, being only half covered over, while the tilt is cocoon, or bottle-shaped, tapering gradually towards the stern, where there is a small round opening through which a man can with difficulty crawl. These Bediyás work with zinc, which is bought in pigs, melted, and run into moulds. From the similarity in colour of zinc and mercury (Rasa), the division has derived its distinctive name from the latter metal.

The Rasias make anklets, bracelets, and collars for the neck (hanslí), which are worn by all Hindu and Muhammadan females of the lower orders.

At their homes the Rasias are cultivators, and having completely amalgamated with the village Muhammadans are strict Farazís. Their standing, however, is so precarious, that prolonged absence from home, or a manifest partiality for boat life, is punished by expulsion from society.

When afloat the Rasia shows the same fondness for animals as other Bediyás, keeping a caged "Mainá," or "Kaim" (purple coot), for amusement or sport; while cocks and hens wander at will throughout the boat.

BERUA.

The Beṛua, or Pátr-Beṛua, caste is an offshot of the Chaṇḍál tribe, with the members of which they still eat and drink, but do not intermarry. Their name is derived from the Hindi Beṛá, a raft of bamboos or reeds, used for catching mullet. It is the well known habit of this fish to jump over any obstacle it meets with in water. The Beṛuas at full tide throw a screen across a creek, and on the surface of the water below it they moor another. As soon as the mullet encounters the first and finds no opening, it leaps over and is caught on the second. The fish are sold in the market, but no Beṛua will cast a net, or earn a livelihood as the Kaibarttas do.

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In Dacca the Beṛuas occupy about five hundred houses, and are generally cultivators. The headman is called Pátr,[1] and the whole caste belongs to one gotra, the Kaṣyapa. The connection with the Chaṇḍál tribe is so intimate that the same Purohit officiates for both.

BHÚINHÁR BRÁHMANS.

A considerable number of these cultivating Bráhmans, of doubtful parentage, reside in Eastern Bengal, acting as policemen, clubmen (láṭhíal), or watchmen. They generally come from Gorakhpúr, or Ghazípúr, and after an absence of a few years return to their homes and families in Hindustan.

The popular idea is, that the Bhúinhárs are descended from a Bráhman father and a Kahár woman, but this origin would give them no right to the rank of Bráhman. The story told by themselves of their degradation is as follows. Bhoja Rájah of Bhojpúr, a great wizard, prepared a feast for the Bráhmans, but none attended, so he sent for Bhṛigu Ṛishí, then residing at Hájípúr in the Chapra district, who also disobeyed the summons on the plea of being engaged in preparing his fields for sowing. Owing to their cultivating land, as their ancestor did, his descendants have been degraded, never having any "jajmán," or clients, never accepting alms, and never eating or drinking with any other Bráhmanical order.

Their Guru is always a Kanaujiya: their Purohit a Sarvaria Bráhman.

They affirm that Rájputs make obeisance to them, and in return receive benediction. The Bengali Bráhmans again, refuse to eat rice, but partake of púrí (buttered scones), sweetmeats, and "khichṛí" prepared by them.

Among themselves the designations Bhúinhár, Gautam, and Ṭhákúr are regarded as synonymous; but the ordinary titles are Ráí, Singh, Pánḍe, Tiwárí, and Chaube; whilst Rájah, and Mahárájah appellations discarded by all the higher orders, are not infrequent.

BHÚÍNMÁLÍ.

The Bhúínmálí is identical with the Háṛí of other parts of Bengal, and in Dinájpúr the names are used synonymously,

[1] Pátra, a competent person.

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while the caste is generally considered as the remnant of a Hinduized aboriginal tribe which was driven into Bengal by the Aryans, or the persecuting Muhammadans.

In Eastern Bengal he is sometimes called "Siddhí-putra," after a Muní of that name. In the Census Rolls of 1872 the Bhúínmálí and Hárí are entered under separate headings among semi-Hinduized aborigines. There has evidently been a difference of opinion among returning officers on this point, for in Dacca 1,954 Háris are returned, although a prolonged search in all corners of the district has failed to discover any persons acknowledging that designation, and 7,267 Bhúínmálís, an aggregate below the actual number. Next to Dacca the districts with the largest settlements are Tipperah (5,522), Rangpúr (3,771), Maldah (2,109), Noakhally (1,943), Farrídpúr (1,836), and Silhet (1,825).

The Dacca Bhúínmálís assert that they were originally Súdras degraded in consequence of the following absurd incident: Párvatí obtained permission from her husband, Ṣiv, to give a feast to her worshippers on earth. All castes were assembled at the entertainment, and in the midst of the enjoyment a luckless Bhúínmálí was overheard saying, "If I had such a beautiful woman in my house, I would cheerfully perform the most menial offices for her." Ṣiv did not allow the speaker to retract what he had said, but gave him a beautiful wife and made him her sweeper. In confirmation of this legend a Bengali proverb defines the Bhúínmálí as the only Hindu ever degraded for love of garbage.

The Bhúínmálí caste has two great subdivisions, the Baṛá-bhágiyá and Chhotá-bhágiyá, who never intermarry, or hold social intercourse with each other. The former are chiefly cultivators, musicians, and palkí bearers; the latter scavengers, looking down with contempt on the Dôm, Mihtar, and Halál-khors, who, after work, enter their houses without bathing, and allow their females to labour at the same offensive trade.

At Saráíl, in Tipperah, Bhúínmálís keep swine, but these recreants are not acknowledged as brethren. In certain villages the Bhúínmálí has ceased to be a professional musician and become a chaukídár, or watchman. No member of the caste ever keeps a shop, as he would have no customers, and never trades, as he has no capital.

A large section of the Bhúínmálí caste is known as Mitra Sení Beháras, tracing their descent from Mitra Sen, the reputed son, or relative, of Ballál Sen, and claiming to be the original bearers of Bengal. They cultivate the soil, and are in great request as household servants by Hindu families. Although the same Bráhman officiates, the cultivating Bará-bhágiyá despises the

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cultivating Mitra Sení, and declines to eat with them. These palanquin bearers, again, will not carry torches, and look down upon those who do.

Although the caste has split up into divisions, the Bhúínmálí is properly one of the village servants, employed in cutting down brushwood, repairing footpaths, sweeping the outside of the Zamíndár's house, removing carcasses from the village, and preparing the "Marocha," or marriage area, for doing which he receives one rupee, if the marriage is that of a village boy, and eight anas if that of a girl. He is likewise the Mash'alchí engaged to carry the torch at Hindu weddings. A Bhúínmálí sweeper never enters a Hindu house to pollute it; but a maiden, called Dásí, or Chhokrí, is employed to sweep the floors of rooms and passages.

The Bhúínmálí also levels the space where the Śráddha is held, constructs the small shed in which the votive offerings are placed, and, when a sacrifice is to be made, smears the ground with cowdung. If the victim is killed in the morning the flesh is distributed among Bráhmans and clean Śúdras; but if it is a Sandhyá, or evening sacrifice, everything, including the cloth by which the animal is bound, becomes the perquisite of the Bhúínmálí.

The Bhúínmálí, besides, prepares and plasters the mound on which the Vastú Pujah is celebrated, receiving the ram as his remuneration, and, whenever a new house is built, he smears cowdung over the sides only, as he would lose caste if he touched the interior. Hindus of all castes smear the inside and steps of their own houses, but never those of others. The Bhúínmálí is the only native who will bedaub a strange house.

The gotras among the Bhúínmálí of Dacca are Paráśara and Aliman, the latter being only found along the banks of the old Bráhmaputra. The caste has a degraded Bráhman as Purohit, and the washerman and barber are members of the caste. The Bhúínmálí generally worship Krishna, and celebrate all the popular Hindu festivals. Along the Lakhya "Káwaj," who is probably the same as Kwájah Khizr, is invoked, as is also Pír Badr. Like the Hindu and Muhammadan peasantry generally, the Bhúínmálí abstains from work during the three days known as "Ambuváchí," which last from the tenth to the thirteenth of the waning moon of Ásárh (June–July) when the earth is believed to be impure, and no Hindu can dig, plough, or even touch it.

Although most anxious to represent themselves as Śúdras, by apeing the prejudices of the higher ranks, the Bhúínmálí are contemned, and obliged to live on the outskirts of villages apart from the Hindus, and to perform any menial work that is required of them. Like other low castes the Bhúínmálí nowa-

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days shudders at the idea of eating pork, although it is within the recollection of men still living, that he was very partial to it. Until the last twenty years he was very friendly with the Chaṇḍál, interchanging visits, and often dining with him, but lately an estrangement has parted them, and the Bhúínmálí treats his former friend as an inferior being, declining to eat with or even work for him. It is difficult to understand the cause of this coldness which has sprung up, but it was probably the result of a vague assertion of superiority on the part of one or other. The Bhúínmálí still works for many castes as low as the Chaṇḍál, and does not feel dishonoured by labouring for the Doí, or the Muhammadan peasant, although he does by toiling for the Jogí weaver.

It is at Hindu weddings that the Bhúínmálí musicians are engaged, creating a most horrid noise with their pipe (sarnáe), and drum (ḍhakká); but a feeling among them indicates that before long musicians will be expelled from the genteel classes. Widows never remarry, but a few years ago it was the universal custom. The Bhúínmálí female is now and then employed as a midwife, or a domestic servant. She is ceremonially unclean for thirty days after parturition as with Śúdras, but it is a curious circumstance that the "Chhaṭhí" ceremony is performed on the ninth day, and not on the sixth, as the word signifies.

BIND, BHIND, BINDU.

The Bind is a semi-Hinduized aboriginal race, widely scattered throughout India. Buchanan was of opinion that Oudh was their original home, but at the present day they are dispersed throughout the north-western provinces, Oudh, and the Gangetic valley. In 1865[1] it was computed that the Bind caste numbered 63,501 individuals in the north-western provinces, and in 1872 the census returns show a total of 10,563 in Bengal, of whom 6,002 belonged to Maldah, 1,100 to Pubna, 1,017 to Nadiyá, and only 153 to Dacca. Settlements of Binds are, however, found along the left bank of the Padma, but less frequently than on the right, or Farrídpúr, side. Originally residents of the Benares district, they were driven by the great famine of 1770 to seek shelter in the fertile delta, which has ever since been their home.

It is extremely doubtful if the Ben of Oudh, generally a musician, is the same as Bin of Arrah, who works as a Beldár, and manufactures saltpetre. In Bhágalpúr the Binds, or Beldárs,

[1] "Supplemental Glossary," i, 287.

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as they are usually called, fish, dig, cultivate the soil, hunt, and act as drug collectors. Mr. Sherring,[1] on the other hand, classifies the Bind, or Bin, with the Núniya caste. In Dacca, again, the Bind recognize three subdivisions, Jutaut Binds, Nún Binds, and Bin. The first is the most aristocratic, while those belonging to the second are degraded, from working as palanquin bearers, manufacturers of salt (nún), diggers, and, it is said, gravediggers. Representatives of the Bin division are not met with in Eastern Bengal.

In Gházípúr the caste is reckoned clean, while in Arrah it has gained, according to native ideas, an enviable position, being employed by the sacred order to carry water in Bráhmanical vessels without causing defilement. Binds in Bengal are unclean, and their brethren in the north-west repudiate any relationship with them. For this reason the Bengali Bind often finds it difficult to procure a wife from the small expatriated communities along the Padma.

A Daṣnámí Gosáin periodically visits the Dacca Binds, acting as their Guru, while a degraded Kanaujiya Bráhman officiates as Purohit. Many of the Bengali Binds belong to the Panch Píriyá sect, others worship Ṣiv, and at the Mahábalí festival sacrifice a ram instead of a he-goat as is usual. At the Ganga Púja a swine is offered to Jalka Deví, the popular goddess of the Chamárs. The patron deity, however, of all Binds is Káṣi Bába, about whom the following childish story is told. A mysterious epidemic was carrying off the herds on the banks of the Ganges, and the ordinary expiatory sacrifices were ineffectual. One evening a clownish Ahír, on going to the river, saw a figure rinsing its mouth from time to time, and making an unearthly sound with a conch shell. The lout concluding that this must be the demon causing the epidemic, crept up and clubbed the unsuspecting bather. Káṣí Náth was the name of the murdered Bráhman, and as the cessation of the murrain coincided with his death, the low Hindustani castes have ever since regarded Káṣí Bába as the maleficent spirit that sends disease among their cattle. Nowadays he is propitiated by the following curious ceremony. As soon as an infectious disease breaks forth the village cattle are massed together, and cotton seed sprinkled over them. The fattest and sleekest animal being singled out is severely beaten with rods. The herd, scared by the noise, scamper off to the nearest shelter followed by the scape bull, and by this means, it is thought, the murrain is stayed.

Like all up-country boatmen who visit Bengal, the Binds invoke Pír Badr, whenever a squall threatens. "Pír Badr!

[1] "Hindu Tribes and Castes," p. 348.

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tákya ek nazar! Pír Badr!" "bestow one glance!" is the ordinary ejaculation.

Karámat 'Alí and the Farazí Maulavís have of late years converted many of these outcast Binds, but the village Muhammadans will not as yet associate with them. These converts are usually styled by the peasantry "Chaylí," from the Bengali word for the Beṛá, or fish trap.

Binds in the upper provinces are commonly addressed by the title Ráwat, but in Bengal Chaudharí is their only designation.

Hindustání Binds are enterprising traders, often visiting Bengal during the cold seasons, with cargoes of wheat, pulse, and "grám." Bengali Binds lead an irregular life. Some cultivate the soil; others kill mullet with the harpoon, or catch them with "Sirkí" screens, like the Beṛua. Many are cunning sportsmen, and during December and January net great numbers of wild fowl and snipe. After the harvest the Binds wander about the country digging up the stores of rice accumulated by field rats in their burrows. From four to six pounds of grain are usually found, but even this quantity is sometimes exceeded. It is said that the Binds feast on the rats, but, as they remark, this would lessen the next year's profit, they carefully avoid injuring them. Another occupation is cutting tamarisk (jháú) on the sandbanks of the Padma, and selling it for firewood. By them are made the best mud brasiers, or Chúlhás, used on board all native boats for cooking.

Finally, Binds freely indulge in spirit drinking, and are very partial to pork, when it can be procured.

BRÁHMAN.

(*a.*) RÁṚHÍ.

The origin of the Bengali Bráhmans is hidden in obscurity. It is, however, generally traced to the introduction of five Bráhmans from Kanauj by Ádisúra, King of Gauṛ, about A.D. 900; but there are grounds for believing that the Vaidika and Sapt-Ṣatí were earlier immigrants, and it is probable, as Dr. Hunter thinks, that the first Aryan settlers in Bengal claimed to be the aristocracy of the new country, and as a natural consequence to be Bráhmans, an idea inseparable (in the Aryan mind) from the rank of an aristocracy. This supposition acquires additional probability from the surviving tradition that Ádisúra applied to the Rájah of Kanauj for priests capable

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of performing certain Vedic ceremonies, as the false Bráhmans of Bengal were incapable, through ignorance, of doing so.

The names, and gotras, of the five Kanauj Bráhmans were :—

Bhúttanáráyana	of the	Sáṇḍilya Gotra
Daksha	„	Kaṣyapa „
Chhándara	„	Vátsya „
Ṣríharsa	„	Bharadvája „
Vedagarbha	„	Savarṇa „

Of the personal history of these men we know little,[1] but it is related that they intermarried with their Bengali neighbours, and the issue became the progenitors of the Varendra tribe, while the children by their Hindustání wives became the founders of the Ráṛhí. The Varendra Bráhmans, on the other hand, maintain that they are the legitimate branch, the Ráṛhí the illegitimate.

During the two following centuries the Bráhmans increased so fast by births, and the influx of other settlers from Hindustan, that Ballál Sen, in the eleventh century, found the Ráṛhí Bráhams domiciled in fifty-six Gáins, or communes, isolated from many Sapta-Ṣatí, Vaidika, and low caste Bráhmans, who in contradistinction were designated Nau-gáins, or outsiders, from residing beyond the limits of the communes.[2]

The exact number of descendants of the five Kanaujuja Bráhmans, who were raised to pre-eminence by the reforms of Ballál Sen, is a subject of lasting dispute between the Ráṛhí and Banga Ghaṭaks. The following particulars derived from the Banga genealogists must therefore be received *cum grano*.

Ballál Sen, under Bráhmanical influence, it is supposed, organised a Samáchára, or enquiry, to ascertain which families possessed special religious qualities, entitling them to the first rank in the sacred order, and to classify the rest, according as they had lost one or other important faculty, in subordinate ranks. The nine personal endowments qualifying for the highest position were :—

1. Áchár, faith in the performance of appropriate duties,
2. Vinaya, modesty, or moral training,
3. Vidyá, learning,
4. Pratishṭha, devotion in consecrating a temple,
5. Tírthadarṣana, the regular visitation of holy places,
6. Nishṭha, piety,
7. Avrittí, observance of legal marriages,
8. Tápasa, devotion,
9. Dána, liberality.

[1] Fragments of moral poems attributed to them, and called Pancha-ratní, are still extant. A translation is to be found in the "New Asiatic Miscellany," vol. i, p. 62. Calcutta, 1789.

[2] "Orissa," by W. W. Hunter, vol. i, p. 249.

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Nineteen families found to have preserved untarnished these nine cardinal virtues were enrolled as the eight Mukhya, or superior, Kulins; families who had neglected Áchár were included in fourteen classes, called Gauṇa, or secondary, Kulins; while the large majority, though regular students of the Vedas, having lost Avrittí, and formed alliances with families of ignoble birth, were divided into thirty-four Ṣrotriyá[1] septs.

These classes of Mukhya, Gauṇa, and Ṣrotriyá were honorary distinctions attached to a hereditary hierarchy, who received from the reigning monarch grants of villages and arable lands. Further, no personal misdemeanour could deprive them of the privileges of their order; but to ensure a pure and aristocratic race it was enacted, that an unequal, or irregular, marriage caused loss of prestige, and forfeiture of rank.

The eight Mukhya Kulína families were:—

Vandya (Banarjí),	Putitunda,
Chatta (Chatarjí),	Gánguli,
Mukhuti (Mukharjí),	Kánjilála,
Goshála,	Kundagrámí.

These names were taken from the village, or commune, where the greatest number of approved reputation were found.

Of the inhabitants of Vandya, only six families were enrolled, namely those of Gáhlana, Maheṣvara, Devala, Vámana, Îṣána, and Makaranda. The descendants of the Kanaujiya Bráhman Daksha were found residing in the village of Chatta, and five families, namely, Bahurúp, Sucha, Aravinda, Haláyudha, and Vángála, were deemed worthy of admission. The Mukhutí returned two families, Utsáha and Garuḍa; the Goshála one, Ṣira; the Putitunda one, Govardhanáchárya; the Gángulí one, Ṣisa; the Kánjílala two, Kanu and Katúhala; and the Kundagramí one, Roshákara.

The fourteen Gauṇa, or secondary, Kulins were:—

Dirdhángí,	Keṣarí,
Páriha,	Ghanteswarí,
Kulabhí,	Dinṣáí,
Poḍárí,	Pítamundí,
Pipalaí,	Mahinta,
Haḍa,	Guḍa,
Rái,	Gaḍagadí.

The status of these families was fixed in accordance with their moral characters. Four were inscribed as "Siddha," or perfected; seven as "Ṣuddha," or pure; and three, including

[1] Literally a Bráhman versed in the study of the Vedas.

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Pipalaí and Dinṣáí, as "Káshṭha," excellent, or "Arí." The designation "Arí," or enemy, was given because a Kulin marrying a daughter of one of them was disgraced.

The thirty-four Gáins of Ṣrotriyás were as follows:—

Páladhí,	Púshalí,
Pákaḍási,	Ákáṣa,
Simaláyí,	Palasáyí,
Vápuli,	Koyárí,
Vhurishṭháta,	Sáharí,
Kulakulí,	Bhattáchárya,
Vatavyala,	Sáteṣvarí,
Kuṣárí,	Náyerí,
Seyaka,	Dáyí,
Kusuma,	Párihala,
Ghoshalí,	Siyárí,
Mashachataka,	Siddhala,
Vasuyárí,	Puṇsika,
Karála,	Nandígrámí,
Anvulí,	Kánjárí,
Tailavatí,	Sunalála,
Múlagrámí,	Válí.

According to some authorities, the Ṣrotriyá were the descendants of the Kanaujiya Bráhmans by Sapta-Ṣati wives, being esteemed inferior to their fathers, but superior to their mothers, maternal grandsires, and to all relatives of the Sapta-Ṣati class. Again, the Banga Ghaṭaks give three more Ṣrotriyá gáins, namely Ghanteṣvarí, Bhatteṣvarí, and Dígál; but the Ráṛhí Ghaṭaks do not recognise more than thirty-four in all.

Such was the classification of Ballál Sen, rendered, it was thought, complete by stringent laws regarding marriage. It was the prerogative of the Gauṇa and Ṣrotriyá to provide wives for the Mukhya Kulins, and to get wives for themselves from their own class equals. The marriage of a daughter into a good Kulin family raised, in public estimation, the character of the father's household, whence arose the strange custom, known as Kula-gotra, by which the reputation of a family depended on the daughter's suitable marriage.

As years rolled on, and families became extinct, the difficulty of obtaining an unexceptionable husband immensely increased. Kulin fathers accordingly often gave away their daughters to Gauṇa, Ṣrotriyá, and even to Sapta-Ṣatí families, thus forming the "Vaṇṣaja"[1] class. Again, the daughters were often married to the sons of Vaṇṣaja parents, in which case the character and dignity of the family were forfeited, and it became "Sukṛiti-bhanga," from whom were descended in the next generation the

[1] Literally, belonging to the family.

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Dvipurusha, in the third the Tripurusha, and in the fourth the Cháturpurusha, after which, as among the Varendras, the branch was blended in the Vaṇṣaja class. It was, moreover, the practice in the various grades for the daughters of the lower lineage to marry with their cousins of the elder branch. If the Sukṛiti-Bhanga Bráhman married into a Kulin family it was dishonoured and degraded; or, if a Kulin married a Vaṇṣaja maiden, similar results followed, and he became a Bhanga, or ruined, Bráhman.

With the Muhammadan invasion of A.D. 1199, the Hindu Empire was overthrown, and the artificial structure of Hindu society underwent a complete revolution. Kulins sold their family rank and honour for money; they increased the number of their wives, without regard to the respectability of the families from which they came, and they enhanced their demands as the supply of suitable wives diminished. But it was not only the selfish and unprincipled behaviour of the Bráhmans in the matter of marriage that lowered their characters in popular estimation. The system from its birth bore the seeds of decay, and was doomed to certain destruction. Purity of life, piety, knowledge, and sympathy with the lower orders, were disregarded, or discouraged, and the sacred order sank demoralized beneath a load of vices, unpitied by the people.

A fortunate thing would it have been for Bengal if the scandal had been swept away, and a radical reform introduced on sounder and more equitable principles; but the evils were increased and the vices diffused among a larger circle, by the classification of an obscure Ghaṭak. This rise and unquestioned influence of a Bráhman reformer is one of the most puzzling incidents in the domestic annals of Bengal. His rank and position were plebeian, yet he acquired such a commanding station as to dictate his own terms to the proudest Kulin, and enforce their observance on the most contumacious.

Tradition has preserved a few events of his career, but none of them indicate the policy by which he overcame the discontent and disobedience of a haughty and still dominant oligarchy.

Deví Vara, a Jessore Ghaṭak, lived ten generations after Ballál Sen, in the fourteenth century.[1] He is said to have been a man of eccentric habits, with a strong, though wayward, will. As a young man he visited Kámákhyá, and became a Siddhavák, or a person who had only to express a wish and it was fulfilled. On returning to Bengal he wandered about the country, like any demented Bairágí, shouting out "Akulam! Akulam!" the Kul, or family honour, is gone! It is probable that this "antic

[1] Another account states that he lived twelve generations ago.

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disposition" was assumed, for it is a popular belief that his subsequent classification of the Bráhmans turned upon the hospitality and favour shown to him during his peregrinations. A story in point is narrated of him. One day entering the house of Yogiṣvara Paṇḍit, head of the Kharḍadaha Mel, who was from home, the inmates treated him with curt civility.

Incensed by their rudeness, he began shouting "Akulam! Akulam!" and Yogiṣvara became an outcast. On returning home Deví Vara was implored to remove the curse, but as this was impossible, he compensated the sufferer by the following prophecy, worthy of Thomas the Rhymer.

"When Ṣaṣamṛiga[1] returns home, when the sky produces fruit, when the barren woman conceives, then, and then only, shall Yogiṣvara lose his Kul."

The following story is told to explain why a good Bráhman like Deví Vara left no children. At a great meeting of Bráhmans convened to reorganise the order, Deví Vara was tormented by his Guru, Prabhákara, to explain why he was born a Ghaṭak, and not a Kulin Bráhman. Provoked beyond endurance, Deví Vara exclaimed "Prabhákara is Akulam!" The Guru retorted, "The house of Deví Vara shall not remain, he shall be 'ultimus suorum.'"

The reorganising scheme of Deví Vara was confined to the Ráṛhí Kulíns of the Mukhya grade, and did not embrace the Gauṇa or Ṣrotriyá, who had already united to form a homogeneous order with certain trivial limitations regarding precedence. In conformity with the new classification the Kulin Bráhmans were included in three grades:—

Svabháva, or original Kulins,
Bhanga,
Vaṇṣaja.

Furthermore, a most important innovation was introduced, in the creation of thirty-six Mels, or septs, named after the home or chief man of a family.

The thirty-six Mels were:—

Phuliya,	Vijáya Pandit,
Kharḍadaha,	Chádáí,
Saivvanandi,	Madhái,
Ballabhí,	Bidyádhari,
Ṣurai,	Párihal,
Áchárya Ṣekhari,	Ṣrí Rangabhattí,
Pandit Ratni,	Máladharakhání,
Bangala,	Kákumví,
Gopala Ghaṭakí,	Harí Majumdárí,
Cháyanarendrí,	Ṣrí Bandhaní,

[1] The constellation Lepus.

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Pramadaní,	Bhairava Ghaṭaki,
Daṣaratha Ghaṭaki,	Áchambita,
Ṣubharajakhání,	Dharádharí,
Naḍiya,	Válí,
Rayamelá,	Rághava Ghosálí,
Bhattarághavi,	Ṣungosarvvanandí,
Dehátí,	Súdánanda Khání,
Chayí,	Chandravatí.

The cardinal point in the new reorganisation was the law restricting the marriages of Kulins to their own Mel. This limitation led to evils far greater than those of previous times. Claims of superiority were advanced and resisted, and families of the highest rank were disgraced, and their places filled by plebeian houses. Whether this innovation was the work of Deví Vara, or introduced subsequently, is uncertain, but the monstrous absurdity known as Páltí-Prakṛití[1] was intended to restrain the social anarchy. By this contrivance marriages in certain corresponding families of equal rank were enjoined, and any violation of the law was visited by dishonour and degradation. For example, the Mukhuti family were obliged to marry their sons to Chatarjí daughters, and the Chatarjí sons to Mukhuti daughters. When it happened that the Mukhuti had only one son, and the Chatarjí ten daughters, the former was compelled to marry the whole ten, or all remained spinsters. The Kulin boy with hundreds of rich offers of marriage must decline all, until he had fulfilled this obligation. Again, the Bhanga, Vaṇṣaja, and Ṣrotriyá septs were in eager quest of Kulin husbands to preserve their reputation, and as the total number of Kulins, even before the absorption of the Gauṇa, never equalled the numbers of the Ṣrotriyá, the competition was great. When the Kulins became still further reduced by the loss of many, who departed from amongst them, and formed the Bhanga and Vaṇṣaja, the competition became extravagant. The polygamy of Kulins was countenanced, and prescribed. They had not only to marry a maiden of their own Mel, but also a Ṣrotriyá wife, and as their pecuniary value rose, the temptation to live by the wages of polygamy became irresistible.

At the present day the classification of Deví Vara is preserved, and the evils of the system have grown so intolerable that legislative interference is solicited by enlightened Hindus. Kulin girls, for want of husbands, are living and dying unmarried, being known as Yamavara, or wedded to Pluto. Svabháva Kulins, yielding to the attractions of a Paṇa, or marriage fee, of two thousand rupees, are breaking their Kul, and marrying Vaṇṣaja girls, who are immediately resigned to the charge of

[1] From the Sanskrit Pálana, guarding, cherishing, and Prakṛiti, nature.

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their parents; but as the Paṇa diminishes ten per cent. with each new wife, it is no uncommon thing for the fee to fall to fifteen or even ten rupees.

As soon as a Svabháva Kulin is degraded to the rank of a Sukṛiti-Bhanga, he adopts matrimony as a profession, and finds no limit to the number of suitors for his hand from among Bhanga and Ṣrotriyá families. As his Haram enlarges from a few up to hundreds, the Bhanga and Ṣrotriyá, ruined by the large marriage fees they have paid, and by the paucity of marriageable girls of their own class, live and die unmarried.

The honour of marrying one's daughter to a Bhanga Kulin is so highly valued in Eastern Bengal, that as soon as a boy is ten years of age, his parents, or guardians, begin discussing his marriage, and before he is twenty he frequently becomes the husband of many wives, of ages varying from five to fifty. The bride, unless of a rich and influential family, rarely sees her husband after marriage, and thus a wide field is opened for adultery and immorality. In a list drawn up by Babú Ubhaya Chunder Dás, the names of two Kulins in Eastern Bengal, each of whom possesses a hundred wives, are given; two with sixty; three with fifty; and three with thirty. This gentleman further asserts, that each Kulin has a register containing the names of the villages where their fathers-in-law reside, and that every cold season he makes a connubial tour, visiting each wife, and after fleecing the foolish parent of as much money as he can, transports himself to another village where he does the same thing. At the end of his tour he returns to his home, living in ease and sensuality until another marriage rouses him to temporary activity.

It is only among Bráhmans of the Ráṛhí Srení that this infamous system exists, for the Varendra Kulins, unreformed by Deví Vara, are said to have as few wives as any other order of high caste Hindus.

The amount of immorality developed by Kulinism is incalculable. Young wives deserted by their husbands, and often living in penury, children brought up without a father, and parents madly ruining their heirs to obtain a licentious polygamous husband for the daughter, is a picture without a redeeming point. Within the last ten years various petitions have been presented to Government urging the necessity of blotting out this hideous crime, but as yet no legislative action has been taken. The two main obstacles to reform are, the opposition of the Ghaṭaks, an influential body, whose existence depends on the continuance of the system, and the selfishness of the Kulins themselves, who prefer certain wealth and ease to the precariousness of a learned, or the exertion of a mercantile, life.

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It is a remarkable fact, that in spite of inbreeding, sloth, and debauchery, and notwithstanding the damp and malarious climate of their homes, the Bráhmanical race of Eastern Bengal has preserved its physique and talents, impaired, it is impossible to doubt, but still on a par with the higher Bengali castes. Sanskrit is still their favourite language, and the chief families can read enough to guide them through the intricate ceremonials of their worship. Few Kulin boys attend the more advanced Government schools, as the obligations of the Mel system call them away while still young ; but boys are either instructed in village schools, or at home by a Paṇḍit.

The tedious ceremonies connected with the marriage of a Raṛhí Kulin are for the most part correctly detailed by Mr. Ward, but there are several points requiring mention which the vicissitudes of the last seventy years have effected. Before any steps can be taken to marry a Kulin, the Ghaṭak must ascertain first, whether the girl has at any time been engaged, or divorced ; second, whether she is younger than the bridegroom elect ; third, whether her name differs from his mother's, and fourth, whether her Gotra is different from his. Owing to the extinction of corresponding Mels a Kulin is nowadays permitted to violate the second and third enactments.

A Kulin father, again, can only preserve his Kul intact by one of three ways :—

1. By giving his legitimate daughter to one of equal rank.
2. By making an effigy of his child with Kuṣa grass (Kuṣa-Kanyá), and giving it in marriage to a Kulin male of equal rank.
3. By saying before Ghaṭak witnesses "I would give my daughter, if I had one, to you," addressing a Kulin present, and by making a Tilak, or symbol of marriage, on his forehead.

This last rite, called Káraṇa, still observed in Eastern Bengal, but fast falling into disuetude in other parts of the country, was lately celebrated by a Zamíndár of Mymensingh, who paid twenty-two thousand rupees to the Bráhmans for permission.

Many Mels having died out, a son of a family whose Páltí-Prakṛiti is dead, must marry the only daughter of a widow ; while in the case of an only daughter of a Kulin widow, for whom no eligible husband is procurable, the mother may marry her to a Ṣrotriyá, and accept "paṇa" without endangering the family prestige.

In Dacca the Kulin bridegroom is married from the bride's house, while the Ṣrotriyá parents bring their daughter to the bridegroom's village, and she is married in the house of a friend.

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The marriages of Kulins are invariably arranged by Ghaṭaks; those of Ṣrotriyás usually by relatives; but as a Ṣrotriyá family is dishonoured if it does not marry a daughter to a Kulin, the Ghaṭaks must negotiate with his parents.

From the foregoing remarks it is obvious that the position of a Kulin parent with a large family of daughters is a most unenviable one. The Ṣástras insist on the early marriages of girls, and censure those who are dilatory. The Kulin therefore, must either pay a large "paṇa" to a Kulin boy, or, if too poor to do so, bribe an octogenarian, or dying Kulin, already possessing a bevy of wives, to condescend to marry his daughter just come of age. Immorality is the natural result, and the number of illegitimate children in Kulin villages is believed to be excessive. The illegitimate son of a Bráhman woman by a Ṣúdra, is facetiously known as Kṛishna-paksha,[1] and generally becomes a Vairágí, while the bastard of a widow by a Kulin is secretly adopted, and the breath of scandal hushed. The occurrence of such an event in a Ṣrotriyá family, however, cannot be concealed, and its effects are disastrous to its respectability.

Ráṛhi Bráhmans have sadly fallen from the standard of purity enjoined by the Bráhmans of Mathurá and Brindában. In accordance with the Ṣástras any Bráhman may accept alms, educate boys in the sacred language, or duties, and instruct mankind generally in virtue and morality. All other occupations are sinful. In Eastern Bengal, however, Bráhmans take service as domestic servants, chiefly as cooks, and do most kinds of husbandry, such as cutting corn and brushwood; but holding the plough, though occasionally resorted to by the very poor, is regarded as derogatory, but does not entail loss of caste. Bengali Bráhmans are as strict as their Hindustání brethren in expelling individuals found selling milk, ghí, iron, lac, or common salt. A Bráhman, moreover, officiating as a temple priest (Pújárí) in a shrine erected and endowed by one of the Nava-Ṣákha, or a Bráhman Devala, living on oblations offered to an idol, is at once expelled. The profession of a physician was formerly abhorrent to the priesthood; but nowadays many highly educated graduates of the Calcutta University are Bráhmans, who, however, lose caste if they dissect bodies.

The Ráṛhí Bráhmans have diverged still farther from their Kanaujiyá brethren in the matter of diet. Ducks, as well as duck's eggs, onions, a variety of the teal (Nárkúlí) caught by the Bhinds, the spotted rail, or Kharail (Porzana maruetta), the "Mogá" fish, and the flesh of sacrifices, are eaten in Bikrampúr, although their stricter brethren are vegetarians.

[1] Literally, the dark half of the month.

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Salted, or dried, fish and meat, and the flesh of birds trapped by birdlime, are rejected by all Bráhmans. The Kámrúpí Bráhmans, on the other hand, eat the flesh of buffaloes, geese, and pigeons, but neither the Vaidika Bráhmans, from whom they are descended, nor any other tribe have as yet followed their example. Furthermore, those Ráṛhí Bráhmans, who conform to certain rules of the Ṣákta ritual, drink spirituous liquors, although the tasting of "Madhu" causes forfeiture of caste in Hindustan, and the smoking of Indian hemp (Gánjha), also prohibited, is year by year becoming more common in Bengal.

The majority of Bengali Bráhmans comply with the Sáma-Veda; but a few, chiefly of the Puṣí Lál gotra, follow the Yajur-Veda. Bráhman boys are invested with the sacred cord when seven years old, or more correctly when seven years and three months old, or eight years after conception. The length of the cord depends on the Veda followed, and Bráhmans who obey the Sáma-Veda acquire a "paitá" either reaching from the top of the right thumb, when the arm is extended, to the tip of the left shoulder, or from the top of the sternum to the right thumb. Those, again, who follow the Yajur-Veda, wear it long enough to reach from the right shoulder to the extended right thumb; and the followers of the Rig-Veda from the navel to the anterior fontanelle.

The "paitá" must consist of three plies of three strands joined by knots (gánṭh), the number depending on the gotra of the Bráhman. Thus, the descendants of the Kanaujiyá Bráhmans belonging to the Sáṇḍilya, Kaṣyapa, and Bharadvája gotras have three knots in each ply; while those of the Vátsya and Savarṇa have five.

Bráhmans observe the Deṣ-áchár, or custom of the particular country in which they reside, if it is not contrary to the Ṣástras; and high caste Kanaujiyá Bráhmans living in Bengal do not lose their good name by officiating as Purohits to low caste Hindustání castes, though they would certainly do so in Hindustan. Ráṛhi Kulins, as a rule, have no Jajman, or communities for whom they perform religious services, but degraded Kulins often, and Ṣrotriyás always, have a circle of families, who remunerate them for attending to their religious wants.

The Guru of the Ráṛhí Ṣreṇí is usually a hereditary office, held by the representative of an old respected Kulin family. Should he die leaving a son, the community take especial care to have him properly educated, and instructed in his duties. The Purohit, too, occupies a hereditary office, and is generally a member of a family living in the immediate neighbourhood of his flock.

Nine-tenths of the Ráṛhí Bráhmans either worship Ṣiv, or follow the Ṣákta ritual of the Tantras. Few Vaishnavas are

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met with, as it is deemed a misdemeanour for an adult Bráhman to forsake the worship of his fathers; but a certain number do join the ranks of the corrupt Vaishnava sects. It is essential in Bengal for a Bráhman, who values orthodoxy, to worship Ṣiv and the Sáligrám, the special deities of the order.

The Ráṛhí Brámans assert that the large majority follow the Dakshináchar form of Ṣákta worship, as being less intricate than the Vámáchar, or Kaula, but other classes of natives deny this, maintaining that in Dacca at least the licentious orgies of the Kaula, or Chakra, Púját, as it is popularly called, have more patrons than any other. When the habits of intoxication and licentiousness so prevalent among the higher ranks of the Ráṛhí Bráhmans are considered, it is impossible to resist the conclusion that the popular charge is quite credible. At these impure revels all castes meet on a footing of equality, but at those directed by Ṣúdras, a degraded Bráhman presides, while at the worship of Ṣáktí, the living personification of the goddess, a Bráhmaní girl, is the object adored. The worshippers being bound by an oath not to divulge the mysteries, it is difficult to ascertain what classes, and what numbers, of Bráhmans patronise the assemblies.[1]

The proper deities for a Bengali Bráhman to worship are Kálí, Manasa Deví, and the Sáligrám, and this may be done in any temple, or house, of a clean caste; but he dare not officiate at the shrine of any other deity.

(*b.*) VARENDRA.

The popular story is, that the five Kanaujiyá Bráhmans, introduced by Ádisúra, settled on the east of the Ganges, and forming alliances with the women of the country, their offspring became the Varendra Bráhmans.

Varendra, or the country north of the Padma, between the rivers Karatoyá and Mahánanda, and embracing the modern Zila's of Rájsháhí, Pubna, and Bograh, is the home of this tribe; but as the Ráṛhí have passed beyond the limits of their proper residence into Dinájpúr, so the Varendra have crossed into the northern part of Mymensingh, belonging to the ancient kingdom of Kámrúp.

Ballál Sen classified the Varendra Bráhmans under three heads—

Kulína,
Ṣuddha Ṣrotriyá,
Kashṭa Ṣrotriyá.

[1] For further particulars see Wilson's "Sects of the Hindus," vol. i, pp. 240–263.

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The Kulina were subdivided into eight Gáins, or village communities, namely—

Maitra,	Láhari,
Bhíma,	Bhádri,
Rudra-Vágísí,	Sádhu-Vágísí,
Santámani, or Ṣáṇḍilya,	Bhadra.

The Ṣuddha, or stainless, Ṣrotriyás were also separated into eight classes—

Karaṇjau,	Bhattaṣali,
Nandanavásí,	Naori,
Champati,	Atharthi,
Jampati,	Káma-devta.

Finally, the Kashṭa, or bad, Ṣrotriyás were resolved into eighty-four families.

A Káp is a Varendra Kulin, who has lost his Kul by making an irregular marriage with a Kashṭa Ṣrotriyá. He retains the same rank among his provincials as a Vaṇsaja does among the Rárhí.

The following story explains the origin of the Káp. One Narasiṇha Naṛal, a Brindában Bráhman, having a grown-up but unmarried daughter, came to Bengal, and while crossing the Padma river, the ferryman upbraided him for keeping her so long a maid, and asked in mockery whether he intended wedding her to Madhu Maitra, or Ráma-dhana Vágísí, the two chief Kulins of the Varendras. Narasiṇha, losing his temper, vowed that he would either marry her to Madhu Maitra, or commit suicide. He accordingly put his daughter, a cow, and a Sáligrám, on board a boat, and proceeded to Guṛanai, near Nátor, where Madhu lived. He met the Bráhman by chance at a bathing ghat, and threatened to sink the boat with its contents, unless he agreed to marry the girl. Madhu sent for his sons, and insisted that one of them should marry her; but all refused, so he himself took her to wife.

At the festival, when food is first taken from the bride's hands, she scoffingly sang—

> "Who is honourable, and who is not,
> To whom shall I give Bháji,[1] and Paramánna?"[2]

The guests believing her to be a Muhammadan damsel in disguise, departed in anger, and declined to hold any further intercourse with the household.

The annual Ṣráddha in memory of his father coming round, Madhu anxious to pacify his relatives, and to induce them to

[1] Rice gruel. [2] Rice and milk.

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attend, went to the house of his brother-in-law, Ráma-dhana, to ask his advice, but finding him from home, accepted refreshment offered by his sister, and on leaving, gave her this riddle—

"If Ráma-dhana comes, he will perform his father's Śráddha; if not, he will never do it!"

On his return, Ráma-dhana being unable to solve the puzzle, went to Madhu's house, and learned its meaning. Thereupon he summoned the chief Kulins, and making light of the misunderstanding, told the guests that they had practised a foolish joke (Káp). The anger of the guests was not appeased, and ever after they lived apart, forming the Káp subdivision.

An offshoot, called Chhíṭa Káp, formerly existed, but Rájah Káṇs Náráyana of Ṭáhirpúr, got it readmitted into communion with the main body.

Varendra Bráhmans have not adopted the extravagant custom of Pálti-Prakṛití; but among the Kulins eight Páṭí, or social grades, are distinguished:—

Nirabhil,	Baini,
Janail,	Atub-Kahní,
Bosnah,	Kutb-Kahní,
Rahala,	Panchuria.

Each Gáin of Varendra Kulins belongs to a Páṭí, but a Páṭí is not always identical with a Gáin, for some members of the Maitra are found marrying with the Nirabhil grade, and others with the Janail. Similar conventionalities are observed by the Śrotriyás.

The gotras of the Varendra are the same as those of the Ráṛhí Śreṇí, namely, Kaśyapa, Vátsya, Śáṇḍilya, Bharadvája, and Savarṇa. Their ordinary titles are, Chakravartti, Parihal, Bhattáchárya, Chaudharí, Majumdár, Bhúmika, and Śikhdár.

The Varendra differ in many respects from the Ráṛhí. With the former, a widow remarries, if the husband dies before puberty. This is called "Ánupúrva Viśishṭa." Again, a Ráṛhí Kulin boy is often married to an old woman, but this is never allowed by the Varendra. Both tribes, however, agree that a Kulin cannot wed a girl with the same name as his mother (Maṭri-náma), nor a kinswoman of his own gotra (Sa-gotra).

When a Varendra Kulin takes to wife the daughter of a Káp, he sinks to her level, but the children have special respect shown them, and are therefore more eligible in marriage. On the other hand, when he weds a Śrotriyá maiden, as is lawful, the children are Kulins. Marriages between the Ráṛhí, Varendra, and Vaidik Bráhmans are strictly forbidden.

When a Kulin cannot get a suitable husband for his daughter, he must either marry her to a figure made of Kuśa grass with the usual formalities, or, after having the marriage service per-

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formed, smear red lead on her forehead, which is the symbol of the married state.

Varendra Bráhmans usually follow the Sáma-Veda, but a few study the Ṛig, Yajur, and even the Atharva-Veda. Different creeds (Mata) are obeyed. One, known as Rájah Rái Ka Mata, is the same as that of Rájah Rám Kṛishna; a second is the creed of Bhinad Rái, a Rájah of Ṭáhirpúr, and a third, derived from the second, is called the Mata of Balihár Rájah.

Vaishnavas are more frequently met with among Varendras than in any other class of Bengali Bráhmans.

Varendra Bráhmins have acquired and retained a more important rank in Bengal than has fallen to the lot of the Ráṛhí Śreṇi.

In Rájsháhí, there are still the Rájas of Nátor, Patiya, Ṭáhirpúr, and Chauganga, and in Mymensingh the Rájah of Susang, all of whom belong to old and respected Varendra families.

(*c.*) VAIDIKA.

This, one of the most honoured and homogeneous divisions of Bengali Bráhmans, is distinguished by its adherence to Vedic rites and Vedic literature, by social independence, and abjuration of polygamy. Some authorities have described them as descendants of the original Bráhmans of Bengal, who refused to submit to the reforms of Ballál Sen, and sought for freedom in the frontier lands of Bengal beyond his jurisdiction. Whether this be correct or not, it is certain that Silhet and Orissa contain the most important colonies of the tribe, and Buchanan mentions[1] a tradition lingering among the Vaidika Bráhmans of Dinájpúr, that they had been introduced into that district by Advaita Subuddhí Náráyaṇa, Rájah of Silhet. In Orissa, again, the Vaidik, or high, Bráhmans are said[2] to be immigrants from Bengal or Kanauj, and date their oldest settlements in Purí from about the twelfth century. Others[3] conjecture that many fled from Orissa through fear of being made Vámácháris, or left-hand worshippers of the Śáktí of Śiva.

A whimsical story is told at the present day by the Ghaṭaks of the Vaidik Bráhmans to account for their gotras, which is evidently of modern invention, being the counterpart of one related of the Ráṛhí Śreṇí Bráhmans. A vulture happened to die on the roof of the palace occupied by Shamal Varman, a Chhatrí Rájah, ruling over the Banga Déśá, in an undetermined era before Ádisúra, and none of the local Bráhmans being able

[1] Vol. ii, 734.
[2] "Hunter's Orissa," vol. ii, app. i, p. 7.
[3] Ward, vol. i, 79.

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to avert the calamity thus foreboded, the monarch wrote to his friend the Rájah of Ayodhyá, and besought him to send five Bráhmans, competent to offer the needful sacrifice, and save the household from the vengeance of the offended deity. The Bráhmans arrived, and were so successful, that amid the smoke of the burnt offering the embodied spirit of the dead vulture was seen to soar heavenwards! To these five Bráhmans the Rájah gave large tracts of land, and to six of their tribe, who subsequently arrived, he allotted other tracts, hence the modern separation into two subdivisions of five and six gotras.

The Kanaujiyá are admitted by all Hindus to be the purest stock of Bráhmans in Northern India, and each offshoot tries by some extravagant story to prove its genuine relationship with the parent stem. Sherring[1] ascertained at Benares that the Vaidika were admitted to be a branch of the Kanaujiyá Bráhmans settled in Bengal, but in Dacca this is not always conceded.

The Vaidika Bráhmans have two great divisions, the Páschátya, or western, and Dákshiṇátya, or southern; the former, alone met with in Eastern Bengal, point to Kanauj as their home; the latter, chiefly inhabiting Central Bengal, claim to belong to the original Bengal stock.

The Páschátya, as has been mentioned, are subdivided into Pancha and Shash gotras. The Pancha, or five, gotras are—

Ṣáṇdilya,	Ṣaunaka,
Ṣavarṇa,	Vasishṭha.
Bharadvája,	

The Bharadvája obeyed the Sáma Veda, but having become extinct, the first gotra of the Shash has taken its place.

The Shash, or six, gotras are—

Ṣunaka,	Váchyara,
Ṛathíkara,	Kaṣyapa,
Kṛishṇátreya,	Gautama.

No two Ghaṭaks, however, repeat the same names, as other gotras have been formed, and usurped a position which cannot be justified. Upamanya, Maitráyalí, Ghṛita Kauṣikí, and Tuṭhíkara are names of uncertain standing.

The Páschátya Vaidiks were originally grouped in fourteen Stháns, or settlements, whence fourteen societies emanated. At the present day, owing to the destructive agency of the River Ganges, the sites of these colonies have been in several instances swept away, leaving no trace behind; but the position of the following eleven has been ascertained:—

In Báqirganj	Sámanta Sára, Chandra-dvípa, Koṭálipáḍa,

[1] "Hindu Tribes and Castes," p. 23.

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In Rájsháhí	Jayárí, Âlambí, Brahma Púraka,
In Farrídpúr	Gaurálí, Paní Kaṇṭaka, Âkharâ,
In Nadiyá	Navadvípa,
In Jessore	Madhyadéṣa.

The sites of Sántalí, Dadhíchigrám, and Maríchigrám have not as yet been determined.

At present many families live beyond the limits of these settlements, intermarrying with aliens like themselves, but, on payment of a heavy fine, they become re-entitled to the full privileges of the Samáj, or association.

Vaidik Bráhmans are very exclusive, neither giving their daughters in marriage to Kulins, nor acting as Purohits to any Ṣúdra, or Bráhman, family, unless the latter can trace their origin to Kanauj. Furthermore, they do not officiate as Pujárís of temples, and although it is considered undignified to live on the charity of Ṣúdras, a few do so. This sept of Bráhmans minister as the Purohits and Gurus of the Rárhí, and Varendra Ṣreṇí, and usually have members of these tribes officiating in the same capacity for them. They have no Kulins, and no Ghaṭaks, and their titles are identical with those of other Bengali Bráhmans; for instance, Chakravarttí, Bhattáchárya, or simply, Ṭhákúr.

They study the Ṛig, Yajur, and Sáma Vedas, while the large majority are Ṣákta worshippers, obeying the ordinances of the Tantras. Vishnu is occasionally worshipped, but for a Vaidik to abandon the time-honoured religion of his family, and become a disciple of a Gosáin, is regarded as highly derogatory, and disgraceful.

A Vaidik is prohibited from marrying into his own or his mother's gotra, as among Rárhí Bráhmans. He can only marry one wife, and it is customary for parents to arrange marriages during infancy, and sometimes before children are born. In the latter case, should either die before puberty, a subsequent marriage is full of difficulties. Formerly, no money was paid for a wife, but of late years the practice has become fashionable. As a rule, the Vaidiks do not touch flesh, even if sacrificed, or fish, and when visiting his disciples he seldom wears shoes, or sandals.

The principal occupation of the Vaidik Bráhmans is the celebration of the old and venerated Vedic ceremonies, which their study of the Vedas enables them do, but astronomy, formerly a favourite attainment, is no longer prosecuted. In

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the Homa and Jaga rites the ministration of a Vaidik is necessary, and even the Rárhí and Varendra Kulins require their assistance. No temple is correctly built, no dwelling-house is auspiciously finished, and no tank is properly excavated unless the Vaidik performs the regulated propitiatory rite of consecration; and should an individual be ill he may offer sacrifice for his recovery in the place of the family Purohit. The Nava-graha Jag, or Graha Púja, the worship of the nine planets, one of their most ordinary rites, consists in piling nine kinds of sacred woods,[1] pouring "Ghí," or clarified butter, over them, and then applying fire, while the Vaidik standing at one side repeats Mantras, or collects, adapted to the particular day of the week.

The Vástú Púja, or ceremonies observed on laying the foundations of a house, are generally performed by them, but if a Vaidik is not available any Bráhman may officiate. On the site of the new building a pit, a cubit square, being dug, and filled in with billets of Bél and Mangoe, chips of the nine sacred plants are thrown in, "Ghí" poured on the pile, and a light being applied, wheat, barley, linseed, and honey are afterwards cast into the flames. Until this expiatory rite is completed the laity are not allowed to enter the enclosure.

If a Rárhí Kulin be on friendly terms with a Vaidik he may eat food in the latter's house, without offence, but they cannot eat together in the caste assembly, as in public the Vaidik can only touch food cooked by one of his own caste.

Every Vaidik learns Sanskrit, but a knowledge of English, or Persian, is highly dishonouring. Vaidiks boast that they never accept service with Hindus or Englishmen, but a few of late years have become Paṇḍits in government schools, an innovation, however, very unpopular with the conservative party of elders. Notwithstanding this exclusiveness the Vaidik becomes independent, and resigned to altered circumstances and new influences whenever he quits home, and is untrammelled by family customs, accepting without compunction any remunerative employment which offers. In Dacca, a Vaidik Bráhman from Murshídábád keeps a liquor shop, but this scandalous occupation does not disqualify him from acting as Purohit to numerous families of Dakhin Rárhí Sonár-baniks, who reside in the immediate neighbourhood.

[1] The nine sacred woods are :—

Palása ..	*Butea frondosa.*	Tajnoḍumbara	*Ficus glomerata.*
Kuṣa ..	*Poa cynosuroides.*	Apánga ..	*Achyranthes aspera.*
Vata ..	*Ficus Indica.*	Khádira ..	*Mimosa catechu.*
Dúrvá ..	*Panicum Dactylon.*	Ṣamí ..	*Adenanthera aculeata.*
Akanda	*Asclepias gigantea.*		

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(*d.*) Sapta-Ṣatí Bráhmans.

The Sapta-Ṣatí Bráhmans are peculiar to Bengal, and extraneous to the ten Bráhmanical tribes. They occupy a low position, admitting their inferiority to the main branches, and their pedigree, though ancient, is uncertain. Ghaṭaks maintain they are descended from Bráhmans banished across the Brahmaputra for resisting the innovations of Ballál Sen; but the popular story is that their ancestors were the seven hundred (Sapta-Ṣatí) ignorant Bráhmans sent by Ádisúra to the court of Kanauj. Sherring,[1] however, mentions a tradition that originally they associated with one of the superior races, but lost their status through the ceremonial delinquencies of the members. At the present day they are still numerous on the north of the Brahmaputra in Tipperah, Silhet, and Mymensingh;[2] but few acknowledge the name.

Whatever was their rank in former days, they have relinquished all class peculiarities, and are gradually being absorbed among the Ṣrotriyá Bráhmans. In Bikrampúr, where many reside, they are said to be divided into twenty-seven septs; but as no one of respectability, or education, will confess that he is a Sapta-Ṣatí, it is impossible to arrive at a correct conclusion. Sherring, on the other hand, enumerates sixteen septs, of which only nine correspond with the following list.

The twenty-seven septs are—

Sagáí,	Mulk-júrí,
Sogáí,	Kandaka,
Nánashi,	Chairika,
Jagáí,	Bántopi,
Helaí,	Latárí,
Kálai, or Karlá,	Pitárí,
Dhai,	Baghráí,
Bánasi,	Pharphara,
Dhánasí,	Bachaní,
Kanthuri,	Jarjara,
Katání,	Halika,
Kuṣala,	Chairaka,
Uchala,	Banika.
Ulaka,	

Sherring likewise gives the gotra to which each sept belongs; but in Bikrampúr the Ghaṭaks allege that having forgotten the names of their saintly progenitors, the Sapta-Ṣatí assumed those of the Kanaujiyá Bráhmans. This misstatement, evidently of

[1] "Hindu Tribes and Castes of Benares," p. 112.
[2] "Topography of Dacca," by James Taylor, p. 229.

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modern origin, is quite consistent with the claim they at present put forth of being Śrotriyá Bráhmans.

Neither Sapta-Śatí Kulins nor Ghaṭaks exist. They, however, give their daughters in marriage to Kulins of the Rárhí Śreṇí, and by paying a heavy dowry, often amounting to one thousand rupees, obtain brides from Śrotriyá families. But cases occasionally occur of their being imposed upon by some treacherous Ghaṭak, who abducts, or buys, a Śúdra girl from another part of the country, and palms her upon them as a maiden of aristocratic, and pure Bráhmanical, lineage. A Kulin Bráhman of the Rárhí Śreṇí will, it is said, eat and drink with the Sapta-Śatí; a Vaṇśaja never.

Śrotriyá Bráhmans usually officiate as Purohits, but in some parts the Sapta-Śatí have Bráhmans of their own. Formerly the teaching of the Yajur Vedar was followed, but of late years their religious rites, having been assimilated to those of the Rárhí Bráhmans, the Sáma Veda is obeyed.

The ordinary title of the Sapta-Śatí is Śarman, never Dev-Sarmmá, as among the ten tribes; but Sirkár, Rái, Chaudharí, and Chakravartí are common appellations.

(*e.*) Bhát.

This is a race differing in many respects from the Bhát, or bards, of Hindustan, and repudiating the usually acknowledged descent from a Kshatriyá and a Bráhman widow. Like the Vaidik Bráhmans they chiefly inhabit Silhet and Tipperah, claiming to be the offspring of the aboriginal Bráhmans employed as Ghaṭaks for the order generally. They likewise affirm that they retired, or were driven, into the borders of Bengal for refusing to submit to the reforming hand of Ballál Sen. In Silhet the Rárhí Bráhmans still eat with the Bháts, but in Dacca the latter are reckoned unclean, and in Tipperah, having fallen in rank, they earn a precarious livelihood by manufacturing umbrellas.

The Bháts are not numerous in any part of Bengal, only 3,372 individuals being entered in the census returns, of whom 44 per cent. reside in Midnapore, and 540 persons in four out of the nine eastern districts.

In January the Bháts leave their homes, travelling to all parts of Eastern Bengal, and, being in great request, are fully engaged during the subsequent Hindu matrimonial season. Each company receives a fixed yearly sum from every Hindu household within a definite area, amounting usually to eight anas. In return they are expected to visit the house, and recite Kavitás, or songs, extolling the worth and renown of the family. Satirical

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songs are great favourites with Hindus, and none win more applause than those laying bare the foibles and well-intentioned vagaries of the English rule, or the eccentricities and irascibility of some local magnate. Very few bards can sing extemporary songs, their effusions, usually composed by one, and learned off by heart by the others, being always metrical, often humorous, and generally seasoned with puns and equivocal words. Their sole occupation is the recital of verses, unaccompanied by instrumental music. They are met with everywhere when Hindu families celebrate a festival, or domestic event, appearing on such occasions uninvited, and exacting by their noisy importunity a share of the food and charity that is being doled to the poor. Their shamelessness in this respect is incredible. During the Durga Púja they force their way into respectable houses, and make such a horrid uproar by shouting and singing that the inmates gladly pay something to be rid of them. Should this persecution have no effect on the rich man inside, they, by means of a brass lotah and an iron rod, madden the most phlegmatic Bábu, who pays liberally for their departure. The Bengali Bhát is, as a rule, uneducated, and very few know Sanskrit.

They have three gotras, Kaṣyapa, Ṣáṇḍilya, and Bharadvája, and are all Ṣákta worshippers, addicted to intemperance.

A Bhát would be dishonoured by acting as a Pujárí, or priest of a temple; or a Purohit.

After residing for six months in Bengal they return to their homes in Silhet with a fund of twenty or thirty rupees, which is augmented by the rent of a piece of land cultivated by other members of his family. The head of the house never cultivates land himself, as is done by the Hindustání Bhát, on which account no fraternization between the two is possible.

(*f.*) Áchárj, Áchárya.

This term is properly applied to the Bráhman who instructs the Kshatriyá and Vaiṣyas in the Vedas; but in Bengal it is the name of a low and despised tribe of Bráhmans. Persons of this class are known as Łagan-Áchárjí, Gaṇaka (astrologer), or Daivajna (calculator of nativities), and, in Purneah, as Upádhyáya, or teachers.

Various traditions as to their origin are current. According to one they are descendants of Ráṛhí Bráhmans, and to another, they spring from the degenerate priesthood residing in Bengal anterior to the reforms of Ballál Sen. Others claim to be descended from a Muní, called Devala, and a Vaiṣya mother; but this parentage gives them no right to the rank of Bráhmans,

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although they are popularly recognized as such by the Ṣúdras, who usually address them as "Ganak Ṭhákúr."

The caste attributes its insignificance and decreasing numbers to a curse laid on it, and at the present day they have not more than sixteen houses in the city of Dacca. The members are therefore obliged to intermarry with Áchárjí Bráhmans in other districts.

This caste recognizes six gotras, namely :—

Sáṇdilya,	Madhu-Kulya,
Bharadvája,	Savarṇa,
Kaṣyapa,	Váchava.

In Eastern Bengal the class is an illiterate one, Sanskrit being rarely studied, but when it is, the Achárjí ceases to be a fortune teller, and becomes a Paṇdit.

At three domestic ceremonies the Achárjí attends, and receives presents. At a Ṣráddha, the offering made to the Sun (Súrya-Argha) is his perquisite, when the Anna-práṣana, at which a child is first given rice to chew, and when the young Bráhman is invested with the sacred thread (Upanaya), his presence is necessary. The offerings he receives on these occasions consist of napkins and clothes, but, if the family be poor, he is content with the former, and a few anas. Strange to say, these despised Bráhmans share with the Dôms the oblations made during eclipses of the sun or moon.

Their chief occupation is casting nativities, deciphering horoscopes, and drawing up almanacs and ephemerides. In the month of Baisákh, the first of the Hindu calendar, they foretell the peculiarities of the ensuing year to each household, acquainting the members with the good or evil fortune that will befall them, and giving warning of the auspicious and unpropitious regents of the sky, land, and water, and many other astrological signs, which have always found credulous believers among the ignorant and superstitious races of men. All Hindus, and most Muhammadan families of the old school, consult these astrologers on the birth of a son, and as much as a hundred rupees are given for an unexceptionable horoscope. Like the gypsies, they still pretend to read fortunes by palmistry, and to be masters of other equally occult sciences. With them a circular mark round the tip of any finger presages wealth and power, a perpendicular wrinkle in the centre of the forehead entitles the lucky person to the title of Ráj-daṇḍ (royal sceptre), or Ráj-bhágí (sharer of empire). Although discredited by the higher and instructed classes, these fortune-tellers exert enormous influence over the happiness and well being of the masses. There is usually something displeasing about the physiognomy of these Bráhmans. They are as black as any Ṣúdra, and their pretended sanctity

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and learning are not belied by their calm and phlegmatic manner. With the greatest presence of mind, they refer any failure in their predictions to some trifling error in the calculations, and, by rearranging their figures, prove that the event would necessarily have occurred had it been correctly demonstrated.

The Achárjí is frequently a gold or silver, smith, and he is the acknowledged painter and delineator of the different gods and goddesses; the Kumhár fashioning the idol, while the Achárjí paints and embellishes it. He also depicts the scenes exhibited on the Misls, or platforms, carried about on great festival days. Their skill is small, as they have no schools of art, and it is imperative that the portraits of the Hindu gods and goddesses shall be of a stereotyped outline, otherwise the populace would not recognise them; but the background may be designed according to the fancy and taste of the artist. It is here that they fail, and their pictures are, as a rule, the sorriest daubs, without any idea of perspective, or anatomy. They possess, however, a slight knowledge of the composition of compound colours, but their art is subservient to Hindu taste, which demands a profusion of bright and abruptly alternating colours. Their paint-brush, made of goat's hair, is called "Tulí."

The Achárjí is also a house decorator, ornamenting cornices, and painting designs of flowers and animals on the walls of rooms.

Astronomy is a sealed book to him, and he has no knowledge of any astronomical books or instruments. Finally, he is often a physician, but his skill is not greater than that of the thousand quacks around; and formerly he inoculated children.

It is a remarkable fact that Achárjí Bráhmans are generally Vaishnavas in creed, differing in this respect from all others of the sacred order, while their religious ceremonies are identical with those of the Bengali Bráhmans. Owing to the paucity of their numbers, a young man has often to pay from two to three hundred rupees for a wife, and many, not being able to meet this expenditure, die unmarried, and their families become extinct.

The Rangsáz, or oil painter, quite distinct from the Muhammadan Naqqásh, is usually an Áchárjí. He is always addressed as Ustádgar. The Rangsáz formerly prepared his own colours, but now English paints, being cheaper and more durable, are procured from Calcutta.

(*g.*) Agradána.

This, the lowest and most unhonoured class of Bráhmans, is usually regarded as a degraded branch of the Sawálákhya

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Bráhmans of Hindustan, who became dishonoured from claiming as their perquisite the offerings presented at the Angapráyaṣchitta, when the next of kin presents offerings at the first Ṣráddha. In Bengal they are in irony called Mahá-purohit, Mahá-Bráhmana, Mahá-Ṣráddhí, or Mahá-putra, and from acting at the funerals of Bráhmans, and members of the Nava-Ṣákha, Marápoḍa Bráhmans. In Hindustan the individual discharging similar duties is known as Mahá-pátra, or Kantaha.

The services of these men can nowadays be dispensed with, as the family Purohit often reads the Mantras at the burning Ghát.

The Agradána, assuming a higher social rank, refuse to eat with the Áchárjí; but the latter do not decline alms given by the former. The Áchárjí again eats with the Ṣúdra, or Patit, Bráhman, who would be excommunicated if he held any social intercourse with the Agradána.

According to their own account, these Bráhmans are degraded Ráṛhí, and their gotras still bear the names of the most holy Munís. These are five in number—

Sáṇḍilya,	Savarṇa,
Bharadvája,	Váchava.
Kaṣyapa,	

Their marriages and religious rites are the same as those of the Ráṛhí Bráhmans. A work, called Ṣráddha-Veda, written in Bengali, is adopted as their guide book. At Ṣráddhas they receive a day's food and from one ana to twenty-five rupees.

The Agradána is usually as illiterate as the Áchárjí. When learned in Sanskrit, he assumes, or is given, the title of Paṇḍit. The caste has no established Panchái't, but when disputes occur five elders meet and consult together.

CHÁÍN, CHÁÍ.

This is one of the largest and most scattered fisher tribes of Northern India. In Bengal they number 67,300 persons, chiefly congregated in Maldah and Murshídábád, while in the nine Eastern districts only 450 are returned. In Bihár as many as 41,686 are registered, being massed in Patna and Mungír, while the Santal pergunnahs contain 17,576. According to Buchanan[1] Nator in Rájsháhí was, in his day, the centre of the tribe; but Maldah now returns more than any other district of Bengal.

The Cháín are found in Oudh, where Carnegy[2] connects them with the Tháru, Rájí, Nat, and other unclassified tribes, inhabiting

[1] "Eastern India," i, 173.
[2] "Races of Oudh," pp. 8, 14.

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the base of the Himalayas, and traces in their physiognomy features peculiar to Mongolian races. Sherring,[1] again, in one place speaks of them as a subdivision of Malláhs, in another as a predatory tribe of Oudh and Gorakhpúr. Beverley, on the other hand, thinks they resemble the Binds, although the Cháíns are most numerous south of the Ganges, the Binds in Northern Bihár. It is most probable that, like other fisher castes, the Cháíns are remnants, or offshoots, of an aboriginal race, having no relationship with the true Aryan Hindus.

Wherever found, the Cháíns are notorious as thieves, and "extraordinary clever impostors and thimbleriggers,"[2] although Mr. Beverley asserts that this bad character is not altogether deserved. The term "Chái-paná," however, is a common term for stealing among the Hindi speaking natives, while throughout Bengal individuals belonging to the caste are watched with great suspicion.

At their homes Cháíns are cultivators, as well as boatmen and fishermen, catching mullet with the "Sirkí" mat, as the Binds do. In Oudh, and the north-western provinces, they are cultivators and prepare Khair, or catechu. In Eastern Bengal they appear as traders in grain and pulse.

As among other impure tribes, a Dasnámí Gosáin acts as Guru, a degraded Maithila Bráhman as Purohit. In Oudh they worship Mahábíra, the Monkey god, Sat Naráyana, and Deví Pátan, while they drink spirits, and feast on pork. Those who come to Bengal, like other fisher tribes, are followers of the Pánch Píriya creed, and worshippers of Koila Bábá, freely indulging in spirits whenever a favourably opportunity presents itself.

CHÁMÁR (H), CHÁMÁR (B), CHARMA-KÁRA (S).

This Hindustani tribe is found in all parts of Bengal, living apart in villages of their own, everywhere following the same customs, and prosecuting the same trade. The north-west provinces is the home of the Chamár, and in 1865 they numbered 3,580,385 individuals. In Bihár, again, according to the census of 1872, there were 711,721, while in Bengal proper, Chámárs and Ṛishís only numbered 393,490. In the nine eastern districts 47,053 were returned, of whom 24,063, or 50·6 per cent., belonged to Dacca.

[1] "Hindu Tribes and Castes," pp. 346, 390.

[2] "Note on Inferior Castes, &c, in the N. W. Provinces," by E. A. Reade, C.S. p. 39.

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The Chamár is descended, according to the Puráṇas, from a boatman and a Chaṇḍál woman; but Menu represents them as being Nisháda, or outcasts, the offspring of a Bráhman and a Śúdra mother. In Oudh, at the present day, their descent is traced to the fabulous hero Nikhad and a Ḍab-gar, or currier woman.[1] There cannot, however, be any doubt that Chamárs belong to a semi-Hinduised aboriginal tribe reduced to the level of other helot races, and expelled from the homes of the Aryan Hindus.

The Chamár is proverbially a black man, but in the Central provinces he is described as a brown, not a dark skinned person, while in Eastern Bengal he is not so swarthy as the average Chaṇḍál, and is infinitely fairer, with a more delicate and intellectual cast of features, than many Śrotriyá Bráhmans.

Chamárs trace their own pedigree to Raví, or Rái, Dás, the famous disciple of Rámánanda at the end of the fourteenth century, and whenever a Chamár is asked what he is, he replies a Raví Dás. Though despised and spurned by all classes, the Chamár is proud and punctilious, never touching the leavings of a Bráhman's meal, nor eating anything cooked by a Bengali Bráhman, although he has no objections if a Hindustání Bráhman prepares it.

According to the Chamárs of Eastern Bengal, the caste has the following seven "gots" or subdivisions:—

Jatúá,	Dohár,
Kuláha,	Kanaujiyá,
Jaiswára,	Korí.
Jhúsia,	

In Dacca the Chamárs all belong to the Jhúsia "got," and came originally from Gházípúr, Mungír, and Arrah. Many have permanently settled in Bengal, but others only remain a few years until money is saved, when they return to spend it at their homes. Chamárs are very gregarious, being generally massed in the large towns, but occasionally small settlements are found scattered throughout the interior.

In Dacca, Chamárs are employed in tanning leather, making shoes, and grooming horses. The Chamṛá-farosh hire them to preserve hides, but there is such bitter enmity between the caste and the Ṛishís, that they are rarely engaged to skin animals.

The Chamár is inconceivably dirty in his habits, and offends others besides the Hindu by his neglect of all sanitary laws. Large droves of pigs are bred by them, and it is no uncommon sight to witness children and pigs wallowing together in the mire. Hides, in various stages of preparation, hang about the

[1] Carnegy's "Traces of Oudh," app., p. 85.

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hut, yet strange to say the women are very prolific, and with the exception of a fisher village, nowhere are so many chubby children to be seen as in a filthy Chamár hamlet. Chamárs eat both beef and pork, and like the European gypsies have no repugnance to cooking the flesh of animals dying naturally.

Hindustání Chamárs are always employed as musicians at Hindu weddings, their favourite instruments being the "Surnáe," or pipe, and varieties of the drum, such as "Ḍholak" and "Ṭása," but in Eastern Bengal no male or female Chamár ever performs as a professional musician, and it is only at domestic festivities that they play on the "Ḍhol," or drum; the "Jhánjh," or cymbals; the "Ektára," or harp; and the "Khanjarí," or tambourine.

By far the most interesting features of the Chamár caste are their religious and social customs. They have no Purohit, their religious ceremonies being directed by one of the elders; but Gurus, who give Mantras to children, are found, and a Hindustání Bráhman is often consulted regarding a lucky day for a wedding. Chamárs have always exhibited a remarkable dislike to Bráhmans, and to the Hindu ritual. They, nevertheless, observe many rites popularly regarded as of Hindu origin, but which were probably festivals of the village gods kept for ages before the Aryan invasion. The large majority of Bengali Chamárs belong to the Sat Náráyana sect, and "Sants" are very numerous among them. Futhermore, the Mahant of that sect is always regarded as the religious head of the whole tribe. In Biláspúr of the central provinces, Chamárs constitute twenty-seven per cent. of the Hindu population, and in 1825 one of their number, named Ghásí Dás, founded a religion which he called Sat-námí.[1] The principal doctrines of his creed were social equality, no idolatry, and the worship of one God, who was not to be represented by any graven image or likeness. Ghásí Dás died in 1850, but his work still lives. Though imbued with many superstitions, the Chamárs have generally adopted this new faith, repudiated Bráhmanical interference, and enlisted many brethren of other districts into their ranks. The Sat-Náráyana sect is also a deistical one, and it is a curious coincidence, that the tribe should have adopted, in places so far apart, a creed that is almost identical.

A few Dacca Chamárs belong to the Kabír "Panth," but none have joined any of the Vaishnava sects.

The principal annual festival of the Chamárs is the Śrí-panchamí, when they abstain from work for two days, spending them in alternate devotion at the Dhámghar, and in intoxication at home. Another of their festivals is the Rámanauamí, or

[1] "Gazetteer of the Central Provinces," p. 101; "The Highlands of Central India," by Captain J. Forsyth, p. 412.

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birthday of Ráma, held on the ninth lunar day of Chaitra (March-April), when they offer flowers, betle-nut, and sweetmeats to their ancestor, Raví Dás.

A few days before the Dashará the Chámaíns perambulate the streets, playing and singing, with a pot of water in the left hand, a sprig of "Ním" in the right, soliciting alms for the approaching Deví festival. Money, or grain, must be got by begging, for they believe the worship would be ineffectual if the offerings had to be paid for.

On the "Nauamí," or ninth lunar day of Áswin (September-October), the day preceding the Dashará, the worship of Deví is observed, and offerings of swine, goats, and spirits, made to the dread goddess. On this day the old Dravidian system of demonolatry, or Shamanism, is exhibited, when one of their number working himself up into a frenzy, becomes possessed by the demon and reveals futurity. The Chamárs place great value on the answers given, and very few are so contented with their lot in life as not to desire an insight into the future.

When sickness, or epidemic diseases, invade their homes, the women fasten a piece of plantain leaf round their necks, and go about begging. Should their wishes be fulfilled, a vow is taken to celebrate the worship of Deví, Ṣítala, or Jalka Deví, whichever goddess is supposed to cause the outbreak. The worship is held on a piece of ground marked off, and smeared with cow-dung. A fire being lighted, and "Ghí" and spirits thrown on it, the worshipper makes obeisance, bowing his forehead to the ground, and muttering certain incantations. A swine is then sacrificed, and the bones and offal being buried, the flesh is roasted and eaten, but no one must take home with him any scrap of the victim.

Jalka Deví seems identical with the Rákhya Kálí of Bengali villagers, and is said to have seven sisters who are worshipped on special occasions.

At Chamár marriages an elder presides, but a Bráhman usually selects the day. The father of the bride, as a rule, receives a sum of money for his daughter. During the marriage service the bridegroom sits on the knee of the bride's father, and the bridegroom's father receives a few ornaments and a cup of spirits, after which each of the guests is offered a cup.

A "Marocha" is not made, but a Hindustaní barber prepares and whitewashes a space, or "Chauk," within which the pair sit. He also stains the feet of the bride and bridegroom with "Álta," or cotton soaked in lac dye, and is responsible that all the relatives and friends are invited to the marriage.

Chamárs have no ceremony at the naming of a child, the name being selected by a relative or intimate friend.

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The only class of natives, not Muhammadans, who still practise the Sagáí, or Levirate marriage, are the Chamárs. When an elder brother dies childless, the younger must marry the widow after a year, or eighteen months, unless they mutually agree not to do so, in which case she returns to her father's house, where she is free to remarry with anyone she pleases.

On her remarriage, the family of her first husband cannot claim any compensation, as is the custom with the Jews and other races, who follow this marriage law. When a younger brother marries his widowed sister-in-law, no service is performed. The formality is gone through of consulting the Panchá́it, with the object of deciding whether the marriage is well-timed or not. An elder brother, again, is prohibited from marrying his younger brother's widow, the sole purpose of the Levirate marriage being the perpetuation and exaltation of the head of the family. Among Muhammadans the Levirate marriage is ordained but rarely performed. According to their legislators the sister-in-law must live for a whole year as a widow, when she may become the "Nikáh" wife of her husband's brother, for that is the only position she can aspire to. Chamárs do not consider concubinage (Ardhí) disgraceful, but being usually poor, few can afford themselves the luxury.

Chamárs still observe the pleasing custom called "Bháí-photá," on the last day of the Hindu year, when sisters present their brothers with a new suit of clothes and sweetmeats, and make with a paste of red sandal wood a dot on their foreheads; a similar usage, known as "Bhrátṛí-dvitíyá," is practised by Bengalis on the second day after the new moon of Kártik.

Chamárs usually bury their dead, and if the husband is buried, his widow will be laid beside him if she had been taught the same Mantra, otherwise her body is burned.

Throughout Hindustan parents frighten naughty children by telling them that Nona Chamáín will carry them off. This redoubtable old witch is said by the Chamárs to have been the mother, or grandmother, of Raví Dás, but why she acquired such unenviable notoriety is unknown. In Bengal her name is never heard of, but a domestic bogey haunts each household. In one it is the "Buṛhí," or old woman, in another, "Bhúta," a ghost, in a third, "Pretní," a witch, and in a fourth, "Gala-Káṭa Káfir," literally, the infidel with his throat gashed.

The Chamáíns, or female Chamárs, are distinguished throughout Bengal by their huge inelegant anklets (Páirí) and bracelets (Bangṛí), made of bell-metal. The former often weigh from eight to ten pounds, the latter from two to four. They also wear the "Ṭiklí," or spangle, on the forehead, although in Bengal it is regarded as a tawdry ornament of the lowest and most

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immoral women. Chamáíns consider it a great attraction to have their bodies tattooed, consequently their chests, foreheads, arms, and legs, are disfigured with patterns of fantastic shape. In Hindustan the Natní is the great tattooer, but not being met with in Bengal, the Chamáíns are often put to great straits, being frequently obliged to pay a visit to their original homes for the purpose of having the fashionable decoration indelibly stained on their bodies.

Chamáíns are the midwives of India, and are generally believed, though erroneously, to be skilled in all the mysteries of parturition. They have no scruples about cutting the navel cord as other Hindus have, but in the villages of the interior where no Chamáíns reside, the females of the Bhúinmálí, Chaṇḍál, and Ghulám Káyath act as midwives, and are equally unscrupulous. It is a proverbial saying among Hindus that a household becomes unclean if a Chamár woman has not attended at the birth of any child belonging to it.

Chamár women are ceremonially unclean for ten days subsequent to childbirth, when after bathing, casting away all old cooking utensils and buying new ones, a feast, called "Bárahiya," is celebrated, upon which she resumes her usual household duties.

CHANḌÁLA.

The Chaṇḍáls, one of the most interesting races in Bengal, are more generally known as Nama-Śúdra, or Changa. The derivation of the former name is uncertain, but it is probably the Sanskrit Namas, adoration, which is always used as a vocative when praying, or the Bengali Námote, below, underneath. Changa again, in Sanskrit, signifies handsome, and was most likely used in irony by the early Hindus. The following synonyms are given by Amara Sinha, Plava (one who moves about), Mátanga (? elephant hunter), Janmagama (life-taker), Nishád-svapácha (dog-eater), Antevásí (one residing on the confines of a village), Diváḳirti, and Púkkasa.

From the earliest recorded times the Chaṇḍálas have been an outcast and helot race, performing menial duties for the Bráhmans, and living apart outside cities occupied by the paramount Aryan race. They are represented by Menu as the offspring of a Śúdra male and a Bráhman female, and as "the lowest of men," who are excluded from the performance of obsequies to their ancestors, and whose touch was as defiling as that of a corpse. In the Mahá Bhárata they are introduced as hired assassins, whose humanity, however, revolts against put-

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ting an innocent boy to death. In the Rámáyana they are described as ill-formed and terrible in aspect, dressing in blue, or yellow, garments with a red cloth over the shoulders, a bear's skin around the loins, and iron ornaments on the wrists. Even the liberal minded Abúl Fazl describes the Chaṇḍáls of the sixteenth century as "vile wretches who eat carrion." At the present day the term Chaṇḍál is throughout India used only in abuse, and is not acknowledged by any race, or caste, as its peculiar designation. In Hindustan it is the common name of the Kantha Bráhman, and everywhere it is an epithet cast at the Dôm. The higher subdivisions of the Nama-śúdras apply it to the lower, while the lower transfer it to the Dôm.

The Dacca Chaṇḍáls retain an obscure tradition of having originally migrated from Gayá, and make mention of a certain Govardhan Chaṇḍál as an ancestor of theirs. There can be no doubt, however, that they belong to a powerful aboriginal, or Dravidian, tribe, who, driven before the Aryan invaders, or by later persecution, sought shelter in the marshy forests of Bengal. The fact that they alone among the population of lower Bengal use the Káyathí Nágarí, the common written language of Dinájpúr, and that a Chaṇḍál Rájah ruled from the fort, whose ruins are still shown in the Bhowál jungle, prove that they were in early times a strongly organized commonwealth driven forth from their homes in the north in search of freedom, and security of religious worship. Mr. Wells[1] quotes a tradition of Hindu invention, current among the Chaṇḍáls of Farrídpúr, to the effect "that they were originally a complete Hindu community consisting of persons of all castes, from the Bráhman downwards, who, on having the misfortune to be cursed in a body by a vengeful Bráhman of unutterable sanctity in Dacca, quitted their ancestral homes, and emigrated bodily to the southern wastes of Farrídpúr, Jessore, and Báqirganj."

According to a tradition of the Dacca Chaṇḍáls they were formerly Bráhmans, who became degraded by eating with Śúdras, but others assert that in days of yore they were the domestic servants of Bráhmans, for which reason they have perpetuated many of the religious observances of their masters. For instance, the Chaṇḍál celebrates the Śráddha on the eleventh day, as Bráhmans do, and the Gayáwál priests conduct the obsequial ceremonies of the Bengali Chaṇḍáls without any compunction.

Mr. Beverley, again, is of opinion that Chaṇḍál is merely a generic title, and the tribe identical with the Mals of the Rájmahal Hills, an undoubted Dravidian clan, and demonstrates from the census figures that in many districts the number of

[1] Appendix to Census Report of 1872, p. vi.

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Chaṇḍáls is in the inverse ratio to the Mals. There appear to be some grounds for this supposition, but an obvious error occurs in the return of 4,663 Mals in Dacca, where none exist, and the omission of any Málos, who are numerous. The latter, though undoubtedly a remnant of some aboriginal race, have not as yet been identified with the Mals.

Dr. Buchanan considered the Chaṇḍál of Bengal to be identical with the Dosádh of Bihár. Although both are equally low in the scale of caste, and characterized by an unusual amount of independence and self-reliance, very great differences actually exist. The Dosádh worships deified heroes belonging to his tribe, the Chaṇḍál never does. The Dosádh invokes Ráhu and Ketu, the former being his tutelary deity, while we find no such divinity reverenced by the Chaṇḍál. Finally, the Śráddha of the Dosádh is celebrated on the thirtieth day as with the Śúdras, that of the Chaṇḍál on the eleventh as with Bráhmans.

The Chaṇḍáls of Eastern Bengal have separated into eight classes, that never eat, and seldom intermarry, with each other :—

1. Hálwah from Hál, a plough, are cultivators.
2. Ghási are grass-cutters.
3. Kandho, from Skandha, the shoulder, are palanquin bearers.
4. Karrál, are fishmongers.
5. Bárí, probably a corruption of Barháí, a carpenter.
6. Beṛua from Byaḍa, Beṛ, an inclosure.
7. Pôd.
8. Baqqál.

The Hálwah claim precedence over all the others, not only as being of purer descent, but as preserving the old tribal customs unchanged. They associate with and marry into Karrál families, but repel the other classes. The Pôd, numerous in Hughlí and Jessore, but unknown in Dacca, are cultivators, potters, and club-men (Láṭhíyals).

Although subdivided according to trades Chaṇḍáls actually work at anything. They are the only Hindus employed in the boats (Bajrá) hired by Europeans, they form a large proportion of the peasantry, and they are shopkeepers, goldsmiths, blacksmiths, oilmen, as well as successful traders. They are, however, debarred from becoming fishermen, although fishing for domestic use is sanctioned. In the census returns of 1872, the Chaṇḍáls, correctly included among the semi-Hinduized aborigines, are met with in every district of Bengal, forming, however, a very small fraction of the population in the most northern, western, and south eastern divisions. They are chiefly congregated in the districts of Báqirganj (326,755); Jessore (271,325); Dacca (191,162); Farrídpúr (156,223); Mymensingh (123,262); and

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Silhet (122,457), forming a total of 1,191,184 persons, or 73 per cent. of the whole Chaṇḍál race in Bengal, which comprises 1,620,545 individuals.

The Chaṇḍáls of Eastern Bengal have only one gotra, the Kaṣyapa, and the large majority are Vaishnavas in creed. They have a Patit Bráhman of their own, but he is not so necessary to them as to the Ṣúdra castes. The washerman and barber are Chaṇḍáls, as professional workmen decline to assist them. The Bhúinmálí is loth to work for them, there being much secret jealousy between the castes, which in some places has broken out into open feuds. At village festivals the Chaṇḍál is treated as equal in rank with the Bhúinmálí and Chamár, and obliged to put off his shoes before he sits down in the assembly. The clean Ṣúdra castes occasionally, and the unclean tribes always, sit with the Chaṇḍál, and at times will accept his dry pipe. Nevertheless, vile as he is according to Hindu notions, the Chaṇḍál is polluted if he touches the stool on which a Súnrí is sitting. Futhermore, the Ṣúdra Bráhmans will nowadays eat food in a rich Chaṇḍál's house, and a Ṣrotriyá will accept of a meal, but not partake of it within his walls, although were he to do so in the utterly vile Sáha's house, he would be irretrievably lost.

The Chaṇḍál is very particular as regards caste prejudices. He never allows an European to stand or walk over his cooking place on board a boat, and if his master inadvertently does so, while the food is preparing, it is at once thrown away. He is also very scrupulous about bathing before meals, and about the cleanliness of his pots and pans. Still more, he takes a pride in his boat, and the tidy state in which he keeps it contrasts forcibly with the appearance of one manned by Muhammadan boatmen.

Many customs characteristic of non-Aryan tribes are being gradually abandoned by the Nama-Ṣúdra. Widow marriage, formerly universally practised, has within a few years been prohibited, and the Chaṇḍální bride, who in old days walked, is now carried in state in a palanquin. Although he has adopted many Hindu ideas, the Chaṇḍál still retains his partiality for spirits and swine's flesh.

After the birth of a male child, the Chaṇḍál mother is ceremonially unclean for ten days, but for a female child the period varies from seven to nine days. Should the child die within eighteen months, a Ṣráddha is observed after three nights, but should it live longer, the obsequial ceremony is held at the expiration of ten days. On the sixth day after the birth of a boy, the Shashṭhí Púja is performed, but omitted if the child be a girl. Whenever a Chamáín, or Ghulám Káyasth female, is

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not at hand, the Chaṇḍální acts as midwife, but she never takes to this occupation as a means of livelihood.

The Chaṇḍáls retain many peculiar religious customs, survivals of an ancient and time-worn cultus. At the Vástu Púja on the Paush "Sankránt," when the earth personified is worshipped, the Chaṇḍáls celebrate an immemorial rite, at which the caste Bráhman does not officiate. They pound rice, work it up into a thin paste, and colouring it red or yellow, dip a reversed cup into the mess, and stamp circular marks with it on the ground around their cottages and on the flanks of the village cattle. This observance, not practised by any other caste, has for its object the preservation of the village and its property from the enmity of malignant spirits.

Throughout Bengal the month of Srávan (July-August) is sacred to the goddess of serpents, Manasa Deví, and on the thirtieth day, the Chaṇḍáls in Eastern Bengal celebrate the "Náo-Ka-Púja," literally boat worship, or as it is more generally called, "Chaṇḍál Kúdní," the Chaṇḍáls rejoicing. As its name imports, the occasion is a very festive one, in Silhet being observed as the great holiday of the year. The gods and goddesses of the Hindu mythology are paraded, but the queen of the day is the great snake goddess, Manasa Deví. A kid, milk, plantains, and sweetmeats are offered to her, and the day is wound up with processions of boats, boat races, feasting, and drinking. On the Dacca river the sight is singularly interesting. Boats manned by twenty or more men, and decked out with flags, are paddled by short rapid strokes to the sound of a monotonous chaunt, and as the goal is neared, loud cries and yells excite the contending crews to fresh exertions. The Kuṭí Muhammadans compete with the Chaṇḍáls for prizes contributed by wealthy Hindu gentlemen.

The Chaṇḍál is one of the most lovable of Bengalis. He is a merry, careless fellow, very patient and hard working, but always ready, when his work is done, to enjoy himself. Chaṇḍáls are generally of very dark complexions, nearer black than brown, of short muscular figures and deep expanded chests. A few are handsome, but their dark sparkling eyes and merry laugh make ample amends for their generally plain features. Singing is a favourite amusement, and a Chaṇḍál crew is rarely without some musical instrument with which to enliven the evening after the toils of the day. When young, the Chaṇḍál is very vain of his personal appearance, always wearing his hair long, and when in holiday attire, combing, oiling, and arranging it in the most winsome fashion known. Many individuals among them are tall and muscular, famed as clubmen and watchmen. During the anarchy that accompanied the downfall

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of the Maghal power, the rivers of Bengal swarmed with river Thugs, or Ḍákáíts, who made travelling unsafe, and inland trade impossible. The Chaṇḍáls furnished the majority of these miscreants, but since their dispersion the Chaṇḍál has become a peaceable and exemplary subject of the English Government.

DHOBÁ, DHOBÍ, DHÁVAKA.

The polite term for a washerman in Bengali is Sabhá-sundar, and is in common use among the people; but in Sanskrit it is Rajaka.

In Eastern Bengal the caste has two great divisions (Śreṇí), Ṣíta, and Ráma; the former claiming to be the descendants of the washermen of Ṣíta, the latter of the washermen of Ráma. The two divisions eat and drink together, but never intermarry. There is only one title (Padaví) among them, Ṣákalya, derived from the name of a Muní, whose sons, owing to a curse, became degraded washermen. In Dacca, moreover, they have only one gotra, the Aliman.

The Dhobí is reckoned as vile, because he washes the puerperal garments, which, according to Hindu ideas, is the occupation of the outcast and most abandoned races. The Dhobí, notwithstanding, assumes many airs, and lays down a fanciful standard of rank to suit his pleasure. Thus in Bikrampúr he declines to wash for the Patní, Ṛishi, Bhúinmálí, and Chaṇḍál, but works for the Sáha, because the Nápit does so, and for all classes of fishermen. He further refuses to attend at the marriages of any Hindus but those belonging to the Nava-Ṣákha, or nine clean castes; and under no circumstances will he wash the clothes worn at funeral ceremonies.

The village Dhobí often holds Chákarán land, receiving presents at all village festivals.

The presence of the washerman is indispensable at marriages of the higher classes, as on the bridal morn he sprinkles the bride and bridegroom with water collected in the palms of his hands from the grooves of his washing board (Pát), and, after the bride has been daubed with turmeric, the Dhobí must touch her to signify that she is purified.

Dhobies have a Bráhman of their own, who officiates at all religious ceremonies. As a class they are Varishnava in creed, a few only being Ṣákta.

Those resident in the city, numbering about two hundred and fifty families, intermarry freely with their brethren living in

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villages. Bright colours being admired by washermen, the fashionable bridal dress is either red or yellow, rarely white; while the bridal crown (Mukuṭa) is of the same colour as the dress. The marriage ceremonies are in every respect the same as those of other Ṣúdra castes.

The city Dhobies have no permanent union (Dal); but whenever disputes arise, or their interests are endangered, they quickly form one, reserving for such occasions a headman, or Parámánik.

Among the natives of Bengal the washerman, like the barber, is proverbially considered untrustworthy, and when the former says the clothes are almost ready he is not to be believed. The Bengali Dhobi is not so dissipated as his Hindustani namesake, whose drinking propensities are notorious, but he is said to indulge frequently in Gánjha smoking.

The washerman is hardworking, regular in his hours of labour, and generally one of the first workmen seen in the early morning, making use of a small native bullock, as the donkey does not thrive in Bengal, for carrying his bundles of clothes to the outskirts of the town. He cannot, however, be said to be a careful washerman, as he treats fine and coarse garments with equal roughness, but for generations the Dacca Dhobies have been famous for their skill, when they choose to exert it, and early in this century it was no uncommon thing for native gentlemen to forward valued articles of apparel from Calcutta to be washed and restored by them. At the present day, Dhobies from Kochh Bihár, and other distant places, are sent while young to learn the trade at Dacca.

For washing muslins and other cotton garments, well or spring water is alone used; but if the articles are the property of a poor man, or are commonplace, the water of the nearest tank or river is accounted sufficiently good. The following is their mode of washing. The cloth is first cleansed with soap, or fuller's earth, then steamed, steeped in earthern vessels filled with soap-suds, beaten on a board, and finally rinsed in cold water. Indigo is in as general use as in England, for removing the yellowish tinge, and whitening the material. The water of the wells and springs, bordering on the red laterite formation, met with on the north of the city, has been for centuries celebrated, and the old bleaching fields of the European factories were all situated in this neighbourhood. Dhobies use rice starch before ironing and folding clothes, for which reason no Bráhman canper form his devotions, or enter a temple, without first of all rinsing in water the garment he has got back from the washerman.

Various plants are used by Dhobies to clarify water, such as

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the "Nir-malí" (*Strychnos potatorum*), "Pui" (*Basella*), "Nágphaní" (*Cactus Indicus*), and several plants of the Mallow family. Alum, though not much valued, is sometimes used.

The Dhobí often gives up his caste trade, and follows the profession of a writer, messenger, or collector of revenue (Tahsíldár), and it is an old native tradition that a Bengali Dhobí was the first interpreter the English factory of Calcutta had, while it is further stated, that our early commercial transactions were solely carried on through the agency of low caste natives. The Dhobí, however, will never engage himself as an indoor servant in the house of an European.

DOAI, DOÍ.

This is a low, mixed class of cultivators, met with in various parts of Eastern Bengal, especially along the banks of the Lakhya river. They either reside in villages separate from those of the Hindus, or in outlying quarters of Hindu villages, along with the Paṭní, Ṛishi, and Bhúinmálí. About a hundred and fifty houses inhabited by them are scattered throughout the jungle at Palás on the Lakhya; but they are still more numerous farther up the river, at Toke and Kapásia, while in the whole Dacca district they occupy about 1,500 houses, with a population of nearly 6,500 individuals. None of the caste are met with farther south than Nángalbandh, opposite old Sunnárgáon, and they place their original home at, or near, Susang Durgápúr, in Mymensingh.

The Doaí of the Eastern districts is distinct from the "Dauyi," described by Buchanan,[1] as the most depraved of the Kochh, and the most impure of the Rájbansí. They are not mentioned by Colonel Dalton. The Doaís of Rangpúr, Mr. Damant, C.S., states, have no Bráhmans, but employ members of their own caste as Purohits, and any stray Bairágí as Guru, the Ṣráddha being held on the eleventh day after decease. They eat pork and drink spirits, while their principal occupation is carrying palankins and fishing. The physiognomy of the "Dauyi" differs from that of the Kochh, with whom they have no tribal affinity.

The Doaí of Dacca are quite different, being undoubtedly a composite race. Some are short, squat men, with an Indo-Chinese type of features; others are tall and muscular, with

[1] Vol. iii. pp. 545, 586.

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large black eyes, aquiline noses, and a profusion of hair on the face, while their complexion is of a light brown. The average height of five adult men, taken at random, was five feet three and a half inches, a standard the same as the average of Bengalis.

There can be little doubt that the Doaís are allied to the Hajaṇg, a mongrel Garo tribe,[1] inhabiting villages in the Mymensingh and Silhet districts, bordering on the Garo hills, who, under Bráhmanical influence, have broken off from their brethren the hillmen. The Doaí are also known as "Lakhí-putra," or children of Lakshmí, and Páṭia Dás, from the matting (Páṭ), which they make. The derivation of the word Doaí is obscure. Hodgson gives "Doí" as the Bodo for water, and it may be that on becoming fishermen this name was given, as Jaliyá has been to the Bengali fisher tribes. At the present day the Doaís have become so thoroughly Hinduized, and have so completely lost their original language and customs, that very little information can be got from them. They have Patit Bráhmans of their own, who confess to having been their priests for three generations only. The weddings and funerals are the same as those of other low caste Hindus, the Śráddha being likewise celebrated on the thirtieth day. The Doaí will drink from the vessels of the lowest Śúdras, but even the Bhúinmálí is disgraced if he drinks from theirs. They disavow the use of pork and spirits, although their neighbours affirm that indulgence in both is universal. They all belong to one gotra, the Aliman, and their sole title is Dás. Disputes are settled by a headman, Pradhán, whose office is not hereditary.

Their religious festivals are Hindu, the majority being Vaishnavas, while a Gosáin or Bairágí is the Guru. Before felling a Gujálí or Śál tree, offerings are made to Chandí, or Durga, the Bráhman officiating; while (if their word is to be believed) no religious rite is ever celebrated without the guidance of the family priest.

Living as they always do on the edge of the forest, they cut firewood for the market, but never become fishermen for profit, nor engage themselves as boatmen. Having lost their ancestral language, they occasionally learn to read and write Bengali, being employed as Tahsíldárs, or rent-collectors, by landlords; while the illiterate become watchmen and messengers. The villagers assert that the Doaí only speak Bengali, never using words foreign to the vernacular.

[1] Doi is a division of the Kochh-Mandai.

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ḌÔM, ḌOMṚÁ, ḌOMA, ḌOMBRA, ḌAMA.

There is a painful interest attaching to this helot race, which has for ages been treated as the very dregs of humanity, and condemned to perform the most degrading and disgusting servile duties. That the race is not of Aryan descent is evident from the prevalent type of physique and complexion, but its exact position among the families of the Indian peninsula is still undetermined. Dr. Caldwell[1] connects the Ḍôms, Pariahs, and Chaṇḍálas with the Dravidian race, and conjectures that prior to the Aryan invasion they were reduced to the condition of slaves; but another theory allies them with certain aboriginal races inhabiting India anterior to the Dravidian migration, who took refuge from the intruders in mountain fastnesses and pestilential jungles, which races have been included by Lenormant[2] in "la race mélanienne aux chevaux plats et non laineux," analogous to the blacks of Australia. It is remarkable that in Kamáon the Ḍôms, said to be of the same lineage as the Ráwat, or Rájí, a tribe of undoubted aboriginal blood, whom they serve as slaves, differ from their masters in having curly hair inclining to wool, and in being all extremely dark.[3] The Ḍôm of Bengal, however, has none of these characteristics. His hair is long, lank, and coarse, while his complexion is oftener of a brown than a black hue.

Sir H. Elliot,[4] on the other hand, traces the original home of the Ḍôm to the banks of the Rohini in Oudh, but the correctness of this supposition has been disputed, and a possible connection between the Ḍôm and Donwár, or Rájput cultivators of Gorakhpúr, has been hazarded.[5] Buchanan, again, identified Ḍôms with the Ḍomtikár, a division of Sarwaria Bráhmans.[6]

There can be no doubt, however, that the term Ḍôm is indiscriminately applied to many predatory and outcast tribes, who have nothing in common, but their degraded position in the eyes of the people. For instance, in the valley of the Brahmaputra, boatmen and fishermen are always called Ḍôms, or Ḍôm-Paṭní; in Chittagong Ḍôm is the title of all fishermen, irrespective of caste; in Oudh of sweepers; and in Arakan of pagoda slaves.[7] The genuine Ḍôms have, moreover, broken up into many tribes. The Maghaiyá Ḍôms are professional thieves, with the same vagabond propensities as the gypsies; the Múshahar Ḍôms of Bihár are hunters who wander throughout

[1] "Grammar of the Dravidian Languages," p. 546.
[2] "Manuel d'Histoire Ancienne," tome iii, 401.
[3] "Asiatic Researches," xvi, 160.
[4] "Supplemental Glossary," i, 84.
[5] "Notes on the Races of Avadh." By P. Carnegy, p. 24.
[6] "Eastern India," ii, 453.
[7] "Journal A.S. of Bengal," x, 679.

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Eastern Bengal shooting tigers, and trapping wild animals; and the town, or scavenger, Ḍôm, or Murda-farosh, is the carrier and undertaker employed at the burial of the dead, with whom Ḍôms manufacturing mats, baskets, and drums, repudiate all relationship.

According to the census returns of 1872, there were in Bengal 222,899 Ḍôms, in Bihar 100,114, and in Orissa 10,615. It is probable, however, that under this head have been included other outcast tribes, as the Paṭní, for in Dacca, where 641 are returned, it is certain that not a single real Ḍôm is domiciled outside the city, while within its limits not more than twenty houses are occupied by them, which indicates a population of about a hundred souls. A tradition survives among the Dacca Ḍôms, that in the days of the Nawábs their ancestors were brought from Patna for employment as executioners (Jallád) and disposers of the dead, hateful duties which they perform at the present day. On the paid establishment of each magistracy a Ḍôm hangman is borne, who officiates whenever sentence of death is carried out. On these occasions he is assisted by his relatives, and as the bolt is drawn, shouts of "Dohái Mahárání!" or "Dohái Judge Sáhib!" are raised to exonerate them from all blame.

By all classes of Hindus the Ḍôm is regarded with both disgust and fear, not only on account of his habits being abhorrent and abominable, but also because he is believed to have no humane or kindly feelings. To those, however, who view him as a human being, the Ḍôm appears as an improvident and dissolute man, addicted to sensuality and intemperance, but often an affectionate husband and indulgent father. As no Hindu can approach a Ḍôm, his peculiar customs are unknown, and are therefore said to be wicked and accursed.

For example, it is universally believed in Bengal that Ḍôms do not bury or burn their dead, but dismember the corpse at night, like the inhabitants of Tibet, placing the pieces in a pot, and sinking them in the nearest river or reservoir. This horrid idea probably originated from the old Hindu law which compelled the Dôms to bury their dead at night. According to their own account, which must, however, be accepted with hesitation, the dead are cast into a river, while the bodies of the rich or influential are buried. When the funeral is ended each man bathes, and successively touches a piece of iron, a stone, and a lump of dry cow-dung, afterwards making offerings of rice and spirits to the manes of the deceased, while the relatives abstain from flesh and fish for nine days. On the tenth day a swine is slaughtered, and its flesh cooked and eaten, after which quantities of raw spirits are drunk until every body is intoxicated.

Their marriage ceremonies are also peculiar. The guests

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being assembled on a propitious day, fixed by a Bráhman, the bridegroom's father takes his son on his knee, and sitting down in the centre of the "Marocha" opposite the bride's father, who is holding his daughter in a similar posture, repeats the names of his ancestors for seven generations, while the bride's father runs over his for three. They then call God to witness the ceremony, and the bridegroom's father addressing the other, asks him, "Have you lost your daughter?" The answer being in the affirmative, a similar interrogation and reply from the opposite party terminates the service.

The boy bridegroom then advances, smears the bride's forehead with "Sindúr" or red lead, the symbol of married life, takes her upon his knee, and finally carries her within doors. Like all aboriginal races, Ḍôms are very fond of gaudy colours, the bridal dress consisting of yellow or red garments for the female, and a yellow cloth with a red turban for the male.

In some parts of Bengal the Ḍôms have a priest called Dharma-Paṇḍit; in Bihár Ḍôm-Bráhman, but the Dacca community have not as yet procured the services of one. They are not on this account less attentive to their religious duties. Many Ḍôms belong to the "Panthá," or doctrines of a certain Súpan, or Ṣobhana, Bhagat, a famed Guru of theirs; while others are Hariṣ-chandís[1] from a Rájah Hariṣ-chandra,[2] who was so generous that he gave away all his wealth in charity, and was reduced to such straits that he took service with a Ḍôm, who treated him kindly. In return the Rájah converted the whole tribe to his religion, which they have faithfully followed ever since.

The principal festival of the Ḍôms is the Śrávannia Púja, observed in the month of that name, corresponding to July and August, when a pig is sacrificed, and its blood caught in a cup. This cup of blood, along with one of milk and three of spirits, are offered to the Deity. Again, on a dark night of Bhádra (August) they offer a pot of milk, four of spirits, a fresh cocoanut, a pipe of tobacco, and a little Indian hemp, to Harí Rám, after which swine are slaughtered, and a feast celebrated.

[1] Wilson's "Religious Sects," i, 181.

[2] It is of this Rájah that the natives of Bengal tell the following story, so strangely like that narrated in the xviiith chapter of the Koran regarding Moses and Joshua. He and his Rání, wandering in the forest almost starved, caught a fish and broiled it on a wood fire. She took it to the river to wash off the ashes, but on touching the water the fish revived, and swam away. At the present day a fish called Kálbosa (*Labeo calbasu*), of black colour and yellow flesh, is identified with the historical one, and no low caste Hindu will touch it. In Hindustan the following couplet is quoted, the moral being the same as that of the English proverb, "Misfortunes never come singly."

"Rájah Nal par bihat pare
Bhúne machhle jal men tire."

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Although the Ḍôm eats the flesh of swine, domestic fowls, and ducks, he abstains from beef, and, in Assam, from buffalo meat. He will eat with a Muhammadan in his house, but refuses to touch, or perhaps more correctly denies in public that he ever touches, food brought from a Christian's table. He will, moreover, feast upon the leavings of any Hindu dinner, except that of the Dhobí, who in his eyes is utterly vile from washing the Chhaṭhi garments after childbirth.

In Eastern Bengal the Ḍômni, or female Ḍôm, only performs as a musician at the weddings of her own people, it being considered derogatory for her to do so at any others. At home the Ḍômni manufactures baskets and rattles for children.

The presence of the Ḍôm at any gathering of pure Hindus defiles them all, but his services at the funeral pyre, when the whole assemblage is unclean, was formerly essential. Of late years, at any rate in Dacca, household servants carry the body to the burning "Ghát," where the pyre constructed by them is lighted by the nearest relative.

A curious custom, observed by all castes throughout Bengal, has the Ḍôm as a participator. Whenever an eclipse of the sun or moon occurs, each Hindu householder places at his door a few copper *paisa*, which are regarded as the perquisite of the Ḍôm.[1]

The Áchárjí Bráhman has recently been claiming this oblation as his due; but it is admitted on all hands that formerly he would have spurned the gift. If the worship of Ráhu is acknowledged to have been adopted by the Bráhmans from the Dosáds, may not the presentation of offerings to the Ḍôms be a survival of a cultus of which this aboriginal race were the recognised exponents.

It is a strange fact that Ḍôms have occasionally raised themselves to positions of distinction and authority. One Nábhají Ḍôm wrote, in the sixteenth century, the Bhakta Málá, a treatise highly valued by the Rámávats; and another, 'Alí Bakhsh Ḍôm, became governor of Rasúlábád, one of the districts of Oudh.[2]

DOSÁD, DOSÁDH.

This semi-Hinduized aboriginal tribe is not numerous in Eastern Bengal, and in the city of Dacca there are not more than fifteen or twenty families of them who lay claim to a more dignified position than is conceded in their native districts of

[1] Wilson's "Religious Sects," i, 60.
[2] Sleeman's "Journey through the Kingdom of Oude," i, 317.

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Tirhut and Mungír. They are employed as house bearers, syces, pankhá coolies, and porters. As a rule the young men are handsome, of a yellowish-brown complexion, with wide expanded nostrils, and the tip of the nose slightly *retroussé*.

Dosáds claim to be descended from the soldiers of Bhím Sen, and to be allied to the Cherú-Chaṇḍáls, while at least one of their deities connect them with the Puraniyá district. The following six subdivisions are recognised :—

Maghaiyá,	Kanaujiyá,
Palawár,	Keot,
Kúrí,	Kúril.

The majority of Dosáds belong to the first, a fact which Buchanan thought indicated that Magadha was their native land. In Maithila, where the Dosáds are styled Hazárás, three small tribes, known as Kámar, or beef-eaters, Palawár, and Kúrin, had separated from the parent stock and been excommunicated. By many Bahaliyás the claim of being Dosáds is insisted on, and in Bengal the Bahaliyá and Dosád eat and smoke together.

In Bihár, Dosád has come to be synonymous with Chaukídár, as all the watchmen belong to that tribe. Although Dosáds are no longer employed as executioners and carriers of dead bodies, they are often found feeding pigs and curing pork.

The most interesting point about the Dosáds, however, is their peculiar religious ceremonies. The demon Ráhu is their patron deity, and in fulfilment of vows, sacrifices are offered to him, when a Bhagat or Chaṭiyá presides. Dr. Buchanan regarded the worship of Ráhu as a survival of an early aboriginal cultus, which the Dosáds were one of the last to give up, and, as they were found reluctant to abandon it, the Bráhmans transformed Ráhu into an "Asura," or demon, and placed him in their Pantheon. Whenever the worship is to be performed in Bengal, priests are procured from Bihár, who are always Dosáds. A ladder, made with sides of green bamboos and rungs of sword-blades, is raised in the midst of a pile of burning mangoe wood, through which the Bhagat walks barefooted, and ascends the ladder without injury. Swine of all ages, a ram, wheaten flour, and rice-milk (Khír), are offered up, after which the worshippers partake of a feast, and drink enormous quantities of fiery spirits.

Next in importance to the worship of Ráhu is that of various deified heroes, in honour of whom huts are erected in different parts of the country. At Sherpúr, near Patna, is the shrine of Gauraiá, a Dosád bandit chief, to which members of all castes resort, the clean making offerings of meal, the unclean sacri-

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ficing a swine, or several young pigs, and pouring out libations of spirit on the ground. In the Taráí, Salesh, said to have been the porter of Bhím Sen, but afterwards a formidable robber, is invoked, a pig being killed, and rice, ghi, sweetmeats, and spirits offered. In other districts Choár Mal is supplicated, and a ram sacrificed. In Mirzápúr, the favoured deity is Bhindáchal; in Patna it is either Bándí, Kárú, Bhairav, Jagdá Má, Kálí, Deví, Pataneṣvarí, or Ketú.

It is worthy of notice that in none of these shrines are there any idols, and that the officiating priests are always Dosáds, who minster to the Śúdra castes frequenting them.

The Sákádvípa Bráhmans act as the hereditary Purohits of the Dosáds, and fix a favourable day for weddings, and the naming of children. To the great indignation of other tribes these Bráhmans assume the aristocratic title of Miṣra, which properly belongs to the Kanaujiyá order. The Guru, called Gosáin, Faqír, Vaishnava, or simply Sádhu, abstains from all manual labour, and from intoxicating drugs. His text book is the "Gyán-ságar,"[1] or Sea of Knowledge, believed to have been written by Vishnu himself, in his form of Chatur-bhuja, or the four-armed. It inculcates the immaterial nature of God (Nirákára), which is regarded by the Bráhmans as a most pernicious heresy.

Dosáds follow the ordinary Hindu ceremonies at marriages, but they often take more than one wife, and the Sagáí, or Levirate marriage custom, is not unknown at the present day.

The female Dosád is unclean for six days after confinement, when she bathes, but is not permitted to touch the household utensils till the twelfth day, when a feast, Bárahí, is given, and she becomes ceremonially clean.

During the Muhammadan rule in Bengal, Dosáds, or Bahaliyás, served in the army, and during the Nawábship of 'Alí Vardí Khán, the native historian[2] stigmatises their licentious conduct as a disgrace to the government.

From the days of William Hamilton[3] it has been generally believed that in the early period of our military history, "Bengali Sepoys almost exclusively filled several of our battalions, and distinguished themselves as brave and active soldiers;" but, as pointed out by Mr. Shore,[4] for years before the battle of Plassey, the troops in Bengal were chiefly composed of Hindustání recruits enlisted there. Futhermore, the

[1] Literally Jnána-sagara.

[2] "A Narrative of the Transactions in Bengal," translated by F. Gladwin, p. 177.

[3] Vol. i, 95.

[4] Shore, F. J. ii, 432.

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Sepoys who served under Lord Clive were, according to Mr. Reade, Dosáds,[1] and they cannot be regarded as Bengalís in the true and ordinary sense of the word.

The majority of Dosáds belong to the Śrí Náráyana sect, but others follow the "Panthá," or doctrines, of Kabír Sáhib, Tulasí Dás, Gorakhnáth, or Nának Sháh.

GAḌARIYÁ.

In the census returns only 604 members of this shepherd caste are entered as resident in Bengal proper, while in Bihár 87,017 are enrolled. Only fifteen families are domiciled in Dacca, being employed in making blankets, hence the name Kammalí often bestowed on them.

The Gaḍariyá is reckoned higher in rank than the Ahír, and equal to the Majrotí and Kṛishnaut Goálás. Buchanan, further, identifies them with the Kuramba, or Kuraba, of Maisúr, who are likewise shepherds.

The Gaḍariyá have the customary seven subdivisions, but the most important are the Níkhar and Dhengár. A few, who have become Muhammadans, are styled Chak, the Hindi for a shepherd, or Chikwá, a butcher, who slaughters animals, but not bullocks. The Bakrá-Kasáí, or goat butcher, is another family who secretly kill cattle.

In Bihár and Bengal this caste is generally reckoned a clean one, but in Puraniyá it is impure. The Gaḍariyá is often found working as a domestic servant, refusing, however, to carry bathing water for his master, or to rinse his body clothes after bathing. He cannot, without incurring expulsion, serve as a cowherd with any but Gaḍariyá masters. He may, however, take household service with any class, even with Christians. Among themselves old men are addressed as Bhagat, or Chaudharí, young men as Rám. Many of this caste are followers of Daryá Dás, a Gaḍariyá,[2] who founded a corrupt Vaishnava sect, abstaining from touching fish, flesh, or spirits. His followers do not worship him as a deity, but simply regard him as their Guru.

The caste Guru is usually a Dasnámí ascetic, the Purohit a Kanaujiyá, but oftener a low Joshí Bráhman.

Gaḍariyá women are unclean from seven to twelve days after confinement, when a feast called "Chhaṭhiyán," is given to

[1] "Note on Inferior Castes, &c," p. 16.
[2] Buchanan, i, p. 499, states that he was a Darzí.

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friends and relatives. The Levirate and widow marriage customs are still observed by the caste.

When a flock of sheep is sold, the Gaḍariyá keeps back a ram, and having assembled his brethren, sacrifices it to Banjárí, after which its flesh is eaten by those who follow the Ṣaiva ritual.

Gaḍariyás make wethers themselves, and like the Highland shepherds are very partial to "Perauntí," or "niceties," which they recommend as a very strengthening delicacy.

GANDHA-BANIK.

This caste claims to be the same as the Banyá of Hindustan, and traces its descent from Chandra Bhava, commonly called Chand Saudágar, "an accomplished man, the son of Koṭíṣ-Vara, the lord of crores," and Sáha Saudágar, mentioned in the Padma Puráṇa. Although this ancient lineage is assumed, the caste no longer wears the Bráhmanical thread; and, instead of mourning like the Agarwálá Banyás for thirteen, mourns like pure Ṣúdras for thirty days.

Another story of their origin is current. Kubja, the hunch-backed slave girl of Rájah Kaṇsa, was carrying home spices and sandal wood when Kṛishna first met her. The son born of their subsequent liaison was naturally the first spice seller, and the father of all Gandha-baniks.

In Bengal this caste numbers 127,178 individuals, being most numerous in Burdwan, 32,105, Murshídábád 11,016, Bírbhúm 10,165, Nadiyá 8,010, and Dacca 6,634. In the city of Dacca alone from one hundred and fifty to two hundred houses, representing a population of about a thousand, are occupied by them.

The Gandha-baniks of Eastern Bengal have four Ṣreṇí, or subdivisions, namely, Aút, Desá, Sankhá, and Chhattís, or thirty-six; the three last intermarrying and eating together. The Aút has a family called Dhaula, the Desá one named Dhallár, after villages where they resided, while other Ṣreṇí are to be found in the neighbourhood of Calcutta and Murshídábád. The titles of the Aút Ṣreṇí are Dutta, Dhur, Kar, Nág, Dhár, and Dé; of the Desá, Sáha, Sádhú, Laha, and Kahn. The caste has six powerful dals, or unions, in Dacca city, the Dalpatís, or headmen being persons of great respectability. In one of the "dals" a curious marriage custom, said to have been observed by their forefathers when they first entered Bengal, is still preserved.

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The bridegroom climbs a "Champa"[1] tree, and sits there while the bride is carried round on a stool seven times. Should no tree be available, a Champá log, placed beneath a canopy, or a platform made of Champá wood planks, is substituted and ornamented with gilt flowers resembling the real Champá blossoms.

The other "dals," who follow the usual Śúdra marriage service, privately associate with this one, but never publicly.

Bridal dresses are made of yellow silk (Cheolí) with a red striped border, the bride wearing hers for ten days after marriage.

The large majority of Gandha-baniks are Vaishnavas, a few Śaivas.

All Bengalí shopkeepers worship Gandheśvarí, a form of Durgá, every morning and evening; but on the full moon of Baisakh (April-May) the Gandha-baniks hold a special service in her honour, arranging in a pyramidal form the weights, scales, drugs, and account books, and placing in front a goblet daubed over with red lead. The caste Bráhman then comes and repeats several invocations, soliciting the favour of the goddess during the ensuing year.

The Gandha-banik is a spice seller, or "Épicier," as well as a druggist. He will not sell rice, vegetables, salt, oil, or spirits, but he will almost every other grocery. He is often called by the Hindi term "Pansárí," which signifies a dealer in groceries, spices, and herbs. Their comparatively high position among Śúdra castes is owing to the circumstance that sandal wood and spices, essential for Hindu religious rites, can only be procured at their shops.

The Gandha-banik obtains his drugs and spices direct from Calcutta, or from the place where they are produced, and buys quinine, iodide of potassium, and sarsaparilla from English druggists. He also sells tin, lead, pewter, copper, and iron, and retails, if licensed, saltpetre, sulphur, and gunpowder, as well as chemicals used by pyrotechnists, and dispenses medicines ordered by Kabírájs. Although Gandha-baniks possess no pharmacopœia, and are ignorant of chemistry, they display wonderful sharpness in distinguishing salts and minerals. Every Gandha-banik has the reputation of being a doctor, and like the druggists of Europe, he is often consulted, and prescribes for trifling ailments. Drugs, at the present day, are sold by apothecary's weight, other articles by the bazar weight of eighty sicca to a *ser*. Kabírájs, however, still use the old Hindu weights, "Pala," "Ratí," "Másha," and "Jau." Boys able to read and write Bengali are apprenticed to a Gandha banik, who

[1] Champaka (*Michelia champaca*).

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makes him familiar with the appearance, names, and prices of drugs, which, it is said, amount in a genuine Pansárí's shop to three hundred and sixty kinds. Most of these go to form the different kinds of Páṭ, or alterative medicine, greatly relied on in Hindu therapeutics. The Gandha-banik is expected to know the proper ingredients in each Páṭ, as well as the proper quantity of each. In the preparation of pills, goat's milk, or lime-juice and water, are used, but by some druggists the juice of the Ghí-Kuwár (*Aloe perfoliata*[1]) is preferred.

The Gandha-banik retails "Charas," Bháng, opium, and Gánjha, but some have scruples about selling the last, and employ a Muhammadan servant to do so. Most of the shops for the sale of Gánjha, however, are leased by members of this caste, who pay a Súnṛí, or Muhammadan, to manage them.

GANDHÍ.

The perfumer, who may belong to any caste, or religion, extracts the essences of flowers by maceration and subsequent distillation. The scents generally preferred are those of the "Champa" (*Michelia champaca*), "Belá" (*Jasminum Zambac*), "Vakula," or "Maulsarí" (*Mimusops Elengi*), and "Júhí" (*Jasminum auriculatum*).

The 'Aṭr of roses and "Guláb," or rosewater, prepared in Dacca are inferior in quality to those made at Gházípúr.

GAṆRÁR, GANDHA-KÁRA, GANDHA-ÁRA, GARWÁL.

This caste, more generally known as Shikárí, or hunters, is called by Bengalis Gandhá Pál, Madhu Mayara, or Mayara Gaṇrár, while their villages bear the name of Shikárí-ṭola, or Shikárí-párá.

In the census returns the Gaṇrár is correctly classified along with the Madak, or Mayara, among the castes engaged in preparing cooked food. In Bengal the caste consists of 14,843 persons, scattered in small numbers throughout the province, but grouped in the following districts: Murshídábád (2,384); Nadiyá (2,268); twenty-four pergunnahs (1,847); and Dacca (1,611).

[1] Sanskrit "Ghṛita-Kumárí."

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There can be no doubt that the Gaṇrár caste is the same as the Madhya-deshí Kándús of Bihár. A tradition still survives, that, five generations ago, their ancestors were brought to Dacca by the Muhammadan government from Súrya-gaṛhí in Bhágalpúr, to act as rowers on board the imperial dispatch boats (Chhíp).

The caste is most numerous in Dacca, but they are also met with in Silhet, Tipperah, and Mymensingh, working as cultivators. Buchanan mentions that the Gaṇrár of Rangpúr originally came from Dacca, two hundred families being in his time domiciled along the banks of the Brahmaputra.

In former days the Gaṇrár had the reputation of being the bravest of all boatmen, and the river Dákáíts never dared to attack boats manned by them. Nowadays, they are great traders, carrying in their large cargo boats, called "Palwár," rice, cotton, and linseed, to Calcutta, Bhagwán-golah, and other centres of trade. They generally do business on their own account, and being honest and straightforward, obtain advances of money on most favourable terms from the bankers.

Gaṇrárs use the three-pronged harpoon (Ṭenṭa) with wonderful dexterity, and rarely miss an object within forty yards. If an alligator takes to carrying off bathers from a "Ghát," the Gaṇrárs are employed to kill it. When the brute is seen basking on a sandbank the sportsman crawls up, and strikes it with a harpoon, to the shaft of which a rope and a float are attached. As soon as the animal is hit, it takes to the water, the Gaṇrárs following in a boat, and every time it rises for air spears are implanted, and it is rare for an alligator to escape from these active and persevering assailants.

Gaṇrárs also kill a great many Gangetic porpoises (Sús) for the sake of the oil, which is in great repute for burning, and as an embrocation for rheumatism. It usually sells for three to five rupees a "*man*." Turtle are frequently harpooned for food, and turtle eggs are deemed a great delicacy by these sportsmen.

Gaṇrárs work at almost any trade, but in Dacca nothing will induce them to cultivate the soil. The women are principally employed in parching grain, and selling it in bázárs.

They all belong to one gotra, the Aliman, and the Purohit is a Patit Bráhman. The caste is a Vaishnava one, but deities unknown to the Bráhmanical Pantheon are worshipped. Like most of the low castes they set afloat the "Beṛá" in honour of Khwájah Khizr, and pay especial adoration to Sat Náráyaṇa. Moreover, on the last day of Ṣrávan they sacrifice a turtle to Manasa Deví, the goddess of snakes, and make offerings in the month of Paush to Buṛa-Buṛí.

The Gaṇrárs of Dacca, through Bráhmanical influence, have

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relinquished the worship of Khala-Kumári, who is regarded by the Gaṇrárs of Rangpúr as the Naiad of the river. This worship, a survival of an earlier cultus, is peculiar to the aboriginal races of Bengal, and like that of Buṛa-Buṛí is only found in the outlying districts, where Hinduism has always been least active and aggressive.

Gaṇrárs rarely eat flesh, but they freely indulge in spirits, and often in Ganjha. At the present day widows do not marry, and the Levirate marriage custom is unknown.[1]

GHAṬAKA.

The Ghaṭaks are Bráhmans engaged in negotiating marriages between families, and each Śreṇí, or division, of the sacred order in Bengal, has its recognized staff, upon whom rests the responsibility of arranging suitable marriages, and of preserving the pristine purity of each family belonging to it. The Varendra, Ráṛhí, and Vaidika Bráhmans possess Ghaṭaks distinct from those employed by the Baidyá and Káyath castes, who intermarry with, and act as agents for, the Bráhmans of their own division, but for no others.

The organisation of the society is referred to Ballál Sen, who settled the Ráṛhí Ghaṭaks in Jessore, Báqirganj, and Bikrampúr, where, with the exception of a few who have lately emigrated to Calcutta, they are domiciled at the present day. The Ghaṭak registers of the Ráṛhí Bráhmans, like those of the Kulin Káyaths, go back twenty-three generations, or five hundred years, and, although any Bráhman may become a Ghaṭak, the highest estimation, and the title Pradhán, or chief, is only bestowed on the individual who can show a long and unbroken pedigree of Ghaṭak ancestors.

There are three grades of Ghaṭaks. The first can repeat off-hand the names of all the members of the main, as well as collateral, branches of any family in his particular part of the country; of the families with which they have married, and of the issue of such marriages.

A Ghaṭak possessing a memory as retentive as this is liable at any wedding to be challenged by some youthful aspirant to a "Vichára," or trial of memory, when he must defend the laurels he has won. It is, however, considered not only rash, but unmannerly, for a challenge to be given to an old Ghaṭak, who

[1] Vivien de St. Martin is of opinion that the Gaṇrár, the Goṇrhi of Bihár, the Gangai of the Tarái, are remnants of the Gangaridae of Pliny and Ptolemy.

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has for years retained, against all comers, a position of this pre-eminence.

The second grade embraces those Ghaṭaks who can only give the name of the "Kula," or family into which a Bráhman or his relatives have married; while the third comprises such as can only name the Vaṇṣa, or lineage, to which the Bráhman belongs.

The text books of the Ghaṭaks are the "Darbha-nanda Miṣra Grantha," a Sanskrit treatise intelligible to few, and the "Kulanáma," a work of little value, from its only containing a confused account of the Bráhmans and their subdivisions.

Ghaṭaks never officiate at religious ceremonies, and always employ Purohits for their own requirements. Every Kulin Bráhman in Eastern Bengal is compelled to employ a Ghaṭak in negotiating the marriages of his family, otherwise the whole race of Ghaṭaks revolt and ostracise him. The rich Bráhman Zamíndárs, who are willing and able to pay a large sum for an unexceptionable Kulin bride, often try to convince the Ghaṭaks that their families are of purer and more honourable descent than they actually are. Bribes are often offered to establish the claim, but are rarely accepted. Disputes however, are common, and the Ghaṭaks who favour a claim that is fallacious, and who attend at an unauthorised marriage, fall in the estimation of those who have questioned its soundness, and declined to be present. The scruples of a single Pradhán Ghaṭak often mar the otherwise perfect satisfaction of a parent on the marriage of his son to a family of higher rank than his own; and should all the leaders unite in forbidding the marriage it is impossible for him to win any permanent promotion beyond that laid down in their registers.

Ghaṭaks of similar rank receive equal fees, while at weddings of rich Kulins, at which hundreds attend, the fees are distributed according to a provisional scale, by which Ghaṭaks of the first estimation receive double what the last get. Thus, if the first is given a hundred rupees, the second is entitled to seven-eighths, or eighty-seven rupees; the third to three-fourths, or seventy-five rupees; the fourth to five-eighths, or sixty-two rupees eight anas; and the fifth to a half, or fifty rupees.

At the present day the two most celebrated Pradhán Ghaṭaks are Káli Náth Kabí-ságar, of Kachadía in Bikrampúr, and Gṛish Chandá Ghaṭaka-Siṇha of Kolah, men not only remarkable for their prodigious memories, but for modesty and general information on all subjects connected with Hindu society.

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GOÁLÁ.

The Goálá, one of the most composite and ill-defined of castes, is often confounded with the Ahír. In Bihár the names are synonymous, while in each province of Bengal the members claim to be the only pure representatives of the clean cowherds of ancient India.

Goálás known as Sat-Gop in Burdwan and Hughlí are styled Gop-Goálás in Eastern Bengal, and arrogate to themselves a higher position than the Ahír. The Goálá is always included among the clean Ṣúdra castes of Bengal, but he is not the first in rank as among the Marhátás.

According to the census returns of 1872, the pastoral Goála caste numbers in Bengal 625,163 individuals, the agricultural Sat-Gop 635,985, while in Dacca the former are 22,788, the latter only 1,085, but in reality no Sat-Gop exist there, and Goálás are found indiscriminately cultivating the soil, keeping cattle, and buying milk to manufacture Ghí.

The Goálas of Eastern Bengal are all included in the following list:—

1. Gop, or Ghose, Goálá,
2. Ṣáda[1] Goálá,
3. Áhírs—
   (*a.*) Gauriyá or Go-baidyá.
   (*b.*) Mahisha Goálás.
4. Daira, or outcast Goálás.

The Gop-Goálás are the only pure Ṣúdras, and never intermarry with any of the other families. It is probable that the Goálá is the descendant of the Áhír, and the crucial test of purity with all the septs is the boiling of milk before the cream rises, a practice enjoined by the Ṣástras.

The Gop-Goálás, comprising the large majority of the tribe in Bengal, have two gotras, the Aliman and Kaṣyapa; the former being more numerous and more respected than the latter, and although they eat together, a milkman of the Aliman would be dishonoured if he took a wife from the Kaṣyapa gotra. In Mymensingh there is an additional gotra, called Paráṣara, but none of the Dacca Goálás associate or intermarry with it.

The Goálá Bráhman is a Patit, often acting as Purohit to "Sukṛiti-bhanga," or outcast Bráhmans. Milkmen mourn thirty days, and their domestic occurrences are celebrated in the ordinary Ṣúdra fashion. The betrothal ceremony, however, is observed with unusual solemnity. The bridegroom's father buys sweetmeats, garlands of flowers, and sandal-wood paste,

[1] Perhaps Sádhu, good.

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which he takes to the house of the Mundle or president of the caste "Panchâít," who immediately summons the Guru, Purohit, and all intimate friends to attend, when each guest is presented with a garland and sweetmeats. The Mundle, accompanied by the party, proceeds to the bride's home. She is formally bedecked with flowers, after which the betrothal is considered complete, and, should any insuperable obstacle supervene to prevent the final marriage, the girl is treated as a widow, and cannot marry any one else. The custom of giving and accepting a marriage fee is not observed by the town Goálás, although it still is by the village.

Gop-Goálás, who have a dairy, sell milk, butter, ghí, curdled milk (Dahí), curds (Chhená), "Khirsá," and "Pát-khirsá," or ripe plantains with milk, and occasionally keep buffaloes for milk, although they object to milk goats.

Three breeds of cows are found in Eastern Bengal, the Bengalí (Deśí), the Hindustání (Deswalí), a handsome milk-white animal, said to have been introduced by Nawáb Shaístah Khán, and a cross-breed, called "Dú-naslá." A Dacca milch cow rarely gives more than ten *sérs* of milk thrice a day, but this quantity is never got unless the animal is stall fed, for which reason the finest milch cows of the "Deswálí" breed are always kept in sheds. A fodder consisting of vetches (Mash-kalái[1]), broken rice, rice dust (Kúṇḍá), and salt, is usually given daily, while those who can afford it add rice and oilcake.

A cow is reckoned impure for three weeks after calving, and no Hindu would taste the milk, or Biestings, during that period. Gop-Goálás will not physic or brand cows, as the Áhír does, unless at Śráddhas, when the "Dharm-sánṛ" is branded by them. The following singular treatment of a newly born calf and its mother is in vogue: The calf's mouth is washed out, and the milkman chewing pepper and ginger expectorates into the animal's open mouth. He then cleans the cow's hoofs, and gives her a ball made of ginger, green turmeric, fennel seeds, and molasses, to which a little Indian hemp is usually added.

Like the Áhírs, the Gop-Goálás are very partial to bright, gaudy colours. The bride dresses in red, and on the great annual festivals of the Janmáshṭamí and Gopáshṭamí Goálás appear in red or yellow turbans.

(*a.*) Sádá Goálás.

This division of milkmen has been outcasted for some economical reason. The bride dresses in white (Sáda), hence perhaps the origin of their name.

[1] Sanskrit, "Másha" (*Phaseolus radiatus*).

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(*b.*) Daira Goálas.

This is another outcast division, which became degraded because it makes butter without first scalding the milk. Hence their nickname, "Mogha-Kára."[1] It is generally believed that the name Daira is merely a corruption of the Bengali Dárí, a beard, because many wear beards, having become Muhammadans.

GODNÁ-WÁLÍ.

There being no Natnís in Bengal, Bediyá women travel about the country with a bag, containing a variety of drugs, a cupping horn (Singá), and a scarificator (Náran). They attract attention by bawling "To tattoo, to cup, and to extract worms from decayed teeth!" They also prescribe for female disorders. It is said that small grubs are kept in a bamboo tube, and while the patient's attention is occupied by the talk of the operator, a maggot is presented as if it had been extracted from the hollow tooth. For this trick she receives a suitable fee.

In tattooing the juice of the "Bhangra" plant (*Indigofera linifolia*) and woman's milk are the materials used, and the punctures are made with needles, or the thorns of the Karaundá (*Carissa Carandas*); while the operation is being performed, a very equivocal Mantra is recited to alleviate pain, and prevent any subsequent inflammation.

In respectable Hindu families an old nurse usually tattoos the girls. Nowadays the ordinary tattoo design, either circular or stellate, is made at the top of the nose in the centre of the forehead; formerly the fashionable stain (Ullikhí) was at the same spot, but a line extended along the bridge of the nose, branching out into two curves over each ala.

Tattoo marks were originally distinctive of Hindu females, but Muhammadan women copied them, and it is only since the Farazí revival that they have discontinued the habit.

Chaṇḍál women are often employed to cure goitre by tattooing. A circular spot on the most prominent part of the swelling is punctured with a bamboo spike, and common ink mixed with the sap of the "Kálí Koshijia" rubbed in.

[1] Sanskrit, Mogha-Karman, one whose actions are fruitless.

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HALWAH DÁS.

This is an offshoot from the Kaibartta tribe, and is probably identical with the Chásá Kaibartta and Paráṣara Dás, although the latter protest against this presumption. Very numerous along both banks of the Meghna in the Tipperah and Báqirganj districts, they are rare west of the Lakhya.

The Halwah Dás are chiefly cultivators, weavers of Jámdání muslins, goldsmiths, and stonecutters, while the educated members are clerks and accountants.

The Bráhman of the Halwah Dás and of the cultivating Kaibarttas is the same person; but the priest of the fisher Kaibarttas is distinct. The Ṣúdra servants everywhere work for them. They have three gotras, Aliman, Kaṣyapa, and Madhu Kuliya; and the common patronymics are Dás, Chaudharí, Biṣwas, and Hazrá.

Kálí is chiefly worshipped, but the educated also observe the annual holiday sacred to Sarasvatí, and the cultivators, relinquishing the Ganga Púját, have adopted the Vástu Púját and the Ambuváchí vacation.

The Halwah Dás drink from the water vessels of the clean Ṣúdra Bráhman, but not from those of Patit Bráhmans. Widows never remarry, but the aboriginal crime of eating flesh and drinking spirits is ineradicable.

Among the Halwah Dás there are the same social ranks as with the Paráṣara Dás, the rich endeavouring to assume a higher position, and refusing to give their daughters in marriage to the lower grades.

JALIYÁ.

The occupation of a fisherman is considered a degrading one throughout India, and no Muhammadan will engage in it.[1] For this reason it is usually followed by unclean, and generally non-Aryan, tribes. In Bengal the fisher castes are remarkable for strength, nerve, and independent bearing. The finest examples of Bengali manhood are found among them, and their muscular figures astonish those accustomed to the feeble and effeminate inhabitants of towns. The physique of the Dacca fisherman is

[1] The dishonour clinging to fisher tribes is apparently of Buddhist origin. It is written that "twenty-one kinds of people will, on account of their evil deeds, "fall into the lowest hell. By performing good works, nineteen of these will be "released; but the hunter and the fisherman, let them attend Pagodas, listen "to the law, and keep the five commandments to the end of their lives, still "they cannot be released from their sins." "Buddhaghosás Parables," p. 183, translated from the Burmese by Captain T. Rogers. London, 1870.

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more robust than that of the same class on the Hughlí, a fact noticed by Bishop Heber fifty years ago.

The three fisher castes of Eastern Bengal, the Kaibartta, Málo, and Tíyar, are undoubtedly representatives of the prehistoric dwellers in the Gangetic delta. As a rule they are short and squat, of a dark brown colour, often verging upon black. Although Hindus by creed, they are fond of showy garments, of earrings, and of long hair, which is either allowed to hang down in glossy curls on their shoulders, or fastened in a knot at the back of the head. The whiskers and moustaches are thin and scrubby; the lips often thick and prominent; the nose short with the nostrils expanded. The physiognomy indicates good temper, sensuality, and melancholy rather than intelligence and shrewdness. Their religious ceremonies consist of many survivals from an earlier and more barbarous cultus. Bura-Buri is a patron deity with them; Khala Kumárí is the Naiad of their rivers, while Manasa Deví, a sylvan goddess, is worshipped with exceptional honour, and, among the Tíyars, certain mythical heroes have earned immortality, and the adoration of generations of sincere worshippers.

The three fisher castes live in amity with one another, and will even smoke together. The Málo, however, is the lowest in rank, while the Kaibartta and Tíyar still dispute about their relative positions. The Kaibartta, again, is more thoroughly Hinduized than either of the other two. A ridiculous distinction is always cited in proof of the inferior rank of the Málo. The Kaibartta and Tíyar in netting always pass the netting needle from above downwards, working from left to right; while the Málo passes it from below upwards, forming his meshes from right to left. It is remarkable that the same difference is adduced by the Bihár fisherman as a proof of the degraded rank of the Banpar.

No one belonging to a fisher caste will fish with a rod and line, or use a harpoon as the Shikárís do. Bengal fishermen use the sean, drift, trawl, bag, and cast nets. The Kaibarttas, however, will not employ an Uthár or Ber net, which are favourites with the Tíyar and Málo.

Nets are made of hemp, never of cotton, and they are steeped in Gáb (*Diospyrus glutinosa*) pounded, and allowed to ferment, by which means the net is dyed of a dark brown colour, becoming after immersion in water almost black. Floats are either made of Sholá, or pieces of bamboo, but dried gourds are occasionally preferred. Sinkers are made of baked clay, or iron.

The following are the common nets in use among Bengali fishermen :—

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1. "Jhakí," or "Kshepla," is the circular cast net[1] met with in all Eastern countries. It is usually six or seven cubits in diameter, and is either thrown from the bank of a stream, or from a boat. The circumference is drawn up into loops, or rather puckered, and weighted with iron. It is folded on the left forearm, while the edge and the central string are held by the right hand. By a sudden and forcible swing of the body the net is cast, and, if properly thrown, alights on the surface of the water, forming a complete circle. On its touching the bottom the fisher slowly draws it towards him by the string just mentioned, and, as he does so the heavily weighted edge comes together, and no fish can escape. The outcast Bágdí in central Bengal swings the net round his head before casting it, but no respectable fisherman would dishonour his calling by so doing.

2. The "Uthár" and "Gúltí" are magnified cast nets, differing only in size and in the dimensions of the meshes. They are shot from a boat placed broadside to a stream, with the net folded on the edge. One man holds the centre rope, while two others gradually unfold, and drop it overboard. As the boat drifts the net falls in a circle, and is then slowly drawn up. One of these nets is often forty feet in diameter, and a long boat like the Jalká is required to shoot it from.

3. The "Sángla" is a small trawl net, used for catching "Hilsá." The lower edge of the bag is weighted, and after being shot the boat drifts with the stream. When a fish passing over the lower lip of the net, to which a rope held by the fisherman is attached, is felt to strike the back of the net, it is suddenly raised and the fish secured.

4. The "Baoti" is a fixed bag net, worked on the same principle.

5. "Chándí" is a large drift net, supported by gourds or bamboo floats, and in the water it hangs as a curtain like the herring net, the fish being caught by the gills.

6. Ber is a large sean, or sweep net, often thirty feet in depth, and seven hundred and fifty in length. Several nets are usually joined together to form this "train fleet," or "drift of nets." The upper edge, or back, is buoyed by bamboos, while the lower, or "foot," is weighted with iron. This is the favourite net with the Málos on the Meghna; but owing to its great length it has to be shot from two boats fastened together, and when drawn the two "wings," or ends, are slowly brought ashore.

7. "Besál," or "Khára," is a fixed net, used either from the side of a boat, balanced by an outrigger, or fixed to posts on the banks of rivers. The net is attached to two bamboos, which

[1] Il Giacchio of Italian fishermen.

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meet at an acute angle in the boat, but branching off until separate about fifteen to twenty feet. One man stands at the angle and lowers the net into the water, while another sits at the stern working a paddle with his leg until a certain distance has been passed over, when the net, which is somewhat bagged, is leisurely raised. This net is fancied by Tíyars and Málos, who at the first dawn of day may be seen fishing with it off bathing ghaṭs, and around steamers and vessels anchored in mid stream. Small fry are usually caught with it, but when fixed on the margin of a river, where there is a backwater or an eddy, large and weighty fish are often netted.

8. "Kona" is a large bag net used at the outlets of rivers and streams. The sides are fixed, and the mouth faces the current. The lower lip rests on the bottom, while the upper remains open, and at intervals the former is raised and the fish taken out.

Bengali fishermen are familiar with the habits of fish, and much might be learned from them on a branch of natural history strangely neglected in India. Night is the favourite time for fishing, quiet being necessary for success, and a full moon, or sunset and sunrise, are favourable times for shooting nets. The first of a spring tide is also a period when fish move.

It is a curious coincidence that the English fisherman, when looking for a place to shoot his large drift, or herring net, raps with a piece of wood the planks of his boat, close to the water line. The Málo is equally aware of the fact that brisk undulation of water frightens fish, causing them to move, and as the net is being drawn, a man beats the side of the boat with an oar, by which means the draught is increased.

During the month of mourning for a parent, no fisherman can ply his trade, or have any dealings in fish, unless he gets a special dispensation from the Purohit.

All fishermen object to sell the skate (Ságus), and will not retail in any way but whole the "Pangas" (*Pimelodus pangasius*), "Garua" (*Silurus garua*), and "Gagar" (*Pimelodus gagora*). Neither will they catch, or sell crabs, nor touch the "Putká," or bladder fish.[1] Many of the fisher castes of India have the Muhammadan aversion to fish without scales, and few will eat, or even handle the "Singi" (*Silurus singeo*). Eels, however, they sometimes cook, but owing to the rich and heating properties of the flesh, it is not a favourite article of food. Muhammadans of the Hanífí school never eat amphibious animals, as the crab, consequently the only Bengali Muhammadans who use them as food are the indulgent residents of Chittagong.

[1] The *Tetrodon patoca*. It emits a sound when lifted out of the water, and fills itself with air. Like the *T. Fahaca* of the Nile, it serves as a plaything for fisher children.

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It is unfortunate we cannot estimate the numbers and distribution of the different fisher tribes from the census returns, as the Tíyars are the only ones specified, the others being included under the comprehensive, but indefinite, terms Jaliyá, Mallah and Mánjhi, which are trade not caste names. The total number of persons belonging to the boating and fishing tribes of Bengal proper is returned at 1,301,174, a very low estimate, if we consider the important place fish holds in the native dietary. The correct composition, however, of the population of Bengal can only be ascertained when a better knowledge of the people and of their different classes and subdivisions has been acquired.

JAUHARÍ.

Dealers in precious stones may be either Muhammadans or Hindus, but the more eager purchasers are, as a rule, persons of the former creed. Many shopkeepers sell gems, but the Jauharí can alone distinguish the real from the spurious.

"'Ilm al-jawáhir" is considered a distinct branch of oriental science, dealing with the qualities of gems, the art of distinguishing good from bad stones, and the knowledge of the virtues inherent in each.

According to oriental authorities, the most precious gems are nine in number,[1] each representing a planet. Black is ascribed to Saturn, green to Jupiter, red to Mars, yellow to the sun, and white to the moon. The colour of gems either depend on the matrix in which they are found embedded, or on the direct influence of its particular planet. Transparent stones are supposed to be formed from drops of rain; opaque ones from water and earth, acted on by the sun and the internal heat of the mine (Harárat-i-ma'dan).

The "Nava-ratna," or nine gems, are the following:—

1. Maṇika, Yáqút, Lál.

The ruby is regarded as the king of stones, and though found in Ceylon and Badakhshán, is said to be only genuine in Burmah. A large one exceeding six Ratís in weight is of priceless value; but should the slightest opacity, or flaw, be present, it is considered unlucky to wear it. A ruby, moreover, is believed to be a preservative against certain diseases, and a safeguard against lightning.

The ruby mines of Badakhshán, which supplied the "Rubis balais" of the French, have been closed for many years.

[1] The Vaijayantí, or necklace of Vishnu, is only set with five, namely, pearl, ruby, emerald, sapphire, and diamond. "Vishnu Puráṇa," p. 158.

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2. Muktá, Motí.

Two varieties of pearls are distinguished, the Ceylon and Basra. According to oriental poets they are drops of vernal rain congealed in oyster shells, and by the same fanciful conceit the origin of amber is ascribed to the tears of "sorrowing sea birds." Pearls found in the fresh water rivers of Bengal by the Bediyás being of little value, are chiefly used in medicine. Tavernier mentions that at the court of Sháh Jahán no person of quality ever appeared in public without wearing earrings having a pearl set between two coloured stones.

3. Híra, Vajra, Almás.

Four varieties of diamonds are known in India, the white, red (Lál, or Gulábí), yellow, and green, which, in accordance with the fanciful nomenclature in fashion are distinguished as Bráhman, Kshatriyá, Vaiṣya, and Ṣúdra. The price of diamonds is estimated by their weight and cutting; The English brilliant is most valued, then the Dutch, Benares, "Takícha," and "Púrab," or Eastern cutting, the two latter being ground according to the rough and faulty fashion peculiar to India. The value of a stone in native ideas is enhanced by being large and heavy, and the workmen think more of leaving the stone big than of unveiling its hidden beauties. A variety, from its hardness called "Kaṛá," is spoken of as being so dark that no amount of polishing will brighten it. This is probably the "Carbonado," so much employed in boring rocks. Indian connoisseurs depreciate Cape diamonds as being dull and yellowish. A diamond with a pink or dark streak is considered by the natives of Hindustan as most unlucky.

4. Marakata, Harin-maṇi, Zummurud, Panná.

The emerald is a very favourite stone with Muhammadans, being used to ornament sword hilts, scabbards, and gold cups. Tavernier[1] asserts that it was unknown in India before the conquest of Peru in 1532; but he is undoubtedly wrong. In 1515, Andrea Corsali[2] says, emeralds are in greater estimation in India than any other stone; Garcia de Orta,[3] in 1563, mentions that Peruvian emeralds were then branded as spurious; and De Boot,[4] in 1609, writes, that during the previous fifty years oriental emeralds had fallen in value, owing to the importation of specimens from the New World; but that the Oriental were really better and more perfect stones. Baldaeus,[5] in the seventeenth century, describes three kinds of emeralds in India, the Scythian, Egyptian, and Peruvian, the first being most valued.

[1] II, c. xvi.
[2] "Ramusio," i, 180.
[3] "Aromatum et simplicium, &c.," edition 1567, p. 199.
[4] "Gemmarum et lapidum historia," p. 101.
[5] "Churchill's Voyages," iii, 656.

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Finally, Streeter[1] describes the Indian emerald as of quite a different quality from those found in South America. Where the oriental emerald came from was unknown to De Orta and De Boot; but of late years the emerald mines of Egypt, mentioned by Pliny, have been described by M. Cailliaud.

The popular belief in Hindustan is, that the finest emeralds formed part of a cargo of a vessel wrecked on the west coast of India, belonging to Alexander the Great.

Many virtues have been attributed to the emerald. Greeks and Arabs believed it to be an infallible preservative of chastity, and to facilitate parturition. A dark coloured stone without flaws is, by Al Suyúṭí, and oriental nations generally, considered a safeguard against snake bites, and, being a surety against epilepsy, is recommended to be worn by the children of noble families. An emerald reduced to powder, and given in a draught, cures leprosy.

5. Indra-níla, Nílam, Nílmaṇi, Çafír.

The sapphire comes either from Burmah or Ceylon. In Europe it has always been considered to prevent evil and impure desires; in the East the owner, it is believed, will never become poor, but if it exhibits the slightest flaw he will certainly die suddenly.

6. Go-meda, Go-medaka.

This is described as a red stone with a yellowish tinge, and is either an agate, or a topaz.

7. Lahsaniya, Chashmdár, 'Ain-ul-hirr.

Indian jewellers distinguish three sorts of cat's eye, one with a yellow, a second with a pale green, and a third with a dark shade or streak. Should the gem possess one or more lines of lustre it becomes priceless, being venerated as a sacred stone. On approaching buried treasure the owner will find the stone leave its setting, and as long as he retains it his wealth will never diminish. It is a preservative against many diseases, and all forms of witchcraft. De Orta and Baldaeus, preserve a superstition current in their day, to the effect that cloth rubbed with a cat's eye is rendered fireproof. The former believes in its truth, but the latter says, "I have found this contrary to truth by my own experience."

8. Prabála, Múngá, Marján.

In India red coral is included among gems, being made into beads for necklaces, and into charms for armlets. Tavernier states that coral was used in the seventeenth century "by the meaner sort of people, all over Asia, more especially by the hillmen of Asam and Bhútan for bracelets and necklaces." At

[1] "Precious Stones and Gems," p. 151.

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the present day, it is given by Hakíms along with pearl powder to cure impotency, and by itself to correct bilious disorders.

9. Pítáṣman, Pukhráj, Topaz.

The topaz was more valued in Europe in former days than it is now; but in the East it has always been a favourite gem, being regarded by Muhammadans as the luckiest of stones. Muhammad is said to have worn one in a ring, which passed to his successors and ensured prosperity. The Khalífa Othman let it fall into a well, and this loss is believed to account for the tumults during his rule, and for his violent death. Confiding in the good fortune conferred by the stone, Aurangzíb always wore one on state occasions, and Tavernier alludes to a topaz in his treasury which cost 18,000 pounds sterling.

These are the nine gems of the Hindus, but many other precious stones, being valued, are invested with preternatural virtues.

The Fírozah, or turquoise, although cheap and common, is more frequently worn by Muhammadans than any other gem. The finest "Basháqi," come from Nishapúr in Khurásán, and Karman. If received as a gift the turquoise is believed to avert the evil eye, to be an antidote against poisons, to grow dim when the well-being of the giver is in danger, and to cure the stings of scorpions, as well as the bites of noxious animals. Another peculiarity attributed to it is that of becoming hazy when the sky is lowering or overcast.

Vaidúrya, Lájaward, or lapis lazuli, is often substituted as one of the nine gems in place of the cat's eye. Mines of this stone still exist in Badakhshán, but, being lightly valued, is rarely seen in Bengal.

Jade, known in Persia as Sang-i-yashm, but more generally throughout the East by its Turki name, "Kash," is not so much admired in Hindustan as in China and the Himálayas.

In India the grey, white, dark green, and red varieties are occasionally seen. The dark green was formerly most admired, and several drinking cups, belonging to Jahángír, are made of it. The different sorts are employed for ornamenting scabbards and the frames of mirrors. Trays, plaques, dagger and "Chaunrí" handles, are often made of this mineral. When bows and arrows were in fashion, the ring worn to protect the thumb was generally formed of jade. Many superstitious virtues are attributed to jade in India, and no Zanánah in Eastern Bengal is without a piece. Cups made of it are said to fly in pieces when poison is poured into them; a fragment is believed to protect the wearer against lightning; and when licked it allays palpitations of the heart. Jade is brought from the mines on the banks of the Karakash river in Khoten and

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Yarkand, which were visited by Goez in 1604, and by Shaw in 1868. The fragments found in the river bring three times the price of the quarried stone, which is injured by the fire used to splinter it. From Yarkand it is chiefly exported to China, and never reaches India in the raw state.[1]

Many of the poorer Muhammadans in Bengal wear either a carnelian ('Aqíq), or an agate[2] (Sulaimání) ring, but a few fancy the moss agate, or Mocha stone ('Aqíq ul-bahr).

The carnelian is said to possess three properties: it calms a person excited by fear or passion; it stops hæmorrhage, especially in females; and it cures bleeding from the gums, or scurvy. Al Tífáshí distinguishes five kinds, red, flesh-coloured (Raṭbi), blue, black, and white.

Amber, much admired in parts of India, is not valued in Dacca, but its electrical properties early attracted attention, and both its Sanskrit name, "Tṛiṇa-gráhin," and its Persian, "Kahrubá," signify "straw drawing."

Amber is found on the eastern frontier along with lignite. Mines exist at Meinkhoon, north-east of Manípúr, and the fossil finds a ready sale among the Singphos and Chinese.[3]

Many oriental works on gems have been written, which are still popular in the East, and at least two have been translated into European languages. The work of Ahmad ibn Yúsuf ibn Muhammad Al-Tífáshí (d. 1253), called "Azhár al-Afkár," was partially done into Latin by Sebald Rau in 1784, and into Italian by Antonio Raineri in 1818. A treatise by the famous Al-Suyúṭi (d. 1505) was translated by the Maronite, Abraham Ecchellensis, in 1647. An abstract of Al Kazwínís' (d. 1275) celebrated "'Ajáíb al-Makhluqát," or Wonders of Creation, has also been published.[4]

Bengal jewellers, however, either follow the "Jawáhir-sina," a work difficult to procure, or the "Jawáhir-námah" of Muhammad bin Mançúr, who lived in the thirteenth century. The latter, however, is a common title for books of gems, and one dedicated to Baber,[5] and another published at Delhi, or Haidarábad, anonymously,[6] are in use in India.

Gems are usually cut in India by Muhammadan Hakkáks; but always set by Hindu Karmakárs.[7]

[1] Regarding jade, more information is to be found in "Astley's Voyages," iv, 645; "Moorcroft's Travels," i, 375; Jule's "Cathay," i, 130; ii, 564; and Shaw's "Visit to High Tartary," p. 474.

[2] Áïsha always wore an agate necklace.

[3] "Journals of Travels," by William Griffith, i, 77.

[4] "J. A. S. of Bengal," xiii, 632.

[5] "J. A. S. of Bengal," i, 353.

[6] "J. A. S. of Bengal," xxiii, 262.

[7] In the "Institutes of Menu" (ix, 329), the Vaiṣya is directed to know the prices of gems, pearls, and metals.

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JOGÍ.

This singular race, found all over Eastern Bengal, is more numerous in Tipperah and Noakhally than Dacca, being everywhere reviled by the Hindus, without any satisfactory reason. The only grounds given by natives for abusing and ill-treating Jogís are that the starch of boiled rice (Már) is used by them in weaving, while the Tantí use parched rice starch (Káí), and that they bury their dead.

In Bengal three different varieties of Jogí are met with, namely—

Jogí, Bengali weavers,
Ját Jogí, Hindustáni snake charmers,
Sannyásí Jogí, religious mendicants.

Jogí, or Yogí, literally means one who practices the Jog, *i.e.*, religious abstraction, or in a lower sense a pretender to superhuman faculties, while the designation is popularly given to any naked Hindu devotee.

In the census returns, the Jogí and Paṭwá are classified as one and the same caste, but in Dacca the latter is always the name of a Muhammadan trade. The weaver Jogí caste in Bengal is computed to include 426,543 individuals, 306,847, or 71 per cent. of the whole number, being distributed throughout the nine eastern districts. Like many outcast races, the Jogí has been driven into the outlying tracts of the province, and at the present day are massed in Silhet (82,038), Tipperah (66,812), Mymensingh (39,644), Noakhally (33,038), and Chittagong (32,314). In Dacca they only muster 16,410 persons.

Until the last few years the Bengali Jogís were all weavers, but now the cloth (Dhotí and Gamcha) manufactured by them is gradually being displaced by English piece goods, and the Jogí finds it difficult to earn a livelihood by weaving. A few who took to agriculture being outcasted, formed a new subdivision, called Hálwah Jogís. In Tipperah the burning of lime has been adopted as an occupation by some, but they, too, have been excommunicated. Others, again, take service under Government, or work as goldsmiths. Recently a shudder ran through the Hindu community when a Jogí was elevated to the bench, but many have already outlived this prejudice, and, except among the upper strata of society, no objections are now raised. The Jogí has peculiar difficulties in having his children educated, as no other boy will live with his son, who is consequently obliged to hire lodgings for himself, and engage servants of his own. The race, however, is ambitious, and recognises the value of education, but being poor, the higher branches of learning are beyond their reach.

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The Jogí uses a much more cumbrous loom than either the Tántí or Juláha, but employs the same comb, or "Shánah," while his shuttle, "Nail,"[1] is peculiar to himself. The women are as expert weavers as the men, the preparation of the warp being exclusively done by them.

Jogís are a contented people, laughing at the prejudices of their neighbours. When they enter the house of any of the clean castes, a very rare occurrence, all cooked food, and any drinking water in the room, are regarded as polluted, and thrown away, but, strange to say, the Śúdra barber and washerman work for them. The Jogí, too, is intolerant, eating food cooked by a Śrotriyá Bráhman, but not that prepared by any Patit, or caste, Bráhman, or by a Śúdra, however pure. The Sannyásí Jogí eats with the weaving Jogí, but a Bairágí will only touch food given by the Adhikárí. Furthermore, the Ekádaśí Jogí will eat with the Sannyásí if he is a Bráhman observing the Śráddha on the eleventh day.

In the burial of their dead all Jogís observe the same ceremonies. The grave (Samádhi, or Ahsan), dug in any vacant spot, is circular, about eight feet deep, and at the bottom a niche is cut for the reception of the corpse. The body, after being washed with water from seven earthen jars, is wrapped in new cloth, the lips being touched with fire to distinguish the funeral from that of a Muhammadan. A necklace made of the Tulasí plant is placed around the neck, and in the right hand a rosary (Jápa). The right forearm, with the thumb inverted, is placed across the chest, while the left, with the thumb in a similar position, rests on the lap, the legs being crossed as in statues of Buddha. Over the left shoulder is hung a cloth bag with four strings, in which four cowries are put. The body being lowered into the grave, and placed in the niche with the face towards the north-east, the grave is filled in, and the relatives deposit on the top an earthen platter with balls of rice (Piṇḍá), plantains, sugar, Ghí, and betel-nuts, as well as a "Huqqa" with its "Chilam" (bowl), a small quantity of tobacco, and a charcoal ball. Finally, from three to seven cowries are scattered on the ground as compensation to "Viṣa-matí" for the piece of earth occupied by the corpse. Women are interred in the exact same way as men.

The bag with its four cowries, and the position of the body are noteworthy. With the cowries the spirit pays the Charon who ferries it across the Vaitaraṇi river, the Hindu Styx; while the body is made to face the north-east because in that corner of the world lies Kailása, the Paradise of Śiv.

[1] Sanskrit Nála, a tube, a shuttle.

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The one title common to all the Jogí tribe is Náth, or lord.

The majority worship Mahádeo, or Ṣiv, but a few Vaishnavas are found among them.

Although all Jogís observe the funeral ceremonies just mentioned, they have separated into two great divisions, the Másya, the more numerous in Dacca, who perform the Ṣráddha thirty days (Másа) after death; and the Ekadaṣí, who celebrate it after eleven (Ekádaṣan) days. The former abound in the southern parts of Bikrampúr, Tipperah, and Noakhally, the latter in the north of Bikrampúr, and throughout the Dacca district generally. No intermarriages take place between them, and each refuses to taste food cooked by the other, although they drink from each other's water vessels.

1. Másya Jogís.

They are the more interesting of the two, having adhered more strictly to the customs of their ancestors than the Ekádaṣí. The following account of their origin is given: In the Vṛihad Yoginí Tantra, their chief religious work, it is written that to Mahádeo were born eight passionless beings (Siddhas), who practised asceticisms, and passed their lives in religious abstraction. Their arrogance and pride, however, offended Mahádeo, who assuming his illusive power, created eight female energies, or Yoginís, and sent them to tempt the Siddhas. It was soon apparent that their virtue was not so impregnable as they boasted, and the issue of their amours were the ancestors of the modern Másya Jogís.

Another account is that a Sannyásí Avadhúta, or scholar, of Benares, who was an incarnation of Ṣiv, had two sons, the elder by a Bráhman woman, becoming the progenitor of the Ekádaṣí Jogís, the younger by a Vaiṣya woman of the Másya; but it is probable that this legend has been invented to account for the fact that the two divisions perform the obsequial rites at different dates.

The Másya Jogís have no Bráhmans who minister to them, but a spiritual leader, Adhikárí, elected by the Purohits, is invested with a cord, and styled Bráhman. In Tipperah and Noakhally the cord is still worn, but in Dacca of late years it has been discarded. The Adhikárí of the Másya Jogís in Dacca is Mathurá Ramaṇa, of Bídgáon, in Bikrampúr, a very illiterate man, who can with difficulty read and write Bengali. The post has been hereditary in his family for eight generations, and nowadays it is only in default of heirs that an election is held. It is a curious circumstance that the Adhikárí bestows the Manrta on the Bráhmans of the Ekádaṣí, and occasionally on

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Sannyasi Jogís, although neither acknowledge any subjection to him. The Adhikárí has no religious duties to perform, as each household employs a Purohit to minister at its religious ceremonies. The Purohit is always a Jogí, inducted by the Adhikárí, and subordinate to him. He is often a relative, or marries a daughter of his master. The Adhikárí, again, has his Purohit, without whose ministration neither he nor any member of his family can marry or be buried.

The great festival of the Másya Jogís is the Ṣivarátrí, held on the fourteenth of the waning moon in Mágh (January-February); but they observe many of the other Hindu festivals, such as the Janmáshṭamí, and offer sacrifices beneath the "Bat" tree to the village goddess, Siddheṣvarí.

In all religious services they use a twig of the Udumbara, or Jagyá dúmúr (*Ficus glomerata*), and regard with special reverence the Tulasí, Bat, Pípal, and "Tamála" (*Diospyrus cordifolia*).

They have Sthán, or residencies, at Brindában, Mathurá, and Gokula, but their chief places of pilgrimage are Benares, Gayá, and Ṣítakhund in Chittagong

2. Ekádaṣí Jogís.

They possess a Sanskrit work called Vṛiddha Ṣátátapíya, in which the Muní Ṣátátapa relates how the divine Ṛishí Nárada was informed by Bráhma that near Káṣí resided many Bráhman and Vaiṣya widows, living by the manufacture of thread, who had given birth to sons and daughters the offspring of Avadhútas, or pupils of Náthas, or ascetics. The Rishí was further directed to proceed to Káṣí, and, in consultation with the Avadhútas, to decide what the caste of these children should be. After much deliberation it was determined that the offspring of the Avadhútas and Bráhman widows should belong to the Ṣiva gotra; while the issue of the Vaiṣya widows should form a class called Náth, the former like the Bráhmans being impure for eleven days, the latter like the Vaiṣya for thirty days. Both classes were required to read six Vedas, to worship their Mátris, or female ancestors, at weddings to perform, each household for itself, the Nandí Ṣráddha in the name of their forefathers, and to wear the sacred cord.

It was farther enacted that the dead should be buried, the lips of the corpse being touched with fire by the son or grandson. It is from these Bráhman widows that the modern Ekádaṣí Jogís claim to be descended, and being of that lineage, mourn for only eleven days, although they have never assumed the Bráhmanical cord.

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The Ekádaśí have Bráhmans of their own, called "Varṇa-Śarman," and addressed as Mahátama, who trace their origin from the issue of a Śrotriyá Bráhman and a Jogí woman. In Bikrampúr alone it is estimated there are at least a hundred of these Jogí Bráhmans.

The majority of this division of Jogís are worshippers of Kṛishná, but a few who follow the Śákta ritual are to be met with. The Gosáins of Nityánanda admit Jogís into their communion, but those of Aḍvayánanda will not.

All Jogís in Eastern Bengal regard the family of Dalál Bazár, in the Noakhally district, as the head of their race, and very proud they are of the distinction which was conferred on that house. In the middle of last century Brijo Ballabh Rái, a Jogí, was Dalál, or broker, his brother Raḍhá Ballabh Rái being Jachandár, or appraiser, of the English factory of Char Páta, on the Meghna. The son of the former developed the trade in Báftah cloth to so great an extent that the Company in 1765 bestowed on him the title and rank of a rájah, presenting him at the same time with a Lákhiráj, or rent free, estate. His grandson still enjoys the property, being respected not only by the Jogís throughout Eastern Bengal, but by all who know him and his family.

The mourning dress of the Jogís is a cotton garment called "Jála Kaccha," literally netted end, manufactured by them, and identical with that worn by other Hindus between the death of a relative and the Śráddha. In a corner of this raiment the Jogí ties a piece of iron, suspending it over his shoulder. On the eleventh day, when the funeral obsequies are about to be performed, the barber, cutting off the iron, gives it to the wearer, who throws it into water, then bathes, offers the Piṇḍa to the manes of the deceased, and returns home.

The Jogí Bráhmans are, with few exceptions, illiterate, but a few gain a livelihood as Páṭhaks, or readers of the epic poems. Jogís are the Mahants of the Kapila Muní shrine in the Sunderbuns, and officiate at the Váruṇi festival in Phálgun.[1]

All Jogís believe that good spirits are at death absorbed into the Deity, while the bad reappear on earth in the form of some unclean animal; but women, however exemplary they may have been in this world, are not cheered by any assurance of a future state, it being believed that death is for them annihilation.

Who, then, are the Jogís? Buchanan thought it probable that they were either the priesthood of the country during the reign of the dynasty to which Gopí-Chandra[2] belonged, or

[1] "J. A. S. of Bengal," vol. xxxix, 238.
[2] *Ibid.*, vol. iii, 534.

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Śúdras dedicated to a religious life, but degraded by the great Śaiva reformer Śankara Áchárya,[1] and that they came with the Pál Rájas from western India. In Rangpúr he found the Jogís living by singing an interminable cyclic song in honour of Gopí-Chandra. This is all the information collected by that shrewd and trustworthy observer, and since the beginning of the century no fresh facts have been added.

After repeated interviews with the Adhikárí and Jogí Bráhmans their history is still uncertain. A tradition, however, survives in Bikrampúr, that their ancestors were Bráhmans, who, forgetting the Gáyatrí, or sacred verses, were degraded.

JÁT-JOGI.

This class of Hindustani vagrants, also called Madárí, Tubriwálas, or Sáṇyá, who play on pipes[2] and exhibit tame snakes, frequently visit Dacca after attending the two annual festivals of Gorakhnáth, near Gorakhpúr. They wander over the country, subsisting as snake charmers, and by capturing wild ones, but scandalising the people by their intemperate and filthy habits. They wear shell bead necklaces, massive brass earrings, called "Gorakhnáth ka mundrá,"[3] and long untrimmed beards. Their homes are in the Mirat or Delhi districts, where they are known as Ját-Jogí. Being usually married, their wives occasionally assist at the snake-charming exhibitions. Tall, fine-looking men they often are, but their garments are always dirty and habits most dissolute. The police are constantly on the watch when the band is on the move, as thefts, and even murders, are attributed to them.

KÁCHARU.

This small caste claims to be an offshoot of the Káyasth, and tell the following absurd story to explain the separation,

[1] J. A. S., vol. iii, 408.

[2] Tomṛi. S. Tumba, a dried gourd (*Lagenaria vulgaris*). An epithet of Śiva is Tumba-Víṇa, having a gourd for a lute. On the gourd mystic figures are usually engraved.

[3] There is a close connection between these Sáṇyas and the Kánpháta Jogís. Both wear similar ornaments, and Śiva is the patron deity. Wilson's "Essays on the Religion of the Hindus," i, 217.

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and consequent debasement: A rich and aspiring Káyasth determined on celebrating the worship of Kálí in his own house, contrary to the wishes of his brethren, and deaf to all arguments he performed the ceremony, but was punished by being excommunicated. This is a most improbable story, as the Kácharu caste is dispersed throughout Eastern Bengal, being very numerous at Madárípúr in Farrídpúr, and it has a Purohit of its own. The Śúdra barber and washerman work for them, although their water vessels are unclean. It is far more probable that, like the Chhoṭá-bhágiya Tántís, they were expelled for adopting a new trade.

In Dacca the Kácharu are gradually relinquishing their caste trade, the manufacture of glass bracelets (Kácha), in which Muhammadans also engage, and are acting as traders, grocers, and shopkeepers.

The caste has three gotras, Aliman, Kaśyapa, and Paráśará. Their patronymics are Dutt, Dáś, and Dé. The principal festival kept is in honour of Viśva-Karma in Bhádra (August-September).

KAHÁR.

According to their census there were, in 1872, 7,821 Rawání Kahárs in the nine eastern districts of Bengal, of whom 1,436 were returned as residents of Dacca; while of the Behára, or Ḍolíya sept, there were 19,569 individuals in the former districts, and 1,226 in Dacca. Kahárs, however, principally inhabit Bihár and Hindustan, and in 1872 there were 378,706 belonging to the caste in the former province, while in 1865 there were 693,519 in the latter. The relation between the Kahár and the Behára[1] is still obscure, but it is probable that the latter term, as well as Ḍolíya, are merely names given to palanquin bearers, and not to any caste.

In accordance with Bráhmanical genealogy, the Káhar is descended from a Bráhman father and a Nisháda or Chaṇḍál mother, but it is now generally admitted that the Kahár and Dhímar are identical, the former being remnants of a primitive race who dwelt in the valley of the Ganges, and the latter outcast Kahárs.

The Kahár being the most docile and industrious of workmen, is in much request throughout Bengal, and of late years he has been in great demand as a coolie for the tea gardens of

[1] Sanskrit, Bhára, a load.

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Assam, Kachar, and Chittagong. A few also come yearly from Chaprah, being employed in the city of Dacca as coolies, porters, and domestic servants; but they always return home as soon as a little money has been saved. These Hindustání, or Rawání, Kahárs, observe a peculiar worship in honour of Gaṇeṣa Jí on the seventh day of the waxing moon of Kártik (October-November), when, accompanied by Bráhmans, they proceed to a wood, and make offerings of vegetables, fruits, and sweetmeats, under an "Ámlá" tree (*Phyllanthus emblica*); but never sacrifice any animal. A feast is then given to the Bráhmans, after which the Kahárs dine, and drink spirits to excess. The entertainment of Bráhmans on this day is accounted as meritorious as the gift of five cows on any other occasion.

Kahárs domiciled in Bengal, and known as Ḍolíya, are proscribed by the Hindustání brethren, because, having ceased to observe the peculiar customs of the caste, they have adopted those of the despised Bengali Ṣúdras. The Ḍolíya are met with along the old post road between Dacca and Calcutta, and at Manshúrábád, on the Padma river, twenty-five houses are occupied by them, while in Farrídpúr still larger settlements occur. Palanquin travelling being no longer the custom in the country, the Ḍolíyas have become cultivators, domestic servants, and palanquin bearers in cities. The Rawání Kahár is an eager and indefatigable sportsman, but the Ḍolíya is content to catch fish in traps, and has given up hunting and snaring game. In one respect the Ḍolíya is unchanged. Spirit drinking is to him, as to the Rawání Kahár, the *summum bonum* of life, but he shudders at the thought of swine's flesh, which is still a favourite article of food with his Hindustání kinsmen. The Ḍolíyas, rejected by the Kahárs and by the Bengalí Ṣúdras, have a Bráhman of their own, and all belong to a gotra called Aliman. The majority are Ṣaiva worshippers, but a few are Vaishnavas.

In Bengal the Hindi name, "Maharáj," is applied to any palanquin bearers not Kahárs, and in Dacca bearers either belong to the Mitra Sení subdivision of the Bhúinmálí caste, or to the Kándho branch of the Chaṇḍál. A few Muhammadan palanquin bearers, called Ḍolí-wálas, or Sawárí-wálas, may occasionally be picked up, but their numbers are yearly diminishing.

Last century the title Kahár was, at Patna, the distinctive appellation of a Hindu slave, as Maulázádah was of a Muhammadan; and the tradition in 1774 was, that the Kahár slavery took its rise when the Muhammadans first invaded Northern India.[1]

[1] "Slavery in India," by James Peggs, p. 6.

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KAIBARTTA, KAIVARTA.

This is by far the most numerous and interesting of the fisher tribes of Eastern Bengal. Their name is radically the same as Kewaṭ, the word Kaibartta being derived from the Sanskrit *Ka*, water, and *Varta*, livelihood, Kewaṭ, from *Ka* and *Vat*, to enclose. There are, however, great difficulties in distinguishing between the two, but Buchanan has offered the following explanation :—

In the west of India there was, and still is, a class of fishermen called Málo, by a woman of which impure tribe Paráṣara Muní begot a son, the famous Vyása. When Vyása established the Hindu religion as it now exists, he naturally favoured his mother's kinsmen, and gave those who adhered to his rules of purity the name of Kaibartta, and appointed Ṣúdra Bráhmans to minister unto them. On the other hand, those who remained fishermen, clinging to their ancestral customs, retained the name of Málo, and continued degraded.

In Bengal, again, there was a powerful tribe called Kewaṭ, whom Ballál Sen in after years raised to the grade of pure Ṣúdras, conferring on them the title Kaibartta as a return for their leaving off their family trade. The Bráhmans, however, refusing to officiate for them, the less scrupulous Vyásakta were appointed. Hence it followed, that wherever the laws of Ballál Sen were observed, the appellation Kewaṭ, given to those who pursued their old and rude habits, came to be regarded as an opprobrious and dishonouring title, and one that ought to be got rid of as soon as possible. In Maithila, Kámrup, and Eastern Bengal, Kewaṭ and Kaibartta are synonymous. This great tribe is therefore subdivided into Halwáha Kaibartta, or Kewaṭ, if in the particular district the latter term is not reckoned disgraceful, and Kewaṭ, or, where that designation is disapproved of, Jalwah Kaibartta, and, if this is not granted, Jáliya, or persons using nets (Jál). In Eastern Bengal they call themselves Dás, or Jalwah, Kaibartta, there being no Chásá, or Halwáha subdivision. In Dacca, moreover, as well as in Kámrup Dhívara, the Sanskrit for a fisherman, is used as a synonym, while, according to the Amara Kosha dictionary, Dás Kaibartta and Dhívara are convertible terms.

The Kaibarttas of Bengal trace their descent from Mátsyagandha, the fisher girl, whose amour with Paráṣara Muní is related in the Mahá Bhárata, and who became the mother of Vyása. Of his descendants, the Vyásakta Bráhmans, they know nothing. Their own Bráhmans are generally confounded with the Patit, and, according to local tradition, it was Ballál Sen who first bestowed on them a degraded priesthood. At the

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great assemblage of the castes, the Kaibarttas pleaded their right to be included among the Nava-Ṣákhá, as being the offspring of a Muni, but the monarch, deaf to all their arguments, alloted them one of the most degraded priests. At the present day these Bráhmans are so despised, that no clean Ṣúdra will touch anything cooked by them, and, in reality, they rank beneath the Ṣúdra. This curious circumstance is suggestive of some such irregular creation as that referred to by Buchanan.

The Kaibarttas were amongst the earliest inhabitants of Bengal, and acquired a commanding position many centuries ago. On the extinction of the Peacock dynasty of Tamluk, Kalu Bhuyá, a Kaibartta from Orissa, founded a line of fisher kings, who are still possessors of the Ráj.[1] He introduced a new religion, including a shapeless block of stone, called "Bargabhíma," which was held in great veneration, and has since been identified as one of the innumerable forms of the dreaded Kálí.

The Dás Kaibartta in Dacca often cultivate the soil, although they have not as yet separated into a distinct caste, as the Chásá and Tútiya Kaibarttas have done in other parts of Bengal. According to Ward,[2] the Chásá Kaibartta is descended from a Ṣúdra male and a female Kshatriyá, but there is little doubt that they were originally fisher Kaibarttas, who took to agriculture. As with the Tíyars the position of the Kaibarttas is uncertain, for while the fisher class is invariably reckoned impure, the agricultural is not always so.

The Jalwah, or fisher Kaibarttas, are all members of one gotra, the Aliman, their common patronymic being Dás, but a few individuals, who practise medicine, have assumed the title of Baidyá. In some places the Ṣúdra Nápit and Dhobá work for them, but this is exceptional. Their Guru is a Gosáin, the Purohit a Patit Bráhman, and the whole caste is Vaishnava in creed.

Their great annual festival is the "Jal pálani," or net preserving, which begins on the first of Mágh (February). From two and a half to seven days is the usual duration of this close period, and on the last day, when the Ganga Újah is celebrated, the net is arranged on the river's bank, and daubed with red lead. Offerings are then made to the river goddess, prayers recited by the priest, and a live kid thrown into the water, which becomes the perquisite of the Bhúinmálí, or Paṭní. A few worship Buṛa-Buṛí, and at the Kálí Újah a kid is sacrificed, its flesh being eaten by the worshippers. The Ṣráddha is solemnized on the thirtieth day after death. In Bikrampúr the customary sum

[1] Hunter's "Orissa," vol. i, 310.
[2] Vol. i, 140.

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paid for a wife is fifty-one rupees; but the market rate is often as high as two hundred rupees. When the Kaibartta has amassed a little money, he gives up the occupation of a fisherman, and becomes a fishmonger (Nikari), using in his leisure hours a cast net, but no other. Kaibarttas generally cultivate a field of hemp, and if they hold no land make advances to the peasantry, who plant out a patch for them; they prepare the fibre and their wives spin it, and manufacture nets, ropes, and twine.

The Kaibarttaní do not generally sell fish in the bazaars, or appear in public, but becoming widows they cannot remarry, and often join the wandering "Boistubis."

The only curers of fish in Easten Bengal are the Kaibarttas, the curing being carried on in November and December, when fish are most abundant. The fish-curers generally belong to Bajitpúr in Mymensingh, or to Báqirganj. Early in Novembar a piece of land is leased by the waterside, and the neighbouring fishermen are engaged to bring the proper kind, the small "Potí," or "Poṇtí," fish. The fish is first of all placed between mats, and trodden under foot, and then slowly dried in the sun, no salt being used. This nasty, and often putrid, mess is exported to those districts where fish are not procurable during the cold season. In Mymensingh larger fish are gutted, dried in the sun, and, without the addition of any brine, buried in pits. At the beginning of the rains, when fresh fish are not procurable, this "Sukhtí," as it is called, is dug up, put on board boats, and transported to Silhet and Kachhár, where it is esteemed a great delicacy, and is retailed by the resident Kaibarttas in the distant villages of the interior.

The preparation of isinglass (Machhí Ka Phúkná) is unknown to the fisher castes of Dacca.

KÁMÁR, KARMAKÁRÁ.

The Kámár combines the trades of the Hindustáni Sonár and Lohár, having no scruples about working with any kind of metal.

As among other Dacca castes, there exists a tradition that they were brought from Upper India by the Muhammadan government. In the 'Aín-i-Akbarí we are informed that there was an iron mine in Sarkar Buzúha, which included Dacca, and in later times Jagírs, called "Áhangar," were granted to the skilled workmen employed in smelting iron from the red laterite soil of the Dacca district. It is very probable, therefore, that

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the tradition referred to is founded on fact. At the present day, however, the Kámárs are unacquainted with the art of smelting iron, and a local supply being unobtainable, they procure pig iron from Calcutta.

The Kámár, as above stated, works with all metals, including gold and silver, and being himself a clean Śúdra, thoroughly despises the professional goldsmith, or Sonár-banik, who is unclean.

In Dacca the caste is said to occupy two hundred houses, and according to the census returns they number 12,072 persons in the district.

The Kaṇsárí, or brasier caste, is no longer met with in the city, the manufacture of the brass utensils, solely used in Hindu households, devolving on the Kámárs, their only competitors being the Ghulám Káyasths, many of whom engage in this trade.

The majority of the Kámárs are Vaishnavas, but a few follow the Śákta ritual, the Purohit being the same as the Bráhman of the other Nava-śákha. They have no Parámánik, but a Panchháit exists, at which the most influential person present presides.

They have only one gotra, the Aliman, and no titles. The caste has always been an illiterate one, its members at the present day only learning sufficient Bengali to enable them to keep accounts.

The Kámár makes an alloy with three parts of copper and four of zinc, called "Bhart," and with it manufactures cups, lotahs, and other vessels.

The "Panní-wálah," or tin-foil maker, is always a Kámár; the tin is obtained in bars from Calcutta, and being run into moulds, is, while still soft, beaten out until thin enough to be cut into strips, which are then stained with lac and turmeric so as to counterfeit the colour of gold. The foil so produced is then sold to the Muhammadan Chúrí-wálah to ornament his glass bracelets, and to the Málákár to embellish chaplets, tiaras, images of gods and goddesses, and the platforms paraded on gala days.

KANAUJIYÁ BRÁHMANS.

There are only ten or twelve houses in Dacca occupied by this Hindustání tribe, but several families having settled in Bengal, are styled Khoṇṭá, and been excommunicated. Finding

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a difficulty in obtaining wives, these outcasts have intermarried with the inferior Bengal tribes, and will eventually become merged in the ranks of the Śrotriyá.

Of the sixteen denominations of the Kanaujiyá subdivision of Bráhmans the most common in Dacca are Dúbe, Tiwárí, and Súkul. These Bráhmans are employed as Dafa'dárs, constables, and Barkandázs; but in former days they held important posts under the Nawábs, and their descendants still proudly wear the "Sarmáí," or cold weather embroidered cap, of the Muhammadan aristocracy. A Dúbe, named Natú Singh, was Názir of the Provincial Court of Appeal last century, and to him Dacca owes the erection of the two hideous towers, called "Názir-Ka-maths," on the spot where the bodies of his father and mother were burned.

At the present day the most famous Kanaujiyá of Dacca is a Tiwárí from Baiswárá, who has raised himself into notoriety by his skill in telling fortunes and casting horoscopes. He is styled "the Bráhman," the Paṇḍit, or Jyotishí, by the Hindus; and Rammál, or Nujúm, by the Muhammadans. His services are as indispensable at the birth and naming of a Muhammadan as of a Hindu child.

KÁNDHO.

This is a subdivision of Chaṇḍáls, formerly palanquin bearers, deriving their names from the Sanskrit Skandha, the shoulder, who still have the Chaṇḍál Bráhmans and servants working for them. At the present day a few carry palkís, when required, but the majority are boatmen, and cultivators. All are included in a gotra, the Kaśyapa. Their principal festivals are the feast of first-fruits, or Lakshmí Púját, celebrated at the full moon of Kártik (October-November); the Buṛa-Buṛí sacrifice on the Paus Sankrántí; and of late years the Trí Náth Melá.

Their widows still remarry, and the old Chaṇḍál fondness for pork and spirits survives.

The Kándho will carry a Sáha, a Mussulmán, or a Farangí in a palanquin; but refuse to bear a Jalwah, or fisherman, a Ṛishí, a Chaṇḍál, a Dhobá, or a Bhúinmálí. They, moreover, imitate the Kahárs in shouting "Rám! Rám! Harí! Harí!" in the act of lifting the pole on to the shoulder.

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KÁNDÚ.

The Kándús, or sugar boilers of Hindustán, happily called "frymen" by early English travellers, occupy about twenty-five houses in the city.

According to the Bráhmans, the Kándú is descended from a Baidyá, or Kahar, father and a Ṣúdra mother, but in Gorakhpúr he is regarded as a Vaiṣya, and the Rájputs drink from their waterpots.[1]

The ordinary subdivisions found in Bengal are—

Kanaujiyá,	Madhya-desh,
Magbaiyá,	Khuránt.

The majority of the Dacca Kándús belong to the two last, and are usually called "Bhaṛ-bhunjás," from their parching and grinding grain, and preparing "Sattú," or flour. Another equally common designation is Pánch Píriya Kándús, from the religious sect to which they all belong. The Dacca Kándús originally came from Damdáhá, in Purneah; but having resided for several generations in Bengal are known as Khoṇtá, or degraded, and Deswálí, or alien, Kándús, by their Hindustání brethren, who decline all communication with them.

In Upper India Kándús are often cultivators, but they also parch grain, and use pack-bullocks, as the Banjárás do, for transporting merchandise and cereals. In Dacca the Kándús are confectioners, as well as watchmen, domestic servants, and coolies. Their lowly origin does not prevent their providing the only food that strict Hindus can eat with unwashed hands.[2]

In the month of Mágh, Kándús, instead of worshipping Sarasvatí, as most Hindus do, pay adoration to Sukha Ṣív Náth. At this festival a pot filled with "Ghi," flour, barley, and other articles of their trade, together with a large quantity of rosin (Dhúná), is set fire to, and the dense smoke is regarded as the symbol or manifestation of their patron deity.

The Dacca Kándús, although employing a Bráhman as Purohit, follow the singular creed called Pánch Píriyá. Many observe the fast of Ramazán; wear the "baddhi" or sash, and the "Kaṅní" or mendicant's garb; offer sweetmeats (Shírní) at Dargahs, and at the Shíah Husainí Ḍalán; and confide in amulets (Ta'wiz) given by the Khwánd-Kár.

In their marriage and funeral ceremonies they follow the Ṣúdra custom. Like the Pánch Píriyá Binds, and Kumhárs, their Guru is the Mahant of the Nának Sháhí Akhárá.

[1] Buchanan, ii, 465.

[2] Vegetable products, such as Guṛ, or molasses, and any sweetmeat cooked by a Sáha, or Muhammadan, without the addition of any other substance than sugar, is called "Jálá," and may be eaten even by Bráhmans without dishonour; but if even water, or milk be added, it is "Pakka," or dressed, and becomes impure.

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KÁNSÁRÍ, KÁṆSYA-KÁRA.

This is an offshoot of the Sonár-banik, outcasted because its members manufactured articles of Káṇsá, or bell-metal, but nowadays, they are workers in brass, and are properly Ṭhatheras, or brasiers. In Dacca very few are to be met with, but at Rájnagar, on the right bank of the Padma, they are numerous.

The Kánsári is a clean Ṣúdra, having the same Bráhman, Nápit, and Dhobá as the Nava-ṣákha; but strange to say, they are all Ṣaivas, no Vaishnavas being found in their ranks. Like other artizan classes they keep the festival of Viṣva-Karma, and refrain from all work.

They manufacture with brass sheeting procured in Calcutta, and hammered into the requisite shape, small caldrons (Bhokná), salvers, and elongated water pots. Cuttings and filings are fused, and worked up.

The utensils are sold to dealers (Páekár), who retail them in the inland villages.

Chaṇḍáls often serve the Kánsári, and become very skilful workmen.

KANTHÁ[1] BRÁHMAN.

This despised Bráhman, sarcastically named Mahábráhman, or Mahápátra, performs for Hindustání families the same offices as the Agradána does for Bengali. They formerly occupied as many as forty houses in Dacca, and a large reservoir of water is still known as "Kantha Ka Taláo," but now only one man, whose ancestors came from Patna, resides there.

This, the most abhorred of Hindustání Bráhmans, notorious for avarice, bad temper, and drunkenness, is considered a degraded branch of the Sawálákhia tribe. They have good grounds for being irascible. They are compelled to live apart, and when seen in public, boys hoot and pelt them. Many absurd stories are told of their doings—one is, that every morning the Kantha drives a peg into the ground, and throws stones at it. If he hits it, he goes home in great glee, regarding his success as an omen of the early death of some rich person. On the other hand, if his aim is bad, he returns disconsolate.[2]

[1] The meaning of this word is obscure, but it may be the Sanskrit Kantha, a rag, or patched garment, worn by ascetics.

[2] The story of Rousseau and Goethe trying to forecast the future by a similar experiment is well known.

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As soon as the funeral service is finished he must fly, and he is lucky if his home is reached with only the execrations of the crowd ringing in his ears.

The Kanthá Bráhman attends at the funerals of all high caste Hindustánís in Dacca, preparing the Piṇḍa, or obsequial ball of rice, and providing the plantain, sesamum seed, and barley to be put in the hands of the corpse before cremation begins. He, too, is the only person who can repeat certain Mantras, or prayers, over the pyre.

At the Śráddha the Kanthá prepares ten Piṇḍas, and one for the "Ekádaśí," as oblations to the manes of the departed. For doing this he receives from the poor presents of curdled milk, sugar, and parched rice (Chúṛá); from the rich, sweetmeats and pieces of cloth.

At the cremation service he gets no remuneration; but at the ensuing Śráddha it is customary for the poor to give him twenty anas, the rich any sum up to one hundred rupees, in return for his labour.

KAPÁLI.

This caste claims to be the offspring of a Karmakár and a Telin, or woman of the oil-making trade.[1] In Hindi Kapáli means sly, and, according to Forbes, is the name of a caste in Bengal, who sell vegetables. It is also one of the titles of Śiva. The common derivation given by Paṇḍits is the Sanskrit Kapála, meaning the head, or a dish. Whether any of these words be the correct origin of the name or not, it is certain that the caste is peculiar to Bengal, and that in Dacca, at least, it is quite distinct from the Kawáli.

Like many Bengal castes, the Kapáli have a vague tradition that their original home was in Upper India; but this tradition has never assumed a legendary form. The caste claims to be of higher rank than the Bhúinmálí, Chaṇḍál, or Sáha, and being descended from clean Śúdras the pure Dhobi and Nápit work for them. The Purohit, who is distinct from that of the Kawálí, is a Patit Bráhman. Their only gotra is Kaśyapa; and the caste Panchá́it is presided over by a headman, called Mu'tabar. The titles found among the Kapálís are Mánjhí, Mundle, Shiqdár, Mála, and Háldár; the families with the first three patronymics being regarded as higher than the others, while a larger sum is paid for their daughters.

[1] According to others the offspring of a Brahman mother and fisherman father.

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In Rangpúr, Buchanan found the Kapálí engaged in making umbrellas; but in Eastern Bengal at the present day they are weavers and cultivators. They chiefly cultivate jute (Koshtá), preparing the fibre themselves, and manufacturing from it coarse canvas (Ṭát) for bags. Men and women weave, their loom being the ordinary native one, but clumsier than that used by the Tántí. Their shuttle is called Váya, and they dispense with the reed (Shánah). They are also careful to explain that the shuttle is shot with the hands, as among the Tántís, and not driven by pedals as with the outcast Jogies.

The Kapálí manufactures three kinds of canvas, the first, "Chálá" being used for the carriage of rape seed; the second, "Chot" for packing goods; and the third, "Ṭát" being in universal demand for floor matting, for boat sails, rice bags, and bags for country produce generally. In Bikrampúr a finer kind of canvas, known as "Vára-Vastra," is woven for the carriage of betle-nuts. The trade of the Kapálí has of late years suffered greatly by the importation of gunny bags from Europe; but they always find a ready market for the sale of matting. Bamboo mats for floors are seldom used in Bengal, but canvas is laid down in every shop, and beneath bedding whenever the ground is slept on. On the Vijaya Daṣamí day of the Durga Púja each Bengali shopkeeper, often including the Muhammadan, regards it as a duty to throw away the old matting of his shop, and replace it by new.

The Kapálís generally reside in villages, where they can cultivate jute, never in large towns, and would lose caste if they worked with hemp or cotton. Their occupation being different from that of the Tántí, the two castes live in amity with one another.

The Kapálí is usually poor, but in former days several of them rose to be Táluqdárs. In Dacca none possess land, but a few having relinquished their caste trade have become boatmen and Modís. The majority of the Kapálís are worshippers of Vishnu, and observe all the common Hindu festivals. They assert that they never taste spirits, but it is generally believed they do. Gánjha smoking, however, is common among them.

KARNI.

This low caste of weavers lay claim to relationship with the great Tántí family, but the claim is repudiated. Nevertheless, it is a curious circumstance that the Nápit, Dhobá, and other

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servants of the clean Śúdra tribes work for them, which would not be the case if they were of humble origin, yet their Purohit is peculiar to themselves.

Various derivations of the name Karní are given. According to some it is merely a corruption of the Hindí Kurmí, while others suggest it is the Sanskrit "Kár," to do, hence by metonomy to do what is forbidden.

The caste is a small one, being only met with in the western Thánas of the Dacca district, along the left bank of the Padma river, but it is more numerous in Farrídpúr and Pubna. It has three gotras, Bharadvája, Aliman, and Kaśyapa. Vaishnavism is the religion of the majority, Śaivism of the minority.

The Karní are exclusively engaged in weaving, agriculture and fishing being strictly forbidden. They manufacture the "Dhotí" or waist-cloth, the "Gamcha," the mourning garment worn by all Hindus, as well as chequered bed curtains (Chárkhána).

KARRÁL.

This name, of doubtful origin,[1] is applied to an outcast subdivision of the great Chaṇḍál tribe which has become degraded from carrying on the business of fishmongers. Their kinsmen neither intermarry nor hold any social intercourse with them, but the same Bráhman and servants work for both.

The Karrál is to the Hindu population what the Mahífarosh, or Panjárí, is to the Muhammadan, and men and women, though they never fish themselves, retail fish in the markets, and often make advances to fishermen.

The caste is more numerous in Farrídpúr than in Dacca, but all along the left, or Dacca bank of the Padma, small colonies are established, while inland individuals are employed as constables and messengers.

The Karráls are all Vaíshnavas in creed, and united in one gotra, the Kaśyapa. They confess to a partiality for spirits, but allege that they abstain from flesh, including pork, unless when the animal has been sacrificed.

[1] The name may be derived from the Sanskrit Karála, great, formidable.

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KAWÁLÍ.

This caste of musicians, often designated Halwah Kawálís, were originally Kapálís, but having adopted a different occupation, were compelled to enroll themselves in a new caste. The same Bráhman, however, officiates for both, but intermarriages, or social intercourse, is strictly prohibited. Buchanan found the Kawálí very numerous west of Patna, living as petty dealers and carriers. The Kapálí, again, he regards as a Bengali tribe, and in Puraniyá he found them engaged in burning lime like the Chunarí.

In Dacca the Kawális preserve a tradition that they are the offspring of a Káyasth father and a Dhobín, or washerwoman, and the Ṣúdra servants work for them, as they also do for the Kapális.

The Kawálí of Dacca is a musician, playing on any instrument taught him by his Ustád, Sirdár, or teacher. When young he is apprenticed to a master, whose credit depends on the proficiency of his pupil. Youths are also taught to dance, and, strange to say, the Purohit does not disdain to join in a dance, or to take a part in a theatrical play. The Kawálí declines to play in the house of any caste who has not the Ṣúdra Nápit, and Dhobá, and refuses to attend at the homes of the Muhammadan Dáí, or Hajjám. They have no objections, however, to play in concert with the Nar, Ṛishí, or Hajjám.

The Kawálís all belong to one gotra, the Aliman. They have no surnames, but several honorary titles, such as Ḍhálí, Mála, Háldár, and Mánjhí, and the most respectful term by which to address them is "Vidyádhara," a name given to the dancers in Indra's heaven.

The great annual festival of the Kawálís is the Ṣrí Panchamí, in honour of Sarasvatí; but its observance is not allowed to interfere with their professional engagements, and they as readily accept employment on that day as on any other. The Kawális are all Vaishnavas, and are hired by Hindu villagers to sing the religious hymns called Harí San-kírtan.

The dancing girls to whom they usually play are either Muhammadans (Báí), or Chaṇḍálnís; but widows belonging to any caste, even to the Bráhman, are often found with them.

The Kawálís observe the Ṣráddha and Shashṭhi ceremony on the same days as the Kapálí, and Ṣúdras generally.

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KÁYASTHA, KÁYATH, KÁIT.

The origin of this important caste is unknown, and all attempts to explain how and when it rose have been fruitless. In one part of the country the members claim to be of higher rank than the Ṣúdras, and repudiate that title; but in Bengal they are classified immediately below the Baidyá caste, with whom they live on terms of great jealousy. If we accept Karaṇa,[1] which means "a man of mixed race," as synonymous with Káyath, the caste is descended from a Bráhman father and a mother of the class next beneath it in rank; but according to other authorities it is the issue of a Kshetriyá father and a Vaiṣya mother. The Káits, however, are better pleased to have their parentage doubtful than to be the reputed offspring of such an ignoble stock.

The word Káyath is generally derived from the Sanskrit Káyá, a body, because the progenitor of the clan is said to have sprung from the body of Brahma, yet it is probable that Káyath was simply a man's and not a tribal name.

The Káyaths of Bengal are believed to be descended from five persons who served the five Bráhmans brought from Kanauj by Adisúra in the ninth century. The names of the five servants were—

Daṣaratha Bosu,
Makaranda Ghose,
Viráṭa, or Súkdeo Gúha,
Kálí Dás Mittra,
Purushottama Datta.

A tradition survives, that after celebrating the "Putreshṭí Jagya," for which their masters had been summoned, the Káyaths returned to Kanauj, but were repudiated as outcasts by their brethren, upon which they came back to Bengal with two other members of their clan, named Nág and Náth, and settled at Pancha-Ṣára in Bikrampúr.

The Káyaths of Bengal are subdivided into four great tribes, who formerly had no connection with one another, although all were engaged in the same profession, but of late years the causes of separation having been removed, individuals belonging to allied tribes intermarry.

The four tribes are—

Uttar-Ráṛhí,
Dakhin-Ráṛhí,
Bangaja,
Varendra.

The distribution of the tribes is as follows:—

The Uttar-Ráṛhí are met with in the districts of Bírbhúm, Burdwan, Murshídábad, parts of Rangpúr, Dinajpúr, Hughli, and Jessore. The Dakhin-Ráṛhí are massed in Burdwan,

[1] In Midnapore Káyasths still describe themselves as Karans.

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Hughli, Midnapúr, 24 Pergunnahs, Jessore, Kishnaghur, and parts of Báqirganj, while in Dacca only two families reside. The Bangaja are established in Báqirganj, Jessore, 24 Pergunnahs, Dacca, Farrídpúr, western part of Mymensingh, eastern part of Pubna, and in several villages of the Bograh district. The Varendra are settled in Rájsháhí, Pubna, Maldah, Bograh, Dinájpúr, as well as here and there throughout Farrídpúr, Jessore, and Kishnaghur.

The second and third tribes are so closely allied that the same gotras are common to both, and of late years they have been fast amalgamating: but the first and fourth, having no Kulins, are more conservative of old party customs. In Eastern Bengal the Bangaja tribe includes nine-tenths of the whole Káyath caste, while the remainder belong to the Dakhin Ráṛhí. The following remarks will therefore be confined to the former.

The Bangaja Káyaths have Ghaṭaks of their own, residing at Edilpúr, in Báqirganj, from whom the account of the various subdivisions has been obtained. The Ghaṭak registers go back twenty-three generations, to the fourteenth century, when the Muhammadans had conquered the most important part of Bengal. It it probable, however, that the occurrences of a later age have been embellished by the traditions of an earlier, and that the present organisation of this great tribe was the work of a reformer who lived long after the reigns of Ádisúra and Ballál Sen. Whoever reorganised the tribe, he gave the rank of Kulin to the four families of—

Vasu or Bosu,	Gúha,
Ghoṣa,	Mittra;

while to Datta, who was of a proud and independent spirit, refusing to be the slave of any Bráhman, was allotted only a half Kul. On the other hand, Dutt, Nág, Náth, and a family of bondsmen, called Dása, were enrolled as Madhalya, or intermediate, Káyaths, with whom the Kulins may marry without loss of rank.

The following is a list of the gotras of the Kulin and Madhalya Káyaths, but the correct order of precedence is a subject of interminable dispute and heart-burning:—

	Padaví.	Gotra.
Kulin	Bosu	Gautama.
	Ghose	Sukláyana.
		Śáṇḍilya.
		Vátsya.
	Gúha	Kaṣyapa.
		Kálkisha.
	Mittra	Viṣvámittra.

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	Padaví.	Gotra.
Madhalya	Dutt	Madhu-Kulyá. Sáṇḍilya. Agni-Vátsya. Bharadvája. Kaṣyapa. Krishnatreya. Vasishṭha. Aliman.
	Nág	Ṣápeyin.
	Náth	Paráṣara.
	Dása	Kaṣyapa. Madhu-Kulyá. Gautama. Aliman. Átreya.

The four families next in order are designated Mahá-pátra:—

Maha-pátra	Sena	Vásukí. Aliman.
	Singha..	Vátsya.
	Siṇha	Gautama. Ghṛita-Kauṣika.
	Dé	Aliman. Ghṛita-Kauṣika. Kaṣyapa. Paráṣara. Madhu Kulyá. Sáṇḍilya. Vátsya. Gautama. Bharadvája. Vasishṭha.
	Raha	Kaṣyapa. Madhu Kulyá. Aliman. Bharadvája. Krishnátreya.

Next below these are fifteen families, who by giving their daughters in marriage to Kulins, can raise themselves to the grade of Mahá-pátra, but a marriage of this nature brings a

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certain amount of discredit on the family of the bridegroom. The fifteen are—

Kara,	Bhadra,	Rakhít,
Dám,	Dhar,	Kúrú,
Palit,	Nandí,	Bistu,
Chanda,	Kúnd,	Addya,
Pál,	Ṣome,	Nandan.

Their gotras, being the same as those of the higher grades, do not require mention.

Regarding the still lower grades, different lists and names are given. According to some, they number seventy-two, but the "Samáj," or council of the Bangaja, only recognise thirty-two, while the larger number is met with among the Dakhin Ráṛhí Káyaths. The thirty-two grades are of very low birth, and Kulins who intermarry with them lose much, if not all, of their family prestige. The following names are not often met with nowadays, but a few are familiar to residents :—

Ketú,	Dhír,
Saí,	Aich,
Sillya,	Bhúnja,
Kharma,	Naha,
Ṣúr,	Subodhid,
Sam,	Híra,
Pahí,	Khíra,
Bidi,	Múscha,
Har,	Pyne,
Aditya,	Gorí,
Oi,	Bhút,
Bardhan,	Khírsan,
Gam,	Poit,
Brama,	Bag,
Loadh,	Balla,
Lodh,	Bal.

The higher grades of Káyaths will only eat with these when paid for so doing. Many of them are writers and educated men, but others are poor and illiterate peasants.

According to the census returns the Káyath caste numbers 1,160,478 individuals, a large proportion of whom are residents of the nine districts of Eastern Bengal. It is likewise remarkable that they are most numerous in Báqirganj (125,164), Mymensingh (105,537), Dacca (102,084), and Midnapore (101,663) districts, on the outer borders of the province, a circumstance that either indicates a descent from mixed races, or a special aptitude for development on the confines of advancing civilization. It must, however, be borne in mind that the term Káyath is often used by the lower classes of Bengal as the equivalent of Ṣúdra.

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The Káyath caste is the most intellectual, and best educated in Bengal. Although of doubtful parentage it has from the earliest historical period been an ambitious and prosperous community, which even under Muhammadan rule held most of the financial and revenue appointments throughout India; and since the English occupation of the country has almost secured the whole of the subordinate Government offices. At present they are as skilful penmen, and as good English scholars as they were formerly Persian. Furthermore, there is perhaps more of a clannish spirit among them than among any other caste of Bengal.

Sir George Campbell describes the Káyaths as "decidedly dark, generally thin, spare men, and on the average short, with often sharp weasel-like features, small and quite low-Aryan." In Dacca the Káyaths are of a deeper brown colour than the Kulin Bráhmans, but every shade of brown may be met with. Some are large powerful men, but after thirty-five they become fat and sleek-headed, and generally indolent. Their undoubted talents are too often expended on chicanery and legal quibbles, and it is very rare to find in Eastern Bengal any highly educated men who love literature for its own sake, not for the favours it bestows. It may be safely said, that every Káyath can read and write Bengali, that a large majority are well versed in English, as taught in the schools, and that a few are acquainted with Sanskrit. It is, however, very seldom that a Káyath is found who can read Persian, as that language is deemed of little value by the Hindus of Bengal, and it is rare indeed for a Hindu boy to attend the Persian class at college.

It is a melancholy fact that this clever and rising caste should always have been extravagant and dissipated. None of the large Zamíndárs of Eastern Bengal are Káyaths, and few families are, as regards wealth, on an equality with the Bráhman and Baidyá houses. Many reasons are given in explanation of this anomaly. Káyaths held almost all the lucrative posts under the Muhammadan rulers of Bengal, were farmers of the revenue, and were not often credited with tender feelings or conscientious doubts. As was said of them by a Muhammadan, who knew them well, they were like a sponge, imbibing what they could on all occasions, but parting with their plunder as readily as it does when squeezed. Whenever a revenue officer was reported to have accumulated wealth, he received a summons to Murshídábád, and was compelled to give up all that he had, or become a Muhammadan. In former days, moreover, the rank of a Káyath depended much on the number of slaves he retained, and wonderful stories are told of the swarms of dependants belonging to the old families. Their marriage ceremonies, likewise, and their religious rites, have always been accompanied

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by more ostentation and lavish expenditure than with other castes. Dissolute and intemperate habits were natural consequences of an uncertain position. Rich to-day, they might be beggars to-morrow, and the savings of years might be swept away by a word from the Nawáb. But, even after a century of peace and security, the Káyaths are the same improvident people they were under the Mughal dynasty.

The Ṣákta worship generates drunkards, and no one can be a devoted worshipper without drinking spirits to a fearful extent. While the doctrines of Chaitanya have united almost all the artisan and agricultural castes in a common faith, the immoral Ṣákta ritual is observed by the three highest and most intelligent of the Hindu castes, namely, the Bráhman, Baidyá, and Káyath. All Kulin Káyaths, and three-fourths of the other subdivisions, follow the Ṣákta worship, and one-half of these celebrate the "Vahmachárí Áchár," or Chakra rites. By this, intoxication is legalised and made a religious duty, while obscenity is countenanced and enforced. English education has not as yet reformed them, and probably at no former period was intoxication so universal and habitual as at the present day.

These strictures, true of the caste collectively, are unjust towards many of the most philanthropic and excellent native gentlemen to be met with in Bengal, who lament the degradation of their brethren, and do their utmost to stem the torrent of unbelief and immorality which is destroying the noblest qualities of their countrymen. As yet their endeavours have proved ineffectual, but it is for the rising generation to realize their position, to denounce the vices of their brethren, and to assume the lead in the advancement and in the civilization of their countrymen.

A Kulin Káyath family is almost as exclusive as that of a Kulin Bráhman, and it is equally dependent on the Ghaṭak for the preservation of its station and purity. A member of this class can only retain his rank by marrying the daughter of a Kulin, or by giving his son or daughter in marriage to a Kulin family. Should any family during three generations neglect to form an alliance with another Kulin family its patrician dignity is lost; but a single, or even a second, *mésalliance* does not lower the credit of the house. Families who have always intermarried with Kulins are called "Gangá-tírtha" Kulins, being regarded as the purest.

When a Kulin Káyath is degraded, he never can regain the position he has lost, but his descendants, by marrying Kulins, thenceforward become known as "Kulaja." Finally, should a Kulin marry a daughter of the Kulaja, or Madhalya classes, he continues to preserve his respectability. This union is called

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"Viśráma-sthán." Adopted children, moreover, do not acquire the position of the person adopting them.

Like other clean Śúdra castes who follow the Śákta ritual, the Kulin Káyath has a private temple, or sacred nook, where a Śiva-linga is erected, and daily worship performed by the head of the household. All Káyaths, except those of the Vaishnava sect, observe the Śrí Panchamí, or "Dawát Púja," on the fifth of the waxing moon in Mágh (January-February). This festival is held in honour of Sarasvatí, the goddess of learning, who, strange to say, is regarded by both Káyaths and prostitutes as their patron deity. On this day the courts and all offices are closed, as no Hindu penman will use pen and ink, or any writing instrument, except a pencil, on that day. When work is resumed a new inkstand and pen must be used, and the penman must write nothing until he has several times transcribed the name of the goddess Durga, with which all Hindu epistolary correspondence begins. Káyaths are expected to spend the holiday in meditating on the goddess Sarasvatí after they have observed certain religious rites, and sacrificed a kid to Káli, or Durga; but in reality they spend it in immorality and dissipation, for which reasons the "goddess of learning" has in some way come to be regarded as the tutelary deity of the "Peshákgar." On this day the Káyath must taste of a Hilsá fish, whatever its price, while from the Srí Panchamí festival in January to the Vijaya Daśamí in September or October, fish must be eaten daily; but from the last to the first month it must not be touched. This curious custom, probably founded on some hygienic superstition, is often reversed by Bengali Káyaths.

As much as a thousand, and occasionally two thousand, rupees are paid by a bride's father to a Kulin Káyath at his marriage, but formerly either fourteen or twenty-one rupees were the recognised sums given, and even now, the formality is gone through of asking the bride's father if he has received that amount, although it is not the custom to accept it. In old families the Purohit officiates at the marriage service, and before it a fast is observed, during which Kálí is worshipped.

The chief strength of the Brahmo Samáj lies in the ranks of the Káyaths, and every Káyath boy attending the Government college becomes a member of this new sect. These boys are necessarily outcasted, and unless their parents cease to associate with them, expulsion befalls the whole family. On returning home a Brahmo boy is not permitted to enter his father's house, but is fed and entertained by himself in an outhouse. In Dacca a few Brahmo households exist, the males and females of which have become Brahmos and Brahmikas, but a few faint-hearted individuals, Brahmos in Ḍacca, are Hindus at their homes. There

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is reason for anticipating that the whole caste will very soon become Brahmos. The Káyaths have time on their side, and are confident that Brahmoism is the destined religion of the Hindus, and that the Crescent will go down before the hosts of Deism. Great rejoicings were lately made on the occasion of the conversion of Záhiruddín of Sunnárgáon, a student of the Dacca college. He was secretly made a Brahmo, and named Jáí Náráyana. Subsequently he became a "Prakásh," or perfect Brahmo, receiving the title of Jala Dhar Bábu, which entitled him to eat and drink with the Káyaths.

Throughout the eastern districts of Bengal there is a very numerous body of natives called Ghulám, or slave, Káyaths, and also known as Shiqdár, or Bháṇḍárí. Their existence as an adjunct, or graft, of the Káyath stock is both interesting and peculiar, and would appear to explain the obscure and heterogeneous character of the main stem. The Ghulám Káyaths are descended from individuals belonging to clean Śúdra castes, who sold themselves, or were sold, as slaves to Káyath masters. It is stoutly denied that anyone belonging to an unclean tribe was ever purchased as a slave, yet it is hard to believe that this never occurred. The physique of the low and impure races has always been better than that of the pure, and on account of their poverty and low standing a slave could at any time be more easily purchased from amongst them. However this may be, it is an undoubted fact that any Ghulám Káyath could, and can, even at the present day, if rich and provident, raise himself by intermarriage as high as the Madhalya grade, and obtain admission among the "Bhadra-lok," or gentry of his countrymen.

For the following translation of a deed of sale I am indebted to the late Bábu Brijo Sundar Mittra, a scion of one of the oldest and most respected Káyath families of Dacca:—

"I, Rám Kisto Pál, son of Túla Rám Pál, and grandson of Rám Deva Pál, do hereby execute this deed of sale.

"Owing to the debts incurred at my marriage, and which I am unable to pay, I, in my proper mind, and of my own free will, sell myself to you on my receiving a sum of Púrojonodohomasi[1] rupees twenty-five, and I and my descendants will serve you as slaves as long as we are given subsistence allowance and clothing, you, your sons, and grandsons shall make us work as slaves, and have power to sell, or make a gift of us to others. On these conditions I execute this bond.

"Dated 19th Kártik, 1201 B.S. (November, 1794)."

Although slavery is illegal, and has been so for many years, the buying and selling of domestic slaves still goes on, and it

[1] Mr. J. D. Ward, C. S. suggests the following reading and interpretation: Púra (full), jana, or gana, dáhá (ten), másha. Each rupee was to value ten full máshas. A "másha" equalled $17\frac{3}{8}$ grains, and a rupee ten máshas.

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may be safely said that there is hardly a family of any distinction which has not several Bhánḍárís on its establishment. The life of the Nafr, or Shahna, as the slave is called in other parts of the country, is most congenial to the Bengali. With rare exceptions he is kindly treated, and in return he regards the welfare and happiness of each member of the family as inseparable from his own. Owing to the deaths of their masters many thousands are scattered throughout Bengal, who are found working at all trades, and do not consider themselves degraded by holding a plough or wielding a mattock. In Bikrampúr they are often boatmen, while in Dacca Káyaths are employed as confectioners, coolies, brasiers, shopkeepers, and venders of Pân and Indian hemp.

Bráhmans, Baidyás, Sáhas, and Banyas possess slaves, but none of these castes have ever permitted their servants to rise in rank, or assume an equality with their masters. It is suggested by the Káyaths that the Ghulám Káyaths of the present day are the descendants of the tribe resident in Bengal before the advent of the Kanauj families; but this conjecture is erroneous, for not only are individuals being added even now to the servile branch, but admissions such as that of Rám Kisto Pál, the subject of the deed of sale (who was a Telí by caste), can be proved by existing documents.

The honorary titles borne by the Káyath families are numerous. The most common are Biswas, Bhúmika, Ḍhálí, Majumdár, Qanúngo, Mahalla-nawíz, Paṭṭadár, Shíqdár, Niyogí, Mustaufí, and Mushrif. Besides these official distinctions, the Rájas of Chandradwíp conferred others, such as Dastá-dár, Thakúrta, and Munçif, which are borne by Guha and Ghose families at the present day. From these titles we learn that formerly the Bengali Káyath wielded other weapons than the pen, and that while some fought in the ranks as shield-bearing (Ḍhálí) soldiers, others commanded as brigadiers (Dastádár).

In olden times the most famous Káyath family in Bengal was the "Banga Adhikárí," which gave for many generations the Qanúngoes, or finance ministers, to the province. Their residence was in Dacca so long as the seat of government was there, and a bazár near their mansion is still named Rái Bazár. A private idol, known as Ṣama Rái, has for two centuries been maintained by the rent of a piece of land. Early in the eighteenth century the family removed to Murshídábád, where its representatives still reside.

The leading Kulin Kayáth family of Dacca is the family of Bose, or, as they prefer calling themselves, Bose-Ṭhákúrs, of Bose-nagar in Bikrampúr. The founder of the house was Deví Dás Bose, Qanúngo of the Nawárah Mahall, whose Muḥarrir,

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or clerk, was Krishna Jívana Majumdár, father of the celebrated Rájah Ráj Bullabh. An old building at Bose-nagar still bears an inscription put up by the builder, Deví Dás, with the date A.H. 1087 (1676).[1]

The oldest and most respected house among the Bangaja Káyaths, however, is that of Chandradwíp. For seventeen generations the family has dwelt in Báqirganj, and its head has always been the Samáj-pati or president of the caste.[2]

HINDUSTÁNÍ KÁYATHS.

At the present day the Lálás, as they are called, only occupy some four houses in Dacca, but formerly they were numerous and influential. The families belong to the Śri Bástab sub-caste, and claim to be descended from Káyaths who accompanied Rájah Man Singh to Dacca in the sixteenth century. In former days important official posts were held by them, such as that of Díwán and Bakhshí. The Díwáns of Nawábs Hasmat Jang and Naçrat Jang were Lálás, but on the death of the last Nawáb in 1843 their families returned to Hindustán. The few who remained behind being poor, accepted service as policemen, Dároghas, and writers. Their general poverty is ascribed to the danger of owning land under the Muhammadan rule, when they were in a position to acquire it.

A few miles north of Dacca an estate, or Ta'luk, is held by the descendants of a certain Jáí Singh, a Hindustání Káyath, and famous killer of tigers. The honorary title of "Bághmárá," and a grant of land, were conferred, on condition that he and his heirs annually presented a live tiger to the Nawáb at Dacca.

KEWAṬ KEOT.

A colony of this widely dispersed fisher caste has for centuries been settled in the city of Dacca, where they occupy from twenty to thirty houses; but no traces of them are to be found

[1] The only other Hindu inscription in Dacca older than this is one on a Śiválaya at Baishthia, near Mánikganj, belonging to the Guha Majumdár family, with the date 1518 Śaka, or A.D. 1440.

[2] "J. A. S. of Bengal," vol. xliii, 205.

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in the interior of the district. A tradition still survives that they were brought from Bihár by the Muhammadan rulers, and employed as messengers and watchmen.

Buchanan was of opinion that the Kewaṭ and Kaibartta originally belonged to one caste, aboriginal to Bengal; but, whether this opinion is well founded, or not, the Dacca Kewaṭs repudiate all relationship with the Kaibarttas, although they do not object to eat or smoke with them. At the present day the Kewaṭ is met with in every part of Bengal. In Orissa it is the most numerous of the fisher tribes, polling 150,387 persons; in Chota Nágpore it comprises 6,191, in Assam 31,300, and in Bihár 135,692. In the Bengal census return the Kewaṭ is included, along with others, under Jeliya, a comprehensive term for all fishermen.

The Kewaṭ caste has three subdivisions, Seo Rámí, Gauṛi or Gonṛhi, and Dhun Kewaṭ, who eat together and intermarry.

In Bihár and Rangpúr Kewaṭs are either fishermen or cultivators; in Assam and Orissa fishermen; while in Dacca, having relinquished fishing, they have generally adopted the occupation of fishmongers, although a few are Podárs or bankers. The Kewaṭ fishmonger usually makes advances to the fishermen, and finds it more profitable to buy small fish by the basket, and large ones by weight, than haggle for each day's catch. The Kewaṭ generally brings the supply from the fishing ground himself, if it is near; but a servant is sent if it is distant.

In Assam the Kewaṭs have separated into two septs, the Halwah, who are cultivators worshipping Kṛishna, and Jaliya, or fishermen following the tenets of Muhammadanism.[1] Buchanan records[2] the curious fact that the Kewaṭs had become Muhammadans in Rangpúr. Equally strange the Dacca Kewaṭs have become followers of the Nának Sháhí faith. Their Guru is the Mahant of the Shújá'at-púr Akháṛá; their Purohit a Maithila Bráhman, called Sám-ojha.[3] The Kantha Bráhman performs their funeral service, and attends at the Ṣráddha observed fifteen days after death; but he is charged with being extortionate, and with demanding more than poor Kewaṭ families can afford.

The Dacca Kewaṭs are all included in one gotra, the Kaṣyapa, and though domiciled in Bengal are not excluded from caste privileges when on a visit to Bihár. Owing to association with more enlightened races, widow marriage has been discontinued; but in Mungír Kewaṭ widows still practise it.

[1] Robinson's "Assam," p. 263.
[2] "Eastern India," iii, 530.
[3] Perhaps Ṣam-yája.

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The great annual festival of the Kewaṭs of Dacca is the Nauámí, or ninth lunar day of Paush (December-January), when every one visits the Akhárá, and after prayers, receives "Mohan Bhog," a sweetmeat specially prepared for the occasion. The Chhaṭh, on the sixth of Kártik, is a great bathing rite observed by Kewaṭs, and all Hindustání castes; while the Ganga Púja, as well as the principal Hindu festivals, are kept. Sacrifices, too, are offered at the proper seasons to Bura-Buri.

KHATRÍ, CHHATRÍ.

In 1872 there were 117,508 Chhatrís resident in Bengal, of whom 14,393 belonged to the eastern districts. There are, however, reasons for supposing that these figures include many individuals having no claim to the rank of Rájputs, for the Surájbansís, Manipúrís, and Kachharís, who call themselves Chhatrís, are offshoots of the great Indo-Chinese family.

The Chhatrís occupy twenty houses in Dacca at the present day. Too poor to become traders, and too proud to cultivate the soil, they obtain employment as post-office clerks, constables, and "Dároghas." The majority belong to the Pachhániya branch of the caste, but members of the Khanna, Chopra, and Dhanwar tribes are met with, who having married with lower grades have severed all connection with their homes. The Purohit of the Dacca Chhatrís is a Sarsút or Sarasvatí Brahman, who pays an annual visit to his flock. Chandika, a form of Durgá, is the patron deity of the caste; but each gotra has its own peculiar idol.

Chhatrís are invested with the sacred cord when eight years old, and individuals who minister at certain religious observances have a thread of one more ply than those who do not.

At Chhatrí marriages the bride, as with Muhammadans, remains in the inner apartments, and the "Manḍúá" is erected in an inner courtyard, where the service is performed.

An interesting tradition connects the modern Khatrís with the foundation of the Muhammadan city. When the Khatrí, Rájah Man Singh, in 1595, occupied Dacca with the Mughal army, and encamped on a tract, cleared of jungle, ever since called Urdú, an image of Durgá, said to have been the property of Veda-bati, the divorced wife of Ádisúra, was found, and deposited in a shrine, called Dhakeśvarí, still regarded as the palladium of the city. At the present day the revenue of this sanctuary is divided between several old Khatrí families and the Brahmáchárí Mahant of the Ramná Ákhárá.

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At Páikpára, and in villages around Barmí Hât on the Lakhya, reside a class of Hindus, calling themselves Ráṇḍá,[1] or Randak, Khatrí, who give a confused account of themselves, repeating the names of Ballál Sen and Rájah Man Singh, as if connected in some mysterious way with their settlement in Bengal and their degraded position among Hindus. Kanaujiyá Bráhmans officiate as Purohits, and a Bengali Bráhman of Pancha Ṣára, near Rámpál, as Guru. The majority follow the worship of Kṛishna, but a few that of Ṣiv. Being naturalised Bengalis they have relinquished the names of former gotras, and adopted the common Ṣúdra one, Aliman. Ṣúdras eat with them in private, but in public refuse to touch their water pots. They are employed as cultivators, shopkeepers, and Ta'llukdárs.

KÍCHAK, KÍCHAKA.

The Kíchak is one of the wandering predatory tribes met with in various parts of Bengal, characterized by the peculiar physiognomy of the Indo-Chinese races. Their home is properly the Morang, or Nepál Taráí, but gangs of them have settled in the north-eastern districts of Bengal.

It is not admitted in Nepál that the Kíchaks and Kiráts,[2] or Kirantís, are the same, an opinion held by Buchanan;[3] but it is beyond a doubt that they are both scions of a pure Turanian stock, and that they live together in Dinájpúr, a part of the ancient Matsyadesh, in Sikhim, and in Nepál.

The Kirantís, again, are identified by Col. Dalton[4] with the Kharwárs of Sháhábád, a tribe of undoubted Turanian descent; while B. H. Hodgson[5] includes the Kíchaks among the broken sub-Himálayan tribes, which he designates Awalia, from their power of withstanding damp or malaria (Sanskrit Ola), along with the Kochh, Garo, Bodo, and Dhimal. They are, moreover, classified with the later Turanian immigrants from the north, and their language is pronounced to be of the complex or

[1] Ráṇḍá, in Bengali, means "childless." Raṇḍa, in Sanskrit, means barren.

[2] Kiráta, literally means one living outside the city, and was applied to different aboriginal tribes dwelling on the east of Bhárata. Dr. Daniel Wright, writing from Katmandoo, in April, 1875, says, that in the Morang are two tribes, included under the generic name Kíchak, called Kochyá and Mechya, who have no claim to be regarded as Kiráts. According to the Paṇḍits the genuine Kiráts are the Yakhas and Khombos of the eastern, and south-eastern parts of Nepál.

[3] "An account of the Kingdom of Nepál," p. 7.

[4] "Ethnology of Bengal," 128.

[5] "Essays," part ii, 14.

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pronomenalized type tending, like their physical attributes, towards assimilation with the Dravidian, or the Santal dialect.

The Kíchak history is a strange and puzzling one. In the Mahábhárata, Kíchaka is the brother-in-law of Rájah Viráṭa, ruler of the Matsya country, who was slain by Bhíma, the second of the Páṇḍava brothers, for insulting his sister Draupadí. The next tradition, preserved by Buchanan,[1] is that the Kíchaks were subjects of Bhímsena, who was either a Rájput ruling their country, or a Kíchak himself. The inhabitants of Puraniyá, early in the present century, had confused accounts of ancient invasions, and conquests of the Kíchak tribe, and mentioned several old princes of Morang to whom worship was still paid, and whose usual priests, or "Pariyal," are said to have been descended from Kíchak warriors. Furthermore, a legend survives that Prithu, Rájah of Kámrúp, fearing that his purity would be defiled by the sight of an abominable tribe of "raw-eaters," called Kíchak, who were invading his kingdom, instead of leading his troops to battle, threw himself into a reservoir of water, and perished, leaving his capital and country to fall without a struggle into the hands of the barbarians. The causes which have reduced a powerful and aggressive people, as indicated by these tales, into the present abject condition of the Kíchak race, are difficult to explain. In habits they resemble the vagrant tribes of Nats Badhaks, and Siyál-Khors, fragments of primitive Indian races, whose genealogy has still to be written; while in features, complexion, and physique they approximate to the Mags and Chakmas of the south-eastern frontier.

The settlement of a gang of Kíchaks in the suburbs of Dacca has furnished a favourable opportunity of studying their peculiar customs and habits. In 1843, an extensive robbery was committed at Náráyanganj, an important town near Dacca, and all attempts to trace the robbers failed until suspicion fell upon a band of Nats, as they were called, who were then passing through the district. The whole party was apprehended, and the robbery brought home to several individuals belonging to it. Further enquiries revealed the existence of numerous allied bands in various parts of Bengal, and of one in particular, engaged as coolies at an Indigo factory, who supplemented their wages by robbing the villages around. Government directed the punishment of the guilty, and the location of the remainder under surveillance at Dacca, where they obtained employment under the municipality. It is said that about thirty men,

[1] "Eastern India," vol. iii, 39, 406.

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besides women and children, were thus provided for, who though in a position most uncongenial to their tastes, have always proved good and useful citizens. Thirty years' contact with alien races, and isolation from their brethren, have produced great changes in their characters and habits, yet the Dacca Kíchaks still preserve many early associations and peculiarities.

According to them the Kíchak tribe has eight subdivisions, or septs, in the following order of precedence :—

Látia,	Gangla,
Sulukí,	Kaiya,
Láthri,	Dádar,
Núniya,	Chaya.

Members of the first four families form the hereditary priesthood, who officiate at all religious ceremonies; but should one of their representatives not be at hand, the head of the family, or party, may perform the service. Each subdivision has a Sardár or Rái, who is elected (Khun-bandhná) by manhood suffrage. It is a remarkable fact that no subdivision can enumerate more than eight Sardárs. The chiefs of the Sulaukí in order are Borak, Kabah, Dewa, Saláwat, Motí Rám, Madárí, and Bábú Rám; of the Lathrí, Hona, Kone, Babu Rám, Súbhá and Bahádar; of the Núniya, Udási, Kazania, Gora, Kutb, Rúrí, Nafar, Dhun Singh, and Usman. The names of the chiefs, as well as those of the different septs are mainly Hindi, an indication that they were given in comparatively modern times, when the tribe broke up into two divisions, one inhabiting the plains, the other the sub-Himálayan Taráí.

A Panchái't, as among Hindus, settles all disputes, and punishes the guilty; while in olden days it passed sentence of death on spies and informers.

Their religious belief is very simple. God as an abstract conception is an incomprehensible idea, but when thunder rolls overhead they say it is the voice of Gokháin (Gosáin). Furthermore, they have a fetich in the oval, bright scarlet-coloured seeds of the "Rakta Chandana"[1] (*Adenanthera pavonina*), but it is difficult to ascertain the exact meaning attached to them. It may be that the wondrous colour and rarity of the seeds have excited their astonishment, and suggested in some undefined way the action of a powerful and benevolent spirit, of whose power they are the visible symbol; but the mysterious respect with which they are treated, and the worship that is paid, presupposes the existence of a spirit embodied in their substance,

[1] The seeds are in general use as weights by goldsmiths, and are often strung on a thread to form a necklace. The same Sanskrit name is given to the red Sandal wood tree (*Pterocarpus Santalinus*) of the Coromandel coast.

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or acting and communicating its power through them. Whatever be the true explanation of the selection, each Kíchak carries a few wrapped in his waist cloth, and, whenever a marauding expedition is starting, each man arranges the seeds on the ground before him, saturates them with sweet oil, makes obeisance, and prays for success in the coming journey. The spirit that watches over them is called "Ákhá," but they also believe in the existence of domestic or household gods, symbolized by small brass idols, called "Deví Durgáo," and corresponding to the Grámdevatas of the modern Bengali villages.

On critical occasions the chiefs sacrifice a goat to "Ákhá," but this is neither an usual nor obligatory act.

Kíchaks bury their dead, placing in the hands of the corpse a few copper coins, and depositing in the grave, water, sweetmeats, rice, and spirits. Their ideas of a future state are confused and rudimentary, and when asked to give a reason for placing perishable articles in the grave, they either reply that their fathers did so, or that it is good for the deceased person to have them.

Kíchaks eat the flesh of almost all animals, but never touch beef. They are very partial to the flesh of the Iguana (Gohsámp), jackal, pig, and civet cat (*Viverra*), but the flesh of snakes is abhorred. Intoxication is universal, and every domestic occurrence is commemorated by a feast, at which an unlimited quantity of coarse fiery spirits is consumed. Polygamy is practised, but three wives are considered enough for the greatest chief. Divorce is common and fashionable, and the marriage bond is easily unloosed, although it has been tied in the presence of the assembled tribe. Social prejudices are unknown, and they have no scruples in eating with Hindus, Muhammadans, or Christians. Omens derived from the appearance, cries, or movements of animals are, as with the Thugs, universally relied on as having a perceptible bearing on the issue of voluntary acts. If a jackal calls in front, or on the right hand, of a gang starting on an expedition, the departure is postponed, but if it howls in the rear, or on the left hand, the augury is favourable, and the start is at once made.[1] This strange belief in the prescience of the jackal has gained for the Kíchaks another appellation, that of "Loharí Khánu.

In former days the tribe was armed with iron weapons, but as these led to identification, they have been laid aside, and

[1] The manifestation of an omen is interpreted in a variety of ways by different tribes. Among the Thugs an omen on the right hand was portentous, on the left auspicious at the beginning, but the reverse at the end of an expedition; while a pair of jackals moving in either direction in front was ominous.

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bamboo spears and swords are made as required, and thrown away as soon as the work of the party is completed.

About thirty years ago[1] the chief Sardárs held Mustájiri, or farmed land, and it was alleged that the Sardárs, along with the Mundle, village officials, and even the police, participated in the plunder brought home by the gangs. Before an expedition started, the Panchâít met and fixed its strength, the individuals who were to compose it, and the rates at which the booty was to be allotted. The Sardár got a double portion, while men, women, and children shared equally. The widows and children of any man killed, or who died, either received a large donation or a pension, so long as the widow remained unmarried. Finally, goats were sacrificed, fidelity pledged, and, after dipping the fingers in the blood of the victims, the flesh was eaten, and spirits drunk.

The Kíchak language is mainly Hindustáni, with words derived from hill tribes residing along the northern frontiers of Bengal. In the following vocabulary sixty per cent. of the words are either pure, or broken, Hindustáni, while a few of the remainder are traced to races living in proximity to the Kíchaks.

[1] "Asiatic Journal," 3rd series, vol. i, 466; iii, 192.

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Comparative Vocabulary of the Kíchak Language.

English.	Kíchak.	Hindustání.	
One	Ekuch	Ek.	
Two	Bay	Do.	
Three	Ten	Tín.	
Four	Chari	Char.	
Five	Panchi	Panch.	
Six	Khoi	Chha.	
Seven	Khat	Sat.	
Eight	Athi	Áth.	
Nine	Lau	Nau.	
Ten	Dokh	Das.	
Twenty	Bikh	Bis.	
Hundred	Khan	Sau	In Lepcha Kha-phagnón.
I	Hu	Ham the plural often used for singular.	Han is Lepcha for thou, Heu for he, she, it.
Me	Munha	Mujhe.	
My	Marhan	Mera.	
Hand	Hathli	Háth.	
Foot	Gorang	Goṛ.	
Eye	Dhola	Ankh.	
Mouth	Bhakho	Munh.	
Nose	Nak	Nak.	
Ear	Kabanawna	Kán.	
Mother	Ai	Má	In Bhutaní Ai; in Naga Aio, or Aia.
Father	Aga	Báp	Bhutaní Appa; Lepcha Abo; Naga Apú.
Brother	Bayo	Bhái.	
Sister	Bai	Bahin.	
Husband	Dhani	Khaṣam.	
Wife	Dhaniyani	Jorú.	
Mother-in-law	Khaku	Sás.	
Father-in-law	Khokaru	Sasur.	
Brother-in-law	Khala	Sálá.	
Sun	Dan	Súraj	In Daffla Doni; in Miri Daania; and in Abor dani.
Moon	Ujiyali	Chand	Ujálá Hindi, light.
Water	Pani	Páni.	
Spirits	Gutttarans, Daru	Dárú.	
Fire	Agi	Ag.	
Gold	Kaban	Soná.	
Cow	Dhara	Gorú.	
Calf	Neru	Lerú.	
Jackal	Lohari	Gídaṛ.	
Ass	Gadhro	Gadhá.	
Horse	Ghoro	Ghorá.	
Dog	Luria	Kuttá.	
Elephant	Kubran, Kuban	Háthí.	

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KOCHH-MÁNDAI.

On the north of Dacca is situated the jungly and generally uncultivated tract of Bhowál, extending, without any important break, to the foot of the Garo hills. Here and there is to be found a people calling itself Kochh-Mándai,[1] the latter word in the Garo language signifying man. In the census returns of 1872, the Kochh and Mándai are erroneously separated into two tribes, the former numbering in the Dacca district 10,928, the latter only 309. In Mymensingh, again, there are entered 12,420 Kochh, and 5,901 Mándai.

The Kochh-Mándai, having preserved no traditions of their origin, are convinced that the villages of Bhowál were the primitive homes of their fathers. All connection with the Rájvansí of Kochh Bihár, or the Hill Garos, is disowned. Mr. Taylor[2] identified them with the Páni Kochh of Dinájpúr, and his conjecture seems well grounded. When the Kochh, in the sixteenth century, under Haju invaded Kámrúp, expelling the Kachári, or Chutia dynasty, a remnant of the vanquished people was left, who, separated more and more from the parent stem, not only by the extension of the Kochh power, but also by incursions of Aryan and Muhammadan races, gradually lost the peculiar characteristics of their ancestors.

The adoption of the name Kochh by the vanquished is not singular, for Colonel Dalton is of opinion that Garos, or a kindred tribe, took the name of Páni Kochh to conciliate the ruling power, and Captain Williamson is the authority for a still more recent change of name on their part. The Daloo clan of Hill Garos about a century ago emigrated to the plains, and married Hajong women. In a few years, having laid aside the national dress, and disowned all relationship with the Hill men, they now claim to be genuine Hajongs. Unless for one or other of these reasons, it is difficult to understand how a tribe, speaking a language composed of many Garo and no Kochh words, relinquished their national name, and adopted that of Kochh-Mándai.

The vernacular is not pure Garo, but a patois made up of words derived from other Hill languages. The Garo numerals have been lost, and Bengali ones made use of, but at present few can speak Bengali, or ever learn more than is necessary for the purposes of buying and selling.

The Kochh-Mándai being an unwritten language, the following vocabulary is given according as the words are pronounced:

Man, Mandai (Garo).
Woman, Mandai-matali.
Wife { Michik (G). Jik (G).

[1] Perhaps the Mandei of Pliny.
[2] "Topography of Dacca," p. 239.

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Husband, Shai.	Iron, Sil (G).
Boy, Mia-dosha.	Fire, Wal (G).
Girl, Maipa-dosha.	Rice, Mai (G).
Daughter, Dampsi.	Rice plant, Maigul Mai.
Sister, Nagadai.	Pepper, Jamsi.
Brother, Jangodai.	Tiger, Matcha (G).
Tree, Phang (Bodo).	Boar, Wak (G).
Dog, Achak (G).	Ear, Nahathong (Dhimal).
Water, Chhi (G).	God, Madai (Mech).
House, Nak (G).	

Of these twenty-two words, eleven belong to the Garo language, one to the Bodo, Dhimal, and Mech respectively, while eight are foreign to any of these languages. The inference to be drawn from this is, that the Kochh-Mándai have been formed by the amalgamation of several kindred tribes, and the fusion of the different languages into one. A comparative list of words used by various races on the eastern frontier will be afterwards given, in which the predominance of the Garo element is very striking.

The Kochh-Mándai have many clans, or "Dúgús," named after certain places or hills in the Assam valley, and identical with the Máchongs, or Maháris, of the Hill Garos. The Garos generally name their clans after demons, rivers, hills, trees, or villages; but, as in the following instance, the most trivial circumstance may give origin to a new title. During the famine of 1770, a Bengali Nápit settled in the Hills, and married a Garo maiden of the Dophoo clan, who bore him many children. There being no Máchong open to them, a new one was created, called Dophoo-Nápit, which still exists. A correct list of all the Dúgús is difficult to get, but the following are the names of the twelve principal ones met with in Bhowál:—

Darang,	Nafak,
Darang-Chiachí,	Chishim,
Darang-Sandana,	Doi,
Darang-Dambuk,	Durgu,
Darang-Dakal,	Chanell,
Maikun,	Shayni.

It is noteworthy that five out of twelve of these names are derived from Darang in Assam, from which place they were probably driven by Assamese tribes. At the present day, though numerous in the eastern Duárs of Goálpára, no Garos dwell on the north of the Brahmaputra in the Darang district.

Another Dúgú, to which many of the Bhowál Kochh-Mándai belong, is worthy of notice. The Mándai name for a Mussulmán being Lori (Garo, Rori), the illegitimate children of Mándai women with Muhammadan villagers are enrolled in a Lari Dúgú, remarkable for observing the "Shab-i-barát" festival.

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The members of all Dúgús being equal, they eat and drink together, and intermarry with women of their own or another clan. No council can legally meet, and no festive assemblage be complete, without a representative of each Dúgú being present.

The Kochh-Mándai are generally of a dark brown complexion, with prominent upper maxillaries, projecting lips, small black eyes obliquely set, retreating foreheads, and broad flat noses. The face is usually smooth, but when the beard and whiskers are grown they are scant and stunted. The ordinary build is short and squat. They are good-natured, inoffensive people, very sociable in habits, fond of music and dancing, and much given to intemperance. By Bengalis they are credited with being truthful, industrious, and virtuous.

Although the partially Hinduized Mándai worship Kálí, Durga, and other Hindu deities, they make offerings to the Ṣál tree (*Shorea robusta*), and under its branches sacrifice a pig to a being called "Játrá-mátá." They worship the sun with a bunch of flowers, propitiate the manes of their ancestors with the usual Hindu rites, and annually celebrate a joyous festival at the harvest home to the same Játrá-mátá. In a day in Mágh, but not on the Sankránti, they sacrifice a swine beneath a Ṣál tree to Bura-Buri, and, like the Doís, pray to Chandí before felling a forest tree. They have no Bráhmans, and no hereditary priesthood, so the oldest and most respected inhabitant presides at all village fêtes.

Women are treated as equals, and not like slaves, as is the custom among the Páni-Kochh. They neither weave nor spin, but are occupied with household affairs, and the cultivation of small patches of land. As a rule the women are not obliged to perform all the hard work as the Hill women are, and although permitted a freedom unknown either to Hindus or Muhammadans, their moral character has remained unsullied.

Marriages are much more free than among their neighbours, the bride and bridegroom being always known to each other before the wedding. Husbands, however, are not selected by the girls, as with the Hill Garos. Mándai women never intermarry with low Hindu castes, and have the reputation of being chaste and loving wives. The marriage ceremony is very simple. Turmeric is liberally sprinkled on the dresses of the couple, and of the assembled guests. The person who officiates pours water on the heads of the pair, and this *douche* is regarded as the sign of an irrevocable union. When the rite is concluded the rest of the day is given up to dancing, drinking, and general merriment, invariably ending in universal intoxication. The bridegroom does not reside in the bride's house, as is the case

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with many of the aboriginal tribes, but he enters at once on the responsibilities of wedded life.

The Mándai permit widow marriage, but for it they have adopted the usual Hindu term, Sagáí. When a widow, or widower, remarries, the wedding ceremony is not performed. The man merely asks the leave of the village elders to marry a certain woman, and if granted, he takes her home, and they are regarded as legally man and wife.

Adoption is sanctioned, but while a wife remains a member of her mother's Dúgú, an adopted child, on payment of a few rupees, belongs to that of the person adopting.

The Mándai burn their dead, and the relatives provide a feast for the mourners, at which as much fiery spirits are consumed as at any Irish wake.

The dress of the Mándai is that of the Bengali lower classes, but they show a greater partiality for bright colours, especially blue ones. The only musical instrument in ordinary use is the drum (Ḍholak), to the monotonous beat of which men and women listen attentively, or dance vigorously, for hours.

The Mándai mother is unclean for eleven days after childbirth; but is not allowed to resume household duties for at least two months longer. The family also remains impure for eleven days after a death, at the expiration of which period a feast being given to all the Dúgús of the neighbourhood, the family again becomes pure.

The Mándai, though settled, only pay rent to the Zamíndár when they cultivate the soil, no money being exacted for a temporary encampment, or for the land on which the village is built. They cultivate the "Baíds," or glades, with rice, and the hard laterite soil of the hillocks, or "Ṭilás," being ploughed, is planted with small patches of mustard, til, tobacco, and various pulses. Jute has of late years become a favourite crop, and, in the midst of the forest, fields of this valuable product are to be met with. The young men are fond of sport, catching deer, teal, and wild birds. They also collect honey for sale in the bazaars. Fishing is not engaged in to any great extent, and only for household supply. The villagers also cut down trees, hewing them into logs for firewood, or for manufacturing charcoal.

The Mandai have yielded so far to Bráhmanical influence as not to eat the domestic fowl, which they rear; but have no objection to kill, and feed on, the wild jungle cock. They are fond of kid's flesh, and of swine, whether wild or domesticated. Dogs, cats, frogs, and snakes, favourite articles of Garo *cuisine*, are abhorrent to the Mándai.

Slavery is unknown. When a debt is incurred the cattle are usually mortgaged to the creditor, but if the debtor be poor he may voluntarily serve until the debt is worked off.

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Comparative Vocabulary of the Kochh-Mándai, and other Kindred Tribes, Inhabiting the Frontier of Eastern Bengal.

English	Kochh-Mándai.	Kochh, Garo Hills.	Hodgson's Kochh.	Hill Garos.	Bodo.	Dhimal.
Woman	Mandai Matali / Michik	Magju	Beti-Choa ..	Michik	Hinjou	Beval.
Boy	Mia Dosha ..	Sasa	Chengra	De pisa / De fante	Hiwa-gotho ..	Wajan.
Girl	Maipu Dosha ..	Magju Sasa ..	Chengri	De Michik ..	Hinjou-gotho ..	Bejan.
Daughter ..	Dampsi	Magju Sasa ..	Beti	De Michik ..	Bishu	Chandi.
Sister	Nagadai	Janau	Bahin	Abi (elder) / Ano (younger)	Bina-nou ..	Rima.
Brother	Jangodai	Bhai, or Jong ..	Bhai	Ada (elder) / Jong (younger)	Bida	Yolla.
Tree	Phang	Pan	Gachh, Ped ..	Bol	Phang .. / Bon-phang	Sing
Rice	Mai	Mai	Dhán	Mai	Mai	Bhako-om.
Paddy	Maigul-mai ..	Mai-fong ..	Dhan gachh ..	Mai-bi-fong ..	Mai-bi-fong ..	Bhako-om-Singh.
Pepper	Jamsi	Moichok	Morich	Jalika	Bánjalút	Morchi.
Tiger	Matcha	Macha	Bag	Matcha	Mocha	Khuna.
Wild Boar ..	Wak	Wak	Banwa-suar ..	Wak	Hagrani-yoma ..	Dincha Ko paya.

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KOERÍ.

The Koerí, a very important agricultural caste of Hindustán, is closely allied to the Kurmí, with whom they drink, but do not eat, while the Kurmí attend their marriages, and partake of the feast.

Their subdivisions vary in different districts, but the few Koerí in Dacca claim to belong to the Kanaujiyá section. The respectful term by which to address them is "Mahto" (Sanskrit Mahátman, noble), but Muráo, greengrocer, is a common appellation, and Dhelphor, clod-breaker, a common nickname.

In Bihár, Koerís are employed as opium growers, in other parts of Hindustán as husbandmen and market gardeners, but in Dacca as constables and policemen.

In Arrah the Koerís, like the Kándús, worship the Pánch Pír, and hold a festival in their honour on the ninth and tenth days of the Dasharà in Aṣwin (September–October). A few are found following the tenets of Kabír and Daryá Dás.

Koerí women are unclean for twelve days after childbirth, at the end of which time the mother bathes twice, and after each bath plasters the house floor. She then marks with red lead five spots on the rim of the well, draws a jar of water, and her purification is complete.

KUMÁR, KUMBHAKÁRA, KUMHÁR.

This caste comprises 281,758 persons in Bengal proper, and in Dacca they number 14,835. Those belonging to Eastern Bengal can give no history of themselves, but are satisfied with the following ridiculous story of their origin. At the marriage of Ṣiv, a "Ghaṭ," or water jar, was wanted, but no one could make it. The god therefore took a bead from his necklace, and with it created a potter; while with a second he made a woman, who became the potter's wife. The man was father of all such as work in pottery, and hence the name Rudra (a title of Ṣiv) Pál applied to all potters.

The Kumárs of Dacca have four subdivisions:—

Rudra Pál,
Barà Bhágiyá Kumárs,
Chhoṭá Bhágiyá Kumárs, or Miṭṭíya Kumárs,
Magí Kumárs.

The first three eat and drink together, but never intermarry. They have the same Purohit, and the only difference between them is, that the two former manufacture earthenware vessels

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for cooking purposes, while the last make water vessels, vats, and jars. The Baṛá Bhágiyá Kumárs, again, have separated into two clans, the first, descended from Tílak Pál, only make black utensils; the second, sprung from Mádhava Pál, like the Chhoṭá Bhágiyá, only manufacture red.

The Magí subdivision is outcasted, having a Purohit of its own. Their debasement is referred to the days when the Mags harried Eastern Bengal, and, entering houses, defiled the inmates.

There seems no reason, however, for concluding that these degraded potters are the offspring of Mags by Kumár women, as they resemble in every feature the genuine stock of potters.

With scarcely a single exception, potters are Vaishnavas in creed. They have only one gotra, the Aliman, and one patronymic, Pál. The caste is a clean Śúdra one, and the Bráhman is common to the Nava-śákhá.

In Dacca the manufacture of pottery is still in its infancy. The wheel in use is the Roman rota, a circular table of baked clay weighted along the rim, revolving rapidly on a pivot cut from the heart of a tamarind tree. The neck and shoulders of all globular vessels are made with the wheel (Chák); but the body is fashioned by hand, often by women. A round ball of hardened clay (Pítna) is held inside, while with a wooden mallet (Boila) the material is beaten from the outside into the requisite shape and thinness. Two kinds of earth are used by the Dacca Kumárs, one called "Báli," the other "Kála miṭṭí;" and one part of the former mixed with two of the lattter are employed in the production of the strongest pottery. For making the common red earthenware vessels, red laterite earth from Bhowál is used, the colour of the rim being deepened by coating it with a mixture of Catechu (Kath) and fuller's earth. The cheap red and black earthenware are both prepared with the same clay, the latter being blackened by covering up the kiln at a certain stage, and adding oil cake to the fire. Bengali potters cannot glaze, or fix the colours on the ware; but are content to paint the vessel after it has been baked. Their colours are always mixed with mucilage, obtained from Bela, or tamarind seeds. Red paints are prepared with red lead; yellow with arsenic (Hartál); green by mixing yellow arsenic and indigo; and black with lamp-black, charred rice, or "Nal" reeds. A gloss is often imparted with the white of duck's eggs, but as this washes off before long, "Garjan" oil is more generally used. Idols, toys, and tobacco-bowls, are also painted with these colours, and the images of deities are further embellished by having powdered mica sprinkled over them while the paint is still wet.

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The manufactory of the Kumár well repays a visit. Beneath the same thatched roof are the kiln, store-house, and dwelling-house, while at the door the clay is prepared. The kiln is called the "Pon," from the Sanskrit Pavana, that which purifies, and the hut the "Ponghar." The kiln is divided into compartments, in which the newly made vessels are arranged, earth being heaped over all. Wood is never used to heat it, but grass, reeds, or bamboo stems are the ordinary combustibles.

The Dacca Kumárs manufacture bricks, tiles, earthenware of all shapes and sizes, idols, and toys; the two last being moulded, if of small size.

As long as there is no demand for articles of artistic beauty, Bengal pottery will remain in its present backward condition, while the necessity of scouring plates and dishes after each meal, and the obligation of breaking all cooking vessels after a death, or pollution from any cause, make Hindus prefer the cheap and brittle articles, rather than the more expensive and durable English ones. The most expert potters, those of Kishnaghar, are said to have acquired the art in Calcutta.

Although Kumárs are prohibited from using the Chák during the month of Baisákh, because Viṣva-Karma, the great artificer, rested from his labours during that month, they are permitted to dig and store clay. A potter never cultivates the soil, or serves as a domestic servant, but he has no objections to become a trader, a cloth merchant, a writer, or a servant to a shopkeeper. The village potter occasionally holds "Chákarán" land on the condition that he supplies the vessels required at all festivals observed by the Zamíndár, or the village community. Hindu households generally contract for their annual supply of earthenware, while a few pay the market rate for what is wanted. The pottery made at Ráí Bazár, in Dacca, bears a great name throughout Eastern Bengal, and in the cold season, boats laden with cocoa-nuts arrive from Sondíp, Noakhally, and Báqírganj, returning full of pots and pans from this mart. Vijayapúr, in Tipperah, is another bazár famous for the excellence of its pottery.

Kumárs still worship the ancient Vedic deities Agní, Brahma, Indra, and Pavana, and on the first of Jyeshṭha (May-June), at the termination of the idle month, special services are held in their honour, at the same time as the festival of Viṣva-Karma is celebrated.

In the city of Dacca the Kumárs have two Dals, or trades unions, one known as Islámpúr, the other as Bhágalpúr, after two quarters of the city where the potters chiefly reside; while outside the city every four or five villages have a Dal to promote the interests of the trade. The headman is styled Parámánik.

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who, on account of the increase in the size of the caste, is obliged to employ assistants, Náiks, or Gumáshtas. They are treated with little deference, and merely execute the orders of their master.

It is considered a dishonouring act for a Kumár to accept a wife without paying money to the father; of late years the price has risen so much that the poorer young men find it difficult to procure wives at all.

(*a.*) Ráj-mahallia Kumhárs.

This class of potters is quite distinct from the Khoṇṭá Kumhárs on the one hand, and the Bengali Kumár on the other. They originally came from Ráj-mahall with a member of the Banga Adhikárí family, and having tarried in Dacca for several generations, lost caste, while those who subsequently arrived from Hindustán were in their turn likewise degraded. There are about two hundred houses belonging to these potters in Ja'farganj, Sultánganj, Rái Bázár, and Kárwán, suburbs of Dacca, and it is remarkable that the caste still speaks a language made up of Hindi and Bengali. Having been settled in Bengal for many years, the clean Śúdra castes drink from their water vessels, while the Śúdra Bráhman, and other servants, work for them. The Śráddha, moreover, is celebrated after thirty days, as with the Nava-Śákhá.

Their gotras are Kaśyapa Kanaka, Ṛishí, and Aladoshí; the common title being Rudra Pál.

Ráj-mahallia Kumhárs have a curious custom, which is a source of much wit among Bengalis. They thatch the drying houses with green grass, merely fastening it down with weights, but never tying it, and when dry the thatch is used for lighting the kiln fire. They manufacture cooking pots for vegetables, milk-pans (Ras-dohana), and salvers on which sweetmeats and other delicacies are handed round at weddings, but will not make idols, or platters used in offerings to deities.

Like the Bengali Kumárs they do no work during the month of Baisákh, and on the first Saturday of that month celebrate the worship of Viśva-Karma. Their trade implements and manufactures are, on that occasion, arranged on the top of the kiln, and ornamented with Bel leaves, while the usual oblations are presented. The Purohit, meanwhile, mutters a few incantations, soliciting the favour of the divine workman.

The wives of these Kumhárs assist their husbands, fashioning the globular part of the vessels, while the men make the necks and rims.

Kumhárs are singular in placing over their wells an earthen-

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ware rim, or "Chák," admirably suited for preventing the ingress of filth. It is made by themselves, but has not been adopted by any other class.

(*b.*) KUMHÁR.

This, the lowest of the potter tribe, is generally distinguished by the epithet Khoṇṭá, or debased, and claims to belong to the Maghaiyá potter family of Patna. They drink water from the vessels of the Kumárs, and the Kumárs from theirs, but hold no communication with the Ráj-mahallia Kumhárs. None of the other Bengali Śúdras, however, admit their equality.

The Kumhár has only one gotra, the Kaṣyapa, and in Bihár Paṇḍit is a respectful term of address. In Dacca they are all Nának Sháhís in creed, the Mahant of the Shujá'atpúr Ákhára being the Guru. They work throughout the month of Baisákh, and on the Dasharáa make oblations of rice, wheat-flour, clay, and red lead to Maháadeo, their patron deity.

Kumhárs only work with "Chikní-miṭṭí," or potter's earth, manufacturing with the Chák, or horizontal wheel, long necked flasks (Çuráhí), lotahs, pipes, waterspouts, balusters, (Gáradía), and toys, but never idols.

On the tenth day after death the Kanthá Bráhman performs a religious service at which he tastes the oblation rice. On the following day the Śráddha is celebrated as among Chaṇḍáls and Ekádaśí Jogís.

KURMÍ, KUMBÍ, KUNBÍ.

This caste is one of the most widely scattered agricultural tribes in India, being, it is generally supposed, descended from a powerful aboriginal community, who retained a respectable position even after the Aryans had conquered Upper India.

Kurmís never agree about the seven divisions of their tribe, and few can even give their names; but those met with in Dacca belong to the Ayodhyá and Jaiswárá clans, while the only other divisions represented are the Ghameta, Maghaiyá, Kachísa, and Samsawar from Bihár.

The Ayodhyá claim to be of the highest dignity and purest blood, coming, as their name indicates, from Oude, where they are usually cultivators, while in Bengal they enlist as sepoys, or constables. Their common title is Mahto, but of late years Ráí and Singh have become fashionable. The Ayodhyá never

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intermarry with other Kurmís, and widow marriage is strictly forbidden. The Purohit is a Sákádvíp Bráhman, and the Guru an "Atít," or Vaishnava mendicant. The majority are followers of Kabír, Daryá Das, or Rámánand.

The Kumbin is unclean until three ceremonies have been performed. On the sixth day after birth the "Gulhattí Chhaṭhí" is observed, at which the mother is obliged to drink rice-gruel. On the twelfth day the "Bárahí," identical with the "Thál-vrata" of Bengali Muhammadans, is kept, and a feast provided for ten or twelve children. Lastly, on the twentieth day, the "Bísaí" is celebrated, when the mother paints the well with red lead, draws water, and becomes clean.

On the marriage day an entertainment was formerly given by the bridegroom, but the expense grew so heavy that the Kurmís very sensibly determined on abolishing the custom, and now refuse to ask for, or give money, on such occasions.

To render thanks for the harvest already reaped and garnered, as well as to ensure an abundant crop next season, the Ayodhyá Kurmís annually celebrate a harvest home in the following manner. In the centre of a piece of ground, levelled and plastered for the purpose, a lofty pole is erected to which the cattle are tethered, and made to tread the new wheat crop. This being finished, the pole is removed, and the hole filled with water, and the sweetmeat "Laḍḍú" consecrated to Mahádeo, and Parameshvara, after which a feast (Jeonár) is given to the Bráhmans.

The Jaiswáṛá, less punctilious than the Ayodhyá, are husbandmen, proverbial for industry and skill, who, from indulging in spirits, and from permitting their widows to marry, are degraded. In Dacca they are chiefly employed as constables, acting however, if necessary, as coolies.

The Bengali Káyasth drinks from their vessels, and smokes their huqqas, but the Kurmí neither eats with them nor with the Koerís, Kándús, or Kaháṛs, although he drinks from their water pots.

The majority of Jaiswáṛá Kurmís are Pánch Píriyas, eating any animal offered as a sacrifice to a Hindu deity, and at the same time keeping the Muharram, and fasting during the Ramazán; while a few are followers of Nának Sháh and Kabír.

At marriages the bridegroom receives presents from the father-in-law, and the Manḍúá or Marocha is constructed as in Bengal.

The same purificatory rites are performed after a confinement as among the Ayodhyá division.

Finally, the Śráddha of a Jaiswáṛá Kurmí is celebrated after thirty days; of an Ayodhyá after thirteen.

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LALBEGÍ.

The sweeper castes of India, vaguely styled Lalbegí, Khákrob, Bhangí,[1] Ráut, Helá, Halál-khor, Sekrí, or Chúhṛá, are remnants of semi-Hinduized aboriginal tribes, although the Puráṇas trace their origin to the issue of a Ṣúdra and a Bráhman widow. It was believed by the early residents in Bengal, that any Hindu expelled from his caste was obliged to herd with the Halál-khors, "the refuse of all tribes, poor unhappy wretches destined to misery from their birth;"[2] but this opinion was founded on ignorance, as outcast Hindus now, as in former days invariably join the ranks of Islám.

Under the Muhammadan government the sweeper tribes were employed as executioners, spies, and scavengers. Manouchi[3] informs us, that in the reign of Sháh Jahán they acted as sweepers in private houses, and picked up from slaves all the secrets of the family for the information of the Koṭwál, or head of the police. When Europeans first resided in India, cooks and domestic servants generally belonged to these vile tribes, and during the Mutiny of 1857, it was no uncommon thing to find a Mihtar engaged as the cook of a newly arrived English Regiment.

In Eastern Bengal the Lalbegí, Ráut, and Sekrí are met with in the large towns; but the regular sweepers employed in hospitals are the Bhúinmálís, or Háṛís, from Chittagong.

In the census reports of 1871 the sweeper tribes are all included under the generic term Mihtar, a name given by the Muhammadans in derision. In Bengal only 40,894 are entered under that head, but it is probable that this only includes the Hindustání emigrants, while in the north-west provinces in 1865 the census gave 310,795 persons.

Although in Oude the Mihtar tribes intermarry, in Bengal they will not even associate together.

The Lalbegí, who constitute the most important body, occupy twenty houses in the city of Dacca. They originally came from Upper India, some with Sepoy regiments, others as wanderers in search of work. Though styled Muhammadans they neither practise circumcision nor abstain from pork. The Lalbegí are employed as sweepers in European households, and are always addressed as Jama'dár by the other servants. On board the river steamers, again, the sweeper is called Topas, a term origi-

[1] This was also the title of one of the Sikh Misls, or confederacies. Cunningham's "History of the Sikhs," p. 106.

[2] "A View of the English Government in Bengal," by H. Verelst, p. 142.

[3] "Histoire générale de l'Empire du Mogol," par le Pére F. Catrou. À Paris, 1705, p. 271.

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nally applied to a mean white, the offspring of a Portuguese father and an Indian mother.

The Lalbegí eats everything that comes from the European table, although he will not eat with the Ráut, and drinks any sort of wine or spirits.

The religious rites of the tribe are partly Hindu, partly Muhammadan. As with Mussulmáns generally, marriages are arranged by an old woman. No Kabín, or marriage settlement, is drawn up, but an Ikrár, or bond, is executed, in which both promise to love one another, and the bridegroom testifies that he will not bring a second wife into his house. Previous to the wedding day the Kandúrí ceremony is observed, as well as other Muhammadan customs, but the services of the Áchárjí Bráhman are not required. Should the marriage be celebrated in the bridegroom's house a fee of twenty anas is paid to the Panchá́it; if in the bride's only five anas.

A few of the Lalbegí keep the fast of Ramazán, although they dare not enter a public mosque.

Their funeral ceremonies differ greatly from the Muhammadans, and resemble in many points those of the Sants, which are probably survivals of an aboriginal cultus. The dead are not permitted to be interred in a Mussulmán cemetery, but are consigned to the tomb in some waste and jungly spot. The corpse is wrapped in five shrouds, a handkerchief is placed under each arm and in each hand, a Kasáwá, or napkin, is bound round the head, and a Khirqá, or blouse, is put on the body. After the grave has been filled in a cloth cover (Phúl ka Chadar) is laid over it, while four pieces of "Agar" wood are inserted at the corners, and set fire to. The rest of the funeral ceremonies are strictly Muhammadan. For four days after a death a fire is not allowed to be lighted in the dwelling-house of the deceased, the family in the meantime receiving food from their neighbours; but on the fifth day a tray laden with betle-nuts, and adorned with flowers, is placed in front of the hut, and a feast is given to the whole tribe.

The Lalbegís however, follow many Hindu customs, observing the Díwálí and the Holí as the greatest festivals of the year. On these occasions a mud image of a mosque with five domes is made, after the model of one still existing at Garh Ghazní, in Kábul, which belonged to their eponymous ancestor, Lál Beg. In front of the image a cock is sacrificed, and offerings, consisting of a Puláo, Sharbat, and sweetmeats made in his name. This absurd story of their descent from a Mughal chief is analogous to the origin of the Bediyá from Núh Nabí. Lál Beg, however, is identified by Sir H. Elliot[1] with Lál Guru, the same

[1] "Supplemental Glossary," i, 32.

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as the Rákshasa Aroṇákarat; but in Benares[1] he is confounded with Pír Zahr, perhaps the famous Chishtíya saint, Sayyíd Sháh Zuhúr. In the Panjáb, again, Mihtars adore Lál Pír, or Bábá Faqír, as the dyers do Pír 'Alí Rangrez, and the blacksmiths Hazrat Dáúd. It is not improbable, therefore, that the Lalbegí, like many other tribes converted to Muhammadanism, have adopted a Muhammadan saint as their common ancestor around whom many idle traditions have been grouped.[2]

LOHÁIT-KURÍ.

A small caste of Hindus known by this name is found along the banks of the Meghna, who represent themselves to be the descendants of a Kaibartta fisherman, bought during a season of famine by a "Kurí,"[3] or parcher of grain, who, in want of a caste, made that now known as Lohait-Kurí. This insignificant body has already separated into two subdivisions, those following the father's profession of fisherman having repudiated connection with the maternal branch, who parch grain.

The caste at present neither associates with the Kaibarttas nor the caste Kurí, or Madhu-Nápit. The majority are fishermen, who will not cast a net, or fish from the shore, but angle with a rod from boats drifting with the stream. They manufacture large rectangular iron (Lohá) hooks, with a shank nearly two inches long (hence the origin of the first part of their name), as well as cotton lines. Iron sinkers are preferred to leaden ones, and the only bait used is a small fish.

A Patit Bráhman ministers to them, and the Śráddha is kept at the expiry of a lunar month. Like other fishermen they observe the "Jal-palaní" for seven days. A heavy fee is paid for a wife, as the caste is a small one, and one hundred rupees are often invested in a suitable helpmate, but a widower has generally to expend two hundred. The Lohait-Koris carry on a considerable trade with their own boats; but will not accept service with any other caste.

[1] Sherring, "Hindu Tribes of Benares," p. 397.

[2] There is a possible connection between Lál Beg and Bábú Lál, the founder of an Unitarian sect. "Religious Sects," i, 347.

[3] Buchanan found in Puraniyá a tribe of fishermen called "Kurí," some of whom spoke Bengali, others Hindi.

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MADHU-NÁPIT.

The following story explains the origin of this caste. The Mahápurohit, Chaitanya having ordered two of his servants to shave him, they obeyed, but realised that they were outcasted. Troubled in mind they pointed out that expulsion from caste privileges was the penalty incurred by executing his command. Chaitanya accordingly bade them become confectioners, and make comfits for him.

The descendants of the two servants have ever since been employed as confectioners, and their purity, according to Hindu ideas, is so excellent that even goddesses partake of the good things they prepare.

The Madhu-Nápit is not included in the Nava-Ṣákha, but the caste Bráhman is the same as that of the clean Ṣúdras; and the water pots are quite pure. In creed the caste is Vaishnava. They have two gotras, Áliman and Kaṣyapa. Madak is the common appellation, but Bengalis often address them as Kurí, or Sáha-Ji; the latter, however, is a title given to any shop-keeper.

The Madhu-Nápit is the most respected confectioner in Eastern Bengal, for the caste Mayara or Madak, is rarely met with, and the Halwáí is usually a Ghulám Kayasth, a Khoṇta Bráhman, or a Kándú. Only ten houses are occupied by the caste in Dacca, but more reside in villages. These confectioners assume great airs, neither intermarrying with other castes, not even with barbers, nor shaving themselves. In former days they would not fry sweetmeats in Ghí, or butter, but now are becoming less fastidious. The common comfits prepared by the Madhu-Nápit are "Jalebí," "Amṛiti," "Khájá," "Chhená-peṛá," "Laḍḍú," "Gojhá," and "Shír-bhúja."

The delicacies offered to idols are "Peṛá," "Barfí," "Iláchi-dána," "Batásá," and "Sandeṣa."

The Madhu-Nápit do not cultivate the soil, but are found employed as writers, goldsmiths, grocers, cloth-merchants, and policemen.

MAITHILA BRÁHMANS.

A few families of this sept reside in Dacca, the illiterate serving in the police, the educated as Purohits to pure Hindustání castes. Their "Jajmans," or flock, consist of Bráhmans, Chhatrís, and Kurmís; occasionally of individuals belonging to the Kándú, Áhír, Kewaṭ, and Surahiyá castes; but no Maithila

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Bráhman will officiate for the Dosád, Tántí, or Chamár. After remaining a few years in Bengal these Bráhmans return to their homes in Tirhút with a little money they have saved.

The ordinary surnames of the order are Ṭhákur, Miṣra, and Ojhá.

MÁLÁKÁRA, MÁLÁKÁR, MÁLÍ.

The Málákár, or maker of garlands, belongs to a clean Śúdra caste, and is included among the Nava-Śákha. The Málákárs of Bengal trace their descent from the garland-maker attached to the household of Rájah Kaṇsa of Mathurá, who, when met by Kṛishna, was asked for a chaplet of flowers, and at once gave it. On being told to fasten it with a string he, for want of any other, took off his sacred thread and tied it, on which Kṛishna most ungenerously rebuked him for his simplicity in parting with his "Poithá," and announced that for the future his caste would be a Śúdra one.

Like others of the higher castes, the Málákárs claim to have originally come from Mathurá, in the reign of Jahángír. They are few in number, but in every Hindu village there is at least one representative who provides daily offerings of flowers for the temples, and marriage tiaras for the village maidens.

The caste had only one gotra, the Aliman, and in the city of Dacca has two Dals, or unions, between which there is no real difference. If, however, a member of one union marries into a family belonging to the other, the marriage feast will be more expensive than if he took a bride from his own, as he must invite the members of both Dals to the ceremony. The bridal dresses must be made of red silk brought from Murshídábád, as cotton cloth is prohibited. The bride is always carried in a Pálkí, or palanquin, while the bridegroom rides on a pony, or in a Sedan chair.

A Málákár will not become a cultivator, and never works as a kitchen gardener, the gardeners of Bengal being generally Chaṇḍáls. In Dacca members of the caste keep shops for piece goods, practise medicine, act as vaccinators, and take service in temples. Their principal occupations, however, are making wreaths, fabricating artificial chaplets and toys from the pith of the Sholá (*Hedysarum lagenarium*). The garlands placed every morning before idols are collected and arranged by Málákárs, who nevertheless refuse to paint figures, this being the profession of the Gaṇaka and Rangrez.

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All the tinsel decorations put on the images and their carriages are designed by Málákárs. At marriages their services are indispensable, for they prepare the crowns (Mukuṭa) worn by the bridal pair. Moreover, no bride would consider the attire complete unless her hair was adorned with a Khopajúṛá, or ornament for the hair-knot, made with leaves of the Jack tree mixed with white Bela blossoms, while at one side of it they place a rose, or some other bright flower. For the bouquet delivered on the bridal morning the Málákár expects to be paid a rupee.

The profession of a Málákár requires a considerable knowledge of flowers, for some are forbidden to be used in religious services, and others can only be exhibited before the shrines of the deities to whom they belong. Thus the "Dhatúrá" is sacred to Ṣiv; the "Aparájita" (*Clitoria ternatea*) to Kálí; the "Bákas' (*Justicia adhatoda*) to Sarasvati; and the "Aṣoka" (*Jonesia Asoca*) to Shaṣṭhhí. The "Javá" (*Hibiscus rosa Sinensis*) or China rose, is of most unlucky omen, and cannot be presented to idols, or employed at weddings.

Strong scented blossoms are selected for religious offerings, and these in Bengal are the "Champá" (*Michelia Champaca*), "Chambelí" (*Jasminum grandiflorum*), "Juhí" (*Jasminum auriculatum*), "Bela" (*Aegle marmelos*), "Gandhráj" (*Gardenia florida*), and the "Hársingár" (*Nyctanthes arbor-tristis*).

Chaplets offered to idols must be tied with the dried fibres of the plantain stem, not with string, and if picked and arranged by one not a Málákár they are unclean. From sixteen to twenty-four anas a month are received by the garland-maker for providing a daily supply of flowers to a temple, but as with everything else, the price of bouquets has greatly risen, and a rupee only procures about half the quantity it formerly did.

The Málákárs are all Vaishnavas in creed, and it is said none of them worship Ṣiv. The Gosáin is the Guru, while their Bráhman is common to them and to the Nava-Ṣákha.

One of the chief occupations of this caste is inoculating for small-pox, and treating individuals attacked by any eruptive fever. Hindus believe that Ṣítala, the goddess of small-pox, is one of seven sisters, who are designated Motiya, Mátariya, Pakauriya, Masúriká, Chamariya, Khudwá, and Pansá. The first four are varieties of small-pox, the names referring to the form, size, and colour of the pustules; the fifth is *Variola maligna*; the sixth is measles; and the seventh is water-pox. Every Málákár keeps images of one or more of these goddesses, and on the first of Chait (March 15th) a festival is held, and the Málákárs superintend the details. It is popularly called "Málíbágh," from the garden where the service is performed, and

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thither Hindus and Muhammadans repair with offerings of clotted milk, cocoa-nuts, and plantains in the hope of propitiating the dreaded sisters.

When small-pox rages, the Málákárs are busiest. As soon as the nature of the disease is determined, the Kabíráj retires, and a Málákár is summoned. His first act is to forbid the introduction of meat, and all food requiring oil or spices for its preparation. He then ties a lock of hair, a cowrie shell, a piece of turmeric, and an article of gold on the right wrist of the patient. The sick person is then laid on the "Mánjh-pattá," the young and unexpanded leaf of the plantain tree, and milk is prescribed as the sole article of food. He is fanned with a branch of the sacred Ním, and anyone entering the chamber is sprinkled with water. Should the fever become aggravated and delirium ensue, or if a child cries much and sleeps little, the Málí performs the Máta pujah. This consists in bathing the image of the goddess causing the disease, and giving a draught of the water to drink. To relieve the irritation of the skin, pease-meal, turmeric, flour, or shell-sawdust, is sprinkled over the body.

If the eruption be copious, a piece of new cloth in the figure of eight is wrapped round the chest and shoulders. On the night between the seventh and eighth days of the eruption the Málí has much to do. He places a waterpot in the sick room, and puts on it Alwá rice, a cocoa-nut, sugar, plantains, a yellow rag, flowers, and a few Ním leaves. Having mumbled several Mantras, he recites the "Qiça," or tale, of the particular goddess, which often occupies six hours.

When the pustules are mature, the Málí dips a thorn of the Karaundá (*Carissa*) in Til oil, and punctures each one. The body is then anointed with oil, and cooling fruits given. When the scabs (Dewlí) have peeled off, another ceremonial, called "Godám," is gone through. All the offerings on the waterpot are rolled in a cloth, and fastened round the waist of the patient. These offerings are the perquisite of the Málí, who also receives a fee.

These minute, and to our ideas absurd, proceedings are practised by the Hindus and Muhammadans, including the bigoted Farazí, whenever small-pox, or other eruptive fever attacks their families. Government vaccinators earn a considerable sum yearly by executing the Ṣítala worship, and when a child is vaccinated a portion of the service is performed.

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MÁLO.

This caste is often designated Jálo, or Jáliya, that is, persons who use a net (Jál); or Jalwah, dwellers on the water.

The Málo, according to Buchanan, came originally from Western India, where they are still numerous. The families who observed the innovations of Vyása were called Kaibarttas, while the adherents of the old tribal customs were known as Málo. According to Menu, however, the "Jhalla" and "Malla" were the offspring of an outcast Kshatriyá.[1] Ward,[2] again, describes them as the descendants of a Mágadha, or bard, and a female Śúdra. Buchanan,[3] on the other hand, distinguishes the "Jhalo" from the Málo, classing the former with the Kaibartta, and connecting the latter with the Dôm and Paṭní. In Rangpúr the Málo is generally called Málo-Paṭni, while in Dacca the Málo and Jálo are synonymous terms for an impure fisher caste.

The caste Purohit is a Patit Bráhman, while the majority being Vaishnavas in creed, their Guru is a Gosáin. Though reckoned unclean, the Śúdra Nápit and Dhoba usually work for them. All belong to one of two gotras, Aliman and Udádhí, the members of which will eat and drink together, but never intermarry. The Udádhí gotra is chiefly found along the Lakhya and Meghna, on the outskirts of the Ballálí country, the Málos belonging to it being less deeply tinged by Hinduism than their brethren of the Aliman gotra. The only titles met with among Málos are Manjhí, Pátr, and Bepárí; while among other fisher castes no honorary distinctions exist. Under the Muhammadan government they served as boatmen, Chaprásís, mace-bearers ('Asa-bardár), and staff-bearers (Sonṭe-bardár) in processions. They were also employed in conveying treasure from Dacca to Murshídábád, while a tradition still survives that early in this century two of their number became great favourites with Nawáb Naçrat Jang, who presented them with golden spinning wheels for their wives' use. The Málos, therefore extol the golden age that has passed, and inveigh against the equality and degeneracy of the present.

Málos generally use a shorter Jalká boat than the Tíyars, but when they fish with the long Uthár net they fasten two boats stem to stern. Like the Kaibartta, the Málo is often a cultivator, and in Bhowál he has been obliged by changes in the course and depth of the rivers to relinquish his caste trade. Málos

[1] Chap. x, 22. [2] Vol. i, 140. [3] Vol iii, 531.

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manufacture twine, but not rope, and traffic in grain, while those who have saved a little money keep grocers' shops, or become fishmongers.

The Málos observe the same close time as the Kaibarttas and Tíyars; while Khala-Kumárí is worshipped in Śrávan (July-August), offerings are made to Bara-Buri in fulfilment of vows, and lights are launched on the river in honour of Khwájah Khizr.

Málo women sell fish in the bazárs, but in some places this practice is considered derogatory to their gentility, and is prohibited. Money is always paid for a bride, and of late years the price has risen to one hundred rupees. The bride's father always presents his daughter with a silken, or other fine, garment. After the birth of a child a feast is given by the rich to the caste Bráhman, and offerings made at a shrine called Dháka Iṣvarí, sacred to Durgá. As is general among the unclean tribes the Śráddha is held on the thirtieth day after death.

MALLÁḤ.

The exact bearing to one another of the different fisher and boating tribes along the Ganges has always been a puzzle. Little information can be derived from the men themselves, for an enquiry of this nature has no interest for them, and as a rule they are neither intelligent nor communicative. Buchanan[1] enumerates five tribes under the generic term Malláhs, namely, the Gongrhri, Suriya, Mariyari, Banpar, and Kewaṭ; Sherring distinguishes ten clans; and Mr. Beverley is doubtful whether the Banpar, Surahiyá, and Mariyárí should be considered as subordinate tribes, or as kindred to the Malláḥs.

The Arabic term for a boatman, Malláh, has undoubtedly been adopted as the name of a caste of Upper India and Bihár; but it has probably been assumed by, or given to, various fisher tribes.

In Eastern Bengal the following are frequently met with :—

Surahiyá,	Tíyar,
Muriárí,	Guṛiya,
Banpar,	Gonṛhí,
Kewaṭ,	Cháín.

Small colonies of these tribes are scattered throughout the Eastern districts; but it is as traders, bringing the produce of Bihár and Tirhut to Dacca, and other Bengal cities, that they are chiefly known.

[1] I, 172.

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All Hindustáni boatmen are, as they say, descended from one Nikhád, or Nishád, who ferried Ráma-Chandra across the Ganges at Allahábád; but there is little doubt that all are of aboriginal descent, and not of pure Hindu blood. If we enquire what are the religious rites performed by them, we find that ceremonials more aboriginal than Hindu predominate. The majority of Mallâhs belong to the Pánch Píriya creed, an excrescence of Muhammadanism, and worshippers of a water god, called Koila-Bábá, described as an old grey-bearded person like Father Neptune, who, as "Ganga Jí ká Beldár," saps and swallows up whatever opposes the sacred stream. Before casting a new net, or starting on a commercial venture, offerings of molasses, and seven kinds of grain, kneaded into balls, are offered to him, and at the end of the ceremony one of the balls is placed on the edge of the water, another on the bow of the boat.[1]

Another rite common to many, if not to all, fisher races is the Bárwaria or Bárahí Púja, when a subscription is made, and in the absence of a Bráhman, a swine is sacrificed on a plain or in a garden.

There is a much closer connection between certain of these tribes than others. Thus the Cháín and Surahiyá are more social and more nearly on an equality than, for instance, the Cháín and Banpar, and, as among the Śúdra castes, while one is considered clean, another is pronounced unclean. With our present imperfect knowledge of these tribes we cannot account for such capricious distinctions, but the causes were probably the same as those now creating divisions among recognised Hindu castes.

All Hindustáni boatmen call themselves Chaudharís; but Bengalis have one contemptuous phrase, Manṛuá-bádí,[2] or Manṛuá eaters, for all foreigners from Upper India. He would, however, be a rash man who used this epithet in their hearing, for it is the one term of abuse most warmly resented.

The custom with all Hindustáni boatmen engaged in trade, is for the net profits to be divided into shares of which the Mánjhí, or shipper, receives one-third, the crew two-thirds.

[1] This ceremony is called by them Deothán; see Elliot's "Supplementary Glossary," i, 245.

[2] Manṛuá is the Eleusine Corocana, the Rágí, of the coast Muhammadans, one of the most productive of grains.

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MURIÁRÍ, MARIYÁRI.

Buchanan was of opinion that this tribe of boatmen belonged to an aboriginal race from the upper valley of the Ganges. Other authorities, however, connect them with the Kewat.

The number and wealth of the Muriárí in Bhágalpúr have raised them to the rank of pure Ṣúdras; but in Purneah and Eastern Bengal impurity is attributed to them. The invariable reply given to enquiries relating to their history and origin is that their progenitor was a certain Kál Dás, who came from the south country.

The Muriárí are very numerous in Arrah, being engaged as ferrymen, boatmen, and fishermen, but refusing to carry Palkis, or become peasants. Many large boats manned by them arrive at the Váruṇí fair in November, laden with pulse and other vegetable products.

The majority of the Muriárí belong to the Pánch Píriya creed; and it is reported that widow marriages are still practised among them.

NÁPIT, NÁPITA, NÁÍ.

The barber of Bengal differs in no respect from the barber of Europe. He is the same character now as he was when Maenas brought the first barber to Rome to shave the famous Scipio Africanus, and although he does not possess in India a shop where idlers lounge, and the plethoric are bled, he still retains the reputation of being loquacious, a retailer of scandal, and with an unusual amount of insight into character. Above all, he is a man of the world, full of anecdote and repartee, and, if rumour is to be believed, he arranges meetings between disconsolate lovers. Furthermore, he is very clannish, and an insult received by one is resented by the whole body, while melancholy indeed is the fate of a Hindu who offends his barber; the whole clan will refuse to shave him, and at last, driven to desperation, he is glad, by the payment of an exorbitant fee, to be restored to their good graces.

In Dacca, the Nápit is a clean Ṣúdra, condescending to shave Europeans and Muhammadans, but declining to draw his razor over the chin of the Chaṇḍál, Bhúinmálí, or such like impure beings. He will shave a Sáha, but will not pare his nails, and will not attend at the weddings of any but the clean Ṣúdras.

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In Eastern Bengal the Nápits are all included in three gotras:—

Aliman, Kaṣyapa, Madhu-Kulyá.

Seel is a title common to every member, but the polite term to address them by is "Nara-sundar." Many, who practise medicine, call themselves "Baidyá."

Nápits are generally Vaishnavas in creed, but a few worship Ṣiv. They have no hereditary leader, but boast of very powerful unions, and a Panchá́it.

In every village there is a barber, and the situation often descends from father to son. In large towns they work independently, and there is no regulation against their following their occupation wherever they like. As a rule, the working classes only shave every eight days, but the higher ranks do so every four, sometimes every second day. In shaving every four days, eight anas a month is usually charged, and for a single shave one paisa, which also includes the charge for ear cleaning, nail paring, shampooing, and cracking each joint of the body. In the houses of the rich the barbership is often a hereditary post, as is that of the Purohit, Dhobá, and Dáí, while he, as well as they, have free access to all parts of the house during the day. The barber pares the nails of Hindu females as well as males, and his presence is required at all domestic occurrences. The day a child is born he pares the mother's nails, and returns on the ninth and thirtieth days to repeat the operation. At the houses of Muhammadans he is only present on the sixth day, the Chhaṭhí. For these services he is given pulse, rice, oil, salt, turmeric, and two paisa, the rich generally adding a piece of cloth and a rupee.

Yet, strange to say, the Nápit also assumes a religious character at weddings, and no marriage is properly performed without him. While the bride and bridegroom are seated within the "Marocha," he approaches, and repeats what is called "Gaura Váchana," a story about the marriage of Ṣiv and Párvatí, having for its moral the duty of submitting to one another, and of bearing with each other's infirmities of temper.

In addition to all these vocations, the barber, like his European namesake of the seventeenth century, practises surgery, opening boils and abscesses, and prescribing in all forms of venereal disease. A considerable number of the native physicians belong to this class, and many of the inoculators of small-pox. When a member of the Nápit caste wishes to study medicine, he is associated with a Kabíráj, who is then called "Adhyápaka," or tutor. The pupil is not bound as an apprentice, but he must obey his master as implicitly as the disciple his Guru. He compounds salves and simples, and daily receives

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instruction from his teacher. The Nápits, who practise inoculation, are generally most reckless, spreading the disease without the slightest consideration for the unprotected. They possess a text book, "Vasanta-ṭiká," but few study it.

Nápits have the reputation of being thrifty and very acute, and many, plying their trade in Dacca, hold land in Tipperah, which is sublet to others. Every year they visit their homes, carrying thither their savings, and at leisure arranging all affairs for the ensuing year. Those who practise medicine often amass considerable wealth, becoming respected members of village society.

Barbers never cultivate the soil, or fish for a livelihood, and will not take service as domestic servants in the houses of the low caste or European, as the Hindustáni Hajjám does. At the present day Nápits are to be met with on the bench, and they also serve as Mukhtárs, Wakíls (attorneys), policemen, and watchmen.

The Nápit is often an exorciser of devils; and if the newly born child has convulsions, or Trismus, he is called in, and performs the "Jhárna-phunkná" deception, which consists in making passes with a Ním branch, while a Mantra, or invocation, is repeated without drawing breath.

The Nápitní, or female barber, has no occupation in Bengal, as she has in Upper India.

No respectable Hindu female ever cuts her hair, except when she dedicates it as a votive offering to a deity, in the hope of curing her child of a dangerous malady. The hair in such cases is cut off and hung on a Ním, or Bat tree. There is a considerable traffic in hair between Calcutta and the eastern shores of the Bay of Bengal. A Mag considers that his good looks in a great measure depend on the size and shape of his top-knot, so, like the females of more civilized races, he braids false tresses with his own. It is generally said, but perhaps by libellers, that the poorer Muhammadan women part with their hair for a consideration.

NAṚ, NAṬA, NARTAKA, NÁṬÁKA.

There is little doubt that the Naṛ, or Naṭa, of Bengal, are identical with the Kathak of Hindustán, and a tradition survives that the caste first came to Dacca in the days of the Nawábs, and received the name of Naṭa from the Sanskrit for a dancer;

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but it is also said that originally they were the same as the Naḍa who manufacture lac bracelets. Ward mentions that in his day none of the caste were to be found in Bengal, and that the Bráhmans traced their descent from a Málákár and a female Ṣúdra. The modern Naṭas, not satisfied with this pedigree, claim to be the offspring of Bharadvája Muní and a dancing girl, and assert that the Gaṇak Bráhmans are sprung from a son of the same holy man. In Hindustán[1] the Kathaks still wear the Bráhmanical cord, and confer their "Áṣír-bád," or benediction, on Ṣúdras, but in Bengal the Naṛs no longer do so, as the original settlers, being few in number, were obliged to take wives from mean castes, and became degraded. Although the Naṛ caste requires to support a Bráhman of its own, the Ṣúdra Nápit and Dhobá work for it. The Naṛs have one gotra, the Bharadvája, and their patronymics are Nandí and Bhakta, by which latter title the caste is sometimes known, but whenever an individual excels in music he is dignified by the title Ustád.

When young, the Naṛ boys are taught dancing, being known as Bhagtiyás; but on reaching manhood they become musicians, or Sapardá, and attend on dancing girls (Báí), who are usually Muhammadans. In former days, no Hindu girls ever danced in public, although dancers among the Bází-gír, and other vagrant tribes, were common, but at present Boistubís, and Hindu prostitutes, are often professional "Nách" girls. There has been a tendency within the last thirty years for the Naṛ caste to separate into two classes, one teaching boys to dance and playing to them, the other attending the Muhammadan Báí. The latter are the better paid, and more skilful musicians, and a band (Sapardáí) accompanying a popular dancing girl often earn as much as twenty rupees a night, while the former consider they are well paid if they get five rupees for one night's amusement. The musical instruments generally used by the Naṛs are the "Sárangí," or fiddle, the "Tablá," or drum, and the "Manjírá," or cymbals. Naṛs treat their instruments with great veneration, and always, on first rising in the morning, make obeisance before them. On the Ṣrí Panchamí, in Mágh, sacred to Sarasvatí, a Naṛ will not play a note until the worship of the goddess is finished.

Like the Ṛishí women, the Naṛ will not play, sing, or dance in public, although at marriages of their own people they still do so.

It is currently believed that many Naṛs have of late years become Muhammadans, but this accusation is denied by the

[1] In Oudh the Kathaks call themselves Bráhmans, and their pedigree is traced from a Chhatrí father and a Bais, or Rájput, mother. They intermarry with kinsmen, called Kirtannia (S. Kirtiyá, a dancer) and Bhagatoá (Bhagtiyá). "Notes on the Races, &c., of Avadh," by P. Carnegy. App. B. 91.

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caste. It is nevertheless true that when a Sapardá falls in love with a dancing girl his only chance of marrying her is by becoming a Muhammadan.

A large proportion of the Dacca Naṛs inhabit an old Saráe, or caravansary, called Bhagtiyá Kaṭrá, built in the seventeenth century by an eunuch named Khwájah 'Ambar.

Many other settlements of this caste are met with in the interior, differing in several respects from the city families. For instance, the Naṛs of Bikrampúr affect the manners of a high-born race, tracing their descent from no earthly parent, but from a Naṭa of Indra's heaven, banished for some delinquency, and degraded to the lowest rank of Hindu society. Like other Śúdras, these Naṛs celebrate the Śráddha on the thirtieth day, are generally Vaishnavas in creed, and have a Patit Bráhman to officiate to them. They decline to play in the houses of the Chaṇḍáls, Bhúinmálís, and other low castes, and, as their services are no longer required, have ceased to perform before Muhammadans. At weddings the Bikrampúr Naṛs play on the "Behlá" (fiddle), "Naqárah" (drum), and "Kása" (a variety of fiddle). If he has no ear for music the Naṛ becomes a cultivator or a shopkeeper, without any loss of respectability. The Hindu Naṛ occupies a position corresponding to that of the Muhammadan Bájunia, but the former is more sought after, as no Hindu will have a Muhammadan musician in his house if he can possibly avoid it.

At Gopínáthpúr, in the east of the Dacca district, there is a settlement of the caste, celebrated as "Ḍholiyas," or drummers, who are in great request at marriages and religious ceremonies, The "Ḍhol" is an instrument of unwieldy dimensions, and, hanging in front, is beaten with the right hand, and with a stick held in the left.

All Bengali singers use a musical treatise, called "Rágamálá," written in the vernacular with the "Rága" and "Rágiṇí" of each song marked. The words are Hindustání, and are generally composed by masters residing in Lucknow, Allahábád, or Benares; but of late years Bengali gentlemen have shown a preference for songs written in their own language. Skilled professional singers, both men and women, learn to improvise, and execute variations (Tán[1]) while singing; and, on becoming adepts, a special musician playing on a "Tán-púrá," or instrument of four strings, accompanies them.

Native singers maintain that Gánjha ruins the voice; but that a drink composed of rice-water, sugar-candy, and black pepper improves and strengthens it. With few exceptions all dancing girls smoke Gánjha to excess.

[1] Sanskrit, "Tána," a tone, keynote.

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Throughout Eastern Bengal the most popular performers are undoubtedly the Kabí-wálí, or Jhumar, who chaunts ribald songs extempore, and the Kemta wálí, usually a Hindu Kasbín, whose dancing is as lascivious as that of the Kahrúá, or fandango, dancer of Upper India. During the annual holidays sacred to Durgá, incredible sums are paid to these performers, and celebrated artistes are sought for throughout India by the agents of the rich landholders.

Besides these various classes of musicians, dancers, and singers, the city of Dacca is enlivened on all occasions of festivity by bands of music. Enterprising Muhammadans, facetiously called "Majors," buy cracked wind instruments, threadbare red coats, and old shakos, which may have figured at Plassey, and allot them to individuals, often Farangís, whose only qualification is having sound lungs. These bands head all processions, and afford great pleasure to the populace, although the music to European ears is of the most horrid and discordant character.[1]

NÚNIYÁ.

A few members of this Bihár caste come to Dacca in search of employment, and are remarkable for their well-proportioned figures, and handsome features. Mr. Magrath regards them as a Hinduized offshoot of the Bhúiyas; but other authorities link them with the Binds and Beldárs. Like the Kurmí, the Núniyás maintain a peculiar and ill-defined relationship with higher castes, a relationship rendered the more inexplicable by their present low position in the social scale.

In Bengal Núniyás readily obtain service with Goálas, or other clean Śúdras, but refuse to work as labourers or domestic servants with low caste families.

PÁCHAK, PÁCHAKA.

In Dacca there is only one Páchak, or preparer of digestive pills, and he is a Chhatrí from Delhi. All castes of Hindus, from the Bráhman to the Chaṇḍál, patronize his shop, swallowing his pills whenever fancy, or expediency, prompts them. The

[1] On Bengali music a most interesting paper, by Mr. C. B. Clark, is contained in the "Calcutta Review" for April, 1874.

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popular digestive pill, called "Battísa," is composed of "thirty-two" ingredients, the chief being the seven kinds of salt,[1] to which senna, various myrobalans, and pepper are added. The Páchak, however, is also skilful in preparing preserves, such as pickles of limes, olives, mangoes, dates, young bamboo shoots, and the fruit of the "Ámlá" tree (*Phyllanthus emblica*), as well as salted limes (Nimbu-ka-járaka) and "Chaṭnís" of endless variety.

Oil pickle is another preserve extensively used by Muhammadans. A Mango being split into two, the stone is removed, and the cavity filled with the seeds of "Methí," or fenugreek, anise, "Kála-jírá" (*Nigella Indica*), and chillies. The two halves pressed together are then put into a jar of mustard oil, and eaten as a condiment.

PARÁṢARA DÁS.

The Paráṣara Dás is undoubtedly a branch of the Kaibartta class; but the highly respected and prosperous native gentlemen belonging to it repudiate this base origin, claiming from certain passages in the portion of the Padma Puráṇa, called Brahma Khaṇḍa, and in the Vṛihad Vyása Sangíta, to be descended from a Khatrí father and a Vaiṣya mother, and, therefore, entitled to equal rank with the Baidyá and Káyath. This pretension, however, is not acknowledged by the latter, who treat them as they do the Kaibarttas, as people with whom no social communion can be held.

The Paráṣara Dás are also known as Halik Kaibarttas, and Sparsha[2] Dás, a name indicating that they are not impure to the "touch." The Sikdárs, or poorer members, are cultivators, being identical with the Chásá Kaibarttas of Burdwan.

The majority of the Paráṣara Dás of Dacca are writers, traders, and factors. The ordinary titles are Maulik, Rái, Chaudharí, Biṣwas, Sirkár, and Majumdár, the two first being assumed by the higher, or Kulin, families, the rest by the Mahápaṭr or Sikdár orders. By paying a marriage fee not

[1] The seven salts are "Pángá," sea salt; "Kálá-namak," impure rock-salt; "Sendhá," rock-salt; "Khár," impure carbonate of soda; "Sámbhar," from the lake near Ajmír; "Láhorí," from the city of that name, and "Chiṛ-Chiṛá," or ashes of the *Achyranthes aspera*.

[2] This may be merely a vulgar pronunciation of Paráṣara, or from Sparṣa, touching.

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exceeding three hundred rupees, a Sikdár may marry into a Kulin family, but this system of purchasing social advancement is discountenanced by the aristocratic families.

In the western parts of the Dacca district the clean Ṣúdras drink from the water vessels of the Paráṣara Dás,[1] although they will not touch those of the Kaibarttas. In Silhet, where the caste is most numerous and influential, the same arbitrary distinction is observed.

In Silhet the caste has not attained to the high and genteel position of their Dacca brethren, but many are still labourers who come to Dacca, and set up as stonecutters, but return and spend their savings at their homes. Stone in blocks is brought from Patna, Mungír, and Mirzápúr, and with chisels the Paráṣara Dás make grindstones, currystones, and "Fíl-páyas," or stands for tables and bedsteads. In Silhet they will not cultivate land themselves, but assume to be pure Ṣúdras, descended from Vyása, the son of the Muní Paráṣara, and a Kaibartta damsel, and consequently entitled to the appellation of Vyásakta, which is adopted by all.

Wherever found, the Paráṣara Dás have the Ṣúdra Nápit and Dhobá working for them, but the Purohit is distinct, although it is maliciously asserted by natives that the Bhúinmálí Bráhman officiates for them.

The majority of the caste are strict followers of the Kṛishna Mantra, observing all the popular Ṣúdra festivals, but they are unusually scrupulous regarding cooked food; for instance, the flesh of kids is prohibited from being prepared in their own houses, and rice cannot be boiled in the same pan as meat.

PÁSÍ.[2]

A few representatives of this semi-Hinduised aboriginal race are to be met with in Dacca, working at all trades, but generally as porters, coolies, or servants to low caste shopkeepers. In Bengal the owners of the toddy and date palms either extract the juice themselves, or employ Bhúinmálís to do so, and shops for the sale of spirituous liquors are usually owned by Súṇṛís, or outcast Ṣúdras. The Pásí is therefore unable to prosecute his ordinary occupation, and is only driven by sheer necessity to leave his home and seek employment at a distance.

[1] In some parts of Dacca this respectable caste is in derision called "Gábar Dás," from S. Garbha Dása, a slave by birth.

[2] From Sanskrit, Páṣa, a noose, or cord.

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The extraction of the juice of the "Tál," or Palmyra palm, as well as that of the Khajúr, or date palm, is a most important operation in Eastern Bengal. The Tál trees are tapped from March to May; the date palms in the cold season.

The juice of the former, or toddy (Táṛí), is used in the manufacture of bread, and as an intoxicating liquor by adding sugar and grains of rice. Hindustání drunkards often add Dhatúrá to increase its intoxicating properties. In Dacca a "Tál" grove is usually rented, and on an average twelve anas a tree are obtained. The quantity of juice extracted varies from an average of five to ten pounds. When fresh this sells for two anas a *seṛ*, but if a day old for only one ana.

Date palm "Táṛí" is rarely drunk, being popularly believed to cause rheumatism, but is extensively used in preparing sugar. A date palm is generally leased for seven anas a year.

PÁṬIAL.

This is a branch of one of the Navaṣákha castes, probably of the Káyath, as the family names are identical with those of its lower divisions, but it is regarded as impure.

The sole occupation of this caste is the manufacture of mats, and they deny that they ever cultivate the soil with their own hands. The mats, coarse, dark-coloured, and thick, are called Moṭá-páṭí, to distinguish them from the finer kinds made at Silhet known as Ṣítal-páṭí. The only plant cultivated for mat-making is the "Mathara"[1] (*Maranta dichotoma*), which grows luxuriantly in the low, marshy parts of Bikrampúr, around the houses of the peasantry. It flowers in June and July, and, while still green, is cut down about the middle of September, the stems being divided into slips are hung from the rafters, and when required for use steeped in water.

Among the Silhet Páṭials women make the mats; consequently the money value of a girl who is a skilful workwoman is considerable, and a father receives from three to five hundred rupees when his daughter marries. In Dacca, on the other hand, men are the sole workers.

Although chiefly found in Bikrampúr, the Paṭials are scattered throughout Eastern Bengal, wherever the nature of the soil admits of the cultivation of the Maranta. The caste is exclusively Vaishnava, and the headman is known as the Pradhán, or Mu'tabar.

The only other caste that makes mats is the Doí, or Páṭia Dás.

[1] Or Mátula, Bengal hemp.

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PAṬNÍ, PÁṬUNÍ, PÁṬAUNÍ.

This is one of the utterly vile castes of Bengal, living in the outskirts of villages near rivers, where their neat and tidy hovels always attract attention. They are very reserved and uncommunicative, but there can be little doubt they were originally Ḍôms. In Rangpúr, and throughout the valley of the Brahmaputra, they are still designated Ḍôm-Paṭní, and in Bengal this is applied to them as a term of abuse. Their other titles are Gangáputra, Ghát-mánjhí, or simply Mánjhí.

According to some authorities they are descended from a Rajaka, or washerman, and a woman of the Vaiśya caste. Paṭnís, however, claim to be the offspring of Mádhava, who ferried Rámá across a river on his way from Ayodhyá to Mithila, and relate how Mádhava, having witnessed the resuscitation of Ahalyá, was afraid to transport the god to the other bank until he had extracted the promise that Rámá would sit on the gunwale with his feet in the water. The simplicity of this ferryman was extraordinary. When Rámá landed, Mádhava complained that the colour of the boat had been changed to a hideous yellow, and that he was ruined. The reply was that the ferry-boat had been converted into pure gold, and as a punishment for his stupidity Rámá announced that his sons would always be ferrymen, and that he should, after death, become the ferryman of the Vaitaraṇi, or Hindu Styx.

Another fiction in the history of the Paṭnís pertains to the reign of Ballál Sen. The monarch became enamoured of a ferryman's daughter, named Padma-vatí, and married her. At the feast "Pákaśparśa," when the bride cooks, and the bridegroom for the first time eats from her hands, the Paṭnís, with inborn obtuseness, and to the great grief of the queen, presented themselves at the end of the festival. For this misconduct they were degraded, and enrolled among the Nícha, or low castes.

The Paṭnís are chiefly massed in Eastern Bengal, there being as many as 41,855 in Silhet, 21,726 in Mymensingh, 19,691 in Kachar, 6,305 in Tipperah, and 4,695 in Dacca. Their aggregate number in Bengal is 127,636, of whom 102,728, or 80 per cent., are returned as residents of the nine eastern districts.

The Paṭní is peculiar to Bengal, the Ghátwál, or ferryman, of Hindustán, being usually one of the Malláh caste. Besides acting as a ferryman the Paṭní often trades, or keeps a grocer's shop, but he neither fishes nor cultivates the soil in the Bikrampúr part of Dacca, although in the north he is generally a peasant. Many still breed swine, but never admit doing so. The Paṭní caulks boats, and is very expert at manufacturing sieves and baskets of ratan.

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In Silhet the Paṭní caste has four subdivisions, having no fellowship with each other:—

1. Ját Paṭní, who are cultivators, and "Modís," or grocers.
2. Balamí, or Ghát Paṭní, are ferrymen.
3. Naqárchí are musicians.
4. Machhwá are fishermen.

The caste Bráhman is a Patit, who generally assumes a pompous title, such as Chakravartí. The barber and washerman are always members of their own caste, as the Śúdra workmen refuse to act for them. The Śráddha is celebrated after thirty days, and wives are impure for one month after childbirth.

The chief festival is the Ganga Púja, and Paṭnís never enter upon the work of a ferry without first of all sacrificing a white kid to the river goddess. They also propitiate Pavana, the Hindu Aeolus, with offerings of salt, sugar, milk, and Gánjha. The majority worship Śiv, eating flesh and drinking spirits, but a few Vaishnavas are to be met with.

Like most Hindu boatmen, on embarking, or when overtaken by a storm, they utter the following invocation:—

"Sar Ganga, daryá, Pánch Pír, Badr, rakhya Káro."

A Muhammadan boatman, under similar circumstances, shouts—

"Allah, Nabí, Ghazí Sáhib, Pánch Pír, Badr, rakhya Káro."

Paṭnís generally combine and farm a ferry for one of their number, exhibiting the same remarkable reliance on each other's honesty as is displayed by other natives when lending money.

All Paṭnís belong to an Aliman gotra, and the headman is styled Pradhán, or Parámánik. Widow marriage is not observed nowadays; and in many other social matters they affect the manners of the Śúdras. For example, they will caulk a boat, but it would be derogatory to paint it, and they freely indulge in intoxicating liquors, although it is sinful to own to it.

The Paṭní is usually a short, squat, and very muscular man. His nose is snub, with the nostrils expanded, and being, like other non-Aryan tribes, very fond of coloured turbans and ornamented jackets, his appearance is striking and peculiar.

RÁNGÁ-WÁLAH.

Pewterers belong to any caste, but are usually degraded Goálas, or Sonár-baniks. Four or five families, who live by melting pewter bars brought from Calcutta, hire workmen before

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the Durgá Púja festival to assist in adorning the grotesque images of the goddess. The pewter is put into an open pan, and when melted a ladle full is taken out and thrown on a stone slab. When cool, the Rángá-wálah presses the soft metal between boards of jack-wood, and works out the pattern with an awl and a sandal wood puncheon.

The pith ornaments, supplied by the Málákár for the figure of Durgá, are decorated by this workman, and a complete set is sold in boxes to villagers for from two to twenty rupees.

The Rángá-wálah stains his tinsel with three colours, red, green, and yellow. The red, or "Gulalí," is procured from the Gandha-banik, and mixed with Garjan oil before being used; the green is made with verdigris (Zangár) and Garjan oil; and the yellow is merely a paste of lac and turmeric.

RÁUT, RÁWAT.

This, the most numerous class of Mihtars in Eastern Bengal, are generally known as Ḍoriyá, or dog-keepers. By their own account two subdivisions of the family are recognised, namely, those residing on the north, and those settled to the south of the river Karma-náśa, neither of whom will intermarry, or associate with the other. The former, also called Tirhutia Ráuts, are degraded by manufacturing brooms and baskets, like the Ḍôms. Both Hindu and Mussulmán Ráuts are found in Eastern Bengal, but the latter never circumcise their children, and after death are not allowed to lie in the public graveyard. The Ráut, though despised by the people around, looks down on the Sáha and Bhúinmálí as still more degraded.

Ráuts are employed as sweepers in private houses, and look after the dogs and cats of the household, a duty occasionally discharged by the Lálbegí. Like the Helas, who are often identified with the Ráuts, they refuse to touch food brought from the European table, or handle the carcass of any dead animal, as is done by the Lálbegí, Ḍôm, and Bhúinmálí. At the caste Pancháít every member must attend, but those assuming Muhammadan customs abstain from touching the pork and spirits partaken of by their so-called Hindu brethren. In Hindustán the Ráut cultivates the soil, in Eastern Bengal he never does.

Their marriage ceremonies resemble those of low Śúdras; but on the wedding day the bridegroom rides, while the bride walks.

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Ráuts worship many Hindu deities, but the principal festival is in Ṣrávan (July-August), when they proceed to the jungle, carrying a young pig, which is sacrificed to Devi, or Bandí Devi, the favourite divinity of low caste Hindus.

When a Ráut dies, the body is wrapped in a clean white sheet, and the mourners on the way to the grave keep shouting "Rám! Rám! Sat hai!" "O Ram, it is true!" On their return to the house of mourning each one drinks a little sweet sharbat, after which spirits are passed round, and the company disperses. On the following morning the name of the deceased is inscribed on a leaf and steeped in milk, which is then poured on the ground. After seven days the Sátwíni Púja, or Ghusl, is observed, on which occasion all the relatives proceed to the river and bathe. The meals are cooked in the house, but not until ten days have expired can any of the inmates shave. A feast, known as the "Daṣamí Kriyá," is then celebrated, at which, all the men being shaved and dressed in their holiday attire, copious draughts of spirits are drunk. On the first anniversary of the death a similar feast is kept.

ṚISHI.

Ṛishí and Mochí are synonyms of the same caste, but the members repudiate the name of Chamár. There can be no doubt, however, that they belong to the same race, although long residence in Bengal has altered them in several respects.

Buchanan met with a tribe of fishermen in Puraniyá called Rishi, and he was of opinion that they were originally an aboriginal tribe of Mithilá. Rishi, however, is often used as a pseudonym to hide the real paternity of a caste, thus the Múshahar Dôm often calls himself "Ṛishi-bálaka," or son of a Ṛishi, and the Bengali Chamár tries to pass incognito as a Ṛishi.

In the census returns of 1872, Ṛishis are enrolled as Chamárs, or Mochís, among the semi-Hinduized aborigines. In Bengal they number 393,490 persons, and are chiefly met with in the twenty-four Pergunnahs, Burdwan, Nadiyá, and Jessore, while in Dacca 24,063 are returned.

The origin of the Ṛishi caste is given in the following legend, related by a Bráhman of theirs.

One of the Prajá-pati, or mind-born sons of Bráhma, was in the habit of providing the flesh of cows and clarified butter, as a burnt offering (Áhuti) to the gods. It was then the custom

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to eat a portion of the sacrifice, restore the victim to life, and drive it into the forest. On one occasion the Prajá-pati, whose wife was pregnant, failed to resuscitate the sacrificial animal, she having clandestinely made away with a portion. Alarmed at this, he summoned all the other Prajá-patís, and they sought by divination to discover the cause of the failure. At last they ascertained what had occurred, and as a punishment the wife was cursed, and expelled from their society. The child which she bore was the first Mochí, or tanner, and mankind having lost the power of reanimating cattle slaughtered for food, the good ceased to kill them.

A Bráhman was bestowed on the Ṛishis by Ballál Sen, and the story goes that in the palace of that monarch there was a Bráhman, who having made himself especially disagreeable by insisting upon being appointed to one of the newly formed castes, had it intimated to him by the Rájah that he would belong to the caste which should first appear to him in the morning. There was also a Ṛishi, a celebrated player on the Naqárah, or kettledrum, whose duty it was to sound the *réveille*. It was easily arranged that the Bráhman should first cast his eyes on him when he awoke, and his descendants have ever since ministered to this despised race.

The Ṛishis of Dacca can give no other history of themselves. In the city they occupy about 450 houses, and in several parts of the district large settlements are found. The subdivisions are numerous, varying in different parts of the country. In Bikrampúr they have separated into three septs:—

1. Ṛishi, musicians and basket makers.
2. Chamár, tanners.
3. Baitál, shoemakers and curriers.

In other quarters, however, they are divided into Baṛá-bhágiya and Chhoṭá-bhágiya, the latter being chiefly found in Bhowál cultivating the soil, and acting as musicians. It is remarkable that they observe the Śráddha on the eleventh day as the Chaṇḍáls do, and abstain from skinning the carcasses of their own cattle.

The only gotra is Śáṇḍilya, while Ṛishi is the general title of the caste; but a few, descended from servants of the Nawábs, who received rent-free lands, still style themselves Chaudharís. They have no Dals, or trades unions, but they possess a Panchá́it, and a president addressed Parámánik, or Moiáli.[1] Nine-tenths of the caste worship Śiv, but imitate the Śúdras in most of their religious ceremonies, while others, peculiar to themselves, resemble those of the Chamárs. Though utterly vile, they are permitted to make offerings at the shrines of Kálí, which a Jogí

[1] Perhaps the Arabic Muwálí, one who assists.

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is not allowed to do. They keep many Hindu festivals, the chief being that in honour of Viṣva-Karma, on the last day of Bhádra. When smallpox prevails, they offer a pig to Ṣítala, first of all smearing the snout with red lead, and repeating certain incantations, after which it is set free, and anyone can seize it.

Like the Chamár, Dhobá, Dosád, and other low castes, the Ṛishi observe the Jalka Deví worship whenever cholera or other epidemic disease breaks out. The Ṛishi women, however, only collect contributions in their own quarter of the city, and wear the wreath of plantain, date palm, or Bena[1] (*Andropogon muricatus*) leaves, for two and a half days, instead of six, as among the Chamárs.

Ṛishis burn their dead, but no religious ceremony is performed at the pyre. On the fourth, tenth, and thirtieth day after death, the Purohit offers "Piṇḍa" to the manes of the deceased.

Men and women are impure for thirty days after a birth or death.

A father generally receives from fifty to sixty rupees for his daughter. The bride is dressed in red garments, and, if rich, rides, but if poor, walks, to the bridegroom's house. Widows still marry, but the offspring of a "Sagáí" marriage is degraded, and the sons have to pay a heavy fine before they can obtain wives. The Levirate marriage is unknown at the present day.

Ṛishis will not touch beef as the Chamárs do, but they are very partial to chickens, and regard pork as a delicacy. Like the Chamárs they are notorious spirit drinkers and Gánjha smokers.

The female Ṛishi differs from the Chamáín in never acting as a midwife, in wearing shell bracelets instead of huge ones of bell-metal, and in never appearing as a professional singer.

Ṛishis work as tanners, shoemakers, saddlers, musicians, and basket makers. They tan hides like the Chamárs, but the only ones they will cure are those of the cow, goat, buffalo, and deer. Their mode of preparing skins is as follows:—The raw hide is rubbed, and then soaked for fifteen to twenty days in a strong solution of lime. It is then deprived of its hair and of any fat that remains, and steeped for six days in acid tamarind juice. Finally, it is put in a vat containing a solution of lac and pounded "Babúl" (*Acacia*), "Garan" (*Ceriops Roxburghianus*), and "Sundarí" (*Heritiera minor*) barks, the hide being after this immersion regarded as properly cured.

The town Ṛishis buy hides from their brethren resident in those parts of the country where cattle abound. The village

[1] "Benā," in Bengali, "Viraṇa" and "Víra-taram" in Sanskrit, are the names of the plant, "Khas-Khas" the Persian for the fibrous roots.

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Ṛishis every morning row up and down the rivers in their neighbourhood in search of carcasses, and when epidemic diseases attack the herds, they find so much to do, that the villagers attribute the spread of the disease to them. It is, doubtless, often the case that they puncture a healthy cow with an Acacia thorn impregnated with virus, but they are rarely, if ever, detected at this villainous trade. The people, however, firmly believe that they do act in this way.

The Ṛishi will not touch a corpse, but will skin the carcass of a dead animal. The skin of the buffalo, sacrificed at the Durgá Púja, is their perquisite, and the skinning of the animal often gives rise to bitter quarrels between rival families.

The Ṛishis make shoes, but of inferior quality to those manufactured by the Chamárs; also, famous baskets with rattan (*Calamus rotang*), from which they derive one of their popular names, "Bet-Mochí," the natives asserting that the baskets are so closely woven that they will hold water. They also collect the roots of the "Dub" grass (*Panicum*), and manufacture the brush (Manjan) used by weavers for starching the warp. In some parts, the Ṛishi castrates bull calves, but this they stoutly deny.

The caste has barbers and washermen who are Ṛishis, and in the city the Hindustání, or Khoṇṭá Bráhman, officiates for them. Illegitimate children are usually brought up to be barbers, or washermen, and wherever the community is a large one no inconvenience is felt.

The Ṭabla-wálah, or drum maker, is always a Ṛishi. Goats' skins are used for the covering, while cows' hides supply the strings for tightening the parchment. On every native drum, at one or both ends, black circles (Khiran) are painted to improve the pitch. The Ṛishi prepares a paste of iron filings and rice, with which he stains the parchment. At all Hindu weddings the Ṛishis are employed as musicians, and engaged in bands, as among Muhammadans. Their favourite instruments are drums of various shapes and sizes, the violin, and the pipe.

In former years, the marriage ceremonies of the Ṛishi were scenes of debauchery and intemperance, but of late intoxicating liquors have been prohibited until all the regular forms have been observed. Even Hindus, who rarely have anything favourable to say of the Ṛishi, confess that nowadays, owing to some unknown cause, both the Chamárs and Ṛishís have become more temperate and more attentive to their religious duties than formerly.

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SÁNKHÁRÍ, ṢANKHA-KÁRA.

The shell-cutter is one of the most homogeneous of Bengali castes, and Dacca has always been famous for shell bracelets manufactured by the resident Sánkhárís. In the whole of Bengal the caste only numbers 11,453 persons, while in the nine eastern districts it embraces 2,735, of whom 1,157 reside in Báqirganj, and 853 in Dacca.

A tradition survives that they orginally came to Eastern Bengal with Ballál Sen, and at the palace of that monarch in Bikrampúr the site of a Sánkhárí Bázár is still shown. When the Muhammadan seat of Government was transferred to Dacca early in the seventeenth century, the shell-cutters were induced to leave their old settlement by the offer of rent-free land in the new city. The Bázár where they now reside has been their headquarters for more than two centuries and a half, but owing to the small size of the rent-free grant, they adopted a very peculiar style of architecture, building two-storied houses with a frontage of six feet and a depth of at least thirty. At the time of the permanent settlement in 1793, the Sánkhárís, being unable to show authentic title deeds, were obliged to pay ground rent like others of their fellow citizens.

The Sánkhárí caste is generally met with in the city; the few residing in the country do not saw shells, but buy them ready cut, and, after grinding, polish them. In Rájsháhí, however, the Kumár cuts and polishes shells, while in Chittagong Muhammadans do so likewise.

Like all Ṣúdra castes, the Sánkhárí has a Bará and a Chhoṭá-bhágya division, the latter being also known as Sunárgáon Sánkhárís. The Chhoṭá-bhágya constitute a very inconsiderable body, occupying not more than twelve houses in a suburb of the city called Khálgárhnagar, where they labour at polishing shells purchased ready cut. These two sections never intermarry, although they belong to one caste, having the same "gotras" and surnames, and one Bráhman, but different "dals," or unions. Members of the Chhoṭá-bhágya have become traders, writers, timber and cloth merchants, claiming on that account to be higher in social rank than those who manufacture shell bracelets.

The main section of the Sánkhárís embraces 350 families, calling themselves Bikrampúr Sánkhárís. In Bengal they are included in the nine clean Ṣúdra castes, their Bráhman being the same as the Káyasth.

Their gotras are six in number:—

Ṣáṇḍilyá,	Kaṣyapa,
Gautama,	Madhu Kulyá,
Aliman,	Gárgya.

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Their Padavís, or patronymics, are Ṣúra, Nág, Nandí, Seña, Dhar, Dutta, and Kara.

It is rare to find a Sánkhárí who is not a follower of Vishnu or Kṛishna, while the majority are vegetarians, abstaining even from fish. Their principal festival is held on the last day of Bhádra (August-September), when they give up work for five days, and worship Agastya Ṛishí, who, according to them, rid the world of a formidable demon called Ṣankha Asura by means of the semicircular saw used by the shell-cutters at the present day. They are also strict observers of the "Jhulanjáttra" and "Janmáshṭamí" in Bhádra, festivals in honour of Kṛishna, kept by all Bengali Vaishnavas. The Sánkhárís generally are disciples of the Ṣántipur Gosáins, but a few recognise the Khardah family as their spiritual leaders.

The Sánkhárí bridegroom rides on horseback, but the bride, in red attire, is carried in a palanquin.

The president is styled Muta'bar, or Pradhán, and the seats in the assembly were formerly arranged by him according to rank, but now no distinctions are admitted. When a shell-cutter lives beyond the precincts of the Bázár he becomes an outcast, and necessarily joins the Sunárgáon division. Not many years have elapsed since a Sánkhárí who took service, educated himself, or followed any other profession, was degraded, but many are now studying in schools and colleges, and accepting employment without losing their position in society.

The shells used for manufacturing bracelets are imported from the Gulf of Manaar. Natives distinguish many varieties, differing in colour and size, but the ordinary conch shell is the Mazza, or Turbinella, napa. The trade in these shells has flourished from the earliest historical times. The "Chank" is mentioned by Abú Zaid in the tenth century of our era. Tavernier includes shell bracelets among the exports of Dacca in 1666, and adds, that in Patna and Bengal there were over two thousand persons employed in manufacturing them.[1]

Towards the end of the seventeeth century the shell trade became a monopoly in the hands of the Dutch. A French missionary in 1700 writes:[2] "It is scarcely credible how jealous the Dutch are of this commerce. It was death to a native to sell them to anyone but to the factory servants at Ceylon. The shells were bought for a trifle, but when despatched in their own vessels to Bengal, the Dutch acquired great profit."

The chank fishery[3] became a royalty of the English Govern-

[1] Tavernier, part ii, book ii, 183–4.

[2] "Lettres Édifiantes," ii, 278.

[3] Accounts of this shell or "sea-horn" fishery are given by Jan Nieuhof in A. and J. Churchill's "Voyages, and Travels," vol. ii, 298, and, of a later date, in "Lettres Édifiantes," x, 121. (Ed. 1781.)

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ment, yielding an annual revenue of 4,000*l.*, but it is now open to all the world. In former days six hundred divers were employed, and in a single season four and a half millions of shells were frequently taken, of the gross annual value of 8,000*l.* The shells are imported by English merchants into Calcutta, purchased by rich Sánkhárís, and retailed to the cutters.

On the arrival of the shells the remains of the mollusc (Pittá) are extracted and sold to native physicians as a medicine for spleen enlargement. The base (Gherá), the lip, and point of the shell are then knocked off with a hammer, the chips being used as gravel for garden walks, or sold to agents from Murshídábád, where beads are made of the larger pieces, and a paint, "Maṭṭiya Sindúr," of the smaller.

In the ordinary shell the whorls turn from right to left, but when one is found with the whorls reversed, "Dakshiṇá-varta,"[1] its price is extravagant, as it is believed to ensure wealth and prosperity. One belonging to a Dacca Zamíndár is so highly prized that he refused an offer of 300 rupees.

From two to eight bracelets are made from one shell. The sawdust is used to prevent the pitting of smallpox, and as an ingredient of a valuable white paint.

The Sánkhárís have the character of being very penurious, and unusually industrious, young and old working to a late hour at night. Boys are taught the trade at a very early age, otherwise their limbs would not brook the awkward posture and confined space in which work is carried on. When sawing, the shell is held by the toes, the semicircular saw kept perpendicular, being moved sideways.

Every married Hindu woman wears shell-bracelets, which are as much a badge of wedded life as the red lead streak on the forehead. Unmarried girls, and Muhammadan females of all ranks, adorn their wrists with lac, never with shell, bracelets.

The Sánkhárí are notoriously filthy in their domestic arrangements. A narrow passage, hardly two feet wide, leads through the house to an open courtyard, where the sewage of the household collects, and is never removed. Epidemic diseases

[1] Reversed shells are holy, because Vishnu grasps one in his hand, and it is related that the god hid himself in it to escape from the fury of his enemies. The reversed shell is "Der linkse Koningshooren," or "Offerhoorn," of the Dutch; and Rumphius mentions that the natives of Amboyna gave 100 pagodas, or £40, for one. In Nieuhof's day, 1665, a specimen was often sold for 800 reals, or £15, and in Calcutta 400, 500, and even 1,000 rupees, have been given. Balfour's "Cyclopædia," sub. Chank.

Reversed shells of other species were formerly much valued by European virtuosos. Chemnitz describes one belonging to a burgomaster of Rotterdam, which was sold for over £10, and Dr. E. Clarke mentions one seen in Copenhagen, "not exceeding an inch in length, worth £50."

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are very prevalent, and the municipal authorities are often required to interfere and compel them to adopt vaccination and cleanliness.

The men, as a rule, are pale and flabby, very subject to elephantiasis, hernia, and hydrocele.

Among them are certain families with white skins, light auburn or red hair, and weak blear eyes, with blue irides, who freely intermarry with other families, and transmit the peculiarity to their children.

The women are remarkable for their beauty, confinement within dark rooms giving them a light wheaten complexion. They are, however, squat, becoming corpulent in adult life, and their features, though still handsome, inanimate. They are very shy, but the fact that in former days their good looks exposed them to the insults and outrages of licentious Muhammadan officials is a sufficient excuse for their timidity. Even nowadays the recollection of past indignities rouses the Sánkhárí to fury, and the greatest abuse that can be cast is to call him a son of 'Abdúl Razzáq, or of Rájah Rám Dás. The former was a Zamíndár of Dacca; the latter the second son of Rájah Ráj Bullabh, Díwán of Bengal. It is stated that they frequently broke into houses and carried off the Sánkhárí girls, being shielded by their rank and influence from any punishment.

An account of a Sánkhárí who has raised himself to a position of great popularity by his skill, is worthy of mention. Badan Chánd Nág is no charlatan, and for twenty years he and his father have treated a considerable proportion of the fractured limbs of citizens. He does not allege, but his patients maintain, that he can effect union of a bone more quickly than the European surgeon. His treatment consists in gently rubbing the seat of fracture with "Momiyáí,"[1] and Sámbhar salt boiled in butter. A leaf of the "Madár" plant (*Asclepias*) is then laid on the limb, and over it tin splints are fastened. This treatment—far in advance of that followed by Kabíráj or Hakím—is successful in cases of simple fracture.

[1] A bitumen brought from Persia, Kábul, and Tibet. Throughout India it is popularly believed to be the "dripping" of Negro boys, who are hung up by the heels, and roasted before a slow fire! Vigne's "Ghazni," p. 62; "J. A. S. Bengal," xlv, 51.

Since the days of Dioscorides, bitumen has by Eastern physicians been considered to possess the following qualities: "discutit, glutinat, emollit, ab inflammatione tuetur." Arabian doctors recognised two kinds, "Al qafr al Yahúdí," from the Dead Sea, and "Al Momiyáí al Qabúri," used in preparing mummies. See also "Ibn Haukal," p. 133.

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SARWARIA BRÁHMANS.

A few Sarwaria, or, as they prefer calling themselves, Ráma-Chandra Bráhmans, are employed in Dacca as constables, doorkeepers, and servants in the houses of rich Bábús. They are of higher rank than the Maithila, and are very strict in expelling any of their tribe who marry in Bengal, or eat sweetmeats prepared by the confectioner.

As with the Maithila, the "Bhánjá," or sister's son, is the Purohit of the family.

SEKRÍ.

This sweeper caste has few representatives in Eastern Bengal, the ten or twelve houses occupied by them being all within the city, and, having become Muhammadans, they can with difficulty be distinguished from the population around. The Mullas having acknowledged them to be true believers, they worship in the public mosques, and are buried in the public graveyard.

Shaikh is a title assumed by all, and their names are generally taken from the day of the week, or from the month in which they were born. For instance, Shaikh Ramazán, and Shaikh Itwárí are common appellations.

At the present day the Dacca Sekrí only work at the manufacture of lucifer matches, or spills of wood tipped with sulphur.

On the east of the Meghna Sekrí colonists are employed as cultivators.

ṢILÁRÍ.

This strange race of magicians, deriving their name from the Sanskrit Ṣilá, a stone, are employed to protect crops from hailstones. They are identical with the "Gárapagárí" of the Central provinces, who are paid village servants; but in Eastern Bengal a member of any caste may become a Ṣilárí, being remunerated according to the success of his enchantments.[1]

[1] Formerly the Ṣilárí was a paid village servant in Bengal, and officiated at an annual festival, which is no longer observed. Taylor's "Topography of Dacca," p. 266.

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Chaṇḍáls, Jogís, and Vairágís are the ordinary Ṣiláris, but a Muhammadan often acts as one, his co-religionists believing as implicitly in this occult science as their Hindu brethren.

At the present day this magical art is falling into disrepute, and it is no unusual thing for the peasantry to punish a Ṣilárí who fails to protect their fields. The Ṣiláris confess that their skill is inadequate to call down a storm on a neighbour's crop, as was formerly done; but they still profess ability to drive away a cloud threatening any tract of country.

As hailstorms in Bengal occur usually in March and April, when the "Boro-dhán," or spring rice, is in the ear, the services of the magician are called for in low lands, where this crop is cultivated. When a storm is impending the Ṣilárí, summoned by the peasantry, rushes, almost naked, from his hut, with a rattan wand in his right hand. Invoking Parameṣvara, the supreme god, he ascends a mound, where, spreading abroad his hands, and waving his rod to indicate the direction the storm-cloud is to take,[1] he recites one or other of the following doggrel incantations, in the vernacular:—

I.

O Narasiṅha! Narasiṅha! mighty Narasiṅha! whom the fourteen gods fear;
On hearing the name Narasiṅha the gods and spirits bend their heads;
My Guru's name is Híra. Wherever you go, that quarter of the world is subdued,
Whether it consists of hills or mountains, trees or jungle.
Should this charm of mine fail, Mahádeva's hair will be uprooted, and fall off.

II.

Diamonds cut stones,
Rivers retire before them,
A gold knife is keen as a diamond,
I have cut it this day into thirty-two,
Begone to the mountains of the north
Having paid your tribute to the south.
Having scattered you, I go home.
My name is Ṣiva Ṣankara.

The above metrical rhapsody was obtained from Rái Chánd Vairágí, a celebrated Ṣilárí, residing at Shámgáon, in Tipperah.

The villagers present their magician with rice, or other food, when his charms have been efficacious, as money is an inauspicious gift.

[1] Compare Exodus ix, 33.

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SONÁR, SONÁR-BANIK, SUVARNA-BANIKA.

In Bengal this caste has broken up into so many divisions that it has become almost impossible to distinguish the minute shades of difference between them. It is allied to the great Bania tribe, and claims to be descended from Vaiṣya parents, although now degraded, and not included in the nine clean Ṣúdra castes. One authority[1] describes them as the offspring of a Baidyá and a Vaiṣya female; while another[2] connects them with the issue of a Bráhman and a Vaiṣya woman, and therefore the same as the Párasava, or mixed order, of Menu. Among the Marhattas Sonárs claim to be Upa-Bráhmaṇas, or minor Bráhmans.

The Bengal Sonárs ascribe their low position to the enmity of Ballál Sen, who ordered them to eat with Ṣúdras, which they refused to do. The incensed monarch appointed spies to watch them, who invented a story that the caste Bráhman having accepted a present from a low caste man sold it to the Sonárs. The Rájah on hearing the false charge, and without making any inquiry, issued an order degrading the whole caste.

It is much more probable, however, that Sonárs are Hindustáni Banias, who, losing rank by residing in Bengal, were placed in an inferior position when the re-organisation of Hindu society was effected.

The total number of Sonár-baniks in Bengal is 60,366, of whom 12,735, or one-fifth, inhabit Burdwan, 8,195 the twenty-four Pergunnahs, 8,097 Hughli, and 292 Dacca. They diminish in numbers on the east of the Ganges; and it would seem from this that they originally settled in the central, and more peaceful, districts.

In eastern Bengal the Sonár-banik caste has four sub-divisions, namely:—

Banga,	Uttar Ráṛhí,
Dakhin Ráṛhí,	Nadiyá, or Sapta Grámí.

1. Banga.

They claim to be descendants of Sonárs resident in Bengal during the reign of Ballál Sen, and are undoubtedly the oldest branch of the family. Two Ṣreṇi are met with, Kulina and Varendra, or Maulika, inferior, which never intermarry. Every Maulika, however, asserts that he is a Kulina, and village Sonárs, by assuming similar claims, cause endless squabbles and feuds. Ward distinguishes between the Sauvarna-kár and

[1] Ward's "Hindus" i, 134.
[2] Wilson's "Glossary," p. 488.

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the Sauvarna-banik; the former being goldsmiths, the latter money-changers. It is remarkable that members of the Banga engaging in the caste profession of goldsmiths are styled Sankara, or mixed, baniks, and excommunicated from the society of their brethren. In the city about forty families reside, twenty-five of whom belong to the pure town stock, and fifteen to the Grámí, or rural. These two branches are still further sundered by having two distinct Dals, or unions.

The Bangas have three gotras, Kaṣyapa, Gautama, and Vyáṣa. The "Padavi," or titles, are—

Sena,	Laha,
Dhar,	Chanda,
Datta,	Pál,
Dé,	Siṇha,
Borál,	Aḍḍi.
Maulika.	

The marriage ceremonies are copied from those observed at the wedding of Śrí Rámachandra and Śíta, while in western Bengal the marriage service is that of Mahádeva and Párvatí. At the former the bridal pair, seated on stools, are carried round the court; at the latter the bridegroom stands, while the bride is borne round him. The bride wears a red dress, as well as a lofty diadem (Mukuṭa) with a red turban, from which tinsel pendants hang. The bridal attire becomes the perquisite of the barber; the dress worn on the second day falls to the Ghaṭaka.

The "Pradhán," or president of the caste assembly, is always a Kulina. The Kulina sometimes marries a Maulika girl when her dowry is large, but this alliance does not exalt her family.

The Banga Sonárs are jewellers, but, as a rule, do not manufacture ornaments. They are often bankers, traders, and shopkeepers. The poorer class accept employment as writers, but would sooner starve than cultivate the soil. The large majority are Vaishnavas, but a few follow the Tantric ritual.

2. Dakhin Ráṛhí Sonárs.

In the city reside about seventy families, who originally sought shelter in Eastern Bengal, along with the Uttar Ráṛhi and Nadiyá Sonárs, from the Marhatta invasion of 1741. Among them rage interminable disputes about precedence, and the confusion is increased by the "Padavís" being the same as those of the Banga.

The houses of Nílámbara Datta and Potiráj Dé are reckoned the first of Kulinas, and next, but at a great interval, are the children of two brothers, Chanda and Madhu, who are Síls, and reside at Balgonah, in Burdwan. Families with the titles of Borál,

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Laha, Chand, and Aḍḍi are deemed more aristocratic than the Maulika.

The gotras of this divisian are—

Madhu Kulyá,	Ṣáṇḍilya,
Kaṣyapa,	Savarṇa,
Gautama,	Bharadvája.

As a general rule the Dakhin Ráṛhí do not intermarry with the Uttar Ráṛhí, but take "Púri," or cake, from them, and even cooked food, if on friendly terms. The daughter of a Kulina marrying a Maulika bridegroom sinks to his level, but the daughter of a Maulika marrying a Kulina is raised to his. Dakhin Ráṛhí women dress like other Hindu females of Eastern Bengal; the Uttar Ráṛhí as women of Burdwan and Hughli.

The Dakhin Ráṛhí worship Lakshmí daily, when rice, sugar, and flowers are offered, and no woman will touch food until this duty is performed. The "goddess of wealth" is also worshipped with especial honour four times every year.

The members of this subdivision are usually employed as writers.

3. Uttar Ráṛhí Sonárs.

Many peculiarities of their earlier home are retained by this subdivision. The women still speak the Burdwan "Bháshá," or dialect, and their dress is that of Central Bengal. The gotras are many, and the following are the most important:—

Madhu Kulyá,	Kaṣyapa,
Ṣáṇḍilya,	Bharadvàja,
Paráṣara,	Brahma Ṛishi,
Nága-Ṛishi,	Gautama,
Aliman,	Savarṇa.

The titles are the same as those of other Sonárs, but they have no Maulika. Their president is styled "Múrdhanya," a Sanskrit word for highest.

The Uttar Ráṛhí still prepares the marriage space, called Marocha, which has been given up by the Dakhin Ráṛhi, and the bride wears the lofty diadem, and appendages of the Banga.

In Dacca there are about seventy families, the men being employed as clerks, accountants, and bankers. Only four annual festivals in honour of Lakshmí are kept, that on the Díwálí being omitted. Manasa Deví is propitiated with great ceremony, and on the Bhagíratha Dashará a branch of "Sij" (*Euphorbia ligularia*), sacred to the "goddess of snakes," is planted in the courtyard, and on every Panchamí, or fifth lunar day of each fortnight up to the Dashará of the Durgá Újah, the Sonárs make offerings to it. On the great day of the feast, the Vijaya Daṣamí, the plant is plucked up and thrown into the river.

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4. Nadiyá, or Sapta Grámí, Sonárs.

This subdivision constitutes a small body numbering some thirty-five households. Driven from their former homes by the Marhattas, they crossed the Ganges, and settled in Dacca.

The principal gotras are—

Madhu Kuliya,	Savarṇa,
Nága-Ṛishi,	Ṣúra-Ṣrí.
Ṣáṇḍilya,	

The patronymics are Síl, Borál, Pál, Sena, Maulika, Dé, Harí Priya Dás, and Karaṇa Varí Dás.

Being a small community the Nadiyá Sonárs intermarry with the Dakhan and Uttar Ráṛhí, and easily obtain wives by giving a large dowry.

While the Ták-sál, or Mint, was open at Dacca, the Nadiyá Sonárs worked as Son-dhoas, goldwashers, or Nyáriyás, in fusing and purifying metals, but since its closure they have worked as Son-dhoas on their own account. The dust and refuse (Gád) of goldsmiths' shops are bought for a sum varying from eight anas to five rupees a *ser*, according to the amount, or nature of the business. The refuse being carefully washed the metallic particles in the sediment are transferred to shallow earthern pans and the larger separated by a skilled workman, or Kárígar. The smaller mixed with cowdung and a calx of lead form a ball, named Piṇḍi, or Peṛá. This ball being placed in a hole partially filled with charcoal, fire is applied, and as the lead melts it carries with it all gold and silver filings, forming a mass, called "Lína." This "Lína" is then dissolved in a crucible, and the gold and silver being unmelted are easily separated.

SÚNṚÍ, ṢAUṆḌIKA, ṢUṆḌAKA.

According to Hindu ideas this is one of the most degraded castes, and the following ridiculous story in the Vaivarta Puráṇa explains the origin of the first distiller, and vendor of spirituous liquors.

Ṣani, the Hindu Saturn, failing to adapt the elephant's head to the mutilated trunk of Gaṇeṣa, Viṣva-Karma, the celestial artificer, was sent for, and by careful dissection and manipulation, he fitted the incongruous parts together, and made one Kedára Sena from the slices cut off in fashioning his *chef d'œuvre*. It is further mentioned that Kedára Sena was ordered to fetch a drink of water for Bhágavatí, weary and athirst. Finding a shell on the river's bank full of water he presented it to her, being unaware that a few grains of rice left in it by a parrot

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had fermented and formed an intoxicating liquid. Bhágavatí, as soon as she had drunk, became aware of the fact, and in her anger condemned the offender to a vile and servile occupation.

The caste is subdivided into two sections, or Śreni, the Ráṛhí and Varendra. The former are distillers called Súnṛi; the latter traders, who have assumed the title of Sáha,[1] or merchant. By some authorities, however, the Sáha is the issue of a Śúdra father and a Súnṛí mother. The members of these two classes neither associate together, nor intermarry. In some parts of Bengal the caste has four divisions, the Ráṛhi, Varendra, Banga, and Magí.

The Hindustání distiller (Kalár, Kalwár) has nothing in common with the Súnṛí, as he only manufactures spirits, and will not vend it, an occupation carried on by Kurmís, or Banias.

The Súnṛí is a very degraded individual, indulging freely in intoxicating liquors. The majority of the workmen in the Government Ábkárí, or excise department, are Súnṛís, and most of the Gánjha shops are owned by them.

The Sáha, again, is perhaps the most enterprising and prosperous community in Bengal, comprising a large number of the cloth merchants, salt-traders, wood-dealers, and bankers. They are usually known as "Amda-wálah," or traders who import goods wholesale, and sell them to petty dealers by retail. Mahájan, Goldár, and Áṛhatdár, or broker, are also common designations. Notwithstanding the improved position of late years, they are still utterly abandoned in the eyes of the Hindus. Even the Bhúínmálí, who works for them, will not touch their food, and a Chaṇḍál loses caste if he lays his hand on the stool on which one of them is sitting. There is a saying among Bengalís, that if a Śúdra be walking down a narrow lane with only Súnṛí houses on each side, and an elephant approaches, he ought to allow the elephant to trample him under foot rather than take refuge in a house of the accursed.

Sáha is the common title of the caste, but on becoming rich the merchant adopts Dás as a surname. A well known Sáha trader of Dacca selected Ráí Chaudharí as his family name, and it has been also adopted by his son.

The Dhobá and Nápit, are members of the Súnṛí caste, the Śúdra washerman and barber declining to work for them. The Bráhman also, peculiar to themselves, boasts that he never accepts alms from any one not a Súnṛí; but it is quite certain that none of the clean castes would present him with charity.

[1] Said to be a corruption of Sádhu, perfect, honest, a merchant. Wilson's "Glossary."

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These Bráhmans, who assume the bombastic titles of Vidyáságar, Vidyálankár, Chakravarttí, and Páṭhak, like the Purohits of other low castes, read the funeral service at the burning Ghát.

Almost every member of the caste is a follower of Chaitanya, and the rich are celebrated for the ostentatious observance of the San-Kírttana chaunts in honour of Kṛishna, after the decease of any relative.

A Súnṛí will not cultivate the soil, although he does so in Central Bengal, nor will he ply as a boatman unless the boat belongs to his caste, and is entirely manned by Súnṛís. He is also prohibited from becoming a fisherman, and from selling fish in the market.

In the Mymensingh district a colony of Sáhas have taken the title of Pánjha, but can give no reason for doing so. They are chiefly Tallukdárs, writers, and shopkeepers, eating and intermarrying with Sáhas in other parts of Bengal.

In various parts of Dacca a Magí Ṣreṇí, quite distinct from the Ráṛhi, or Varendra, and accounted fallen and outcast, is to be met with. It is stated that in old days the Mags made marauding expeditions into this part of Bengal, and defiled the houses by outraging their women, as was also done with the Tántí, Telís, and Kumhárs. The Súnṛí barber and washerman work for them, but the Purohit is always distinct.

The greater number of Sáhas belong to an Aliman gotra, a few to a Kaṣyapa.

Although the Ṣúdra Nápit occasionally shaves the Sáhas, he will not attend at any of their religious ceremonies, when a member of the caste has to be employed.

The chief rites observed by this caste are the worship of Gaṇeṣa on the first of Baisákh, and the first of Aghan (Nov.-Dec.); of Gandheṣvárí on the tenth of Ásín, the Daṣamí, or day before the Durgá Púja; and of Ganga, whenever their boats are starting on a trading voyage. The majority being Vaishnavas, animals are rarely sacrificed to any deity, but when it is done the victim is afterwards released.

Sáhas are very fond of pigeons, and in the courtyard of almost every house a dovecot is fixed, as they believe the air fanned by pigeons' wings wafts them luck. They are also devoted worshippers of Kártikeya, the Hindu god of war, constructing annually in November a life size effigy of the god, and keeping it within the female enclosure for a year. Other Hindu castes throw the image into the river immediately after the Kártik Púja; but the Sáhas allege that their special veneration of the god is often rewarded, the barren rejoicing, and the husband becoming the joyful father of children. It is easy to understand in what way this figure gives rise to scandalous

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stories among Bengalís, and how the Sáha becomes a butt for the wit and sarcasm of his neighbours.

According to the census of 1872 there were 430,582 persons belonging to this caste in Bengal, of whom 63,511 resided in Dacca, and 225,558, or fifty-two per cent. of the whole Súnṛí population, in the nine eastern districts.

SURAHIYÁ, SURAIYÁ.

This class of boatmen[1] properly belongs to Maldah and Tirhut, but a few families have been long settled in Dacca, and being a small colony wives are with difficulty procured.

The Surahiyá are enterprising and hardy sailors, often met with in Eastern Bengal during the cold season in large trading vessels laden with grain, pulse, or fuller's earth, which is sold to Mahájans, and a cargo of rice shipped for the return voyage. In Gházípúr the Surahiyás are cultivators, who readily engage themselves as boatmen. They are very muscular and large boned, offering a striking contrast to the average Bengali "Mánjhís."

Their origin, like that of other boatmen, is traced to the fabulous hero Nikhád. There is a shadowy connection between the Surahiyá and Cháin. The former use the water vessels and huqqas of the latter; but the Cháin, assuming a higher rank, will smoke, but neither eat nor intermarry, with the Suraiya.

"Kalwat Malláh" is given as another name for this caste; "Jal-Chhatrí" as the ordinary title; and Kaṣyapa as the common gotra.

The Pánch Píriya creed is that usually followed, but like other boatmen, Koila Bába is worshipped on the Dashará, and various superstitious rites are observed in fulfilment of vows, and to ensure good fortune.[2]

[1] Buchanan calls them "Suriya Malas" (i, 172), and in Bíhár they are included among the Malláhs.

[2] Walter Hamilton (i, 111) mentions that in consequence of the great famine of 1770, many Hindus, from eating food cooked by unclean hands, were outcasted, and subsequently joined a caste called Saryuriya, "because in 60 years a famine, or some other great calamity, is supposed to occur in the year Saryuriya."

The year 1770, according to Hindu calculations, was known as Ṣárvari, the thirty-fourth of the Vṛihas-pati, or cycle of 60 years, on which the natives looked for a recurrence of calamities.

Can the outcasted Saryuriya have any connection with the Suraiyá boatmen?

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SÚRAJ-BANṢÍ, SÚRYA-VANṢI.

This honourable Rájput title has been assumed, within the last few years, by a hybrid race of Indo-Chinese origin, inhabiting the jungly tract of Bhowál bordering on the alluvial plains of Eastern Bengal. Their history is a most significant one, as it exhibits the compromising spirit and assimilative nature of Bráhmanism, when brought in contact with races of lower civilisation. The Súraj-banṣís were formerly regarded as akin to the Kochh-mandáí, but the Bráhmans, taking advantage of their credulity and ignorance, led them to believe that they were descendants of the Chhatrí who, by throwing away their sacred thread, escaped from the death-dealing axe of Paraṣuráma. Accordingly, in 1871, they proceeded in a body to the house of their Zamíndár, Kálí Náráyaṇa Rái, Rái Bahádur, a Ṣrotriyá Bráhman, and requested him to reinvest them with the sacred cord. An offer of five hundred rupees was made, but declined. Disappointed at this unexpected rebuff they retired to consult, and, after grave deliberation, it was decided to offer two thousand rupees, when the scruples of the crafty Bráhman being laid to rest, the sacred cord was with due solemnity presented, and ever since the Súraj-banṣí have assumed the high rank of Chhatrí, to the great disgust of Hindus generally.

The Kochh-mandáí, who reside in the same jungle, assert that a few years ago the Súraj-banṣí were known as Kochh-mandáí, and that even at present "Banṣí" is their ordinary appellation. The Súraj-banṣí are peculiar to Bhowál, and are not met with beyond the limits of the Dacca district. They are certainly allied to the Kochh-mandáí, but, by marrying with low Bengali tribes, have lost the characteristic Indo-Chinese physique and physiognomy, and inherited those of Bengali lowlanders. Their original language, too, has been forgotten, and the Bengali vernacular is universally spoken. The Súraj-banṣí is generally a darker and taller, but less muscular man, than the Kochh-mandáí. Certain of them still retain the peculiar Indo-Chinese cast of features, with oblique eyes, and scanty growth of hair; but the majority have the common Bengali countenance, with bushy moustaches and voluminous cues, for they already ape the Vaishnava fashion of wearing the hair. Even now they call themselves worshippers of Vishnu, and have engaged the services of a Patit-Bráhman as Purohit. They have invented three gotras, Kaṣyapa, Aliman, and Madhu Kuliyá, and marriages into the same gotra are strictly forbidden. Furthermore, having assumed the sacred badge of the Chhatrís, they imitate them in observing the Ṣráddha on the nineteenth day after death.

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By Hindus they are not admitted to belong to a clean caste, but the Śúdra servants are beginning to work for them, and in a few years they will doubtless have secured an established position, as the Kachárís and Manípúrís have done under exactly similar circumstances.[1] Partiality for pork, one of the besetting sins of the Indo-Chinese and Kolarian tribes, is most difficult to eradicate, in most instances surviving long after the tribe has adopted the Hindu ritual, and Hindu habits. The Kochh-mandáí affirm that the Súraj-banṣí secretly indulge in the forbidden luxury, although to curious strangers the fact is stoutly denied. Widow marriages have also been abandoned and polygamy sanctioned.

The Súraj-banṣís claim to be aborigines of Kámrúp, and believe they substantiate the claim by citing their bi-annual (in Phálgun and Baisákh) worship, held beneath a "Ṣál" tree in honour of Kámaka Deví, the tutelary goddess of that country.

The Sun (Súraj), their reputed ancestor, is worshipped with especial honour, but Durgá, Manasa Deví, and Búṛa-Búṛí, are also invoked in seasons of affliction and sickness.

SUTÁR, SÚTRADHÁRA.

This is a very low caste of carpenters met with in all parts of Bengal, and, according to the census of 1872, numbering 177,755 persons, who chiefly inhabit Mymensingh (21,479), Burdwán (15,973), Dacca (15,907), Silhet (13,097), and Tipperah (11,804). It is essentially a caste of the Delta, and it seems most probable that the boat-building trade attracted them to the chief seats of that industry. There can be little doubt that Sutárs belong to an aboriginal, and therefore despised, race, yet they have the effrontery to assert that they are descended from Karṇa, the son of Kuntí, and the Sun-god, as related in the Mahá Bhárata. Karṇa was adopted by Adhi-ratha, a charioteer of Anga (Bihár), a Sutár by profession, who consequently became a Sutár himself. It was Ballál Sen, however, who humbled them. The story goes that a complaint being lodged against the Bráhmans for not performing religious ceremonies for the caste, until all other castes had been served, the monarch, to prevent further controversy, enrolled them among the Nícha, giving them a Bráhman of their own.

[1] The Kachárís were converted to Hinduism, and made Chhatrís of the Súraj-banṣi tribe, about A.D. 1790 ("J. A. S. of Bengal," vol. ix, 831). The Manípúrís, again, were converted about the beginning of the eighteenth century by a Mahant of Silhet (Wheeler's "Mahá Bhárata," p. 421).

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The Sutár caste has three subdivisions in Dacca:—

1. Sutár, who makes boats, household furniture, beams, wheels, and ploughs.
2. Chúṛá-Kuṭí, who parch and husk rice, make wooden necklaces, and burn shells for lime.
3. Káthuria, who make ploughs, tubs, platters, and wooden agricultural implements.

The Sutárs claim, and are admitted to have, precedence of the other two divisions. Their name of "thread-holder" is derived from the Sanskrit "Sútra," the thread with which the course of the saw is marked. Sutárs are all included in one gotra, the Aliman, and invariably belong to the Vaishnava creed. In the city of Dacca about one hundred and fifty houses are occupied by them. The caste has a Panchâít, but no union (Dal), and their headman, styled Parámánik, settles disputes between members. It is derogatory for a Sutár to fell a tree, which is done by a class of Chaṇḍáls, called "Karántí," from the Sanskrit Kara-pattra, a saw. Turning (Kundí-Kárí), however, is the legitimate occupation of a carpenter, and he is permitted to make moulds used by confectioners for preparing fancy sweetmeats, and by plasterers for ornamenting cornices and roofs. Sutárs never cultivate the soil, but frequently carry on business as Mahájans, or wholesale traders. Muhammadan carpenters, unknown in Dacca, are common in Chittagong, where they are employed as shipwrights.

It is estimated that there are four hundred houses occupied by the Chúṛá-Kuṭí division in the Dacca district, and fifty in Náráyanganj alone. The members, however, are gradually relinquishing their ancestral trade, and of late years have taken Muhammadan servants to husk rice, while they themselves act as grocers, selling pulse, grain, and oils, or as writers, servants, and shopkeepers. The only wooden article now made by them is the sandal-wood necklace worn by all Hindus. The Purohit is distinct from the family priest of the other sub-divisions. The headman is styled Pradhán, and the only gotra is Aliman. The Chúrá-Kuṭi are all Vaishnavas in creed, the Guru being the Farídábád Gosáin. Their principal festivities are the Gandheṣvarí on the tenth Asín (Sept.); and New Year's day, on the first of Baisákh.

The Káthuria subdivision, scattered throughout the Dacca district, is engaged in cultivating the soil, building boats, and manufacturing lime with the fresh water shells dredged from the extensive "Jhíls," or marshes, in the interior of Bikrampúr, being for this reason often confounded with the Chunarí caste, a perfectly distinct community.

The Bráhman of this subdivision is an Áchárjí, who performs

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the same religious ceremonies as the priests of the other two. The headman is known as Sardár.

The members of these three subdivisions, although intimately related, neither intermarry nor associate together.

TÁNTÍ, TÁNTUVÁYA.

This is one of the most interesting castes in Bengal. The produce of their looms has been celebrated from the earliest historical times, and the weavers have suffered more from the vicissitudes of the last century than any other class. According to their own traditions, they were brought from Maldah early in the seventeenth century, and settled in the new metropolis of the province, receiving great encouragement from the Mughal Viceroys, and the ladies of the Delhi court, who obtained their beautiful muslins from Dacca.

Although "Dacca Muslins" have acquired a world-wide celebrity, the number of weavers at the present day in Eastern Bengal is small. In 1872 there were 358,689 Tántís in Bengal, of whom only 31,457, or 8 per cent., resided in the nine eastern districts, while nearly one-third belonged to the Midnapore district. In the Dacca district 8,906 persons were returned.

The Tántís of the city of Dacca, who form the richest and most important body, have separated into two Śreṇí, or associations, called Baṛá-bhágiya, or Jhámpániya, from the "Jhámpán," or sedan chair in which the bridegroom sits, and Chhoṭá-bhágiya, of Káyath origin, who becoming weavers were expelled from their caste. The former number at least ten to one of the latter.

The gotras of the Baṛá-bhágiya are—

Bharadvája,	Aliman,
Paráśara,	Śáṇḍilaya,
Gautama,	Vyása,
Madhu Kuliyá,	Kaśyapa,
Kulyá Ṛishi,	Savarṇa,
Ágastya Ṛishi,	Magí.

Baisákh is the name assumed by all, although the designation was originally taken by rich persons, who had given up weaving and become cloth merchants. A few titles inherited from their forefathers, employed as weavers in the Aurang, or Company's factory, are still preserved: "Jáchandár," appraiser; "Muhkím," supervisor; "Dalál," broker; and "Sirdár," are

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the most common. Family nicknames are perhaps oftener met with than in any other caste, and households, called Mesha (sheep) and Chhagrí (goat), are well known to the citizens, having, it is supposed, been acquired because their ancestors had accidentally killed these animals.

With few exceptions Tántís are Vaishnavas, being probably the most obsequious disciples of the Khardah Gosáins. They have no Panchháit, and no headman, but the rich guide and instruct their poorer brethren, while the trade interests of the caste are secured by the supervision of powerful Dals, or guilds, presided over by a Dalpatí, or director.

Although he holds a degraded position in Bihár, the Tántí has had sufficient influence in Bengal to raise himself to the grade of clean Śúdra, having the same Purohit as the Nava-Śákha. The purity of a Tántí depends on the quality of the starch used in weaving. The Śúdra weaver prepares starch from parched rice boiled in water, or "Kái," which is not according to Hindu ideas, "Ento," or, as Muhammadans call it, "Jhúṭhá," leavings. Impure weavers, as the Jogís, make starch (Már) by merely boiling rice, a process that is considered utterly abhorrent.

A peculiar subdivision of outcaste Tántís belonging to a Magí Śreṇí reside in Mag Bazár, a suburb of Dacca, who, though excommunicated for the same reasons as the Magí Kumárs, conform to all the customs of the Śúdra Tántí.

The Dacca Tántís have always been celebrated for the magnificent procession which parades the streets of the city on the Janmáshṭamí, or birthday of their god Kṛishna, in Bhádra (Aug.–Sept.). As long as a Nawáb lived at Dacca, his troopers and band led the pageant, and at the present day, though divested of many of its attractions, it is still the most popular exhibition in Eastern Bengal. For many generations the Dacca weavers have resided in two quarters of the city, Tántí Bazár and Nawábpúr, and on the day following the birthday of Kṛishna a procession issues from each of these quarters, and perambulates the streets. In 1853 the processions met, and a faction fight ensued. In 1855 the Government ordered that for the future they should never be permitted to come out on the same day, and each quarter, therefore, takes precedence on alternate years, the peace of the city having been so far assured.

Kṛishna is worshipped by the Tántí Bazár section under the form of Muralí Mohan; by the Nawábpúr, as the Sáligrám, or Lukhí Náráyana.

At the present day the processions are preceded by a string of elephants, and a "Panja," or model of a hand, presented by a former Nawáb, is borne aloft as at the Muharram pageant.

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The peculiar part of the cavalcade, however, are the "Misls," or raised platforms, carried on men's shoulders. On these are placed images of Hindu gods, figures, and often caricatures of local celebrities. On others are Nách girls and buffoons reciting comic songs, and bandying chaff with the crowd. In fact, the anniversary and the show have come to be regarded as the occasion of a holiday, when thousands of villagers throng the city bent on pleasure and amusement, which are more considered than the deity in whose honour it is held.

There is, however, another class of Tántís settled in Eastern Bengal, quite distinct from the city weavers, claiming to be the descendants of the original Tántís of Bengal, who supplied the people with cotton fabrics for ages before the reign of Jahángír. Although assuming a superiority over the Baisákhs, which is not conceded, there can be little doubt that these Banga Tántís were earlier settlers in Bengal than their rivals.

The Banga Tántís observe with especial pomp the Kámadeva Púját, or worship of the Indian Cupid, which, though generally neglected in Bengal, and entirely omitted by the Jhámpániya Tántís, is still kept up in Bhowál, Kámrúp, and the districts bordering on that country. It is undoubtedly a worship of earlier origin than that of Krishna. On the Madana Chaturdasí, or fourteenth day of the waxing moon of Chait (March–April), the festival is held, but it does not last for seven days as formerly. The Purohit officiates, no victims being sacrificed.

The Banga Tántís, moreover, celebrate the Janmáshṭamí, but in a different way from the Baisákhs. Two boys, gorgeously dressed, representing Krishna and his foster-father, Nanda Gop, are carried about in great state, and with much discordant noise.

The Visvakarma worship is observed on the usual day, and, as with the Baisákhs, the loom, shuttle, and other implements of weaving are adored.

The Banga Tántís are chiefly settled at Dhámráí, an old town about twenty miles north of Dacca, where they occupy about two hundred and fifty houses. Their bridal dresses are white, and not of red or other coloured silk, as with the Dacca weavers. They manufacture the native "Sári," and "Chadar," as well as Ḍoriyá and Nau-battí muslins, which are sent to Dacca to be embroidered. At Dhámráí the famous female spinners (Kátaní), who wind the fine native thread, are still found, but in no other part of Eastern Bengal. In illustration of the delicate touch of these spinners, the story goes, that one of them wound eighty-eight yards of thread on a reel which only weighed one "Ratí," or two grains. Nowadays a Ratí of the finest thread equals seventy yards, which proves that either a coarser cotton is grown, or the women have lost their delicate sensibility of touch.

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The Chhoṭá-bhágiya, or Káyath Tántís, formerly goldsmiths, took to weaving as a more profitable trade, and now eat with, and visit the Baisákhs, although they do not reciprocate the politeness. The richer families having always adopted the prerogatives of the Káyaths, have been recognised, and if wealthy, receive wives from them. At present only from twenty to twenty-five houses in Dacca are occupied by them, and several households work as goldsmiths, bankers, and engravers (Naqqásh).

Five different sorts of cloth were manufactured by the Dacca Tántís in their palmy days, but the art of making the finer qualities has been lost. The five varieties were—

1. Malmal. Muslins of the first quality included the "Ábrawán,"[1] "Tanzíb," and "Malmal" made of Desí cotton or Kapás; of the second quality were the "Shabnam," "Khaçah," "Jhúna," "Sarkár 'Alí," "Ganga Jal," and "Terindam;"[2] of the third were the coarser muslins, collectively called "Báftah," comprising "Hammám," "Dimtí" (? Dimyáṭí), "San," "Jangal Khaçah," and "Galá-band."
2. Ḍoriyá, striped and ribbed muslins, such as "Ráj-koṭ," "Dakhan," Pádsháhí-dár," "Kunti-dár," "Kághazí," and "Kelá-páṭ."
3. Chár-Khánah, checkered muslins, such as "Nandan-sháhí," "Anár-dána," "Kabútar-khopí," "Sá-Kuttá," "Bachhá-dár," and "Kuntí-dár."
4. Jámdání, by the early European traders called "Nainsukh,"[3] or embroidered muslins. The different sorts are distinguished by the coloured flowers, sprigs (Búṭí), or network pattern on them. The commonest are "Sháhbarga-búṭí," "Chawal," "Mel," "Tirchhá," and "Dublí-jál."
5. Kashída, or Chikan, muslins embroidered with Múgá, or Tasar silk, generally dyed red, blue, or yellow. The commoner ones are "Kaṭáw-Rúmi," "Naubatti" or "Naubatí," "Yahúdí," "'Azízullah," and "Samundar Lahar."

The common Dhotí, Chadar, and Oṛhní, or wrapper with a coloured or embroidered end, were always regarded as distinct

[1] Ábrawán, literally running water, was solely made for the Delhi Zanánah, and the following stories regarding its gossamer-like texture are still told by the natives. A daughter of Aurangzíb, one day on entering the room, was rebuked for wearing immodest drapery, but justified her conduct on the plea that she was wearing seven suits (Jámá). Again, in the reign of 'Alí Vardí Khán (1742-56), a Dacca Tántí was flogged, and banished from the city for not preventing his cow from eating up a web of Ábrawán, which had been laid out to bleach on the grass.

[2] Probably from Arabic Ṭarah, mode, and Persian Andám, figure.

[3] Nayana-Sukha, pleasing to the eye.

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from the foregoing being woven at their homes by weavers of various castes.

On glancing over the preceding list one is struck by the predominance of Arabic, Persian, and Hindi words, and the rarity of Sanskrit and Bengali.

That weaving, like other native arts, was known in Hindustán prior to the foundation of the Bengal kingdom is beyond a doubt, and that the earlier settlers brought it with them into the Delta is likely, but it would seem that either the names given by the dominant Muhammadans displaced the native ones, or that the liberal Mussulmán rulers stimulated, it may be developed, the manufacture of the finer sorts of muslins. That the inhabitants of Bengal at an early period made cotton cloth of wondrous fineness is undoubted, for the two Muhammadan travellers of the ninth century mention that in an Indian country called Rahmi[1] were woven cotton garments "so fine that they may be drawn through a ring of middling size." Unfortunately we possess no further evidence until A.D. 1506, three hundred years after the Muhammadan conquest, when the Roman Vartomannus[2] visited the fabled city of Bengalla, where the finest cotton and silk in all the world was produced, and whence yearly sailed fifty ships laden with cotton and silk goods. The earliest traveller, however, who gives us the names of the fine cotton fabrics of Bengal, is the Arab author of the "Muhít," written in 1554.[3] He mentions among the goods exported from Chittagong by his countrymen a fine cloth (Chautár), muslin sashes, called Malmal, the finest being known as Malmalí Sháhí, terms which are Hindi and Persian. Furthermore, when Cæsar Frederick visited Chittagong (1563–81), "bombast cloth of every sort" was exported thence. After his day the authorities are numerous, and names identical with those in use in the present day are cited.

The conjecture that the Muhammadans merely developed an already flourishing trade is strengthened by the fact that the terms in use by the Dacca weavers for the warp, woof, shuttle, and loom generally are Sanskrit, while later improvements, such as the Sháná, or reed, the Charkhá, or spinning wheel, and the Daftí, or reed frame, are Persian.

The decline of the cotton trade of Eastern Bengal has been sketched by a former resident of Dacca, Mr. James Taylor,[4]

[1] Rahmi, however, may not be Bengal, but as it was the country of elephants, of a shell currency, and of the "Karkandan," or unicorn (rhinoceros), the assumption is not altogether groundless. Elliot's "History of India," vol. i, 361.

[2] "Ludovici Vartomanni Navigatio," p. 259.

[3] Journal "A. S. of Bengal," vol. v, 467.

[4] "A Descriptive and Historical Account of the Cotton Manufacture of Dacca, in Bengal," by a former resident of Dacca. London, 1851.

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while much curious information is contained in Mr. Bolt's "Considerations," and in the works of Edmund Burke. Under the Mughal government, and even as late as the Nawábship of 'Alí Vardí Khán (1742–56), the weavers manufactured in perfect liberty, and the enterprising among them advanced money to promote the trade, but with Siráj-ud-daulah (1756–7) the decadence began, and, during his eventful reign, seven hundred families of weavers left their homes at Jangalbárí, in Mymensingh, owing to oppression, and emigrated to other districts. Before 1765, when the English obtained the Díwání of Bengal, bullion was regularly imported from Europe to meet the requirements of the traders, but after that day advances were made from the provincial treasuries to buy the annual stock, or "investment." This gave a new and unprecedented stimulus to weaving, and in 1787, the most prosperous year on record, the estimated prime cost of the cloths entered at the custom house of Dacca amounted to fifty lakhs of rupees, or 625,000*l*. This prosperity, however, was very deceptive, being founded on injustice and intolerable oppression. The first decline may be traced to the rapacity of the "Banyans" and Gomastas, who arbitrarily decided the quantity of goods each weaver was to deliver, the prices he was to receive, while his name being entered on a register, he was not permitted to work for anyone but his own Gomasta. When the annual supply was ready the Gomasta held a bazár at which the Jáchandár, or appraiser, fixed the price of the goods, but the rascality, Mr. Bolts says,[1] was beyond imagination, and the prices were often fifteen per cent. often forty, below the market rate.

The deplorable condition of the weavers in 1773 is depicted in the following extract from a letter written by Mr. Rouse, the chief of Dacca.[2] "The weavers are in general a timid, helpless people; many of them poor to the utmost degree of wretchedness, incapable of keeping accounts, industrious as it were by instinct, unable to defend themselves if oppressed, and satisfied if with continual labour they derive from the fair dealing and humanity of their employer a moderate subsistence for their families."

The following incident that occurred in 1767 gives a vivid idea of the state of matters in Dacca at that period. Mr. Thomas Kelsall, chief of Dacca, being informed that a certain weaver, Kṛishna Pál Kumár, was suspected of selling muslins to the French factory, ordered him to be seized, but he found shelter with the French. His relatives, however, were imprisoned and beaten, and their houses pillaged. Upon this the weaver gave

[1] "Considerations," part i, 193.
[2] Burke's Works (Bohn's Edition), iv, 73.

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himself up to the Díwán, Bhikam Lál Ṭhákur, who ordered him to be flogged, after which he was confined in the factory for eleven days, during which time the Peons fleeced him of forty-nine rupees and two pieces of cloth. By Mr. Kelsall's order his head was shaved, his face blackened "with lime and ink," and being mounted on an ox,[1] he was paraded through Nawábpúr, where the brokers and Paikárs lived. After three more days the accused was forwarded to the Nawáb for trial, who, finding no fault, discharged him.

This hateful system was at last swept away, and the weavers for a short time enjoyed comparative freedom of trade, and unusual prosperity; but in 1769 Arkwright obtained his patent, in 1779 Crompton invented the mule, and the cotton manufactures of Lancashire have gradually driven the finer and less durable fabrics of the Bengali weavers out of the market, and all but annihilated the trade.

(*a*) Hindustání Tántís.

The Hindustání, or Mungírya, weavers are very common in Dacca, where they comprehend a large proportion of the "Moṭhiás," or coolies, street porters, pankha pullers, gardeners, aud packers of jute; while at home they are weavers and cultivators.

Two divisions are met with, the Kanaujiya and Tirhutiya; the former the more numerous, being of higher rank than the latter, who are despised and shut out from all social intercourse.

In Bihár the Tántí is unclean; in Dacca he is included among the Nava Ṣákha.

The Kanaujiya have one gotra, the Kaṣyapa. They worship "Máhá-mayá," or Durgá, in fulfilment of vows, keeping the ninth and tenth days of the Durgá Púja as holydays, consecrated to her. On a certain date in Kártik, they proceed to an open plain, and sacrifice a male goat to Kálí, a "Khaçí" to Madhu Kunwár, who, they say, was a Tántí.

On the sixth day after a birth the Chhaṭhi is held, and on the twelfth the mother goes to the well, smears red lead on the edge in the name of Kamalá (Lakshmí), then draws water and carries it within doors, when she is pronounced clean.

The Tirhutiya, degraded by carrying palanquins, and by acting as musicians at their homes, collect in Dacca during the jute season, and are remarkable for their squalor and stupidity. They also work as syces, gardeners, boatmen and musicians.

[1] A donkey was the animal usually employed, but it does not live in the damp climate of Dacca. This punishment is called by the Hindus "Gadhe pár charhána;" by the Muhammadans "Tashhír."

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Flesh and fish are eaten by them, and each time spirits are drunk a few drops are offered to Mahádeva. All belong to one gotra, the Paráśara. A Hindustání Bráhman officiates at religious ceremonies, and the Guru is usually a Sannyasí. The title of Bráhman is conferred on the sister's son (Bhánjá), and great deference is paid him, although through ignorance unable to preside at the family assembly.

Kálí, Durgá, and Mahádeva are worshipped, but the majority follow the teaching of one Buddh Rám, a Mochí of Tírhut, who founded a sect, differing in some slight respects from that of Nának Sháh. They observe few caste usages, but many superstitious rites, such as burning "Ghi" in a lamp and adding rosin, in execution of vows.

The Levirate marriage is still lawful, and the purificatory ceremonies performed on the twelfth day are the same as those of the Kanaujiyá. The wedding expenses are borne by the bridegroom, and the bride is carried with much parade in a palanquin, enclosed with curtains (Mihaffa).

In Tirhut Tántis weave, grow opium, and cultivate the soil.

With both classes of Tántís, the headman, Sirdar, or Mahto, is a very important personage, who accepts contracts, acts as purveyor, and keeps all accounts.

TAMBOLÍ, TÁMBÚLI.

This caste is not numerous in Bengal, but, wherever found, is regarded as one of the clean Śúdra castes, still wearing the Bráhmanical cord in some parts of Hindustán, although it has been disused for ages in others. In Bengal the term Tambolí is applied to any person engaged in retailing Pân,[1] and is not confined, as it ought to be, to the members of a particular caste. The census rolls, by enumerating 59,726 persons as belonging to the caste, have endorsed this popular use of the word, while in Dacca, where there are not fifty individuals pertaining to it, the number entered is 200. The few resident in the city state that their ancestors came from the Burdwán district, where they still send for their wives, as the Hindustání Tambolí refuses to give his daughters in marriage to the Bengali.

The Hindustání Tambolí caste, members of which are occasionally met with in Eastern Bengal, has seven, the legitimate

[1] Támbúla, the leaf of Piper Betel.

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number of Ṣreṇí, and preserve the connection with their original home at Benares and Mungír, by obtaining wives from these places. The seven branches are—

Maghaiyá,	Kurram,
Tirhutia,	Karan,
Bhojpúria,	Súryá-dvija.
Kanaujiyá,	

It has only one gotra, the Kaṣyapa. Yellow silk is the proper bridal dress, but should the family be poor, cotton dyed with turmeric is unobjectionable. In Hindustán the Tamboli often acts as a Pansárí, or druggist; when domiciled in Bengal he keeps stores, sometimes wine shops.

The Bengali Tamboli, again, have three gotras, Kaṣyapa, Bharadvája, and Vyása. Their titles, or "Padaví," are—

Sen,	Singh,
Pál,	Chail,
Khur,	Dé,
Datta,	Rakhít.

The most common honorary title is Chaudharí.

The bride and bridegroom still dress in yellow, and ride in a Lálkí, or Ḍolí, a palanquin with an elongated pole, and a canopy overhead.

In Eastern Bengal the Tamboli never cultivates Pân, and, having rivals in the sale of the leaf, is gradually taking to other occupations. In Hindustán selling Pân is the privilege of the caste, but in Dacca the "Khílí-wálás" are Khatrís, Káyasths, Namu-Ṣúdras, and often Muhammadans. A "Khílí" is a packet ready made for chewing, and four of them equal one "Dháná."

The aromatics masticated with Pân differ in Bengal from those used in Upper India. Bengalis add cloves, dill, coriander, Ajwáyan,[1] cinnamon, and long pepper; while the Hindustánís prefer small cardamons (Gujrátí iláchí), mace, and rose water.

Only two kinds of betle-nut are known in Bengal, the Dakhaní or Penang nut, which is rare, and very expensive, and the Deṣí, or common nut, grown in every village of Bengal, and universally chewed.

The lime, too, mixed with the "Kath" (Catechu) is of two qualities. In Dacca Silhet lime slaked, and mixed with Dahí, or curds, is in general use, while in other parts of the province lime prepared from fresh water shells by the Chunarí caste, is alone used.

[1] *Ligusticum Ajowan*, a favourite culinary and medicinal spice. It is the "Yavánika," or "Brahma-darbhá," of Sanskrit writers.

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TOIL-PÁL, TELÍ, TAILÍ, TAILIKA, TAILA-KÁRA.

In Eastern Bengal there are two great subdivisions of this caste, the Toil-pál, or Manuhar Pál, and the Telí, the former being the richer and more numerous. The Toil-pál are frequently distinguished by the epithet "Do-paṭṭí," from having adopted the Śúdra marriage custom of carrying the bride and bridegroom on stools. The Telí, again, are known as "Ek-gáchhí," from their planting a "Champa" tree, on which the bridegroom sits, while the bride is carried round him several times, as with the Gandha-baniks.

Originally, however, there were no divisions, and all oilmen belonged to one caste, but wealth having begot new objects of desire, the richer families, ashamed of their ancestral occupation, have adopted a new name to conceal their parentage. In Nadiyá and Kishnaghar another separation has taken place, the Tilís affecting to be of a higher lineage than the Telís, although they still retain the old family titles. Wealth and prosperity have made them give up the manufacture of oil, and led them to become "Amdawáláh," traders buying goods wholesale and selling them by retail.

In the northern parts of the Dacca district, beyond the limits of the Ballálí country, the oilman caste has other divisions varying in almost every Parganah. In the Ráípúra jurisdiction there are four classes, the "Satrah," or seventeen families; the "Báís," or twenty-two; the "Chaubís," or twenty-four; and the "Chár," or four, each taking rank in the order named, and large dowries being given by the last three for wives belonging to the first class.

In Dacca the Toil-páls and Telís intermarry, and are regarded as clean Śúdras. The gotras common to both are Aliman, Śáṇḍilyá, and Kaśyapa. The Padavís, or family surnames, are—

Pál,	Dé,
Nandí,	Kúndú.

Chaudharí and Shiqdár, honorary titles bestowed by the native government, are common among them, while the headman is styled Mundle. In former days their unions (Dals) were notorious for the faction fights which broke out whenever differences of opinion were expressed. No "Dal" exists at the present day, but the Mundle summons a Panchá́it when required.

The degraded Kolú caste found in other parts of Bengal are not met with in Dacca. There are, however, two outcast classes of oilmen in Eastern Bengal, who have been excommunicated because they manufacture oil in a novel manner; the first, or Gáchhua Telí, express the oil by crushing the seed between

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wooden rollers; the second, or Bhúnja Telí, parch the seed, and then extract the oil.

The pure Telís only extract Til oil from the sesamum seed, and caste is forfeited if any other oil be manufactured. The "Ghání," or oil mill driven by bullocks, is never used, the oil being prepared in the following manner. The seeds are boiled, and given to the Muhammadan Kútí to husk. After being sifted, the Telí puts them into large vats (Jálá), boiling water being poured in, and the seeds allowed to soak for twelve hours. In the morning the liquid is beaten with bamboo paddles (Ghoṭna) and left to settle, when the oil floating on the surface is skimmed off and stored, no attempts to purify it being made. The refuse (Khalí) is given to cattle.

The Telí caste is found in all parts of the country, the Til oil being eaten by Hindus at every meal, but oilmen are chiefly massed on high lands, where the Til plant (*Sesamum orientale*) grows best. In 1872 the oilman caste, including the Telí, Tilí, and Kolú throughout Bengal, numbered 572,659 persons, while in Dacca alone it comprised 5 Telí, 556 Kolú, and 13,150 Tilís, or a total of 13,711 individuals. It has been already pointed out that this repudiation of the primary name is not defended by the caste itself, nor attributed to any better motive than the pretension of the richer families. The Kolú, again, has probably been confounded with the Muhammadan "Kolú," engaged in expressing oil.

The Telí caste is a Vaishnava one. Their principal festivals are those in honour of Lakshmí, Sarasvatí and Gandheṣvarí, the last being celebrated on the Dashará in Aṣwín (Sept.–Oct.), and not on the full moon of Baisákh (April–May) as with the Gandha-baniks. Many oilmen have given up the oil trade and become bankers, cloth-dealers, and shopkeepers, but, like other clean Ṣúdrás, will not sell spirits, or cultivate the soil.

Members of this caste have acquired historical renown. Kṛishna Kánta Nandí, better known as Kánta Baboo, the "Banyan" of Warren Hastings, immortalised by the eloquent invectives of Edmund Burke, was a Telí by caste, and did much to raise its position among the Hindus. On visiting Jagannáth, he offered to provide an "Atka," or assignment of land for the maintenance of the poor, but the "Paṇḍá," or presiding priest, refused to accept it from the hands of such an unworthy person. Kánta Baboo successfully appealed to the Paṇḍits of Nadiyá and Hughlí, who decided that the Telí, by using the balance (Tulá) in his trade, must necessarily belong to the Bania, a clean Ṣúdra caste. Kánta Babu died in 1780, and it is said that he first introduced the "Nath," or nose-ring, among the females of his caste, it having previously been only worn by Bráhmans,

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and the higher Ṣúdras. The present representative of his family, Mahárání Sarnamáyí of Kásimbázár, is renowned for her charity and munificence in support of works devised for the advancement of her countrymen and countrywomen.

Many of the wealthiest gentlemen of Bengal are members of the Telí caste, and the Kúndú family of Baghyakúl, and the Pál Chaudharís of Lohu-jang, in Dacca, are second to none of the merchants of Bengal.

TIN-WÁLAH.

This is the name of a flourishing trade followed, without los of caste, by Ghulám Káyaths and Sonár-baniks, who make boxes, water pipes, lanterns, and standing lamps of zinc, tin sheeting, or the tin lining of old packing cases, and paint them with various gaudy colours.

TÍYARS.[1]

In various parts of India races called by this name are found, but it is highly improbable that they spring from the same parent stock. Dr. Caldwell[2] states that Teers (properly Tívárs, or islanders) of Southern India "are certainly immigrants from Ceylon." In Maisúr[3] the Tíyars, or Shánárs, included among the Panchaman, or outcast tribes, worship peculiar gods symbolised by stones, drink spirits, and eat the flesh of swine, fowls, and goats. Wilson defines Tíyar as a caste in Malabar, whose occupations are agriculture and "Tárí" drawing. Sir H. Elliot[4] identifies the Tíyar of Hindustan with the Dhímar, an offshoot of the Káhar caste. Mandelslo,[5] again, in 1638, found in Gujarát a tribe called "Theer," or "Halál-Khors," employed as sweepers and executioners, "qui ne sont Payens, ni Mahometans." In Oudh the "Teehurs have no fixed or defined religion, live in great poverty, eating anything, are expert thieves, but industrious peasants, and are disowned by both Hindus and Muhammadans."[6]

[1] In Purchas they are called "Tiberi," and in other books of travel "Teermen."

[2] "Grammar of the Dravidian Languages," Introd. p. 110.

[3] Buchanan's "Mysore," ii, 415.

[4] "Supplemental Glossary," i, 80.

[5] "Voyage des Indes," Liv. i, 219.

[6] "The People of India," ii, 85.

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In Bengal, on the other hand, the fisher Tíyar belongs to a semi-Hinduized aboriginal, or perhaps Dravidian race, deriving its name from the Sanskrit Tívara,[1] a hunter, or perhaps fisherman. In most districts the tribe has assumed the honourable title of Ráj-baṇsí, as the Kochh have also done, probably, as Buchanan thinks, because in prehistoric times they were settled in the Gangetic provinces, and ruled over by a Rájah of their own.

As a race the Tíyars are short and muscular, with prominent cheek bones, dark brown, almost black, complexions, thick and generally projecting lips, and long coarse hair worn in a cue, which has often a reddish tinge towards the tip, a peculiarity common to them and other low castes, which, although in the first instance produced by exposure, is now, if not hereditary at least characteristic. In Eastern Bengal, where no subdivisions exist, the Tíyars call themselves Ráj-baṇsi, or sometimes, as in Mymensingh, Tilak Dás, while those living on the Ganges lay claim to the title of Súraj-baṇsí. According to Buchanan the Tíyars of Bhágalpúr are divided into "Báman-jagya," who are cultivators and clean Ṣúdras, and "Govaríya," who fish, eat pork, drink spirits, and are outcasts. Wherever they are regarded as pure, a Dasṇámi ascetic acts as Guru, and a Maithila Bráhman as Purohit; when impure, a Gosáin of Bengal is Guru, and a Patit, or degraded Bráhman, is Purohit.

In Bihár and Bengal generally, Tíyars are reckoned impure, and along the northern bank of the Ganges Tíyars employed in manufacturing mats of the "Nal" reed, and known as Nal Tíyars, are considered so utterly vile that the fisher Tíyars repudiate any fellowship with them.

The Tíyar caste is distributed irregularly through Bengal. In Bihár they number 49,717 souls, while in Bengal proper 331,661 individuals are returned, of whom 141,213, or 42 per cent., belong to Rangpúr; 49,709 to the 24 Pergunnahs; 23,051 to Hughli; 16,304 to Midnapúr; 17,364 to Dinájpúr; 14,451 to Mymensingh; and only 7,988 to Dacca. In Orissa, again, there are only 3,743 Tíyars.

In Dacca the Tíyars occupy an uncertain position, in one part of the district being pure and Pancha-varta, having the five Ṣúdra servants working for them, while in another, being unclean, these servants are members of their own caste. Tíyars in Eastern Bengal are usually fishermen, but where the fishery has become unproductive, or the river has silted up, they are found cultivating the soil, keeping shops, and acting as boatmen. They manufacture their own nets, but their long narrow boats, called "Jalká," are made by Chaṇḍáls.

[1] From the root "Tíra," a shore, and connected with "Dhívara" a fisherman.

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As is done by all Bengali fishermen, the Jal Pálani, on the "Tilwá" Sankrántí in Mágh (Jan.–Feb.), when the sun enters Capricorn, is observed by the Tíyars. The close time lasts from two to fifteen days, but the demand for fish being steady they catch on the eve of the festival an extra supply, and keep them alive for purposes of sale, there being no offence in selling, although there is in catching, fish at that period, when prices being high, profits are unusually good.

Among Tíyars three social grades are recognised, the highest being the "Pradhán," or chief families, next the "Parámániks," while the rest go to form the "Gaṇa," or lower orders. The last can only intermarry with the higher by paying a large sum of money, the father receiving in all cases money for his daughter, so that female children are more valued than among the true Hindus. Widows never marry, but either earn a livelihood by selling fish, by manufacturing string, or, if desirous of change of life and scene, by becoming Boistubis (Vaishnavís).

Tíyars are almost to a man Vaishnava in creed, their religious ceremonies being always held beneath trees. The Seorhá (*Trophis aspera*), a very common scrubby plant, is held in especial veneration by them, and its shade is usually selected as the scene of their worship; but should this tree be not at hand, the Ním, Bel, or Gujálí (*Shorea robusta*), forms an efficient substitute. Hindustání Tíyars sacrifice a goat to Kálí on the Diwálí, and the animal, not being decapitated in the orthodox Hindu way, is stabbed with a sharp pointed piece of wood, a practice universal among the aboriginal races of India, after which, as with the Dosáds, the flesh is eaten by the worshippers. Bengali Tíyars, on the other hand, sacrifice a swine to Buṛa-Buṛi on the Paus (Dec.–Jan.) Sankrántí, slaughtering it in the same way as their Hindustání brethren. At the Ganga festival in Jeth (May) they offer a white kid, pigeons, and milk, and adore with great solemnity Mánasa Deví, in the month of Ṣrávan (July–August).

As was natural, the Tíyars have peopled the waters and streams with beneficent and wicked spirits, whose friendship is to be secured, and enmity averted, by various religious rites. Along the banks of the river Lakhya they worship Pír Badr, Khwájah Khizr, and, in fulfilment of vows, offer through any Mussulmán, a goat to Madár, whom they regard as a water god, but who may be identified with Sháh Madár Badí'uddín. In stormy weather, and in bad fishing seasons, they invoke Khala-Kumárí, a Naiad, to whom the first fruits are presented in the same way as Hindus do to Lakshmí.

In Purneah Tíyars worship a peculiar deity, called Prem Rájah, or Pamiráj, who they say belonged to their tribe, and was celebrated brigand residing at Bahurágar in Tirhut. Having

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been on many occasions favoured by the deity, he was translated (Aprakáśa), and disappeared along with his boat. In 1864, one Baijua Tíyar gave out that Pamiráj had appeared to him in a vision, and ordained that the Tíyars should cease to be fishermen, and devote themselves instead to certain religious rites which would procure general prosperity. Great excitement ensued, and in February, 1865, about four thousand Tíyars from Ghazípúr, Benares, and the adjoining districts, assembled at Gogra in Purneah, and after offering holy water to a private idol belonging to Baijua, which he said came to him out of a bamboo post, 3,000 goats were sacrificed. Shortly afterwards another meeting of the tribe was held in the Benares district, at which a murder was committed. This movement was a repetition of a precisely similar one among the Dosáds of Bihár, in 1863, and, like it, was short-lived and unsuccessful.[1]

VAÍṢYA.

It has been the opinion of most writers on the castes of Eastern India, that the Vaiṣya no longer exists. Ward[2] says that they have become blended with the Ṣúdras; Buchanan[3] identifies them with the Bania caste; Mr. Beames[4] regards the caste as extinct with the exception of a small body of Bais Banias in Oudh, whose claim, however, is disputed by some; and Mr. Beverley[5] in the census report, expresses the opinion that the claims of any trading class to be considered pure Vaiṣyas are "absolutely worthless."

In the Bhowál Parganah of Dacca, and at Jahángírpúr in the Mymensingh portion of Bhowál, a considerable colony of persons calling themselves Vaiṣyas, and recognised as such by the higher castes, has been settled from time immemorial. A few families are also to be met with at Chát Mohur in the Ráj-sháhí district.

The duties devolving on the Vaiṣya caste, according to Menu, were agriculture, trade, and attendance on cattle; but its members were likewise expected to understand the proper seasons for sowing seed, the qualities of different soils, the prices of gems, cloth, iron, coral, and perfumes, and the ordinary weights and measures.

The progenitor of the caste is said to have sprung from the

[1] Annual Report on the Administration of the Bengal Presidency for 1865-6, p. 27.
[2] Vol. i, 65, 91.
[3] "Eastern India," vol. i, 161; ii, 735.
[4] Elliot's "Supplemental Glossary," vol. i, 166.
[5] Census Report for 1872, p. 171.

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thigh of Brahma, hence the synonyms of "Úravya" and "Úruja." The other names of the caste are "Arya," Bhúmiṣprik, Vit, Dvija, Vaṇik, Bhúmijíví, Vyanaharta, Vártika, and Pañik.

The Vaiṣyas of Eastern Bengal can give no account of themselves, nor do they possess any traditions of their original home. They deny that Ballál Sen ruled over, or reorganised them, and boast that no honorary titles inherited from ancestors serving the Muhammadan government survive. For these reasons they regard themselves as exceptionally pure, having lived uncontaminated amid the changes of the country.

The Vaiṣyas are generally short and squat, some having fine aquiline noses and prominent superciliary ridges, while others have broad cheek bones, badly formed chins and lower jaws. Their physignomy suggests cunning combined with intelligence, but many exhibit the inanimate vacant expression so common among Bengali low castes.

The Vaiṣyas have relinquished many of the peculiar duties enjoined by Menu, though still wearing the sacred cord, composed of three strands knotted together, and another disconnected one of three threads, called "Utarí." The ceremony of tonsure, "Chúḍá-Karman," is observed before the thirteenth year, not postponed to the twenty-fourth after conception, as laid down by Menu, and on this occasion the youth is invested with the Bráhmanical cord. Vaiṣyas repeat the whole of the Gáyatrí, but the Bráhmans assert, that at the present day few know more than three-fourths of it, and not having full permission to bestow a blessing on the Ṣúdras they twist the "Poitá" round the right thumb, and holding the right hand on a level with the navel confer the usual benediction. Vaiṣyas are permitted to read one of the four Vedas, and that always followed is the Yajur-veda. Each household celebrates by itself the Sáligrám, Chakra, and Vishnu Púja hs, although Bráhmans dispute their right to do so, without requiring the services of the Guru, or Purohit, who are Ṣrotriyá Bráhmans. In creed the caste is a Vaishnava one, yet a few Ṣákta worshippers are met with. The Vaiṣyas formerly committed the heinous sin, in Hindu eyes, of marrying in their own "gotra;" but of late years, in order to stay the scandal, new "gotras" have been formed. The most common are—

Aliman,	Madhu Kuliyá,
Kaṣyapa,	Kátyáyana.
Ṣáṇḍilya,	

They have no peculiar titles, but Gupta is often added to their names, while individuals employed as assistants to merchants frequently assume the surname of Biṣwas,[1] literally a

[1] In Puraniyá Biṣwas means a storekeeper, while in Dacca Bháṇḍárí is used in the same sense.

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holder of one-fourth share. Menu affirms that the first part of a Vaiṣya name should indicate wealth, the second prosperity; but the Bengali Vaiṣyas have ceased conforming to this rule, and the names ordinarily met with are Rám Kamár, Dev Náráyana, Ṣítala Chandra, or Rám Gopála, to which the surname Vaiṣya is always appended.

A Vaiṣya was of old allowed to marry a Ṣúdra woman as his second wife, but this custom, owing to the hard times of modern life, has died out.

Baidyás and Káyasths residing within the Ballálí country refuse to touch food prepared by the Vaiṣyas, but those living beyond the limits readily do so.

The Vaiṣya is generally a tolerable Bengali scholar, but few learn English, as it entails expense, and delays the young from starting in life. In Mymensingh a few enter government employ, but the majority are Wakíls, Mukhtárs (attorneys), Tahsíldárs, and Amíns, or land surveyors. Formerly the cultivation of the soil was general, but nowadays holding a plough is considered dishonourable, while managing a harrow is admissible.

When a Vaiṣya meets a Bráhman he does not, like other Hindus, make the salutation "Praṇáma," as the Bráhman bestows his benediction without it. Among Vaiṣyas the period of impurity after a death is fifteen days. All the Hindu festivals are observed by them, but the favourite one is that in honour of Lakshmí, the goddess of wealth.

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SECTION IV.

ARMENIANS.

SETTLEMENT IN PERSIA.
SETTLEMENT IN INDIA IN SIXTEENTH AND SEVENTEENTH CENTURIES.
CENSUS OF, IN BENGAL.
CAUSES OF THEIR DEGENERACY.
PRIESTS, RELIGIOUS FESTIVALS, CUSTOMS, MARRIAGES.
PROSPECTS OF THE RACE IN INDIA.

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ARMENIANS.

In 1605 Sháh 'Abbás invaded Armenia, and transferred 12,000 inhabitants of Julfa, on the Araxes, to the neighbourhood of Ispahán, where he allotted them land on the banks of the Zindarúd, which subsequently became the site of a town, since known as New Julfa. While Sháh 'Abbás lived, he treated the settlers with remarkable liberality, advancing money without exacting interest, granting the free exercise of their religion, and permitting them to elect a "Kalán-tar," or headman, of their own. No Muhammadan was allowed to reside within the walls, and, as the murder of an Armenian could only be expiated by the rigorous law of retaliation, the inhabitants were respected, and favoured, by the Persians themselves. During the reign of Sháh Husain (1694–1722), however, many of these privileges were repealed, and the slayer of an Armenian was absolved from all punishment on payment of a load of corn. The prosperity of the settlement was destroyed by Sháh Mahmúd and the Afgháns in 1722, but not until after a gallant though unavailing resistance.[1] Previous to the Afghán invasion the Persian Armenians numbered about 70,000 souls, but in 1742 the oppressive exactions of Nádir Sháh forced many to leave their homes, and seek an asylum in India and other countries. As a consequence, in 1829,[2] only 500 poor Armenian families resided in New Julfa, where formerly 2,500 families throve, and throughout Persia their numbers had dwindled to 12,383 persons. In 1877 two thousand Armenians remained in Julfa, the children being educated by the Church Missionary Society. Education is only encouraged as a means of enabling the young men to emigrate from poverty-stricken Persia to India.[3]

We possess no information regarding the first appearance of the Armenians in India; but we know that in the sixteenth century they were settled at Goa, and that a deputation visited, in 1590, the court of Akbar.[4] At Agra is still shown the tomb-

[1] Hanway's "Historical Account," ii, 160.
[2] "History of Persia," by Sir J. Malcolm, ii, 374.
[3] "Through Persia by Caravan," by Arthur Arnold, 1877.
[4] Elliot's "History," vi, 85.

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stone of one Khwájah Martinas, who died in 1611.[1] It was, however, into Western India that Armenians chiefly congregated. In 1623 Pietro della Valle found the Dutch intermarrying with them; and in 1638 Mandelslo encountered Armenians in Surát and Gujarát. Tavernier,[2] moreover, has preserved the name of one Corgia, brought up by Sháh Jahán, an excellent wit and poet, much in the King's favour, who had conferred on him many fair commands, though he could never by threats or promises win him to turn Muhammadan. Bernier, too, mentions Armenians in Delhi, who were ruining the inland trade of the Dutch by their competition.

If Mr. Glanius is to be relied on, a body of Armenian cavalry, celebrated for its horses and discipline, accompanied the army of Mír Jamlah, in 1662, when he invaded Assam.

Towards the end of the seventeenth century many Armenians resided at Chinsurah, and they possessed "a pretty good garden" opposite Calcutta. During the latter days of Muhammadan rule the principal Armenian settlement in Bengal was at Saidábád, near Murshídábád, whence were annually exported valuable assortments of piece goods and raw silk.

The Armenians have always been distinguished as enterprising traders throughout Asia, and as early as 1690, when the East India Company was entering upon its marvellous career, Mr. Charnock received[3] instructions to employ them to sell the annual shipments in the interior, and buy fine muslins and other valuable goods. The ostensible reason for this preference being that they could transact business with the native traders better than agents of the Company provided with a firmán.[3] In 1694, again, a proposal was made to the Armenians of Ispahán to sell the goods of the Company, or barter them for silk, money, and "Caramania wool;" but this project failed, as the Armenians themselves imported, by Aleppo, the goods of the Turkey Company. During the eighteenth century, the Armenian community in Bengal prospered, and, favoured by many special grants from the Imperial court, secured much of the inland trade of the province. Several individuals raised themselves to positions of eminence during the civil wars preceding the overthrow of the Mughal power. Coja (Khwájah) Gregory, better known as Gurghin Khán, commanded the artillery of Mír Qásim at the battle of Gheriah, in August, 1763; while his brother, Coja Petrus, or Petrus Arrathoon, was still more intimately connected with the early struggles of the Company, being as Gumástha, or agent, of both Sirájuddaulah, and Mír Qásim,

[1] "J. A. S." of Bengal, August, 1874.
[2] "Voyage," Liv. i, c. 7.
[3] "Annals of the E. I. Company," iii, 88, 160.

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mixed up with many of the intrigues of that eventful period. The latter survived till 1782, when he died, leaving great wealth. At this time the Armenians were often charged, but probably without sufficient reason, with being turbulent and crafty, and doing much injury by thwarting the policy of the English Company. In spite of this accusation, however, they were permitted to reside in Calcutta in 1758; but an order forbidding their dwelling in the smaller factories was in force as late as 1765. The Court of Directors, regarding this busy people as the pioneers of commerce, issued an order that whenever a certain number congregated together, an Armenian church should be built for them.

The history of the Armenian colony at Dacca has not been preserved. It is stated, on doubtful authority, that when Job Charnock returned to Calcutta in 1698, he invited the Armenian merchants in Dacca to settle in the new town; but the first authentic record is a time-worn tombstone in the old churchyard of Tezgáon, which marks the grave of one Avitis, an Armenian trader, who died on the 5th August, 1714. At the middle of the eighteenth century Armenians, as well as Europeans, were extensively engaged in the slave trade, and if we judge of the morality of the time by that described by one of their number, the standard was not a high one. In 1747 a rich Armenian died at Dacca without heirs, and to prevent the estate lapsing to the Nawáb, the narrator consented to come forward as a son of the deceased. The perjury is justified on the plea that it prevented "wild beasts from eating the flesh of lambs."[1]

According to the census of 1866 there were 703 Armenians resident in Calcutta, while on the 6th April, 1876, they numbered 707. In 1872, again, the Armenian population of Bengal proper was only 875, and of that number 710 resided in and around Calcutta, and 113 in Dacca. Mr. I. G. N. Pogose, in 1870, estimated the Dacca Armenians at 107, of whom 36 were males, 23 females, and 48 children. The professions and occupations of the males were as follows: one was a priest, five landholders, three merchants, one a barrister, five shopkeepers, seven shopmen, and four Government servants. Until comparatively recent times no Armenian could hold land; but under the Muhammadan rule many were farmers of the revenue and executive officers.

The causes which have checked the growth of the Armenians in Eastern India have been recapitulated by a writer in the Calcutta Review,[2] who points out that the early settlers were

[1] "The Life and Adventures of Joseph Émin, an Armenian." London, 1792.
[2] "The Armenian in India Physically considered," vol. xxx, June, 1858.

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robust, energetic, and frugal men, devoting their whole time and thoughts to trade, while their descendants, lacking many of the peculiar traits of the race, have sadly degenerated. Separation from home influences, and association with alien races, effected a marked change of habits, and, resisting the introduction of European customs, they insensibly adopted many Indian ones. The indolence, moreover, induced by a hot, uncongenial climate, along with a rooted aversion to physical exertion, promoted habits of immorality and intemperance. Early marriages became fashionable, the offspring growing up sickly and tainted by disease. In-breeding still further impaired the race, and only those families who sought for brides in distant cities, or among immigrants from Persia, have inherited the muscular healthy constitutions of the parent stock. As late as a generation ago the Armenians of India were generally illiterate, being totally ignorant of European literature. They spoke and often read Armenian, they conversed fluently in Persian, Urdú, and Bengali; but they were unacquainted with the English language. Of late years, however, although Armenian is still the language of their homes, English is spoken universally, and an English education is considered indispensable. The English costume, too, is always worn, and the national dress is only seen on festive occasions.

The modern Armenian is proverbially hospitable, while his open-handed charity to the poor of all creeds, his benevolence, and sympathy for the destitute and unfortunate of his own faith, and his kindness to his native servants and acquaintances, excite the admiration of his fellow townsmen.

The Catholicos, or Patriarch, of the Armenian church resides at Echmadzin, in Russian Armenia. Not only is he the Primate, but his monastery is the centre where pilgrims join in fraternal union with their brethren of other lands, and from which the Chrism, or holy oil, is brought for the services of the church in the East. The Bishop of Julfa has jurisdiction over all the Armenian churches in India, and by him the priests are inducted, or translated. India has so few attractions for the priesthood, that livings in that country, it is said, can only be got by an offering of twenty Tománs, equivalent to ten guineas. The priests met with in India are always married men, whose wives and families remain at Julfa, as hostages for their return. Five years is the fixed period of their residence, but on application a transfer to another church is often obtained. The greatest objection to this system is, that new arrivals can only converse in Persian and Armenian, while their flock speak Armenian, rarely Persian. Having acquired the vernacular, they are transferred to Singapore, or China, where

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another language has to be learned, under the same discouraging circumstances.

The position of an Armenian priest in India is an unenviable one. Separated from all his dearest ties, he finds himself in a small community stirred by the influences of strange races, and rival faiths, and dependent on the goodwill and liberality of his brethren. Services, beginning before daybreak, and lasting for six or seven hours, at which the congregation only attend towards the end; fasts twice every week, and during Lent continuing for weeks, tell upon the strongest constitutions. But the interest shown in the spiritual welfare of his flock, the sympathy shown to the sick and dying, and their moral, and generally blameless, lives, are the bonds which bind and endear them to their people.

The four great festivals of the Armenian church are the Nativity, Ascension, Annunciation, and that observed in honour of St. George. These festivals, as in the Greek church, are kept according to the old style; for instance, the Nativity, along with the Epiphany, on the 6th January. The Assumption, however, celebrated by the Greek and Latin churches on the 15th August, is commemmorated by the Armenian on the Sunday between the 12th and 18th of that month.

The dogmas, rites, and practices of the Armenian church in India[1] are identical with those of the parent establishment, being uninfluenced by contact with other Christian churches, but several customs are followed which are not mentioned by writers on such matters. Thus, on the Assumption, raisins wrapped in coloured paper are distributed in the church; and until late years a large pile of dry grass was collected near the church door on Ash Wednesday, and at a certain part of the service the congregation, carrying lighted tapers, defiled out of the building, and set fire to it.

At Easter and Christmas, after service, the priest visits each household, presenting the goodman with a cake of unleavened bread, in return for which he receives a fee, and his attendants wine, sweetmeats, and dyed eggs. Although they disbelieve in the purgatory of the Roman Church, Armenians admit that the spirits of the dead remain till the Day of Judgment in Paradise, or a place of probation. During Christmas and Holy Week, therefore, incense and wax tapers are forwarded to the priest who performs a service at the grave of the deceased relatives. Armenians are forbidden, like the Jews and Muham-

[1] For interesting particulars regarding this Christian Sect, see "Histoire, Dogmes, Traditions et Liturgie de l'Eglise Arménienne Orientale." Par E. Dulaurier, Paris, 1855.

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madans, to eat blood or things strangled, and on Christmas and Easter the flesh eaten must have been killed by a Christian, and a godfather.

The public declaration of vows is one of the most solemn ceremonies of the Armenians. The person vowing presents the priest with two wax candles and two rupees for each pledge. Two gilt hands with the forefingers and thumbs united, the other fingers extended and adorned with jewels, being taken from the altar are dipped into holy water, and the lips of all present touched, while the witness kneeling rests his forehead on the floor. The priest, after repeating certain prayers, holds the two hands over the people and blesses them.

Armenians esteem the "Little Gospel" as only second in value to the Bible itself, and are fond of detailing incidents recorded in it. This uncanonical scripture is the "Historia de Nativitate Mariæ et de Infantiâ Salvatoris."[1]

Last century the Armenians observed many Persian, Bengali, and European customs. The dress of the men consisted of a Persian vest, or Jámah, fastened with a belt (Paṭká), and loose trousers. Their head-dress was a black brimless hat, about eight inches high. The costume of the women resembled that of the men, but the vests were longer. They wore the hair hanging down loose behind, adorned with strings of pearls and other gems, and covered with a hat, called Kambhara. Moreover, their teeth were stained with Misí, the hands and feet with Menhdí. It was considered indecorous and improper for the women to speak to, or appear before men in public, and, like the Muhammadan wife, the Armenian had to endure great hardships when most requiring sympathy; the doors and windows of her room were carefully closed against evil spirits for forty days, a fire was kept burning on the threshold, and no one dared to enter the room till mustard seed had been cast on the embers. As a further protection the child was arrayed with strings of amulets and charms.

The amusements of the men were confined to kite-flying, in which pastime much money was lost and won, and to the fighting of rams and game cocks. Native music was, and still is, preferred to European, and dinner parties wound up with "Nách" dancing and singing. At meals tables were not used, but mats and carpets being spread, the guests squatted and ate with their fingers. The Armenian *cuisine* more nearly resembles that of the Muhammadans than the English, and at feasts the variety of dishes is so embarrassing that the etiquette requiring each guest to taste of every dish becomes positively dangerous.

[1] Giles' "Uncanonical Gospels." London, 1852.

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Armenian marriages are ordinarily negotiated by the parents, or guardians. A few days before the wedding the hands and feet of the bride are stained with Menhdí. The bridle trousseau, exhibited on a table, is blessed by the priest, who takes two rings, dropping them into a glass of wine and consecrates it. The rings are then taken out and placed one on the ring finger of the bride, the other on that of the bridegroom. A portion of the wine being drunk by the bridegroom, he hands the glass to the bride, who tastes it. Sweetmeats wrapped in tinted paper, and a sherbet, known as "Guláb-nabát," are served to the guests.

The marriage ceremony in a few respects differs from that followed in Western Europe. For instance, before entering the church the pair, standing beneath the bell tower, plight their troth in the hearing of the priest, after which they kneel at the altar with their heads covered with veils. Throughout the service the sponsor holds a silver cross over the pair, and when the service ends the priest gives the bridegroom a belt and a cross, which are worn for three days, and can only be removed after the reading of certain prayers, until which time the marriage is not consummated.

As soon as an Armenian expires, the arms are crossed over the chest, and a wax taper being lighted, is placed at the head, while incense is burned in the room. The priest being informed of the death, orders the church bells to be tolled as an intimation to the friends. At the burial the priest, relatives, and friends follow on foot, while the coffin is preceded by persons carrying a cross and torches. The coffin is first of all placed beneath the campanile, and prayers being offered up, it is borne into the church and placed on a catafalque surrounded by tapers, where it remains until the appointed service is read.

In the room where the deceased expired a candle is kept constantly burning for forty days, while on the seventh and fortieth days, as well as on the anniversary of the death, a mass is celebrated in the church, and after the last service a feast, to which all relatives and friends are invited, is given, at which a peculiar kind of Puláo with raisins is handed round.

The future of the Armenian race in India is difficult to predict; but if the tendency to adopt English ideas and ways extends, it must overcome the contrary spirit still influencing the majority. In many respects the Jew and Armenian resemble one another. Cut off from the cradle of their religion and nationality they sojourn apart from the European, and exhibit few sympathies for the Hindu or Muhammadan. Each has preserved an ancient established religion which, ordinarily at least, debars the alien and Gentile from admission into its pale,

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and each is yearning for a spiritual and temporal supremacy in their original home. With such aspirations, however, it has become the habit with Armenians to educate their boys as English parents do, and so successfully has this been followed out, that several have in competition gained admission into the Army and Indian Civil Service. The education and position of the Armenian female, however, leaves much to be desired. She is generally brought up with only a superficial knowledge of any language; she leads a secluded, uninteresting life, diversified by attendance at church, and by visits to her relatives, and her sympathies are neither cultivated nor encouraged. Until she is raised to an equality with her husband, and acquires those accomplishments which adorn her European sister, it cannot be predicated of the Armenians that the future is for them altogether bright and cheerful.

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SECTION V.

PORTUGUESE OF EASTERN BENGAL.

FIRST APPEARANCE IN 1516.
JESUIT MISSION, 1599.
WARFARE WITH MAGS AND MUGHALS DURING SEVENTEENTH CENTURY.
FINAL SUBMISSION, 1665.
PORTUGUESE MISSION.
CENSUS OF PORTUGUESE CHRISTIANS.
THEIR PRESENT OCCUPATIONS AND HABITS.

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PORTUGUESE IN EASTERN BENGAL.

"THE first Portugall," as far as Antonio Galvam knew,[1] "which drunke of the river Ganges was a knight, called J. Coello." In 1516 Fernando Perez de Andrada was sent with a letter to him, but the credit of having discovered and observed the country is due to Don John de Silveira, who was commissioned in 1518 to negotiate with the King of Bengal. The embassy was hospitably received by the governor of "Chatigan," but a quarrel arose, and though speedily quelled broke out again, and with great difficulty a treaty was concluded. The governor, however, was only dissembling. The Portuguese vessels were attacked by a swarm of war boats, which they repulsed, but were obliged to retire to Ceylon in a very crippled state.[2]

Another account is, that Silveira, being sent to establish a factory in Bengal, met with a most unfriendly reception owing to a rumour that his fleet was a piratical one. The expedition passed the winter amid great hardships, especially from famine, and the crews would have perished miserably but for the opportune arrival of another flotilla under Juan Coello.[3]

It is in connection with this expedition that Dacca is first mentioned in history. Fonseca refers to a governor of the city of "Daracca," and Castanheda styles him "do Señor da Cidade Darraçao."[4]

In 1527 a Portuguese vessel was wrecked on the coast of Chakaria, south of Chatigan. The crew on reaching dry land were ill-treated by the inhabitants and one of them killed.[5]

As early as 1528 the Emperor Baber casually mentions that the Bengalis were famous for their knowledge of artillery, acquired, there is reason for believing, from the Portuguese. A few years later Mahmúd Sháh, king of Bengal, hard pressed by the Afgháns under Shír Sháh, applied for aid to the Viceroy at Goa. In 1537 a small force was sent under Martin Alfonso de

[1] "The Discoveries of the World." Reprinted by the Hakluyt Society, p. 131.
[2] "Osorio da Fonseca," p. 412; "Lopez de Castanheda," Lib. iv, cc. 38, 39.
[3] "Faria-y-Sousa," i, 220.
[4] "Fonseca," Lib. xi, 413; "Castanheda," op. cit.
[5] "Histoire Générale des Voyages," 1, 141.

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Melo, but before it could reach Gaur, that city had been taken by the Afgháns. The Portuguese soldiers were at first ill-used, but their bravery in holding the pass of Taliágarh gained them better treatment, and permission was granted to build a fort at Chatigan.

The Portuguese had no established government, settlement, or fortress in Bengal at the end of the sixteenth century. As a writer remarks, having no laws, no police, and no religion, they lived like the natives. A lucrative and thriving trade, however, was carried on at Hughli, or, as it was then called, Golin and Porto Pequèno, as well as at Chatigan, or Porto Grande. Furthermore, numerous Portuguese adventurers resided with their families in Bandels,[1] trading in salt and cotton goods, which were shipped in "Foists," or Jaleas, to Dianga,[2] and the Portuguese settlements on the Malabar coast. Others took service with native princes and fought bravely against Mughal and Afghán. These mercenaries were regarded as rebels (levantádos del rey), because they neither assisted their countrymen nor paid tribute to the Goa Government. Their character was infamous. The majority was composed of military deserters, ruined traders, renegade priests, and spendthrifts of all ranks and professions, who, resorting to Bengal, led scandalous lives, without any religion or law. The dishonour brought on the Christian name forced the Church to interfere, and at the end of 1597 a deputation, consisting of two Jesuit fathers from Goa and one from Dianga, was sent by the Archbishop of Goa to preach the gospel in Bengal and minister to the Portuguese settled there.

In 1598 the fathers arrived at Hughli, where many Portuguese and native Christians resided. The number of professing Christians far exceeded what was anticipated, and at "Ciandecan," or Jessore, the mission baptised two hundred free and bond men. The toleration of the native rulers and officials is most surprising. When the fathers left Hughli, after founding a school and an hospital, the first in Bengal, the Munçif did not exact the customary fees. At "Ciandecan" they were given a piece of land rent free on which to build a church, and got permission to preach and convert at pleasure. At Śrípúr the same liberality was shown. Six hundred pieces of gold were assigned as an annual contribution; while at Baklá the salary of two priests was paid by the Rája.

[1] From Persian "Bandar," an emporium, mart.

[2] The site of Dianga is still doubtful. Du Jarric (Liv. vi) says it is "une ville sise en ce port de Chatigam, ou les nefs qui viennent de l'Inde, mouillent l'anchre." Van der Heiden describes it as "eene Stadt in de haven van Chatigam."

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In 1601 the Jesuits had two missions in Eastern Bengal, one at Jessore, the other at Chatigan. Owing, however, to disturbances, the Jesuit fathers were withdrawn, and the church of Eastern Bengal was transferred to the care of Augustinian monks from Goa. At the end of the sixteenth century there were churches at Jessore, Baklá, Dacca, Śrípúr, and Noricol,[1] supported by Portuguese settlers and native converts.[2]

Very little is said of the internal condition of the country. Ḍákáits infested the tidal branches of the Ganges at that time, as they did two centuries later. The country generally was remarkably fertile, and the abundance of corn and fruit almost incredible. Wherever they went the Hindu and Muhammadan inhabitants treated them with marked respect and kindness. Father Pimenta has left us the following charming description of the scenery of the Delta.

"The route from Baklá to Jessore is so agreeable and picturesque that I have not seen its equal. Plains irrigated by numerous rivers whose banks are adorned with the most beautiful trees. On the one side you perceive large herds of deer, on the other flocks of cattle. I forbear mentioning the luxuriant fields of rice, the thickets of sugar-bearing reeds (*Arundineta calamis mellifluis redundantia*), the hives of bees, the monkeys bounding from tree to tree, and such like objects that afford pleasure to travellers. Tigers and crocodiles that feed through our neglect, or fault, on human beings, are common. In the woods rhinoceroses are seen, but thus far I have met with none."[3]

In 1602 the Portuguese of Chittagong, being harassed by attacks of the Arakanese, made Sondíp their chief stronghold. This island, situated in the estuary of the Ganges, is probably the oldest and most permanent of the group which the mighty river is for ever building up and destroying. It had belonged to the Rájah of Baklá, but the Muhammadans took possession, and when Le Blanc and Cæsar Frederick landed, between 1565 and 1586, the Moorish inhabitants were most friendly and courteous. The fertility of the island was unparalleled, the population large and prosperous, and the cheapness of food extraordinary. The manufacture of salt and the trade of shipbuilding were carried on with great energy and success.

The Portuguese, under command of Dominique Carvallho, a vassal of the Baklá Rájah, and Manuel de Mattos, from Cha-

[1] In Rájnagar, on right bank of Padma.

[2] For further particulars regarding the Jesuit Mission, see R. P. Petri Jarrici, "Thesaurus," iii, 2, c. xxix; "De rebus Japonicis, Indicis, &c." Ã Johanne Hayo, Scoto, S. J. P., 809; "Exemplum Epistolæ P. Nicolai Pimentæ." Romæ, 1602.

[3] "Exemplum," p. 91.

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tigan, seized the island, but before they could secure their hold the King of Arakan[1] with a large fleet, and supported by a hundred "Kosahs[2]" from Ṣrípúr, sailed for Sondíp. The Portuguese joined battle and were victorious, capturing over a hundred war boats, but so many of their own vessels were disabled that they hastily evacuated the island and retreated to Baklá, Ṣrípúr, and "Ciandecan." The King of Arakan having recovered Sondíp, invaded Baklá, threatened Jessore, and boasted that he would conquer the whole of Bengal.

In May, 1603, Carvallho was at Ṣrípúr, a city belonging to the Bhúya Kedar Rái, superintending the equipment of thirty "Jaleas,"[3] when a fleet sent by the viceroy, Rájah Man Singh, and consisting of one hundred "Kosahs" under "Mandarai,"[4] hove in sight. Carvallho, hastily disposing his ships, engaged the enemy, and after a stubborn fight captured several vessels, and put the rest to flight. Mandarai was slain, and Carvallho severely wounded. The Muhammadan historian[5] gives a very different account of the battle. Kaid Rái Zamíndár, of Bikrampúr, he says, had been subdued by Rájah Man Singh, but in 1603, forming an alliance with the Mag Rajáh, he rebelled and laid siege to a fort near Sunnárgáon. On hearing of this rebellion the viceroy sent a force under Ibráhim Atka, and others. The confederates were defeated and many boats taken. The narrative, however, ends with the suspicious statement that the Rájah was compelled to entrench himself in front of the imperial troops to provide safety against their attacks.

Carvallho proceeded to Hughli to have his wounds treated, and on his recovery, being invited by the Bhúya of Jessore to join in a war against the Mags, he proceeded, in spite of many warnings, to that court, where he was made prisoner and put to death.

Although the Portuguese were turbulent and lawless, pillaging Mags, Hindus, and Muhammadans without distinction, they were sometimes entrusted with high military commands in Bengal. For instance, Pyrard de Laval mentions[6] one "Jean Garie," who had under him ten thousand of the Bengal troops.

In 1607 the Mag Rájah made war, captured Dianga, and

[1] "Rex Tiparæ, Chaconæ et Bengalæ, Pegusii dominus." De Jarric, tom. iii, lib. 3, c. xxix.

[2] A "Kosah" was a war boat driven by oars, but having one mast.

[3] A "Jalea," from Sanskrit "Jala," water, was a name applied to boats generally.

[4] "Vir impiger et totâ Bengalâ notissimus." De Jarric. Mandarim was the title given by the Portuguese to any governor, or commander, in the East. It is derived from "Mandár," to command. The English title, Mandarin, for a Chinese official, is the same word.

[5] Elliot's "History of India," vi, 109.

[6] "Voyage de François Pyrard de Laval," p. 239.

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drove the survivors to the islands of the Meghna. Sondíp, which had fallen into the hands of the Mughals, was held by a force under Fath Khán, who had put to death all the Portuguese and the Christian slaves in the island. A few escaped with Sebastian Gonzales Tibao, and became pirates, plundering villages and conveying the booty to Baklá, where they sold it. Fath Khán having equipped a fleet, set sail to extirpate these pests, but Sebastian Pinto attacked his vessels off Dakhin Sháhbázpúr, destroyed a great number, and killed Fath Khán. In March, 1609, the Portuguese, supported by troops from Baklá, laid siege to the fort of Sondíp, held by the Mughals under a brother of Fath Khán, while the Hindu population looked on with characteristic indifference. The fort was stormed and taken after a gallant defence. The garrison and all the Muhammadans in the island, a thousand in number, were in retaliation massacred in cold blood. Gonzales perfidiously broke the agreement made with the Baklá Rájah, and instead of paying him half the revenue obtained from the island, refused to come to any understanding. The adjacent islands of Dakhin Sháhbázpúr and Paṭelá-bhanga were annexed, and having in this lawless manner acquired possession of a small territory, Gonzales ruled both with wonderful tact and sagacity. Trade flourished, and the Portuguese became the envy and dread of the neighbouring princes. Good fortune also favoured them. A brother of the Mag Rajáh, expelled from his country, sought shelter at Sondíp. Gonzales married his sister, and after exacting a large sum of money, is suspected to have poisoned his brother-in-law.

The unsettled state of the eastern frontier, and the devastation of the Delta by the Portuguese, forced Jahángír to transfer the seat of government from Ráj-Mahal to Dacca. In 1608 the viceroy, Islám Khán Fathpúrí, removed to the new capital and at once took measures to extirpate the Portuguese, and secure a durable peace. The district of Dacca was then a settled portion of the empire, but farther south Mughals, Afgháns, and rebellious vassals[1] contended for power. In 1610 the Mag Rájah made a treaty with Gonzales, in which it was agreed that the latter should command the allied fleets and act in concert with the Arakan army as it marched along the coast, and that all territory conquered should be equally divided between the two contracting parties. The campaign began, Lakhípúr and Bhaluah were overrun, but on meeting the Mughal army the Arakanese, owing to the shameful defection of the Portuguese, were totally defeated. Gonzales, a witness of the disastrous battle,

[1] In a mosque at Farrídpúr is an inscription of the date A. H. 1013 (1604), preserving the name of one 'Ajab Bahádur Khán Sultání, but omitting all mention of an Emperor, which could only have been erected by a rebel.

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fled to Sondíp, after putting to death all the captains of the Mag fleet. The Mughals reoccupied Bhaluah without opposition, but did not follow the fugitives to Chátgáon. To consummate his villainy Gonzales waged war against his late allies, plundered and burned their villages, and, sailing up the Arakan river, attempted, but unsuccessfully, to capture the vessels anchored there.

Up to this time Gonzales had refused to obey, or recognise, the viceroy at Goa, but in 1615, being hard pressed by the Mags, he submitted and urged an immediate invasion of Arakan. A fleet was accordingly sent under command of D. Francis de Menezes Roxo. It sailed up the Arakan river on the 3rd October, but the Mags, assisted by some Dutch vessels, offered a stubborn resistance, and obliged the Portuguese to retire. In November Gonzales arrived with fifty sail, when a combined attack was made, but De Menezes being killed, the assailants fell into disorder and retreated.

Gonzales returned to Sondíp, but his power and popularity were gone, and his dispirited followers quarrelling among themselves, allowed the Mags to take the island. After ruling nine years, Gonzales was stripped of his possessions; "his sovereignty passed like a shadow, his pride was humbled, and his villainies punished."[1]

The Portuguese never recovered from this defeat, although their flag waved for many years unchallenged in the Delta, and the imperial Nawárah dared not meet their "Galliasses[2] in fair fight. Bernier,[3] however, makes mention of another Portuguese adventurer who acquired temporary power. "It was these same pirates," he says, "who at this time took Sondíp, in which a certain notorious monk of S. Augustine, named Fra Joañ, acted the petty sovereign for several years, having managed, God knows how, to get rid of (*se defaire*) the commandant of the place."

For the next fifty years the Portuguese lived by piracy, and by making raids upon the peaceful villages of Bengal. Some entered the military employ of the Arakan monarch, and commanded expeditions sent against Bengal, Pegu, and Siam;[4] others joined the imperial artillery, and Jahángír was wont to say that one Portuguese soldier would beat three of his own people.

[1] "Faria y Sousa," iii, 268.

[2] Tavernier describes the "Galeaça" as a long swift boat, often with fifty oars a side, and two men to each oar. It was generally gaudily painted and ornamented with blue colours and gold foil.

[3] "Histoire de la dernière revolution des États du Grand Mogol." Paris, 1670. The incident is not mentioned by Faria y Sousa, whose history ends with 1640; and as Bernier left India in 1668, it must have occurred between these dates.

[4] "Voyage de Wouter Schouten," ii, 168.

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Many assisted Sháh Shújá in his ill-starred rebellion of 1660, and when his cause was lost became Dákáits infesting the Sunderbuns, and lying in ambush in a creek near Ságar, still known as "Rogues' River," waylaid vessels beating up the Hughli.

In 1662 the shipwrecked crew of the "Ter Schelling"[1] arrived at Bhaluah, where they found Muhammadans speaking Portuguese, and the Moorish commander protected by a body-guard "consisting wholly of Christians negro-born, and subjects of the King of Portugal," who were treated with especial honour on account of their valour. Other writers, however, give a different estimate of these "negro-born" Portuguese, and in the seventeenth century their usual sobriquet was "Gallínhas del Mar," on account of their habitual cowardice. The history of two centuries confirms the latter judgment, and, except under very exceptional circumstances, the Portuguese Eurasian has never proved himself a valiant soldier.

The capture of Hughli in 1632, and the slaughter of its brave defenders, was the death blow to Portuguese prestige in Bengal, and in 1666, when Sháyista Khán determined on annexing Chátgáon and the islands at the mouth of the Meghna, he threatened the Portuguese with the fate of the Hughli garrison if they did not submit and become subjects of Sháh Jahán. The evil deeds which provoked the Muhammadan viceroy to interference are detailed by Bernier, a most prejudiced authority. Bad as the Portuguese undoubtedly were, their cruelty was exceeded by that of the Mags, who penetrated into the interior pillaging and ravaging the country, and leaving behind a name hateful even to modern Bengalis.

On the appointment of Sháyista Khán in 1664 to the government of Bengal, an expedition was organised against the Portuguese banditti. The fleet, a very powerful one, supported by several Dutch vessels, being put into the highest state of efficiency, was directed to act in concert with the army preparing to march on Chittagong. Alarmed by these preparations, and won over by bribes, many Portuguese left Chittagong "in forty or fifty galliasses," and gave themselves up as prisoners to the Nawáb at Dacca, who overwhelmed them with favours. Many were induced by large pay to enlist in the Imperial army, while a settlement at Farangí Bazár was established for the old and physically unfit.

[1] "A Relation of an unfortunate Voyage to the Kingdom of Bengala." By Mr. Glanius. London, 168?, 8vo. This is merely an English translation of "Vervarelyke Schip-Breuk van t'oost Indisch Jacht Ter Schelling under het landt van Bengale." Amsterdam, 1675, 4to. The author is Frans van der Heiden.

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When the army and fleet of the Mughals advanced upon Chittagong, the island of Sondíp was occupied by Diláwar, a Muhammadan, and troops in league with the Mags. A detachment was landed, the fort was besieged and taken, but a Mag flotilla coming in sight, the troops were hurriedly withdrawn, and the transports sailed to Nawakhálí. In the following December a larger force occupied the island, and held it. The main army then advanced along the coast, meeting with little opposition. Letters were sent to the Portuguese in the Mag service offering advantageous terms on submission. Several of these letters being intercepted, the Mag Rájah tried to induce the soldiers to remove into the interior of Arakan, but refusing to do so, they finally left in a body for Bengal. On the 18th December, 1665, they arrived at Nawakhálí, and the leaders set out for Dacca, where they were graciously received by the viceroy. Some were enrolled as volunteers under an Englishman named Captain Moore,[1] and joined in the expedition against Chittagong.

On the 16th January, 1666, the garrison of that town capitulated, and the Portuguese soldiers who had distinguished themselves in the campaign received grants of land.

With the capture of Chittagong and the pacification of the Eastern frontier the history of the Portuguese, as an independent and aggressive power, terminates. Throughout the Dacca and adjoining districts numerous settlements of Portuguese Christians are still to be found, but none can claim relationship with the soldiers of the seventeenth century.

The following sketch of the Portuguese mission since its foundation in Bengal embraces the origin and history of these settlements.

The Portuguese mission in Bengal was founded in 1598, by the Augustine Archbishop of Goa. On arrival at Hughli the missionaries obtained a grant of rent-free land. This grant originally consisted of 260 acres, but during last century it dwindled one-half. A chapel was built at Bandel, near Chinsurah, and dedicated to "Nuestra Senora del Rosario." The first "regent" was Fre Bernardo de Jesus, and to this church all the other parochial churches in Bengal were affiliated.

Since the beginning of the seventeenth century the Bishop of S. Thomé, or Mailapúr, in Madras, has been the head of the Bengal Church. In 1606 Pope Paulus V made S. Thomé an episcopal see, and by consistorial letters annexed to it the provinces of Bengal, Pegu, and Orissa. The special mission to

[1] Nothing further has been learned regarding this soldier, but at the present day a small "Tappá" or division, in Bikrampúr is named after him.

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Bengal was vested in the Augustinian monks of Goa, upon one of whom the title and prerogatives of Vicar General were conferred.

A tradition is preserved by the mission, that in 1599 one of their number, Fre Luis des Chagos, was stopped on his way to Silhet by certain Christians who besought him to relieve them from landlord tyranny. On his return he bought the villages and lands of Nágori and Bhágori in Bhowál, settling in them thirteen families of Christians, including a converted Bráhman. A piece of land was also purchased at Náráyandih, a suburb of Dacca, which still belongs to the mission.

The church of Nágori, however, bears the date 1664, and is dedicated to St. Nicola da Tolentino,[1] the patron saint of the Augustine order.

During the seventeenth century the success of the Augustine monks was most extraordinary. In 1602, three years after its foundation, the Hughli mission consisted of over 500 persons, among whom were many "grands seigneurs," and by the end of the century the sacrament was administered to 10,000 converts.

The parochial church of Dacca, dedicated "a la Assumpcion de nuestra Senora," was at Tezgáon, on the north of the city, and its graveyard still contains the oldest tombstones and epitaphs in Eastern Bengal. The early history of the mission is very interesting. Its success was chiefly owing to the conversion of a member of a distinguished Hindu family. The son of the Zamíndár of Bosnah,[2] one of the twelve Bhúyas, moved by the preaching of the monks, was persuaded to become a Christian. Being baptized as Don Antonio del Rosario, he induced his wife and brethren to follow his example.

Manrique,[3] a Spanish Augustine monk, describing Dacca in 1641, mentions that families of Christians resided in the suburbs, at Náráyandih, "Manaxor," and "Pulgari," and that a handsome, though small, convent, as well as a good church, existed. Much intolerance was practised by Muhammadan Mullas, Pírs, and Darweshes, who denounced all Christians for eating animals slaughtered in an unorthodox way. The Nawáb, however, protected them, and the position of the mission was so secure that another chapel and residency were about to be built in Dacca as well as two in the Bandels of Srípúr and Norícol. In

[1] S. Nicola da Tolentino died A.D. 1308, and was canonized by encyclical letters of Pope Eugenius IV, in 1446.

[2] "Donde assiste Don Antonio del Rosario, hijo del Rey de Busna, à quien no solo convertieron nostros religiosos sinoque le redimio del cautiverio el Padre Manuel del Rosario," p. 24. "Christiandad del Japan." Su Autor El P.M. Fr. Joseph Sicardo. En Madrid 1698, fol.

[3] "Itinerario de las Missiones que hizo El Padre F. Sebastian Manrique." Roma, 1649, 4to.

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1679 the converts in Eastern Bengal were estimated at 30,000, and Don Antonio, attached to the Church of Norícol in Rájnagar, had joint charge with the "rector" of 1,000 Christians.

At the end of the seventeenth century the Portuguese churches in Eastern Bengal and Assam were those of "Chandpúr in Tipperah, Banja, perhaps Banga, in Farrídpúr, Pippli, Balasor, "Tambolin," Jessore with 300 Christians, Hughli, Tezgáon, Dacca, and "Arrayal de Bencamatis," or Rangamati, in Assam. In 1713 Laynez, Bishop of S. Thomé, visited Bengal. He found Christian congregations at Hughli, Pippli, Chittagong, Dacca, Husainpúr in Mymensingh, and Rangamati in Assam.

It is difficult to arrive at any certain conclusion regarding the number of Portuguese Christians at different periods. Bernier was told by the priests that Hughli contained over 8,000, and that in other parts of Bengal there were 25,000. Monsignor Cerri,[1] secretary of the congregation De propagandâ fide, writing about 1680, estimated the number at 22,000, divided into eleven parishes, each of which had a vicar and a curate. It was, he admits, hard to find any adult converts save Portuguese slaves, who had been bought, and made Christians. In 1840, according to Mr. Taylor,[2] the number belonging to the three parishes of Dacca, Bhowál, and Husainábád was 10,150. In 1873 the Portuguese vicar of Husainábád calculated that 3,000 persons belonged to his church, while the French priest of the adjoining parish rated his at 1,200.

The census of the Dacca Farangís for 1877 and 1878 has been kindly furnished by Mr. R. D. Lyall, C.S., who considers the returns of the French Mission more exact than the Portuguese.

Mission.	*Parishes.*	1877.	1878.
Portuguese	Dacca	103	212
	Nágori	1,221	1,265
	Tezgáon	140	122
	Husainábád ..	2820	2833
		4,284	4,432
French ..	Bandura, Tumilía, Sualpúr ..	5,000	1,440 + 2,020 = 4,060

The total number of Dacca Farangís may therefore be estimated at 8,500, but nearly 2,000 under the French fathers, being converted natives, have no right to be called Farangís at all

[1] "An Account of the Roman Catholic Religion throughout the World," translated by Sir Richard Steele. London 1715.

[2] "Topography of Dacca," p. 252.

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The system by which the Portuguese made converts was not one that could prosper. Children of both sexes, either kidnapped or purchased, were made Christians, while girls after baptism became concubines and their offspring Christians. At one time this trade flourished to such an extent that the slave-dealers boasted of having converted more Hindus in a year than all the missionaries of India did in ten. When the Portuguese power in the Delta was overthrown slave-catching ceased, and a final blow was dealt to this novel plan of converting the natives. With the seventeenth century the Portuguese mission ceased to triumph, and during the last century and a half it has not held its own against Muhammadan aggression. Many reasons for this failure are assigned, but Monsignor Cerri refers it to the immorality of the priests and laity, the former leading loose lives, exhibiting great ignorance and extreme avarice, and retaining large staffs of servants given up to all manner of vice and lewdness. The Goa priests, to whose care the Christians of Bengal were confided, have for many generations been half-castes, born and bred at Goa. Each parish church, moreover, is endowed with rent-free land, or with property held and managed by the vicar. Communication with S. Thomé being irregular and uncertain, the internal economy and discipline of the parishes are not interfered with as long as the annual donation is sent to Goa. An illiterate priesthood, a rich isolated establishment, and a simple credulous laity, was a combination of evils sufficient to ruin any church. No one who has given a thought to the Portuguese clergy of Eastern Bengal can wonder that they, inheriting a faulty system from their predecessors, have failed to instil new life among their flocks. Occupied as they generally are with the management of valuable church property, and of lawsuits inseparable from the possession of land in Bengal, little time, and less zeal, are expended on the spiritual welfare of their tenantry. A school is always attached to the church, but the instruction given is of the most rudimentary kind, and no attempts are made to raise the standard of education.

Such being the actual state of matters, it is not surprising that the congregation De propagandâ fide has for long been striving to gain possession of the churches and endowments of the Portuguese mission. Various lawsuits have been instituted, and in several instances, as at Dacca and Chittagong, the decision of the courts has been in favour of the congregation. The French mission, guided by the able and benevolent Monseigneur Dufal, has within the last fifteen years infused new spiritual life among these neglected Christians. The good bishop, assisted by an admirable staff of clergy, devote themselves to improving the people, and their schools are crowded with hundreds of

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boys eager for knowledge. The nuns of the "Sacré Cœur" are engaged in an equally beneficent task. To them is confided the religious and moral training of the girls, and the schools conducted by them are models of order and propriety.

Two centuries ago the Portuguese Christians were divided into three classes, "reynol," including those born in Europe, "castiço," those born in India of Portuguese parents, and "mestiço," or half-castes. These three classes no longer exist. The modern Christians are for the most part the offspring of the last and most numerous division, but they have lost all traces of their European parentage. Here and there a face, characterised by large and rugged features, strikes a stranger accustomed to the regular and more delicate lineaments of the average Bengali, but in complexion the Farangís are as swarthy as a Chaṇḍál. The distinctive and favourite appellation of these Christians is Farangí, but the natives nickname them the "Kálá" or "Maṭṭí," earth-coloured Farangís.

The Farangí peasant dresses exactly like the Hindu or Muhammadan ryot, but on gala days, especially among the wealthier classes, the peculiar costume, still worn at Chittagong, is put on. It consists of striped drawers, a shirt, or cloth doublet, a skull cap with flaps fastened behind, and slippers. The women on festivals wear a white lace veil, or mantilla, covering the head and shoulders, while the common dress is a petticoat and a loose muslin jacket.[1]

In Bhowál the title Bocto (Sanskrit Bhakta, a worshipper), is exclusively applied to the families of the first settlers, but in other places the name, it is said, was given to the secretaries who also acted as catechists in the absence of the pastor.[2]

According to the French clergy, the Dacca Farangís are more moral, but quite as improvident as those of Chittagong. A poor man will not hesitate to borrow three hundred rupees for his marriage, while the rich will often squander eight hundred for the same purpose. The Bazár rate of interest being exorbitant, the borrower becomes impoverished for life, and rarely succeeds in clearing himself of the debt. The large majority of Farangís in Eastern Bengal are simple peasants, but many young men go to Calcutta, taking service as cooks, or undertakers ("Poberies" from the Portuguese Pobre, poor).

The peasantry are industrious though poor. They cultivate the church lands, but the profit of their toil goes to Goa to support churches and monasteries. On the whole, their position is an

[1] For further particulars regarding the "Feringhees," see "Calcutta Review," vol. liii, for 1871.

[2] Père Barbier, however, writing from Chittagong in 1713, says: "Les Chrétiens du dedans des terres, nommés Boctos." Lettres Édifiantes, ii, 590.

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unenviable one, being worse than that of ryots under good native landlords, who generally do something for the improvement of their estates.

The minor excommunication, depriving the sinner of the sacraments until he yields and confesses his faults, is at once a powerful and convenient weapon for subduing any quarrelsome ryot. When the priest is only the farmer and a Bráhman the landlord, the edifying spectacle is seen of a peasant appealing to the latter for redress, who, if he thinks the punishment excessive, issues an order to readmit the accused to all the privileges of the church, and very rarely is the order disobeyed.

The majority of Farangís read and some write Bengali, which has become the vernacular of all classes. Each individual is given at baptism a Portuguese name, but an assumed Bengali one is commonly used. A few Portuguese words are still spoken, and the names of festivals and religious ceremonies are the same as in Europe. Yet, strange to say, Lent is called "Roza," the Persian name of the Ramazán fast. No Farangí possesses a Bible, but each one wears a rosary and a crucifix. On Fridays they eschew flesh, and during Lent observe a strict fast. In most houses a recess, containing an altar, or "Prie-dieu," is found, before which a lamp is lighted every evening, and on which flowers are arranged on "festá" days.

On account of the prejudices of Hindus and Muhammadans there is no Farangí shopkeeper in the villages of the interior. In Bhowál swine are generally kept, and large quantities of ham, bacon, and pork sausages, exported to Calcutta.

Farangís live in friendship and neighbourly sympathy with the natives, and are generally esteemed for moderation and liberality. They cannot, however, be considered the equal of the frugal, sober, and industrious Hindu or Muhammadan ryot. In blind subservience to their priests, in superstition, and in servility to oppression, the Farangís are on a par with their neighbours, but in their intemperate habits, against which the pulpit fulminates in vain, they sink below the non-Christian races around them.

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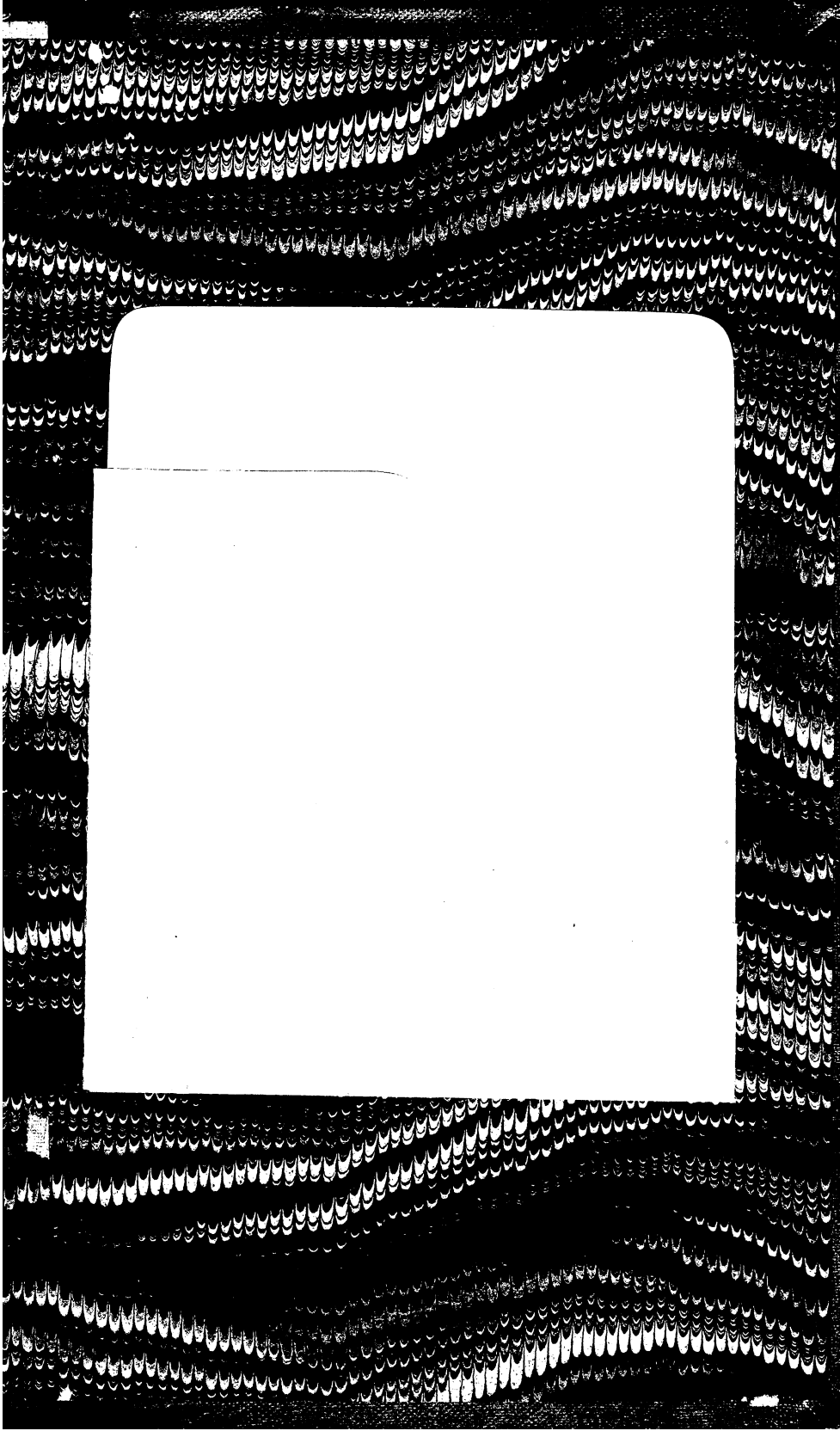

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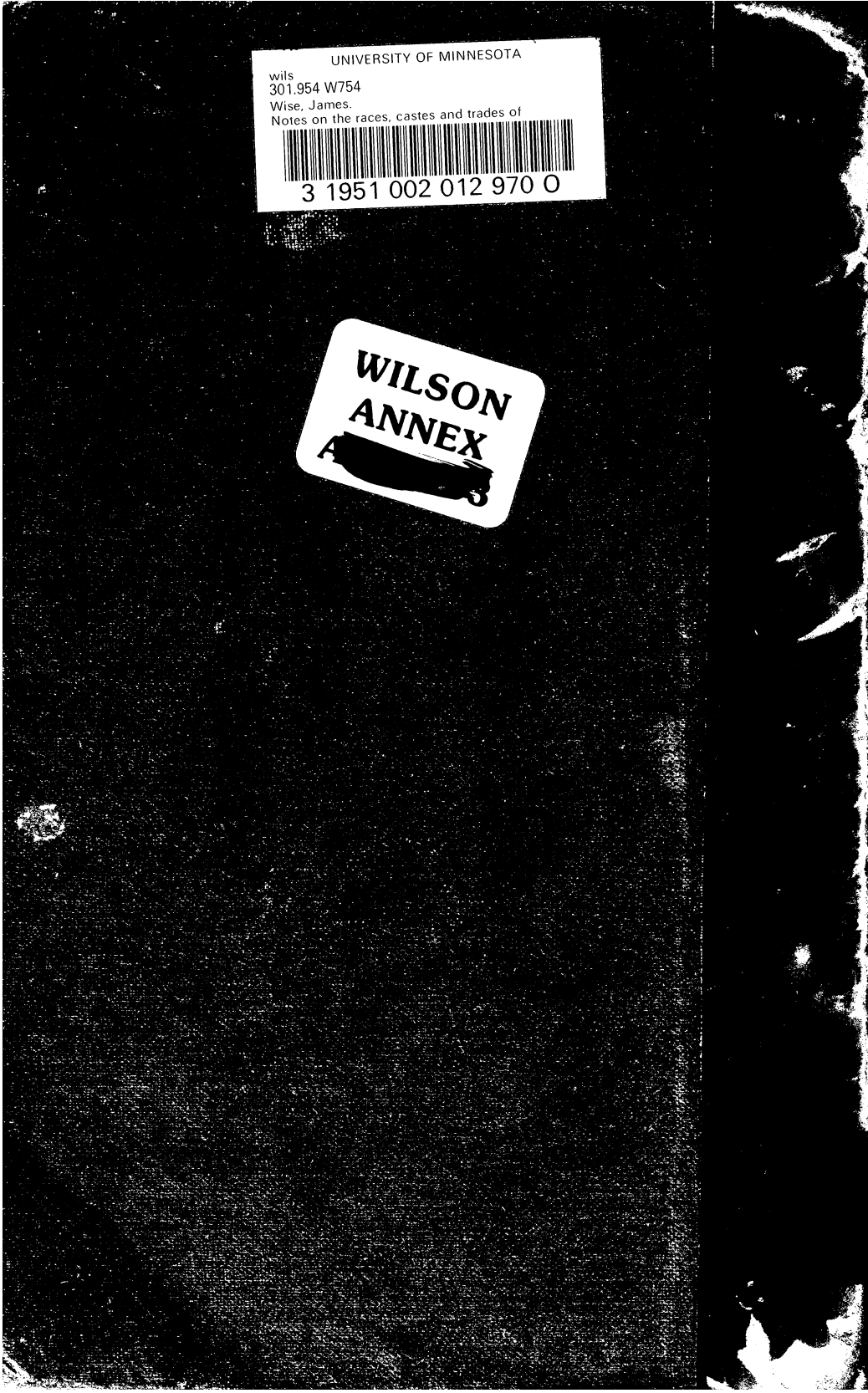
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